DEGREE PROJECT

From Overtourism to Responsible Branding: Developing Conscientious Place Brands in Coastal Communities

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We dedicate this study to the memory of Nathan's father, Capt. Wayne Sibly, who died in Perth, Western Australia, in February 2026.

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Abstract

Tourism-dependent coastal communities increasingly face the consequences of growth that outpaces local capacity. Visitor numbers rise, residents are crowded out of decisions taken on their behalf, and place brands risk projecting an image the place itself cannot sustain. This thesis asks in what way a conscientious place branding perspective can support the development of place brands in such communities. The study is based on the case of Saltstraumen, a small village in Nordland, Norway, known for the world's strongest tidal current and situated within a marine protected area, where sport fishing has grown faster than local governance has adapted.

The research is guided by a conceptual framework of conscientious place branding organised around four dimensions: transformative public purpose, stakeholder fairness, temporal and ecological responsibility, and participatory openness and co-creation. Integrity and accountability ran across the four as cross-cutting commitments, which means that they are overarching principles that apply across all four dimensions of the framework. The study followed a single-case, holistic design with an abductive logic. Seventeen semi-structured interviews were conducted with internal stakeholders, including residents, businesses, and public actors, complemented by fieldwork and a member-checking conversation with regional administration. The material was analysed using reflexive thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke).

Three findings stood out. First, economic continuity operated as a substrate beneath the four dimensions rather than as a parallel pillar; without it, the other commitments were difficult for stakeholders to sustain. Second, an observed pattern termed Layered Accountability: integrity commitments held within each governance layer but did not aggregate across layers in a way residents could address. Third, identity negotiation appeared as a precondition for, rather than an outcome of, a conscientious place brand, particularly in settings without a constituted village-scale brand author.

The thesis contributes a refined conceptual framework and an empirical account of how conscientious branding takes shape in a small Nordic coastal community.

Keywords: place branding, conscientious branding, conscientious place branding, small tourism dependent community

Sammanfattning

Kustsamhällen som är beroende av turism möter i allt större utsträckning konsekvenserna av tillväxt som överstiger den lokala kapaciteten. Antalet besökare ökar, invånare stängs ut från beslut som fattas å deras vägnar och platsvarumärken riskerar att projicera en bild som platsen själv inte kan upprätthålla. Denna studie undersöker på vilket sätt ett conscientious place branding-perspektiv kan bidra till utvecklingen av platsvarumärken i sådana samhällen. Studien utgår från Saltstraumen, en liten by i Nordland i Norge, känd för världens starkaste malström och som är belägen inom ett skyddat havsområde, där sportfisket har vuxit snabbare än vad den lokala styrningens har kunnat anpassa.

Studien styrs av ett teoretiskt ramverk baserat på conscientious place branding organiserat kring fyra dimensioner: transformativt offentligt syfte, rättvisa mellan intressenter, tidsmässigt och ekologiskt ansvar samt deltagande öppenhet och medskapande. Integritet och ansvar löper som övergripande principer genom samtliga fyra dimensioner, vilket innebär att de fungerar som övergripande riktlinjer som gäller för hela ramverket. Studien genomfördes som en enskild fallstudie med holistisk design och abduktiv logik. Sjutton semistrukturerade intervjuer genomfördes med interna intressenter, inklusive invånare, näringsidkare och offentliga kommunala aktörer, kompletterat med fältarbete samt en återkopplingsintervju med regional förvaltning. Materialet analyserades med reflexiv tematisk analys (Braun och Clarke).

Tre centrala resultat framträdde. För det första så fungerande ekonomisk kontinuitet som ett underliggande fundament snarare än separat pelare till de fyra dimensionerna; utan detta blev det svårt för aktörerna att upprätthålla de övriga åtagandena. För det andra identifierades ett mönster som benämns skiktat ansvar: integritetsåtaganden upprätthölls inom respektive styrningsnivå men fanns inte mellan nivåerna på ett sätt som invånare kunde förhålla sig till. För det tredje framstod identitetsförhandling som en förutsättning snarare än ett resultat av ett conscientious platsvarumärke, särskilt i sammanhang där det saknas en etablerad lokal "varumärkesförfattare".

Uppsatsen bidrar med ett raffinerat teoretiskt ramverk samt en empirisk beskrivning av hur conscientious branding kan ta form i ett mindre nordiskt kustsamhälle.

Nyckelord: platsvarumärke, conscientious branding, conscientious place branding, små turismberoende samhällen

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1. Introduction

This thesis focuses on place branding in the context of small tourism-dependent communities, where increasing tourism creates both opportunities and challenges for local stakeholders. The study uses Saltstraumen in northern Norway as a case to explore how residents, businesses and other internal stakeholders perceive tourism development, as well as how these perceptions relate to place identity and local place dynamics. The analysis is approached through a conscientious place branding perspective, which places attention on a transformative purpose, fairness, openness and long-term responsibility in the branding process. This introductory chapter presents the background of the case, introduces the two main theories place branding and conscientious branding, outlines the problem discussion and presents the overall purpose of the study.

1.1 Background

Tourism has increasingly become an important part of many small communities, offering economic opportunities (Liu et al., 2023). As destinations compete to attract more visitors, developing a strong and meaningful place brand has become essential for differentiating themselves in the crowd of competing tourist destinations (Mohn, 2024). At the same time, efforts to attract more tourists through branding can create/bring challenges when visitor numbers grow too high, in turn affecting residents' everyday lives, negatively impacting sustainability and placing increasing pressure on local environments (Cheer, 2024; Mihalic, 2020). This explores a central tension in tourism-dependent places, where efforts to attract visitors may contribute to environmental pressure on the very ecosystems that form the basis of the destination's appeal. In this way, tourism can paradoxically undermine the very qualities that make a place attractive in the first place.

Examples of such tensions can be observed in both large-scale tourist destinations and smaller communities experiencing tourism growth. A large-scale example of this is in 2026 the long-running cherry blossom festival in Fujiyoshida, Japan, was cancelled after local authorities concluded that "the peaceful lives of residents are at risk" due to congestion, littering and other disruptive tourist behaviour near Mount Fuji (McPhee, 2026). Similar tensions can be observed on a smaller scale in Nordic coastal regions where tourism growth places pressure on fragile environments and local communities (Bogason et al., 2025). Lofoten in Norway is a smaller community facing over tourism and the environmental impact this has on the area is of the greatest concern (Thomas, 2025). Together these examples illustrate a broader challenge of attracting visitors while avoiding the environmental and social consequences that increased tourism can create.

The examples of Mount Fuji and Lofoten illustrate how overtourism may create social and environmental pressures on different scales. On a similar, yet smaller scale, tension can be observed in Saltstraumen, a small coastal community in northern Norway that forms the case study for this thesis. For Saltstraumen, the central question is how tourism can continue to generate economic value while still preserving the environment and not disturbing the

community life that makes the place attractive in the first place. Saltstraumen is located in Nordland County and is internationally known for one of the world's strongest tidal currents (Visit Norway, n.d.a). It is also a marine protected area with a purpose to protect rare and vulnerable nature and species, yet fishing remains permitted and fish stocks have reportedly shown signs of decline in recent years (Olsen, 2024). This produces a paradox in which the protected status signals conservation while the area functions as a high-traffic tourism destination where fishing remains permitted (Alt om Saltstraumen, n.d.). Saltstraumen has experienced growing tourism activity in recent years and according to a municipal survey conducted in 2023 by Prologue et al., residents recognise tourism as an important source of income when they at the same time express concern about environmental strain and social disruption.

Unlike Fujiyoshida (McPhee, 2026) or larger cities such as Barcelona, where social disturbance is often the primary concern (Elorrieta et al., 2022), Saltstraumen faces both social and environmental pressure simultaneously, with the marine protected area as a particularly sensitive issue. These developments reflect a broader shift in place branding research, moving away from a narrow focus on tourism as an economic activity toward a consideration of multiple stakeholders and long-term social and environmental sustainability, including conservation and protection of the environment (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Garanti et al., 2024; Kraff et al., 2025; Kavaratzis, 2012; Kavaratzis & Hatch, 2013; Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015). This leads to a central question for Saltstraumen's future: what is the place, and who is it truly for? Unlike destinations where overtourism has already developed into a full-scale crisis, Saltstraumen is a community at a stage where the direction of future development remains open, which makes it an interesting case for studying how tourism strategies are shaped before tensions become irreversible. At this stage tourism offers important economic benefits, yet environmental pressures on the marine protected area and impacts on everyday lives of residents make these trade-offs increasingly difficult to ignore. The combination of these social and environmental sensitivities make Saltstraumen a suitable case for exploring how place branding can be conducted responsibly, with attention to multiple forms of sustainability.

This thesis takes Saltstraumen as a case study to explore how place branding in a small tourism community intersects with stakeholder (resident) perspectives and the sustainability concerns. The case provides an opportunity to examine how place branding theory can be understood and further developed in light of the tensions described above. As part of the background for the study, preliminary discussions with a local partner NORD&NE pointed to an interest in gaining deeper insight into locals' perspective of place identity and sustainable tourism development in Saltstraumen. These discussions raised questions about whether the local values align with Saltstraumen's tourism positioning and how residents prioritise issues such as sustainability, cultural heritage, economic development and environmental protection. Drawing on place branding and conscientious branding theory (CBT), the study investigates how local stakeholders perceive Saltstraumen's identity and desired tourism image. It also asks whether conscientious place branding can support the development of place brands that align with community values and long-term sustainability goals. The following subsections

introduce the core concepts of place branding and conscientious branding that guide this analysis.

1.1.1 Place branding

Place branding is a widely researched concept in academic literature and has been approached from several perspectives and with different definitions (Vuignier, 2017). An early definition of place branding describes it as a "the practice of applying brand strategy and other marketing techniques and disciplines to the economic, social, political and cultural development of cities, regions and countries" (Anholt, 2004, as cited in Kerr, 2006, p. 278). This definition focuses on promotional aspects, while more recent definitions include a focus on people. Boisen (2015) describes place branding as "the conscious process of creating, gaining, enhancing and reshaping the distinct presence of a place in the minds and hearts of people" (p. 14). Place branding can also be understood as a process in which different elements and actors work together to shape how a place is experienced (Eshuis & Ripoll González, 2025). Following this perspective, the study approaches place branding as a socially embedded and stakeholder-driven process rather than as a purely promotional activity. Earlier perspectives, however, have more often framed place branding as a strategy for increasing a place's visibility and competitiveness (Anholt, 2010).

Within this framework, the study focuses on three core concepts of place branding: stakeholder involvement, place identity and place image. Stakeholders include both internal actors, such as residents, investors and local businesses, and external actors, such as visitors (Kavaratzis & Ashworth, 2010; Stoica et al., 2022). Place identity and place image are closely connected to stakeholder involvement, as stakeholders contribute both to how a place understands itself and how it is perceived by others. Place identity refers to the attributes and characteristics that define a place and distinguish it from others, while place image describes the attributes, expectations and feelings that people associate with a place based on perceptions and experiences (Matlovičová, 2024). Stakeholder perspectives therefore connect the internal understanding of a place with its external perception.

In small communities, such as Saltstraumen, tourism development does not operate independently of residents' everyday lives and externally promoted images may emphasise qualities that do not fully reflect the local values. When economic growth and visitor attraction are prioritised, tensions may arise if community-defined values such as environmental protection and quality of life are given secondary priority. This may result in a misalignment between the internal identity and the externally communicated image. In such contexts, the distinction between place identity and place image becomes more than a theoretical concept, as it shapes how branding strategies are perceived and negotiated within the community. These dynamics suggest that the relationship between place identity and place image involves tensions that complicate simplified understandings of branding as a tool for competitiveness and external attractiveness.

The tension described above has increasingly been recognised in recent place branding research. Studies have identified connections between place branding and sustainable development, suggesting that branding may contribute to social, economic and environmental sustainability (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025). However, the implications for social and environmental sustainability in tourism-dependent communities remain less fully explored.
The growing focus on sustainability has encouraged researchers to question how places are branded, for whom branding strategies are developed, and whose interests they ultimately serve. These questions advanced the conscientious branding perspective, which centres on stakeholder inclusion, fairness, responsibility and a transformative purpose in brand development.

1.1.2 Conscientious branding theory

In small tourism-dependent communities, such as Saltstraumen, where economic ambitions intersect with environmental protection and community well-being, questions arise about whose interests branding strategies ultimately serve. As discussed in the place branding section, tensions may emerge between internal place identity and externally promoted images, particularly when competitiveness and external attractiveness are prioritised (Anholt, 2010). The increasing emphasis on stakeholder involvement and sustainability in place branding research therefore invites considerations of how branding may move beyond promotion and competitiveness toward a more ethically grounded conception of branding as part of broader social and environmental processes.

Conscientious branding offers such a perspective by integrating ethical values (beyond regular corporate social responsibility initiatives) into strategic decision-making while prioritizing long-term social and environmental considerations (Tjandra, et al., 2025). Emerging in the early 2000s as a response to what some researchers viewed as an increasingly narrow and self-absorbed direction in branding, conscientious branding shifts attention from purely economic performance to a more stakeholder-oriented and socially accountable approach (Ind & Ryder, 2011). As a theory originally derived from corporate branding, it has been defined as "the strategic purpose that drives an open, inclusive, and participatory stakeholder-driven creation of value that considers the long-term social, environmental and socio-political consequences of a brand's actions" (Guzmán et al., 2024, p. 138). The definition suggests that branding extends beyond communication or market positioning into processes through which value is defined and responsibility negotiated over time.

Central to conscientious branding theory is the idea that branding is guided by a transformative purpose and grounded in a belief system that prioritizes stakeholder fairness, openness and temporal responsibility. Transformative purpose implies that branding extends beyond profit and contributes to long-term societal goals; it treats brands as actors with a moral purpose for social and environmental well-being (Tjandra et al., 2025). The belief system provides a moral foundation that guides strategic choices beyond economic goals and the theory suggests that these principles can be expressed through concrete economic,

environmental and social practices. Tracking measurable impact allows the theory to illustrate how commitments and progress can be observed by stakeholders (Tjandra et al., 2025). This theoretical foundation also emphasizes the role of stakeholders. These principles are not realized in isolation but through active engagement with those affected by branding decisions.

A key concept within conscientious branding is co-creation, which refers to the involvement of internal and external stakeholders participating in shaping values and being engaged in strategic decision-making (Hatch & Schultz, 2010; Ramaswamy & Ozcan, 2016; Iglesias & Ind, 2020). Co-creation extends beyond consultation or feedback; it involves stakeholders having genuine influence over which values, priorities, and environmental or social concerns are addressed within branding processes (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Iglesias et al., 2023; Grimm et al., 2025). Conscientious branding cannot be developed through a purely top-down approach, but requires the active inclusion of different stakeholder groups (Iglesias & Ind, 2020). This approach broadens the focus of branding from primarily shareholders or consumers toward understanding how multiple stakeholder interests are represented and how value is co-created across these groups.

In the context of place branding in tourist-dependent communities, such as Saltstraumen, conscientious branding offers a lens for understanding how branding interacts with internal place identity, external place image and sustainable development. Through ethical responsibility, inclusive stakeholder engagement and transformative purpose, conscientious branding provides ways to balance tourism with the well-being of the community and the environment. The marine ecosystem in Saltstraumen, for example, could be viewed either as a stakeholder with its own interests (Kortetmäki et al., 2023) or a shared concern of other internal stakeholders such as residents and local businesses. Driscoll and Starik (2004) discuss that non-human nature is what forms the broader context within which all human business takes place and based on this perspective would function as a stakeholder due to its embedded role in all economic activity. Saltstraumen is known for its maelstrom as well as for the fishing (Alt om Saltstraumen, n.d.; Visit Norway, n.d.a), which makes the natural environment a central part of the destination's current identity within the local tourism system. Building on the idea of co-creation, this perspective shows that branding is part of wider social and environmental systems, where the decisions and interactions of stakeholders shape both how the place is understood and how it develops over time within its surrounding environment. Understanding these dynamics in Saltstraumen provides the theoretical foundation for exploring the challenges of balancing tourism growth with environmental and social priorities.

1.2 Problem Discussion

As discussed in the introduction, tourism development raises questions about how places can balance economic opportunities with social and environmental concerns (Mihalic, 2020). While tourism can support local economies, growing visitor numbers may also place pressure on local communities and ecosystems through congestion, environmental degradation and pressure on local infrastructure (Seraphin et al., 2018; Ntalakos et al., 2025). In small

tourism-dependent places such as Saltstraumen, these dynamics can become particularly visible because tourism development intersects closely with residents' everyday lives and with fragile local ecosystems (Lukman et al., 2022). These challenges suggest that it is necessary to look beyond tourism management alone and examine how destinations are represented through branding. The way a destination is promoted can influence the type of tourism it attracts and therefore shape how tourism develops over time. As research increasingly looks beyond a narrow focus on economic outcomes and tourism competitiveness, the literature also has begun to consider how destinations can maintain both community well-being and environmental quality, as well as addressing the question of who these places are truly for (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025).

As Saltstraumen is currently at a stage where the direction of future tourism development remains relatively open, an important question concerns how the area can balance economic opportunities with the preservation of its sensitive marine environment and the well-being of the local population. Place branding that encourages increased visitation without considering the limitations of a protected marine environment could risk contributing to tourism pressures that threaten the very qualities that make Saltstraumen attractive to visitors. Place branding has traditionally been used as a competitive tool to differentiate destinations and increase their attractiveness to visitors and other businesses (Anholt, 2010; Cleave et al., 2016). Although sustainability considerations have increasingly been acknowledged in place branding research, scholars argue that such concerns are often incorporated as extra objectives rather than fundamentally reshaping how branding processes are organised or whose interests they prioritise (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025).

Another challenge, visible in tourism communities such as Saltstraumen, concerns how different stakeholders are represented within place branding processes. Stakeholders in place branding include a range of internal and external actors whose interests may influence branding strategies (Stoica et al., 2022). However, these actors do not always have equal influence in shaping place brands and actors with stronger economic interests may sometimes receive greater attention. At the same time, the natural environment itself is rarely considered a proper stakeholder within place branding processes, despite being a central element of many destinations' identities and attractiveness. As mentioned by Driscoll and Starik (2004), as non-human nature is what forms the broader context within where all human business takes place, it would position the environment as part of the stakeholder system surrounding business activities. For Saltstraumen the tidal current and fishing are two recognized elements of the destination's attractiveness (Alt om Saltstraumen, n.d.; Visit Norway, n.d.a). But unlike human stakeholders, the environment cannot directly participate in decision-making processes or express its own interests. This limitation is especially clear in Saltstraumen, where the marine environment is often treated more as a resource for tourism promotion than as a stakeholder with interests or considerations, as Norway allows fishing within marine protected areas (Bergstrøm, 2021). Conscientious branding, in contrast, advocates for the importance of stakeholder fairness (Tjandra et al., 2025), which could also involve greater consideration of environmental interests within branding decisions.

Balancing the interests of different stakeholders has proven to be challenging in place branding practice. Branding strategies may emphasise certain characteristics of a destination to attract visitors, while residents' experiences and values may point to different priorities (Hay et al., 2022). In the case of Saltstraumen, residents have expressed concerns about environmental impacts as well as feelings of being overlooked in favour of tourism development (Prologue et al., 2023). Such situations may create a mismatch between the internal identity of a place and the external image promoted to visitors, which can weaken the authenticity and long-term effectiveness of place branding (Kavaratzis & Hatch, 2013). Research has also shown that visitors may experience lower satisfaction when there is a significant gap between the marketed image of a destination and its actual identity (Nogueira & Carvalho, 2024). When place brands are developed primarily through top-down processes without meaningful stakeholder engagement, they may therefore achieve short-term visibility but struggle to remain viable over time (Hay et al., 2022).

Co-creation, a central concept in conscientious branding (Iglesias & Ind, 2020), argues that stakeholders should participate in shaping brand values and strategic priorities. Although stakeholder involvement is also recognised as important in place branding research, scholars have called for more participatory approaches regarding the involvement of residents in the co-creation of brands for destination (Hay et al., 2022). However, as participation in place branding processes is not always evenly distributed, it raises questions about whose voices are represented in the development of place brands. In Saltstraumen internal stakeholders have reported that they do not feel fully listened to in tourism-related discussions (Prologue et al., 2023). Research also suggests that prioritising residents' experiences and affective engagement is important when developing place brands that aim to be both more inclusive and sustainable (Golestaneh et al., 2022).

In the case of Saltstraumen, where tourism development creates both important economic opportunities and increasing social and environmental pressures, the transformative purpose in conscientious branding becomes relevant to consider. Rather than focusing primarily on economic outcomes and profit, conscientious branding places importance on long-term environmental and social well-being alongside the financial benefits (Tjandra et al., 2025). This perspective enables an examination of who the place is truly for, by shifting the focus from short-term visitor growth toward the long-term health of the community and its environment. Through principles such as stakeholder fairness, openness, and integrity and accountability, conscientious branding encourages branding processes that aim to balance the interests of different stakeholders. The transformative purpose therefore reframes branding as more than a communication strategy. It positions branding as a process that can influence how places evolve over time.

Taken together, the issues of Saltstraumen discussed above point towards a general question concerning how tourism-dependent communities can approach place branding in situations where tourism development creates both opportunities and tensions, that take local communities and long-term sustainability into account. Saltstraumen provides a relevant case for examining this question and the study explores how a conscientious place branding

perspective can contribute to the development of place brands in tourism-dependent communities.

1.2.1 Theoretical lens

In place branding research, brands are often understood as dynamic and socially constructed, meaning that place identities develop through ongoing interactions between stakeholders and their interpretations of the place (Kavaratzis & Hatch, 2013). Based on this, changes in how a destination is branded may gradually influence both how the place is understood internally and perceived externally. A conscientious branding perspective suggests that such changes should occur through fair stakeholder involvement and co-creation, allowing stakeholders to participate in shaping the evolving place brand and the values it represents.

Despite increasing attention to sustainability and stakeholder participation in place branding research, limited studies have explored how the transformative purpose central to conscientious branding may influence the development of place identity and branding strategies in tourism-dependent communities. Traditional place branding has often prioritised competitiveness and visitor attractiveness (Anholt, 2010; Kotler et al., 1993; Swain, 2024). Emerging research on more participatory and sustainability-oriented approaches suggests that branding can also express community values and support long-term social and economic well-being (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020; Zenker & Erfgen, 2014). At the same time, research on sustainable place branding and conscientious tourism advocate for ethical, community-centred and environmentally responsible travel practices (Caruana et al., 2014; Gijsbers & Gonzalez Gutierrez de Leon, 2019; Pasquinelli & Kavaratzis, 2025; Rastegar, 2022), yet their translation into concrete place branding strategies remains limited. This indicates that insights from conscientious branding and place branding have not yet been systematically integrated, even though this perspective may be relevant for destinations like Saltstraumen, where the direction of future tourism development is still open and contested.

The theoretical contribution of the thesis lies in exploring the concept of conscientious place branding, an emerging research concept used in this thesis to name the integration of place branding and conscientious branding theory, by examining what this bridge looks like in practice and what it offers to destinations navigating the tensions between tourism development, community well-being and environmental responsibility. Place branding research has not fully explored how conscientious branding principles can reshape place branding processes and influence the development of place identity in small tourism communities. By examining these dynamics in the context of Saltstraumen, this thesis contributes to a deeper understanding of how branding can move beyond its traditional role as a competitive marketing tool and instead function as a more inclusive and ethically grounded process that supports sustainable tourism development. The practical contribution relates to providing insights for destinations such as Saltstraumen that are seeking to balance tourism development with environmental protection and community well-being. In doing so, the study addresses the broader question of how place branding can evolve beyond a competitive

marketing tool toward a more transformative approach that works across the three dimensions of economy, environmental and social sustainability. These considerations raise the question of how principles from conscientious branding can be integrated into place branding processes in tourism-dependent communities such as Saltstraumen.

This study focuses on internal stakeholders, such as residents, local businesses and public actors, as they are directly embedded in the local context and central to place development processes. Due to time and scope limitations, external stakeholders such as tourists and visitors are not included, and a more extensive study would be required to capture their perspectives.

1.3 Purpose and Research questions

The purpose of this thesis is to explore how conscientious branding theory can be integrated with place branding in small tourism communities. Using Saltstraumen in northern Norway as a case study, the study examines local stakeholder perceptions of tourism development, place identity and stakeholder engagement in Saltstraumen. By drawing on insights from conscientious branding theory, the research aims to contribute to the emerging discussion on conscientious place branding and to provide insights into how ethically grounded branding approaches may help tourism destinations develop branding strategies that balance economic development with community well-being and long-term sustainability. How these three relate to one another; whether they are best understood as weights to be balanced against each other, or whether one of them stands in a different relation to the others, is itself part of what the case is asked to surface.

Overall research question: In what way can a conscientious place branding perspective support the development of place brands in tourism-dependent communities?

Four sub-research questions follow from this overall question. They are derived from the literature review and stated at its close (section 2.6).

1.4 Delimitations

This thesis is subject to several delimitations. First, the empirical focus is on Saltstraumen as a single case; while the aim is to explore insights relevant for other small, tourism-oriented communities, the findings are not intended to be statistically generalisable beyond this context. This is in line with qualitative case study research, where the aim is not statistical generalisation but instead to develop in-depth understanding of a specific context and generate insights that may be transferable to similar settings. Second, the study concentrates on internal stakeholders, primarily residents, local businesses and local authorities, and does not investigate tourist perceptions or external market positioning. Third, the focus is on the strategic and participatory processes of developing a conscientious place brand, rather than on designing specific marketing campaigns or evaluating detailed economic impacts. Finally, the research is cross-sectional, capturing stakeholder perceptions and branding possibilities at one

point in time within a 20-week thesis period. These delimitations are necessary to keep the project feasible and to maintain a clear focus on stakeholder participation, community values and the potential of conscientious place branding in a tourism-dependent community.

2. Literature Review

A literature review brings together and evaluates existing research on a specific topic. It is one of the important early steps in a thesis research project, as it provides a foundation for the study and helps to identify gaps in current knowledge (Knopf, 2006). This study is grounded in two main theoretical areas: place branding and conscientious branding. The review first explores place branding and its key concepts, followed by conscientious branding and its core principles. It then examines how these two perspectives relate to each other, and based on this the review develops propositions for a conscientious place branding perspective and presents the conceptual framework for the study. The literature review also forms the basis for the sub-research questions, as these are derived from the themes and gaps identified in a literature review. The review is primarily based on peer-reviewed academic articles found through the LTU library database EBSCO, and also to a lesser extent Google Scholar. Searched keywords included for example "place branding," "place identity," "place image," "co-creation," and "conscientious branding," used both individually and in combination. The focus has been mainly on research published from 2020 onwards, while also including earlier studies that are highly cited, particularly relevant for the topic or written by key authors in the field showcased in Table 1 below.

Table 1

Key authors and concepts

	Place branding	**Conscientious branding**
Central concern	Building and managing a place's identity and image to support competitiveness, attractiveness and stakeholder value	Embedding ethical purpose, fairness and accountability into how a brand is built and governed
Key constructs	Place identity, place image, stakeholder participation, co-creation, the place brand as socially constructed and dynamic	Transformative public purpose, stakeholder fairness and well-being, integrity and accountability, participatory co-creation
Key authors	Kavaratzis; Kavaratzis & Hatch; Zenker & Erfgen; Ripoll González & Gale; Klijn et al.	Iglesias & Ind; Tjandra et al.; Markovic et al.; Pasquinelli & Kavaratzis;
Main overlap	Both treat the brand as co-created with stakeholders rather than imposed, and both increasingly admit values beyond competitiveness	
Main divergence	Place branding centres the	Conscientious branding

	place and its positioning; accountability and ethical purpose are secondary	centres ethical purpose and accountability; it is developed for organisations with a single identifiable author, not places
Where they meet	Section 2.6 synthesises the two into a conscientious place branding framework.	

2.1 Place branding

Place branding has developed into a broad and interdisciplinary field that goes beyond traditional marketing perspectives. This section reviews the evolution of place branding research and introduces its key concepts, including stakeholder participation and co-creation, place identity and place image. These concepts are central to understanding how place brands are developed and shaped over time. Mihalis Kavaratzis is one of the key contributors to this field, and although several of his works were published prior to 2020, they remain highly relevant and are often cited in contemporary studies in the field.

2.1.1 Evolution of the place branding research

This section outlines how place branding research has developed from the early 1990s to the 2020s, focusing on the main ideas relevant to this study. It begins with reviewing earlier research on place branding mainly as a promotional tool to attract tourists, moves on to literature on city branding and relationship networks, followed by place image and identity, increased focus on stakeholder involvement and co-creation. The section concludes with more recent discussion on sustainability and inclusion in place branding.

Research on place branding has existed since the late 1980s and early 1990s, with academic interest increasing from around 2008 and onwards. Early research in the 1990s largely focused on the use of marketing strategies to construct a positive place image of destinations in order to influence tourists' preferences and destination choices (Swain, 2024). Work by scholars such as Kotler and Crompton helped shape this early perspective on destination and tourism marketing. Crompton and Ankomah (1993), for instance, describe destination selection as a multi-stage decision process in which tourists gradually narrow down a large number of possible destinations into a smaller set of preferred alternatives. This perspective suggests that destinations must strategically position themselves to remain within tourists' consideration sets throughout the decision-making process. Similarly, Kotler et al. (1993) argued that destinations have to identify and communicate their unique competitive advantages in order to attract visitors. At the same time, they already recognised the potential paradox of tourism success, that excessive tourism growth may lead to environmental degradation, infrastructure pressure, congestion and social disruption. This insight is relevant for destinations such as Saltstraumen, where the natural environment forms the core of the tourism offering but also requires careful protection due to its status as a marine reserve. These early discussions therefore demonstrate the importance of considering the long-term

consequences of tourism development and not only focus on competitiveness, unchecked growth may undermine the very qualities that make places attractive.

During the early 2000s, place branding research began to move beyond purely promotional perspectives and developed more structured conceptual frameworks for understanding how place brands are formed. Scholars increasingly examined how destinations could strategically build associations with visitors through elements such as entertainment or food. Later in the decade, the research focus shifted further toward measuring brand equity and identifying the factors influencing how city and destination brands are perceived by visitors (Swain, 2024). The influential author on place branding over the years, Kavaratzis, proposed an early framework for understanding city branding. Kavaratzis (2004) argued that city branding serves a dual function: on the one hand, it supports economic policy by helping cities attract investment and tourism in an increasingly competitive global environment, and on the other hand, it contributes to strengthening residents' sense of local identity and belonging. This perspective expanded the understanding of place branding by recognising that branding processes influence not only external audiences but also internal communities.

Another important contribution from this period is Hankinson's (2004) relational network model of place brands. Earlier studies had often referred to "destination branding" or "city branding" without conceptualising place branding as a proper term with a distinct framework. Hankinson (2004) argued that place brands should be understood as relational networks rather than as traditional product brands. In this model the core of the brand represents the identity of the place and acts as a foundation for developing and communicating the brand. This core identity is shaped by elements such as brand personality, positioning and the reality of the place, which personality and positioning having to remain realistic. The brand core is then connected to several relationship networks, including consumer relationships, media relationships, infrastructure relationships and primary service relationships such as hotels, attractions and events. By conceptualising place brands as networks of relationships, Hankinson argued that branding outcomes are shaped through interactions between multiple actors rather than through the actions of a single marketing authority. Together, the frameworks developed by Kavaratzis (2004) and Hankinson (2004) contributed to expanding place branding research beyond a narrow marketing perspective and introduced the importance of relationships and stakeholders in the branding process.

During the 2010s, place branding research increasingly focused on the psychological and emotional dimensions of destination brands. Scholars explored the concept of destination brand personality and its influence on tourists' decision-making processes. Research suggested that when the perceived personality of a destination aligns with tourists' own personality traits, a sense of self-congruity is created, which in turn may strengthen tourists' intentions to revisit the destination and increase brand loyalty (Swain, 2024). Building on this idea, Daye (2010) claimed that successful destination brands should communicate more than the physical attributes of a place. As tourists increasingly seek meaningful experiences, strong brands must also convey symbolic meanings, emotions and values that resonate with visitors'

lifestyles and own values. Place branding therefore becomes a way of communicating what a place represents, rather than simply promoting what it offers physically.

Identity and image in relation to place brands had already been introduced prior in earlier decade studies, for example by Hankinson (2004), and building on this shift toward more socially embedded perspectives, Kavaratzis and Hatch (2013) introduced an identity-based approach to place branding that significantly influenced later research in the field. Their framework conceptualises place identity as a dynamic process shaped through ongoing dialogue between internal stakeholders, such as residents and local organisations, and external perceptions (from for example visitors) of the place. Grounded in organisational identity theory, the authors explain how place culture, place identity and image interact in shaping place brands over time. This perspective moved the field fully away from viewing place branding as a purely promotional activity and instead conceptualized branding as an ongoing social process involving multiple stakeholders. Related studies by Braun et al. (2013) and Zenker and Erfgen (2014) further discussed the important role of residents as active participants and ambassadors of place brands, which can influence how places are perceived by visitors.

Later research in the 2010s continued to develop these ideas by emphasising collaboration, storytelling and co-creation in place branding processes. Scholars examined how place brands emerge through interactions between different stakeholder groups rather than through top-down marketing strategies alone. Collaborative stakeholder engagement has been linked to the co-creation of value and to strengthening the identity and visibility of destinations in the global tourism market (Swain, 2024). Stakeholders taking part in the place branding process with a bottom-up approach, sometimes referred to as participatory place branding, foreground the role of residents and local stakeholders in shaping how places are represented (Zenker & Erfgen, 2014). Similarly, Kavaratzis and Kalandides (2015) argue that stakeholder participation can increase the legitimacy of place brands and for the brand to be effective it should be co-created with the people who live at the place. Research also suggests that storytelling can serve as a tool for co-creation, allowing stakeholders to collaboratively construct narratives that represent the identity of a place (Stoica et al., 2022). These developments reinforce the idea that place brands are not simply designed by marketing authorities but instead emerge through complex interactions between multiple actors.

More recent research from the 2020s has increasingly focused on sustainability, more inclusivity and ethical considerations within place branding. Some studies argue that sustainability should be understood as a multidimensional concept that includes environmental, social and economic aspects rather than focusing solely on economic growth (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025). However, current research suggests that sustainability is not yet fully integrated into place branding theory and practice. For example, Aguilera-Cora and Fernández-Cavia (2025) found that connections between place branding and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are still relatively limited, and sustainability initiatives are often incorporated as complementary elements rather than as core components of branding strategies. Recent discussions of more inclusive place branding also address

questions of accessibility, participation and justice in tourism development. This perspective considers who has access to destinations, who benefits from tourism development and who is able to participate in branding and development processes (Kraff et al., 2025). Earlier research on stakeholder collaboration and co-creation is extended by prioritizing justice and representation in place branding. This shift reflects how place branding has moved beyond a primarily marketing-oriented activity toward a more complex process shaped by social interaction and stakeholder engagement.

When considering the evolution of place branding research, several themes emerge as central to understanding how place brands are formed and developed. In particular the concepts of stakeholder participation, co-creation, place identity and place image have become increasingly prominent in the literature. These concepts illustrate how place branding has evolved from a primarily marketing-oriented activity toward a more complex process involving social interaction and stakeholder engagement. As stakeholder participation has become a central element in contemporary place branding research, it is therefore important to examine more closely how stakeholders influence the development and representation of place brands.

2.1.2 Stakeholders and place branding

Stakeholder theory provides a foundation for understanding the role of different actors in place branding processes. Freeman defines stakeholders as "any group or individual who can affect or is affected by the achievement of the organisation's objectives" (Freeman, 1984 as cited in Hillebrand et al., 2015, p. 413). Originally developed within organizational management literature, stakeholder theory considers groups such as employees, investors, suppliers, customers, governments and communities as actors whose interests influence organisational decision-making (Donaldson & Preston, 1995). Places however differ from corporations in important ways. Unlike corporations, places are not controlled by a single organisation and the place stakeholders are often not bound by formal contractual relationships. Instead places consist of diverse actors who interact in more complex and loosely structured governance systems. In the context of place branding stakeholders are therefore commonly understood to include both internal and external actors connected to the place who can influence branding processes, such as residents, local businesses, investors, authorities, communities and visitors (Kavaratzis & Ashworth, 2010; Stoica et al., 2022).

Within place branding research, stakeholders are widely recognised as central to the development of place brands. Kavaratzis (2012) argues that place branding is driven by stakeholders, as they collectively shape what a place represents and how it is managed. Based on this perspective, a place brand does not belong solely to marketing organisations or municipalities, but rather belong to the stakeholders. This understanding is further developed by Kavaratzis and Hatch (2013), who conceptualise place branding as a continuous process in which place identity, place image and local culture of the place are shaped through ongoing dialogue among stakeholders. Place brands emerge through the interaction between internal stakeholders, such as residents, businesses and community organisations and external actors

including visitors and investors. The nature of a place brand is that it is co-created and managed by a wide range of stakeholders who collectively contribute meaning to the brand (Braun et al., 2013; Kavaratzis, 2012). More recent research supports this view, suggesting that place branding developed through collaboration among local stakeholders demonstrates branding as a collective process shaped by community participation rather than it being marketing-driven (Logar, 2025).

When stakeholders are involved in the branding process, they are more likely to develop a sense of belonging and commitment to the place and its brand (Braun et al., 2013; Golestaneh et al., 2022; Ripoll González et al., 2024). This involvement can foster stronger emotional connections between stakeholders and the brand and increase their willingness to support and promote it (Hakala, 2021). Also, collaborative branding processes can contribute to clearer and more coherent branding strategies, while also increasing the overall performance in the effectiveness of attractiveness of the destination for external audiences such as tourists (Klijn et al., 2012). These findings indicate that active stakeholder participation can strengthen both the legitimacy and long-term effectiveness of place branding initiatives.

Because place branding is shaped through collaboration between multiple actors, internal stakeholders often hold important roles in the branding process. Golestaneh et al. (2022) argue that place brands are largely formed through the experiences of internal stakeholders who adopt and co-create the brand in their daily lives, rather than through traditional promotional campaigns alone. For this reason, it is important that internal stakeholders feel represented and acknowledged within place branding processes. Although many place branding strategies primarily target external audiences such as tourists, internal stakeholders in general play an important role in defining and delivering the place brand in practice. Engaging stakeholders early in the development process has been shown to strengthen support for the brand and contribute to more sustainable and widely accepted branding outcomes (Ripoll González et al., 2024). But, because places consist of diverse groups with varying interests and values, it poses a challenge to represent all perspectives equally.

2.1.3 Challenges in stakeholder representativeness

Place branding is shaped by many different actors, some of whom directly influence how the place is perceived, while others form part of the broader network that supports and maintains the brand over time. Because multiple groups are involved in decision-making and coordination, place branding can take the form of a governance process. Studies on governance indicate that involving stakeholders influences the achievement of effective outcomes in branding (Klijn et al., 2012). However, including multiple stakeholder perspectives does not eliminate tensions within place branding processes, but is instead a source of tensions. Research shows that stakeholders may hold different, and sometimes conflicting, views about the purpose and meaning of place branding initiatives (Källström & Siljeklint, 2024). These differences introduce the politics between stakeholders into the place branding processes, as considering all different perspectives of every stakeholder complicates brand development. Kavaratzis and Kalandides (2015) mention that place branding involves

functioning as a selective political process. Place branding would therefore operate in a political context and this places municipalities and local authorities in an influential position when deciding whose voices are included in branding initiatives. Some stakeholders may be more influential due to their roles, their access to resources or their established networks, which create differences in how decisions are shaped. In the place branding process, different internal stakeholders (local businesses, residents, authorities) do not always have the same level of influence (Reynolds et al., 2022; Hay, 2022).

Who benefits from tourism and who gets access to opportunities to participate in the branding and development processes (Kraff et al., 2025) can further illustrate the differences in influence and selection among stakeholders. Some stakeholders gain influence in the branding process through their networks and resources. Research shows that stakeholders' influence in place branding can be shaped by the capital (cultural and social) they possess. Cultural knowledge and skills contribute to giving them authority. For example, stakeholders may use general know-how about branding or specific knowledge about the local area to make their voices heard (Reynolds et al., 2022). According to Marzano and Scott (2009), authority is an important part of the political dynamics between stakeholders in place branding. Some actors hold formal authority based on organisational roles or legal responsibilities, while others gain influence through their knowledge or personal engagement with the destination. Authority is also associated with access to resources, such as funding, which can be used to steer decisions in a particular direction (Reynolds et al., 2022; Marzano & Scott, 2009). Stakeholders in leadership positions may use their authority to guide branding in line with their own interests, at times excluding others from participation. Instead of reducing conflict, this use of authority could lead to tensions, as decisions are shaped by a smaller group of influential actors (Marzano & Scott, 2009). This indicates that authority play an important role in influence in the branding process, but social capital has to also be considered.

Social capital includes connections and relationships that allow stakeholders to work through the branding process and maintain influence. Similar to authority, social capital can reinforce exclusion, as established and recognised social networks may give certain stakeholders greater ability to shape outcomes, and leave others with fewer opportunities (Reynolds et al., 2022). Persuasion also plays a role in these dynamics and can be used as a form of social power in place branding. Instead of decisions being shaped through equal participation, some stakeholders may influence outcomes by convincing others to support particular ideas. This involves maintaining strategic relationships or using language and rhetorical skills. Because of this, decisions are more shaped by those able to persuade others than through open discussions and mutual agreements (Marzano & Scott, 2009). Influence in place branding is unevenly distributed and that outcomes are more likely to be shaped by those who have knowledge and a stronger network (Reynolds et al., 2022).

Apart from cultural and social capital, the greater power structures in society also shape stakeholder influence. Stakeholders with greater economic or political power, such as businesses, property owners or political authorities, may receive greater attention within

branding initiatives, while the perspectives of residents and other local actors may be overlooked. When such imbalances occur, the resulting brand identity can fail to reflect the meanings and emotional connections that residents associate with the place (Hay, 2022). Power imbalances between stakeholders can therefore create challenges for place branding initiatives. If the interests of less influential stakeholders, such as regular residents, are overshadowed by those of more powerful stakeholders, place branding may be perceived as lacking legitimacy and may function primarily as a political or commercial tool rather than as a genuine representation of the destination and its community (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015). In such cases, economic interests may dominate branding strategies, while the well-being and perspectives of local communities receive less attention. However, place branding initiatives are less likely to succeed if residents do not feel connected to the brand or do not support the branding strategy. Studies suggest that resident engagement is linked to the long-term sustainability of place branding initiatives (Hay, 2022).

2.1.4 Participation and inclusiveness

These challenges have led to increased attention on more inclusive and participatory approaches to place branding. Kavaratzis (2012) discusses place branding processes that involve reconsidering which actors are given the opportunity to participate, with a focus on stakeholders with weaker voices to also be included in the decision-making processes. It draws attention toward broader stakeholder perspectives within tourism development and place branding initiatives. Research suggests having a stronger focus on resident participation in place branding processes instead of prioritizing external audiences such as visitors or investors (Styvén et al., 2020). Although participatory branding approaches are increasingly discussed in the literature, questions remain regarding whose voices are actually included in branding processes and whether all stakeholder groups are given the equal opportunities to influence branding decisions. Golestaneh et al. (2022) note that place branding strategies often emphasise social interaction and shared experiences among stakeholders as part of more inclusive place brands.

The challenges also influence the role of public authorities and destination managers within place branding processes. Rather than acting as traditional top-down decision-makers, scholars increasingly argue that place branding leaders may take on the role of facilitators of stakeholder dialogue (Kavaratzis, 2012). In this role managers coordinate collaboration between different stakeholders instead of attempting to control the brand themselves. The role is described as to stimulate dialogue and participation in the co-creation process as an equal partner, with focus on engagement (Kavaratzis & Hatch, 2013; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). This reflects a shift to more open communication among the actors involved in the process as well as the coordinating of top-down initiatives that would reflect the needs and expectations of other stakeholders (Braun et al., 2013; Stoica et al., 2022). Participatory governance and resident involvement have been linked to increased legitimacy and inclusiveness in place branding processes (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015).

However, existing power imbalances often shape how participation is organised in practice, and not all stakeholders participate actively in co-creation processes. Stakeholders may feel that participation would have little impact when they lack influence or authority within branding initiatives (Ripoll González & Gale, 2020), which illustrates the difficulties of including stakeholders with weaker voices in branding processes (Kavaratzis, 2012). Inclusiveness in place branding also relates to broader questions of justice, representation and fairness. Kraff et al. (2025) discuss inclusive place branding initiatives in relation to issues such as power, agency and accountability that promote fair participation among different stakeholder groups. They note that attention to representative diversity may be linked to more inclusive and sustainable development of places. However, the extent to which such diversity is achieved depends on how power relations, networks, social and/or cultural capital shape participation and determine whose input is given weight in the place branding process. Alongside this there are also stakeholders who may view branding primarily as the responsibility of municipalities or tourism authorities and may therefore have limited interest in becoming involved in branding processes themselves (Källström & Siljeklint, 2024).

As collective and publicly shared brands, place brands are therefore continuously shaped through the interactions of multiple stakeholders. Through these interactions, the meanings associated with a place are negotiated and renegotiated over time. Research suggests that place branding initiatives should generate benefits for several different groups connected to the place, rather than prioritising the interests of only a limited number of actors (Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). This assumes that stakeholder interests can be balanced in practice, even though place branding involves political decision-making processes where unequal influence and selective inclusion may shape whose interests are prioritised. Stoica et al. (2022), for example, describe a case in which municipal actors selected particular residents from a place branding storytelling initiative because they conveyed the branding message the actors agreed with. The selective representation resulted in criticism from other residents who felt that their perspectives were excluded from the process. Such examples illustrate the importance of transparency and fairness in stakeholder engagement, as selective inclusion may undermine the legitimacy of place branding initiatives.

Understanding the role of stakeholders in shaping place brands reinforces the importance of examining how different actors contribute to defining what a place represents. This is where the concepts of place identity and place image become relevant, as they describe how places are internally understood by stakeholders and externally perceived by visitors and other audiences. The following section therefore explores the relationship between place identity and place image and their role in the development of place brands.

2.1.5 Place identity and place image

Identity and image are central concepts in branding research, originating from marketing theory where brand identity refers to the company's intended message and brand image reflects consumers' perceptions (Nandan, 2005). Aaker (1996, p. 68) defines brand identity as "a unique set of brand associations that the brand strategist aspires to create or maintain,"

while Keller (1993, p. 2) describes brand image as “the set of associations linked to the brand that consumers hold in memory.” In place branding these concepts have been adapted to reflect the interactions between a place, its residents and the external audiences. Unlike corporate brands, place identity is not solely constructed by managers; it emerges through continuous dialogue between internal and external stakeholders connected to a place (Kavaratzis & Hatch, 2013). Therefore place identity can be defined as “the process through which people, through interactions with places, identify themselves in terms of belonging to a specific place” (Matlovičová, 2024, p. 71). Because residents play an important role in representing the place brand, their perception and involvement in the branding process influence how the place's identity is maintained. This points to the role of local community involvement in place branding processes (Hay et al., 2022).

Place image in contrast represents how the place is perceived externally. Cheng and Zhang (2021, p. 532) define place image as “the comprehensive result of people’s experiences, beliefs, feelings, knowledge, and impressions with respect to a place.” While place identity tends to be a shared, collective perception held by a community, place image is more fragmented and could differ between individuals. For every person, the image of a place is a unique combination of personal experiences and emotional associations, making it a more subjective construct than identity (Matlovičová, 2024). This distinction can be understood by viewing place identity as the image produced by the place, while place image is the image received by the audience. The distinction becomes important when considering the identity-image gap, a common challenge in place branding. When the projected image of a place does not align with the reality lived by residents, external stakeholders may encounter a brand that feels inauthentic, leading to dissatisfaction or even damage to the place's reputation (Hudson et al., 2017; Matlovičová, 2024). Nogueira and Carvalho (2024) found that larger gaps between projected and perceived images correlated with lower satisfaction among visitors.

Furthermore, research has found that place brands are often defined by external stakeholders' perceptions (place brand image), instead of being rooted in the internal community's own values. This type of market-driven approach often leads to a place brand that reflects external visitors' expectations more than the actual identity of the residents, creating an authenticity gap between what is marketed and what is lived (Hay et al., 2022). The case of Hamburg illustrates these dynamics: by focusing on a stereotyped place image of creative and wealthy residents, they ignored the views of the general internal stakeholders living there. This top-down communication resulted in widespread distrust between residents and the municipality and social movements like “Not in our Name” were created. The case illustrates the risk of imposing a forced identity that residents do not recognize as their own just to attract tourists and it suggests that prioritizing external stakeholders perceptions over internal identity in place branding can lead to tensions and conflicts (Zenker & Petersen, 2014).

Such tensions are often related to how stakeholder involvement and co-creation are handled. Managers and local authorities play a role in facilitating bottom-up branding processes, where residents contribute to defining and communicating the place brand. If managers build a

brand from the top-down, they may create a brand image that does not match the actual place identity (Hudson et al., 2017). Research shows that incorporating residents' stories can strengthen the connection between identity and external image. When a brand represents the community's actual experiences, it becomes more closely connected to place identity, and with greater consistency between the identity and image factors it can contribute to a place brand being more in line with the community's own values (Hay et al., 2022; Hudson et al., 2017).

Internal stakeholders who feel represented and valued are more likely to act as organic place ambassadors who carry the place brand through daily interactions and routines (Braun et al., 2013). The willingness of stakeholders to contribute to and participate in place branding initiatives depends largely on their perception of the brand's worth and their own sense of belonging (Ripoll González et al., 2023). A strong sense of place identity, combined with perceived brand value, is linked to higher levels of engagement and long-term commitment to the brand.

Place identity and image are not static and therefore places are difficult to reduce to a single identity (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015). Because a place is defined by both its history and its physical location, it is constantly evolving, meaning that what a place represents to people is changing (Matlovičová, 2024). This indicates that a place's identity and image are not fixed and may change over time. Cheng and Zhang (2021) found in their study that change in the ownership of a bridge and capital flow to this bridge weakened the place's identity by depriving locals of meaningful social spaces that they felt was part of the identity. A place image focused primarily on economic goals and attracting investments often comes at the expense of the residents' social well-being and sense of belonging. As resident satisfaction is tied more closely to local heritage than to commercial growth, local identity is often treated as a foundational element when planning new development or image changes (Cheng & Zhang, 2021). The legitimacy of a new place image is linked to how it reflects the residents' existing identity. If development ignores this identity, it risks alienating the local population and making them feel like outsiders within their own village.

Change in place identity or image is not inherently bad, and when internal stakeholders participate meaningfully, modifications in identity and image can occur naturally and strengthen the place brand rather than creating conflict. Kavaratzis and Hatch (2013) argue that because place identity is dynamic and socially constructed through constant dialogues between stakeholders, the vision of a place remains flexible and subject to ongoing reconsideration. The way stakeholders interact, their values, experiences and perspectives change and evolve over time and therefore their understanding of the place may also gradually change. Re-evaluating the place brand vision over time would reflect interaction among stakeholders and support the continuous development of the place brand and its identity. Because place identities are shaped through multiple stakeholder perspectives, ongoing re-evaluations of the place brand may involve tensions over whose interpretations of the place become represented and legitimised within the branding process. Källström and Siljeklint (2024) mentioned that participants in a place branding process may hold different

values regarding who the branding should target, what its objectives should be, how stakeholders should participate and what the main purpose of place branding is.

The literature suggests that place identity and place image are socially constructed and continuously negotiated through stakeholder interactions. The internal perspectives of residents remain important, as they reflect the experiences and cultural meaning of a place. When branding strategies prioritise certain stakeholder interests or external tourism goals over local identities, tensions may arise between tourism development goals and the community's own understanding of the place. This way maintaining authenticity in place branding becomes a process of balancing competing stakeholder perspectives and negotiating which identities and values are represented within the brand. As authenticity in place branding is closely connected to residents' perceptions and their sense of belonging, excluding certain groups of residents or other local perspectives may weaken residents' overall connection to the place brand. Place branding therefore extends beyond external communication and depends on how different stakeholder perspectives are acknowledged and incorporated into branding decisions, as well as how these decisions influence the future development of the place.

For this study the concept of place identity helps with understanding issues that may emerge when branding and tourist development focus primarily on attracting visitors instead of reflecting the local communities' experiences. The literature on place branding suggests that when internal stakeholders are excluded from branding decisions, top-down branding processes can create strong resistance, sometimes resulting in the revision of place branding to better align with internal stakeholder identities. This is illustrated by the "Not in our Name" campaign in Hamburg where exclusion from branding decisions led to opposition from residents. For emerging destinations such as Saltstraumen, where a place brand has not been established yet, there is potential to include residents' voices from the beginning. With Saltstraumen not yet having a place brand, understanding the current residents' sense of identity may help with identifying the values and priorities that could guide place branding efforts. But when taking multiple stakeholder perceptions into account, tensions could arise between the different stakeholder priorities and the economic development goals of the place
As discussed in section 2.1.2, stakeholders' voices and priorities are often valued and listened to differently, which complicates decision-making and the inclusion of multiple stakeholder groups. This gives rise to questions about how place branding processes can address issues of fairness and long-term value creation when stakeholder influence is unevenly distributed. The following section introduces Conscientious branding theory as a framework for exploring these issues more in depth.

2.2 Conscientious branding

Conscientious branding has developed over the last decade as a response to the perceived limitations of corporate social responsibility (CSR), sustainability programmes and generic brand purpose initiatives that often remain peripheral to core strategy. Rather than denoting a bundle of philanthropic activities, it frames conscience as a guiding belief system or moral

compass that shapes how brands define their purpose, relate to stakeholders and handle strategic trade-offs over time (Ind & Iglesias, 2022). Conscientious branding therefore seeks to integrate ethical reflection and responsibility into the heart of brand management while acknowledging that brands continue to operate in competitive, profit-seeking markets (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Tjandra et al., 2025).

2.2.1 Origins and evolution

The idea of attaching "conscience" to organisations begins before its application to brands, but conscientious branding entered branding literature through a 2011 special issue of the *Journal of Brand Management* on "conscientious brands" (Ind & Ryder, 2011). Early work in that issue identified themes that remain central: a stakeholder orientation, dissatisfaction with CSR as an often reputational and tangential activity, the importance of long-term horizons, and an explicitly human-centric view of business (Olsen & Peretz, 2011; Rindell et al., 2011).

After a relative lull, Iglesias and Ind's (2020) commentary on conscientious corporate brand co-creation re-booted the construct by locating conscience explicitly at the level of the corporate brand and connecting it to co-creation with multiple stakeholders. Subsequent contributions include conceptual frameworks, empirical tests and edited collections that extend the idea into B2B contexts and internal branding (Abratt & Kleyn, 2023; Biedenbach, 2025; Markovic et al., 2023; Tjandra et al., 2025). This body of work now treats conscientious branding as a distinct, though still emerging, stream within corporate branding and brand ethics.

2.2.2 Core definitional elements

Despite some variation in emphasis, recent syntheses identify a shared core of what makes a brand conscientious. First, conscientious brands are said to be guided by a transformative purpose: an articulated raison d'être, oriented not only to market differentiation but to making a positive social and/or environmental contribution. Second, they are based on a set of guiding principles or values that inform decisions about what the brand will and won't do in situations of ambiguity or conflict (Ind & Iglesias, 2022).

Third, Tjandra et al. (2025) argue that conscientious brands tend to share three cross-cutting commitments, regardless of sector or category: stakeholder fairness, temporal responsibility and organisational openness. Stakeholder fairness refers to efforts to balance the legitimate interests of multiple stakeholder groups rather than defaulting to shareholder primacy (Iglesias & Ind, 2020). Temporal responsibility captures a willingness to privilege long-term social and environmental value over short-term gains where these conflict. Organisational openness, finally, denotes a readiness to engage in dialogue, expose decisions to public scrutiny and accept stakeholder challenge as part of brand governance (Iglesias et al., 2023; Tjandra et al., 2025).

These elements differentiate conscientious branding from more instrumental approaches to responsibility or purpose. Whereas CSR is often criticised as a reputation-oriented add-on that

leaves core practices untouched, conscience is presented as an overarching guiding mindset that shapes how organisations approach CSR, sustainability and purpose rather than being reducible to any one of these domains (Golob & Podnar, 2019; Iglesias & Ind, 2020).

2.2.3 The conscientious corporate brand (CCB)

Within this broader stream, the conscientious corporate brand (CCB) crystallises the construct at the corporate level. Abratt and Kleyn (2023) define a CCB as a corporate brand that stakeholders perceive as prioritising ethical leadership and co-creation across all value-chain activities in ways that contribute to social and environmental sustainability. Building on earlier work by Rindell et al. (2011), they propose a framework in which organisational purpose, ethical organisational culture, stakeholder co-creation and the ethical expression of value-chain activities jointly shape perceptions of a conscientious corporate brand (Abratt & Kleyn, 2023).

Empirically, Abratt et al. (2025) show that organisational purpose, understood as a long-term "why" that extends beyond profit, has a positive effect on stakeholder perceptions of a brand as conscientious, even when purpose is only moderately strong, with brand authenticity mediating this relationship. Vredenburg et al. (2020) argue that authenticity is determined by the alignment of brand purpose and values with both messaging and prosocial corporate practice, and that misalignment between these elements produces "woke washing", where activist claims overtake the practices that should support them. This condition connects directly to the participatory tensions discussed in section 2.1.2: where stakeholder inclusion is selective or governed from the top down, the gap between stated purpose and lived practice widens, and authenticity claims become harder to sustain. Iglesias et al. (2023), in their study of Unilever, reinforce this view by showing that a conscientious corporate brand is built through collaborative processes in which manifold stakeholders, including business partners outside the firm, are strategically aligned with the brand's purpose and values. Liewendahl et al. (2025) further demonstrate at the internal level that employee alignment with conscientious brand promises depends on clarity, time to uphold those values, and employee agency in their co-creation, and they caution that co-creation does not in itself guarantee alignment. Taken together, these contributions suggest that authenticity is less a property the brand declares than an outcome of how inclusively and consistently its purpose is enacted across internal and external stakeholders.

2.2.4 Purpose and guiding principles

Across the conscientious branding literature, purpose is treated as both a strategic and moral device. It is strategic in that it orients resource allocation, positioning and innovation, and moral in that it encodes the brand’s view of what is worth striving for beyond financial performance (Iglesias & Ind, 2016, 2020). For conscientious brands, purpose cannot function as a flexible slogan; it has to be core to identity and strategy and to be enacted consistently over time if it is to retain credibility (Tjandra et al., 2025).

Ind and Iglesias (2022) argue that a conscientious brand's belief system combines such a transformative purpose with a singular set of guiding principles that specify how stakeholder fairness, temporal responsibility and openness are understood in that organisation. Purpose looks forward and shapes intent, whereas principles provide criteria for assessing whether specific actions and outcomes remain aligned with the belief system (Dierksmeier, 2013; Ind & Iglesias, 2022). Recent work stresses that conscientious brands therefore need to invest in impact measures and key performance indicators that evaluate social, environmental and economic outcomes for different stakeholders, not only financial returns (Hansen & Schaltegger, 2016; Tjandra et al., 2025).

2.2.5 Stakeholders, co-creation and governance

A further defining feature of conscientious branding is its stakeholder-centric and co-creative character. Drawing on the corporate brand co-creation literature, Iglesias and Ind (2020) argue that brands in contemporary hyper-connected environments can no longer be tightly controlled by managers, but are co-created through ongoing performances; communicating, internalising, contesting and elucidating by multiple internal and external stakeholders. From this perspective, conscientious brands treat stakeholders as partners in value creation and in shaping the brand's social and environmental agenda, rather than as passive recipients of messages (Iglesias, 2020; Ramaswamy & Ozcan, 2016).

This co-creative view has implications for leadership and governance. Conscientious brands are said to require participatory, empathetic and transformative leadership styles that are willing to share power, listen to dissent and integrate stakeholder input into strategic decisions (Ind et al., 2013; Iglesias & Ind, 2020). Scholars also point to the need for new governance mechanisms that formally incorporate key stakeholder groups into decision-making and reporting systems, alongside increased organisational self-disclosure to support transparency and accountability (Hatch & Schultz, 2010; Iglesias & Ind, 2020).

2.2.6 Culture, authenticity and internal alignment

The internal dimension of conscientious branding has become an important focus in recent work. Ethical organisational culture, characterised by clear values, stakeholder balance, process integrity and a long-term horizon, is repeatedly identified as a prerequisite for translating a brand's conscience into consistent behaviour (Ardichvili et al., 2009; Abratt et al., 2025). Abratt et al. (2025) further find that ethical culture moderates the relationship between organisational purpose and brand authenticity, and that perceived CSR reinforces the association between purpose and conscientious brand perceptions.

Brand authenticity itself is treated as a mechanism through which conscientious intentions are recognised and rewarded by stakeholders (Morhart et al., 2015; Napoli et al., 2014). Recent studies link authenticity to perceptions that the brand is truthful, responsible and transparent, and to the perceived consistency between internal values and external actions (Lehman et al., 2019; Södergren, 2021). In the context of conscientious corporate brands, Guzmán et al. (2024) show that authenticity is a key predictor of whether B2B brands are perceived as

conscientious, which supports the view that internal alignment and "lived values" are essential antecedents of conscientious branding.

The employee perspective lends support to the proposition that conscientious branding should be built inside-out through culture, HR practices and internal branding, not only 'outside-in' through communications (Biedenbach & Biedenbach, 2022; Iglesias & Saleem, 2015). Yet if conscientious branding rests on such inside-out alignment between values, culture and behaviour, what happens when that alignment fails, or when the gap between stated purpose and lived practice becomes visible to stakeholders?

2.2.7 Dark sides, moral failure and resilience

While much of the early literature emphasised the aspirational and transformative potential of conscientious branding, more recent work explicitly addresses its "dark side". Even brands that are genuinely oriented by conscience may commit moral failures, for instance through misleading environmental claims, poorly judged activist campaigns or inconsistencies between rhetoric and practice, which can trigger accusations of greenwashing, woke-washing or hypocrisy (Biedenbach, 2025; Vredenburg et al., 2020).

Biedenbach's (2025) content analysis of cases decided by the Swedish Advertising Ombudsman shows how moral failures associated with environmental claims occur across organisations with varying degrees of conscientious branding, from "emerging sustainability actors" to "unapologetic sustainability change leaders". They argues that such failures can function as decisive moments for organisational moral development and persistent resilience, insofar as they force organisations to revisit and recalibrate their ethical and moral infrastructures; codes of conduct, values, decision processes, in light of public challenge (Biedenbach, 2025). At the same time, the study underlines that without robust ethical infrastructures and openness to learning, conscientious rhetoric can quickly be undermined by perceived inconsistency, feeding stakeholder scepticism rather than trust.

Read across the wider literature, this is part of a recurring tension rather than an isolated finding. Conscientious branding proposes that purpose, culture and behaviour should be aligned inside-out (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Biedenbach & Biedenbach, 2022), and place branding increasingly moves toward bottom-up, participatory models in which residents and other internal stakeholders shape the brand (Kavaratzis, 2012; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). Yet internal disagreements over values, uneven stakeholder power, and external commercial or political pressures make either form of alignment difficult to sustain in practice (Marzano & Scott, 2009; Vredenburg et al., 2020; Liewendahl et al., 2025). Consistent with this, conscientious branding is best understood as an ongoing process of "becoming", rather than a stable state that, once achieved, can be taken for granted (Grimm et al., 2025; Tjandra et al., 2025). It also situates conscientious branding within a realistic account of contemporary capitalism: brands operate under pressures for growth, investor returns and competitive positioning, and these structural constraints can limit the depth and

consistency of conscientious practice even when intentions are sincere (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Markovic et al., 2023).

2.2.8 Ongoing debates and tensions

Because it asks brands to "do the right thing while building a profitable business" (Ind & Iglesias, 2022, p. 1), conscientious branding explicitly foregrounds tensions between moral aspiration and market discipline. Scholars debate, for example, whether conscience can genuinely reshape core business models or whether it risks becoming another layer in what Dierksmeier (2013) calls the moralisation of capitalism without structural change. Relatedly, there is concern that the language of conscience, like that of CSR and purpose before it, may be co-opted into existing managerial toolkits, producing ethically scented versions of conventional branding rather than substantive transformation (Biedenbach, 2025).

At the same time, the literature documents shifts in how some brands conceptualise their stakeholder responsibilities, time horizons and governance arrangements, suggesting that conscientious branding can open space for more participatory, long-term and justice-oriented forms of brand management, even if these remain fragile and contested (Abratt & Kleyn, 2023; Iglesias et al., 2023; Tjandra et al., 2025). It is this ambivalent, in-progress quality that makes conscientious branding a fertile lens for examining how brands handle the moral and political pressures of contemporary markets.

These tensions can be observed in the tourism development setting, where the pressure for economic growth can conflict with the environmental and societal well-being. Different priorities among stakeholders can create difficulties in balancing profit with moral aspirations. The next section reviews literature related to tourism developments and its effects on the local communities.

2.3 Tourism developments and community tensions

Overtourism, defined as a rise in tourist activity that diminishes the very qualities that make a destination appealing, can significantly impact local communities as residents may begin to avoid heavily touristed areas or feel dissatisfied with changes in their neighbourhoods (Jover & Díaz-Parra, 2022). It occurs when a destination's resources, facilities or infrastructure are used beyond their capacity. As tourists share these spaces with local residents and commuters, increasing numbers of all user groups intensify pressure on local environments. Broader societal trends, such as rise of internet usage, social media exposure and real-estate speculation have further contributed to the challenges associated with overtourism (Koens et al., 2018).

Overtourism is not a single issue, but something that is the result of multiple combined effects. It emerges from the accumulation of impacts related to tourist behaviour, stakeholder interactions and broader changes in the physical, economic and social environment. This suggests that tourism-related challenges are complex and they reflect deeper tensions in how

tourism is developed and managed. Tourism is frequently associated with social and environmental problems, such as overcrowding and environmental degradation (Back et al., 2025; Koens et al., 2018). It can also negatively affect community well-being, for example through the displacement of residents due to short-term rental platforms and the disruptive behaviour of tourists who do not behave appropriately in local settings (Back et al., 2025; Bouchon & Rauscher, 2019). When looking at place branding, different stakeholders have varying levels of influence and interest over how a place is developed (Marzano & Scott, 2009; Reynolds et al., 2022). Some stakeholders, such as business owners or those renting out accommodation, may prioritise economic gains and want the place to be branded in a way that attracts as many visitors as possible. If these actors have greater influence, it could lead to social issues that can also later develop into environmental problems. This can in turn affect how the residents experience and identify with the place, and therefore may create a gap between their sense of place identity and the image that is being presented to visitors.

But while tourism can have these negative effects, it is also recognised as an important contributor to local economies. Handler (2026) found that participants in their study acknowledged tourism's role in creating employment opportunities and supporting the growth of local businesses, such as hotels and retail. Similarly, Lukman et al. (2022) and Croes et al. (2024) report that residents often perceive tourism as having positive economic effects. However, despite these benefits, concerns remain regarding the distribution of tourism-generated income. In many cases local residents feel that economic gains are unevenly distributed and that external actors benefit more than the local community (Handler, 2026). It indicates a tension between economic growth and local benefit distribution and leads to questions about who tourism development is actually for. This relates to concerns about fairness and how benefits are distributed between stakeholders (Ripoll González & Gale, 2020), which connects to both calls for more inclusive place branding and to the focus on stakeholder fairness in conscientious branding. The latter proposes that brands should balance the interests of different stakeholder groups rather than focus on shareholders alone. In tourism today multiple stakeholder perspectives and overall fairness are not always taken into account and the environment itself is rarely treated as a stakeholder.

Several studies have found that local residents often perceive tourism as having negative environmental impacts (Kim et al., 2013; Lukman et al., 2022; Ntalakos et al., 2025). In protected natural areas, individuals working within the tourism sector are sometimes even more aware of environmental degradation than those outside it, possibly due to their closer interaction with tourism activities. Long-term residents also tend to show greater sensitivity to environmental changes, as they have experienced the gradual transformation of their surroundings over time (Magadán-Díaz & Rivas-García, 2022). Saltstraumen's status as a protected natural area raises the unresolved question of whether the environment itself should be treated as a stakeholder, or only as a shared concern represented through residents, businesses and conservation bodies (Kortetmäki et al., 2023). Such a context suggests the need for greater emphasis on inclusion and fairness across stakeholders, as well as on balancing short-term and long-term goals, what conscientious branding describes as temporal and ecological responsibility. Attracting more visitors to achieve short-term goals may

produce negative long-term consequences for the environment. Place branding's concern with inclusion and fairness and conscientious branding's concept of a transformative purpose, in which development goes beyond profit to contribute positively to society and the environment, are therefore best read as complementary lenses that this thesis treats together.

A more recent strand within this conversation is regenerative tourism, which extends the sustainability framing by asking tourism not only to reduce harm but to contribute to the health of the social-ecological systems in which it operates. In a state-of-the-art review Bellato and Pollock (2025) trace the concept's lineage from regenerative development and living-systems thinking and characterise it as a shift away from extractive operating models towards arrangements in which tourism is positioned as a contributor to the wellbeing of places and communities. The review notes that the concept is often misread as a stronger version of sustainability or as the slogan that visitors should leave a place better than they found it, and argues for a more substantive reading in which place and its communities are centred and growth is reframed as the building of relational capacity rather than as increases in volume. Regenerative tourism is not synonymous with conscientious place branding, but the two are closely adjacent: both move beyond the do-less-harm framing of sustainability, both treat the long-term health of place and community as constitutive rather than instrumental, and both place participatory and stakeholder considerations at the centre of how development decisions are made. Where conscientious branding asks how a place communicates and accounts for the choices it makes, regenerative tourism asks what kind of tourism the place is choosing to host. Read alongside one another, the two literatures provide complementary vocabularies for the kind of tourism development this thesis examines.

However, perceptions of tourism are not uniform. Kageyama et al. (2025) found that stakeholders connected to marine protected areas may value these environments differently depending on their interests and priorities. This indicates that tourism development involves multiple and sometimes conflicting perspectives, which has also been discussed in place branding research where different stakeholder groups contribute to shaping a place brand.

The literature has documented how stakeholder groups with authority through position, cultural capital, or stronger networks can exert disproportionate influence over how a place is represented (Marzano & Scott, 2009; Reynolds et al., 2022), though it has so far offered recommendations for inclusion rather than a settled account of how such asymmetries can be addressed in practice. Because of that, decision-making processes need to account for these different perspectives, particularly in situations where stakeholder interests do not align. The literature responds to this with calls for more inclusive and participatory governance, on the grounds that branding without internal stakeholder agreement risks producing imposed identities that residents reject, as in the 'Not in our Name' campaign against Hamburg's marketing. Co-creation and participatory principles are accordingly proposed as relevant to managing tourism development. Rogowski (2025) offers supporting evidence, finding that measures aimed at managing overtourism were more widely accepted by local stakeholders when developed through participatory decision-making. How such processes hold up when stakeholder interests remain in conflict, or when participation itself is shaped by the same

asymmetries it is meant to correct, is less well established and an open question for further study.

Together these findings indicate that tourism development is a setting in which place branding and conscientious branding can productively be examined together. The tension between economic growth and the preservation of social and environmental conditions, where tourism generates economic benefits for a place while also imposing social and environmental costs on local communities, surfaces precisely the questions both literatures attempt to answer: who shapes the brand, whose interests are served by it, and over what time horizon. Addressing this tension requires more balanced and inclusive approaches to destination development, where stakeholders' perspectives and the long-term sustainability concerns are more carefully considered. These challenges are relevant for place branding as they suggest that branding efforts need to move beyond promoting a positive image to also consider how the developments affect local communities. This is consistent with conscientious branding, which focuses on temporal responsibility and fairness, with a transformative purpose aimed at giving long-term societal benefits.

2.4 Overlapping frameworks: co-creation and sustainability as bridge concepts

Two specific areas of overlap structure the rest of this chapter: stakeholder co-creation of brand meaning and value, and social and environmental sustainability as a shared reference point for branding practice. Together they provide the conceptual bridge through which conscientious branding can be translated into a place-branding context, and motivate the empirical questions this thesis addresses in Saltstraumen.

2.4.1 Co-creation across conscientious corporate branding and place branding

Across both conscientious corporate branding and place branding, brands are increasingly understood as multi-actor, co-created constructs rather than fixed entities controlled top down by a managerial centre. Brand et al. (2025) argue that in hyper connected environments it is misleading to treat brands as stable bundles of attributes determined by senior leadership, because customers, employees, influencers and other actors continually negotiate elements of brand meaning and influence marketing decisions. From this perspective, brands dynamically evolve in interactions among a brand "conductor" and multiple actors, shifting the managerial task from defining meaning to facilitating a process of co-creation. A similar move is evident in place branding, where scholars emphasise the interactive formation of place brands and the role of stakeholder participation in making and remaking place meanings over time (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015; Kavaratzis & Hatch, 2021). The formation of brands is also connected to place identity as the identity emerges through stakeholder's ongoing interactions and sense of belonging (Matlovičová, 2024), and this attachment then in turn shapes how they engage in co-creation and branding initiatives.

The organisational and governance implications of this co-creative turn are foregrounded in both literatures. Hatch and Schultz (2010) recast brand co-creation as a full-stakeholder process that extends beyond consumers to include employees, investors, media and other publics, arguing that co-creation is rooted in company–stakeholder engagement and organisational self-disclosure and necessarily involves sharing control over brands with stakeholders. Brands thus become dynamic and sometimes contested arenas in which power and meaning are continually negotiated, and managers must accept a loss of control as stakeholders gain access to organisational practices and culture (Hatch & Schultz, 2010). Place-branding contributions translate these organisational concerns into a public-governance register: Ripoll González and Gale (2020), for example, conceptualise participatory place branding as a form of governance in which brand legitimacy depends on iterative communication between public authorities and diverse stakeholders, while also showing that public managers often struggle to reconcile rhetorical commitments to participation with a reluctance to relinquish control. This points to a structural difference between the fields: conscientious branding is typically framed in relation to commercial corporations operating under shareholder-value constraints, whereas place branding is usually associated with public or quasi-public organisations whose formal mandate is to serve residents and communities. On the face of it, this might appear to make place branding a more natural site for conscientious principles than the commercial settings in which they were developed. Whether the institutional arrangements of public and quasi-public place-branding bodies actually deliver on the accountability that conscientious branding requires, however, is an empirical question rather than a structural given.

Within this shared multi-actor view, both streams pay particular attention to the platforms and practices through which co-creation occurs. Ramaswamy and Ozcan (2016) describe brand-engagement platforms that connect customers, employees, partners and other stakeholders in joint experiential creation of brand value, treating stakeholders as "experiencers" whose situated experiences drive innovation and the expansion of brand value. Conscientious branding takes up this platform logic but explicitly ties it to a moral belief system: Tjandra et al. (2025) identify organisational openness as a core attribute of conscientious brands, defined as the belief that a brand can only realise its purpose by influencing others and being open to influence itself, and argue that openness requires brands to listen to stakeholder needs, engage in dialogue and co-create innovative solutions in purpose-driven relationships. In place branding, Stoica et al. (2022) similarly define place brand co-creation as an umbrella term for complex brand meanings emerging through stakeholders' participation in place activities, collaborations and exchanges of ideas and resources that are often deliberately organised through campaigns and storytelling initiatives. Both approaches, therefore, foreground dialogue, access and interaction as the mechanisms through which stakeholders become co-creators rather than passive recipients.

At the same time, both literatures recognise the ambivalence and risks of co-creation. Place-branding studies show that stakeholder participation can increase satisfaction, strengthen social cohesion and democratise public services, but it can also intensify disputes and damage place reputations when stakeholders feel excluded, misrepresented or

instrumentalised (Stoica et al., 2022; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). When managers have strong top-down control, or when certain stakeholders are given disproportionate influence in the branding process, the literature typically describes the result as a brand that fails to reflect residents' place identity, as in the 'Not in our Name' situation in Hamburg's place brand development (Zenker & Petersen, 2014). This framing is useful but leaves two issues underspecified: residents rarely hold a single, settled place identity that a brand could either reflect or fail to reflect, and participatory remedies are themselves shaped by the asymmetries of authority, cultural capital and network position they are meant to correct (Marzano & Scott, 2009; Reynolds et al., 2022). The same difficulty surfaces in corporate-branding debates, where co-creation can slide into co-destruction once brand owners lose control over meaning or fail to respond in good faith to stakeholder input, producing accusations of hypocrisy or 'woke-washing' even for brands that see themselves as conscientious. Co-creation thus does more than introduce a double-edged condition for legitimacy: it places authenticity itself in continuous dispute, since the brand's realisation depends on whose participation counts, whose place identity is recognised, and on what terms (Vredenburg et al., 2020).

Taken together, these strands show that conscientious corporate branding and contemporary place branding converge on a view of brands as co-created, multi-actor constructs in which managers or place authorities act as facilitators or conductors rather than sole authors. In conscientious branding, this co-creative orientation is explicitly anchored in a moral belief system: organisational openness forms part of a broader conscience concerned with transformative purpose, stakeholder fairness and temporal responsibility (Tjandra et al., 2025). In place branding, co-creation is tied to public value, democratic participation and the governance of shared places, with a sharper focus on territorial power relations, collective ownership of narratives and the political risks of exclusion or symbolic participation (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015; Stoica et al., 2022).

For this thesis, these parallels raise concrete empirical questions. If both literatures insist that stakeholders are co-authors of brand meaning, how do residents and local authorities in tourism-dependent communities understand their own and others' roles in co-creating the place brand, and how does this play out in a setting such as Saltstraumen? To what extent do they desire or experience shared control, and how do they manage the risks and conflicts associated with co-creation? These issues are taken up in Research Questions 2 and 4, which examine stakeholder fairness and shared well-being, and participatory openness and co-creation, in Saltstraumen's branding and tourism development.

2.4.2 Sustainability and responsibility as shared value horizons

A second important overlap concerns the growing centrality of social and environmental sustainability as a reference point for branding in both conscientious corporate branding and place branding. In corporate work, this appears in debates on CSR, ESG and responsible innovation, but conscientious branding reframes these under a broader moral belief system that expects brands to balance profitability with long-term social and environmental improvement (Tjandra et al., 2025). In place branding, similar concerns are articulated

through concepts such as destination social responsibility, sustainable destinations and sustainability-driven place branding, all of which seek to integrate environmental and social considerations into how places are developed and communicated (Garanti et al., 2024; Pasquinelli & Kavaratzis, 2025).

On the corporate side, sustainability is connected with an expanded notion of brand value with conscience as an overarching lens. Co-creation research shows that in digitally networked markets, consumers cocreate not only economic value but also shared meanings, relationships and collective forms of value (Ramaswamy & Ozcan, 2016), and conscientious branding builds on this by defining brands around transformative purposes, stakeholder fairness and temporal responsibility, with sustainability embedded in core strategy rather than appended as a separate programme (Tjandra et al., 2025). CSR and ESG activities are therefore judged in terms of whether they coherently express the brand's conscience and long-term commitments, rather than simply adding reputational benefits (Markovic et al., 2023).

On the place-branding side, sustainability has moved from background context to explicit brand content, but with an emphasis on destinations, governance and perceptions. Empirical studies report that when destinations foreground economic, social and environmental dimensions in their branding, this is associated with stronger trust, image, perceived value, loyalty and intentions to revisit, although such efforts are often only partially visible or understandable to visitors, making their actual impact difficult to assess (Garanti et al., 2024). A further question is how sustainability messaging directed at visitors aligns with the stakeholders' own understanding of the place's identity, since misalignment has been linked to perceptions of inauthenticity and prioritisation of external expectations over internal ones (Hay et al., 2022; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). How destinations balance these two pressures, sustainability claims that strengthen external perception and sustainability practice that maintains internal legitimacy, is an empirical question this thesis takes up in the Saltstraumen case. Pasquinelli and Kavaratzis (2025) argue that sustainable-tourism research has documented unsustainable instances more thoroughly than it has conceptualised the "sustainable destination," and they position place branding (understood as identity-driven communication that shapes networks of associations) as a potential mechanism for sustainability messaging/meaning-making among residents, tourists and other stakeholders. In their account, branding can facilitate internal multilogues and coalitions around balanced socio-cultural, economic and environmental development, but the link between place branding and sustainable destinations remains fragile and vulnerable to "green" repackaging when not grounded in substantive change (Pasquinelli & Kavaratzis, 2025).

Comparing the two fields, a shared core becomes visible: both conscientious branding and sustainable place branding foreground long-term responsibility, fairness across stakeholders and intergenerational justice as legitimate criteria for evaluating brand strategy, even though they are applied in different institutional settings (Tjandra et al., 2025; Pasquinelli & Kavaratzis, 2025).

In corporate contexts, these principles must continually be reconciled with profit imperatives and investor expectations, so conscience functions as a demanding ideal negotiated within a shareholder-value frame (Tjandra et al., 2025). Place branding faces its own structural pressures, including political accountability cycles and reliance on tourism for tax revenue and local employment, which can pull strategy toward short-term visibility and growth even when long-term stakeholder fairness is the stated aim (Klijn et al., 2012; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). These pressures sit within public-value and multi-stakeholder governance arrangements where primary accountability is to residents, communities and ecosystems rather than shareholders (Eshuis & Edwards, 2013). From this perspective, sustainable place branding can be read as a public-sector analogue to conscientious branding: both seek to integrate environmental and social responsibility into the heart of brand strategy, but they operate under different governance logics that condition how trade-offs between economic, social and environmental goals are recognised and handled.

For Saltstraumen, this raises questions about how local actors connect branding and tourism initiatives to longer-term environmental and social trajectories. Do residents and authorities frame tourism development in terms of intergenerational justice and ecological limits, or primarily in terms of short-term attractiveness and growth? How do they weigh different stakeholders' claims when sustainability goals require trade-offs? These questions underpin transformative public purpose, stakeholder fairness and shared well-being, temporal and ecological responsibility, participatory openness and co-creation, and a cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability.

2.4.3 Interim synthesis: a shared conceptual space and emerging accountability

The co-creation and sustainability literatures together reveal a meaningful overlap between conscientious corporate branding and emerging approaches to place branding. Co-creation research in both fields portrays brands as multi-actor projects in which managers or place authorities orchestrate networks of stakeholder interactions rather than unilaterally determining brand meaning, while sustainability-oriented work emphasises long-term environmental and social responsibility, stakeholder fairness and intergenerational justice as legitimate foundations for branding strategies.

Across both streams, a further cross-cutting concern implicitly surfaces: questions of integrity and accountability. Conscientious-branding scholars stress that brands must align stated purposes and values with everyday practices and be willing to confront tensions and "backsliding" when profit pressures or practical constraints undermine moral commitments (Tjandra et al., 2025). Place-branding research on greenwashing, symbolic participation and uneven development similarly points to the need for mechanisms that hold place-branding efforts accountable for their social and environmental consequences, not just their communicative appeal (Eshuis & Edwards, 2013; Aguilera-Cora & Fernández-Cavia, 2025; Liu & Park, 2025). Place identity is important in this context as it can help explain whether the place brands are viewed as authentic and legitimate by the local stakeholders rather than as a form of "greenwashing" made to attract visitors.

This overlapping conceptual space, where stakeholder co-creation, sustainability, and integrity/accountability meet, provides the bridge that enables this thesis to propose conscientious place branding. By adapting the moral and stakeholder-oriented attributes of conscientious brands (transformative purpose, fairness, temporal responsibility, openness and a cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability) to a place-branding context already oriented toward public value, participation and sustainable-destination development, the next section develops a framework established from existing literature but tailored to the specific governance scenarios of tourism-dependent communities like Saltstraumen. This, in turn, sets up the research questions that guide the empirical investigation.

2.5 Conscientious place branding

Building on the overlaps identified in Section 2.4, this section develops the idea of conscientious place branding as an integrative framework that combines the moral belief system of conscientious corporate branding with governance-oriented place branding. It first translates key conscientious-branding beliefs into a place context, then explains why places are a promising yet constrained arena for such an orientation, and finally sets out the resulting conceptual framework, research gaps and research questions guiding this thesis.

2.5.1 From conscientious branding to conscientious place branding

Recent work on conscientious brands conceptualises them as organisations that embed a moral belief system guiding strategic decisions and actions toward positive transformative change, going beyond CSR initiatives that are often disconnected from core strategy (Tjandra et al., 2025). From a stakeholder perspective, this belief system can be summarised in four core commitments: transformative purpose, stakeholder fairness, temporal responsibility and organisational openness, all of which must be enacted with integrity and subject to accountability.

Translating these insights to a place context suggests defining conscientious place branding through four dimensions and a cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability. First, the place brand is guided by a transformative public purpose that explicitly targets social and environmental improvement in the place and its wider ecosystems, rather than focusing only on competitiveness or growth. Second, stakeholder fairness and shared well-being refers to balancing the needs and claims of residents, local businesses, visitors, future generations and non-human nature, while recognising that not all claims can be reconciled and that explicit, reasoned judgements are required. Third, temporal and ecological responsibility connects short-term branding and tourism initiatives with long-term sustainable-development trajectories, instead of treating image work as separate from structural change. Fourth, participatory openness and co-creation is enacted through governance processes based on participation and dialogue, in which residents and other stakeholders are invited not simply to endorse pre-defined narratives but to help shape both narratives and underlying policy directions. Cutting across these four dimensions, integrity

and accountability require aligning stated values with everyday practices, being transparent about difficult trade-offs, and using outcome measures that can be tracked over time, rather than relying on aspirational claims.

In this framing, place authorities, destination organisations and other lead actors become custodians of a public conscience rather than owners of a purely commercial asset, responsible for facilitating co-creative branding processes that remain grounded in shared values, public-value outcomes and long-term environmental responsibility

2.5.2 Why conscientious branding is particularly relevant for places

Conscientious branding appears particularly relevant for places because contemporary scholarship already conceptualises place branding as a governance and public-value mechanism. Aguilera-Cora et al. (2025) define place branding as a governance and policy tool that can stimulate long-term environmental, social and economic goals and contribute to residents' well-being, often through collaborative governance involving multiple autonomous stakeholders. SDG-oriented work similarly describes place branding as a strategy for managing perceptions that can play a key role in sustainable development, while warning that public-fuelled branding must comply with sustainability standards to avoid reinforcing unsustainable trajectories (Aguilera-Cora & Fernández-Cavia, 2025).

By contrast, conscientious-branding studies emphasise that corporate conscience must be continually negotiated within a dominant shareholder-value frame, balancing immediate profit demands against longer-term social and environmental ambitions (Tjandra et al., 2025). This contrast suggests that places may be structurally better positioned to adopt a conscientious branding logic: their primary accountability is to residents, communities and future generations rather than investors, and place branding is already linked to public policy and sustainable-development goals. Places are also characterised by pre-existing identities shaped by local stakeholders through their experiences and interactions, and the history of the place. This distinguishes places from corporate brands which can be more deliberately designed and controlled by an organization. Place identity is therefore central for branding, as brand development strategies that are not aligned with how stakeholders understand and identify with the place risk being resisted or rejected, especially if the branding processes are dominated by top-down decision-making or unequal stakeholder influences. This type of challenge is addressed in conscientious branding as stakeholder fairness and inclusion are core elements of the framework. At the same time, participatory and governance-oriented accounts of place branding show that public branding can reproduce inequalities and symbolic participation rather than substantively sharing power. The framework set out in the next section responds to this concern through four dimensions and a cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020; Liu & Park, 2025).

2.5.3 Anticipated tensions and risks

The literature also makes clear that applying a conscientious logic to place branding is neither straightforward nor risk-free. Scholars note that sustainability agendas and SDG frameworks are often referenced in abstract terms without being operationalised, raising concerns that they can become symbolic overlays or even facilitate greenwashing if not tied to concrete governance and accountability mechanisms (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Aguilera-Cora & Fernández-Cavia, 2025). Case studies such as Busan's "Ocean Capital" strategy further show how branding used as a governance platform can marginalise low-income residents and reduce citizen participation to superficial forms, even when framed as collaborative (Liu & Park, 2025).

These dynamics mirror concerns in the conscientious-branding literature about backsliding and moral failure: tensions between commercial and moral goals can lead brands that see themselves as conscientious to fall short in practice, and stakeholders may respond negatively when they perceive purpose claims as inauthentic or instrumental (Tjandra et al., 2025; Fernandes et al., 2024). For conscientious place branding, this implies that simply articulating a transformative purpose or aligning with SDGs is insufficient. Without substantive participation, transparent trade-offs and mechanisms that allow stakeholders to contest and reshape brand strategies, place branding risks reproducing the very problems conscientious branding seeks to address.

2.6 Conceptual framework and operationalisation

Taken together, these strands support defining conscientious place branding as a place-branding approach in which a territory's brand is guided by a transformative public purpose, pursues stakeholder fairness and shared well-being, exercises temporal and ecological responsibility, and enacts participatory openness and co-creation, all underpinned by cross-cutting integrity and accountability. In this framework, place authorities and other lead actors function as custodians of a public conscience, responsible for aligning brand narratives with social and environmental outcomes and for sharing agenda-setting and decision-making power with stakeholders.

Table 2 summarises this framework by showing how key conscientious-branding beliefs map onto place-branding concepts and how they are operationalised for the Saltstraumen case (e.g. how "transformative public purpose" is interpreted locally, what counts as "fair" distribution of tourism benefits and burdens, and how the temporal-and-ecological and participatory-openness dimensions are recognised in practice).

Table 2

Summarized conscientious place-branding framework

Conscientious branding (core attribute)	**Place branding (parallel concept)**	**Conscientious place branding (integrated dimension)**	**Illustrative indicators (Saltstraumen)**
Transformative purpose: Purpose beyond profit; aims to create positive impact; must be embedded, not an add-on.	Place branding as **governance/policy mechanism** and identity-driven development (not only promotion), oriented toward long-term socio-cultural, environmental and economic goals.	**Transformative public purpose**: the place brand articulates a shared public purpose beyond competitiveness, guiding tourism and development toward community and ecological well-being.	How residents/officials define "what Saltstraumen should be known for"; success criteria include more than visitor growth (e.g. ecosystem health, community well-being).
Stakeholder fairness: Intra- and inter-stakeholder fairness; balancing competing needs; trade-offs are real.	Place branding as a **multi-stakeholder** project; participatory place branding seeks legitimacy, but exclusion and marginalisation can occur (token participation, uneven benefits).	**Stakeholder fairness & shared well-being**: branding and tourism decisions aim for fair distribution of benefits/burdens and recognition of affected groups, with explicit attention to trade-offs.	Perceived winners/losers of tourism; views on what is "fair" (who should benefit, who should decide); evidence of inclusion /recognition vs. marginalisation.
Temporal responsibility: Balancing short-term objectives with long-term social/environmental ambitions; intergenerational justice).	**Sustainable destination/place branding:** sustainability as balancing socio-cultural, economic and environmental development; branding can support sustainability meaning-making, but link is "frail" and can become rhetorical.	**Temporal & ecological responsibility**: branding aligns with long-term sustainable development pathways and ecological limits (including future generations), rather than short-term campaigns.	References to future generations, ecological limits, carrying capacity; willingness to accept limits/trade-offs for long-term viability; long-term planning language vs. short-term growth talk.
Organisational openness: Brands must be open to influence; dialogue; co-creation;	Place brands are **co-created** through stakeholders' interactions and roles; participatory	**Participatory openness & co-creation**: residents/actors help shape brand meaning and related	Stakeholder accounts of involvement (consultation vs co-decision); perceived ability to

Conscientious branding (core attribute)	**Place branding (parallel concept)**	**Conscientious place branding (integrated dimension)**	**Illustrative indicators (Saltstraumen)**
transparency; stakeholder engagement).	governance is required for legitimacy, but can be symbolic.	policy directions through ongoing, meaningful participation (not just consultation).	influence narratives/policies; evidence of multilogue mechanisms (forums, co-design, citizen panels).
Cross-cutting integrity and accountability (applies to all dimensions above): Conscientious brands and place brands alike require a foundation of moral integrity and accountability that cuts across purpose, stakeholder fairness, temporal responsibility and openness. This involves aligning stated values with everyday practices, being transparent about difficult trade-offs between stakeholders and across time, and using outcome measures that can be tracked over time, rather than relying on aspirational claims.			Perceived gap between brand story and reality; presence/absence of monitoring indicators (environmental and social); transparency about progress and failures; trust/scepticism toward official narratives.

2.6.1 Identified gaps and research questions

Although the building blocks of conscientious place branding can be assembled from existing scholarship, several gaps remain. Conscientious branding has been developed almost exclusively for corporate contexts and has not been systematically examined in public, territorially bounded settings; place-branding research has moved toward governance, participation and sustainability but rarely draws on moral-belief-system constructs such as conscience; and there is little empirical work at the scale of small, tourism-dependent communities that compares resident and authority perspectives on such an orientation.

These gaps motivate the four research questions that guide this thesis, which are aligned with the dimensions of the conscientious place-branding framework and shadowed by the cross-cutting concern for integrity and accountability. They ask how residents and local authorities in Saltstraumen conceptualise the transformative public purpose of the place brand; how they prioritise and balance stakeholder fairness; how they connect short-term branding and tourism initiatives to long-term sustainable-development trajectories; and to what extent they expect organisational openness and participatory co-creation in place-branding governance.

Sub-research questions:
To explore how the framework resonates in a tourism-dependent place, this thesis addresses four research questions, each aligned with one framework element and all shadowed by the cross-cutting concern for integrity and accountability:

1. **How do residents and local authorities in Saltstraumen conceptualise the transformative public purpose of the place brand?**
   This examines shared understandings of the place's core identity (raison d'être) and its orientation toward social and environmental outcomes beyond tourism growth.
2. **In what ways do residents and local authorities prioritise and balance stakeholder fairness in place branding and tourism development?**
   This investigates perceptions of legitimate claims, trade-offs and inclusion across residents, businesses, visitors and nature.
3. **How do residents and local authorities connect short-term branding and tourism initiatives to long-term sustainable development?**
   This probes views on temporal horizons, intergenerational justice and alignment between image work and structural change.
4. **To what extent do residents and local authorities expect organisational openness and participatory co-creation in place-branding governance?**
   This assesses desired levels of dialogue, scrutiny and power-sharing in shaping brand narratives and policies.

A cross-cutting element of moral integrity and accountability underpins all four questions: aligning stated values with practices, transparently addressing trade-offs and using impact measures to demonstrate social and environmental outcomes beyond rhetoric. By answering

these questions, the thesis aims to make two contributions. Conceptually, it elaborates and positions conscientious place branding as a new framework at the intersection of conscientious branding and place branding. Empirically, it provides a case-based assessment of how such an approach resonates within a real tourism community, offering insights into the opportunities and tensions involved in moving toward a more conscientious place brand.

3. Methodology

The main objective of research is to generate answers to questions or solutions to problems and to present these in the form of findings that may support practical decision-making. Achieving this requires the use of appropriate research methods (Lapan et al., 2011) and a number of methodological decisions were necessary to ensure that the research questions and overall aim of the study could be fulfilled. This section presents the purpose, approach and strategy of the research, the data collection and analysis tool, and how trustworthiness was ensured throughout the research process.

3.1 Research purpose

In order to address the research questions and achieve the overall aim of this study, an exploratory research purpose was chosen. There are four types of research purposes: exploratory, descriptive, explanatory, and correlational (Goundar, 2012). Exploratory research is suitable when a topic is not well understood and limited prior knowledge exists. It provides the researcher with the opportunity to examine phenomena that have not yet been thoroughly investigated with the goal of discovering new categories of meaning and providing a foundation for future studies (Hurst, 2023).

This study has used an exploratory approach as conscientious place branding remains a relatively undeveloped field. While previous research has examined place branding and conscientious branding separately, the integration of these two concepts has not been fully explored yet. There is currently no established model for conscientious place branding, and this study sought to examine whether and how this integration can contribute to the development of ethically grounded and sustainable place brands in small tourism-dependent communities. Saltstraumen provided an informative case for exploring how stakeholders perceive and value their community and how these perceptions can relate to the branding process, especially in a community facing the challenge of balancing tourism growth with environmental and social sustainability.

The exploratory research purpose also gave the study the flexibility to explore the framework's four dimensions and its cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability in an open way without predefined expectations. This flexibility allowed the study to investigate how these elements might be applied in the context of Saltstraumen and to understand the variety of internal stakeholders' perceptions and experiences. An exploratory research purpose was therefore well-suited to a qualitative approach, as it requires flexibility in the research design and allows the study to adapt as new insights emerge (Lapan et al., 2011).

3.2 Research approach

According to Lapan et al. (2011), researchers draw on scientific and social scientific approaches to develop empirical knowledge about both physical and social phenomena. Two

main research approaches are used: qualitative and quantitative. These approaches differ in terms of the role of the researcher and the type of knowledge they produce. Quantitative research aims to generate generalizable findings by maintaining distance from the subject of study, while qualitative research involves closer engagement with participants and focuses on understanding phenomena within their specific contexts. Qualitative research does not aim for generalization in the same way, instead it seeks to provide in-depth insights into particular cases.

Qualitative research is suitable for exploratory studies as it allows the researcher to examine phenomena from the perspective of those experiencing them and aims to generate new insights rather than test fixed hypotheses (Lapan et al., 2011). This approach was suitable for the study, as conscientious place branding is a relatively unexplored field. Instead of testing an existing model, this study sought to explore how a conscientious place branding perspective may support the development of place brands in the case of Saltstraumen. A quantitative approach would not have been suitable for this study because it relies on clearly defined variables and measurable outcomes. Since conscientious place branding is still an emerging concept, there is limited theoretical clarity about how such variables should be defined. Using a quantitative design would also have been less able to capture the experiences and contextual meanings through which stakeholders relate to place and branding.

This required an understanding of Saltstraumen from the perspective of local stakeholders and how these perceptions relate to potential place branding processes. Internal stakeholders, such as residents, local businesses and public actors, play a central role in shaping place identity and are therefore important contributors to co-creating the place brand, as discussed in the literature review. A qualitative approach made it possible to examine stakeholders' perspectives in detail and to understand how they make sense of their experiences and the tourism development of their community. Lapan et al. (2011) stated that qualitative research focuses on how individuals construct meaning based on their experiences and interactions with the world around them.

This study was grounded in a social constructivist perspective, which holds that reality is produced through social interaction rather than existing independently of it (Lapan et al., 2011). On this view, place and place brand are not fixed objects but meanings continuously constructed and contested among stakeholders. The study therefore treats individual stakeholders' accounts as situated windows onto this collective construction, rather than as reports of a single underlying reality. Based on the literature review findings, place branding is not seen as a fixed or objective concept but as an ongoing process shaped by dialogue and interaction among stakeholders. In the case of Saltstraumen this means that there is no single true place identity or brand. Instead, different stakeholders may hold different understandings of the place, based on their experiences and values. A qualitative, social constructivist approach was therefore appropriate for capturing these multiple perspectives and for exploring how they may contribute to the development of a future place brand.

Qualitative research seeks to understand the perspectives of individuals whose experiences are not directly observable to others. It does so by using open-ended questions that encourage reflection and understanding, rather than relying on tests or other quantitative measures (Lapan et al., 2011). This was implemented through semi-structured interviews within a case study research strategy.

3.2.1 Abductive reasoning

The research approach can be based on three types of reasoning: deductive, abductive and inductive. Deductive reasoning tests already existing theories against empirical data while inductive reasoning focuses on generating new theoretical insights from observations (Hurst, 2023). Abductive reasoning combines elements of both approaches and involves moving back and forth between theoretical concepts and empirical observations in order to develop a deeper understanding of the phenomenon being studied. It is useful when existing theories do not fully explain the empirical findings. In such a situation the researcher would seek to interpret unexpected or unclear observations by exploring how they may relate to, or extend or challenge existing theoretical perspectives (Tavory & Timmermans, 2014).

This process does not proceed in a straight line, but involves ongoing reflection and adjustment as new insights emerge from the collected data. The abductive approach connects theory and data while allowing flexibility throughout the research process (Tavory & Timmermans, 2014). This makes abductive reasoning suitable for exploratory, qualitative studies where the aim is to gain new insights into relatively unexplored phenomena. In this thesis the research was guided by existing theories of place branding and conscientious branding, which together formed the basis of the conceptual framework set out in section 2.6. That framework organises conscientious place branding into four dimensions: transformative public purpose, stakeholder fairness and shared well-being, temporal and ecological responsibility, and participatory openness and co-creation. A cross-cutting concern for integrity and accountability underpins all four. The study did not aim to test these theories in a strict or predefined way; the framework instead served as a starting point for exploring how each of these dimensions could be understood in the Saltstraumen context. This approach was appropriate given the exploratory nature of the study and the absence of an established model for conscientious place branding.

An abductive approach is suitable for case studies. According to Perry (1998), using a pure induction approach could risk overlooking relevant theoretical insights, meanwhile relying only on a strict deduction may limit the possibility of developing new theories. With abductive reasoning existing theory can guide the structure of a case study and inform how data are interpreted. This approach ensured that the study remained open to new insights that were found in the empirical data. Even though the conceptual framework guided the development of the interview guide and the initial stages of analysis, the findings were not limited to these initial themes. This made it possible to identify additional themes and perspectives that were not fully captured by the original conceptual framework and it contributed to refining the understanding of conscientious place branding.

3.3 Research strategy

There are several research strategies used within social science, including experiments, surveys, case studies, archival analysis and histories (Yin, 1994). This thesis applied a case study research strategy, as it enabled an in-depth investigation of a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context. Case studies are useful for producing detailed and context-rich insights because they focus on examining a single case in depth (Moore et al., 2011). Perry defines case studies as "a research methodology based on interviews that is used in a postgraduate thesis involving a body of knowledge" (Perry, 1998, p. 786).

Case studies can be applied to exploratory, descriptive and explanatory research purposes, and the choice of strategy depends on the type of research question, the level of control over events by the researcher and whether the focus is on contemporary or historical phenomena (Yin, 1994). In this study, the overall research question asked: "*In what way can a conscientious place branding perspective support the development of place brands in tourism-dependent communities?"* In research design, "what" questions can be linked to exploratory purposes and case studies more often address "how" and "why" questions related to contemporary events that the researcher cannot control (Yin, 1994). The overall research question was framed using the phrase "in what way", which functions similarly to a "how" question by exploring the processes through which a conscientious perspective can support brand development. The sub-research questions were also addressing the "how" perspective. According to Yin (1994), the type of research question is the first and most important factor in determining which strategy will best fit the study. The study examined ongoing developments in Saltstraumen, such as increasing tourism pressure, environmental concerns and resident perceptions of the developments, and these are events which the researcher had no control over. These characteristics further supported the suitability of a case study approach.

Yin (1994) further states that case studies are appropriate when investigating contemporary phenomena where the boundaries between the phenomenon and its context are not clearly defined. This was relevant for the study, as tourism development, place branding and stakeholder perceptions are closely interconnected and cannot be understood in isolation from the local context. Also there is no single clear outcome of tourism development in Saltstraumen, as different stakeholders may evaluate its impacts in different ways. This made the case study research strategy suitable for capturing these multiple perspectives.

Case studies are also useful for understanding complex social phenomena, as they allow researchers to retain the holistic and meaningful characteristics of real-life situations. They also allow the use of multiple sources of data, such as interviews and documents, which strengthens the credibility of the findings by allowing different sources of information to be compared (Yin, 1994). Although interviews were the main primary data source tool for the study, the interview data were used as part of a wider process of triangulation that helped the researcher understand the reality beyond the interview situation (Perry, 1998). The other data sources were official documents, maps, pictures and official government/tourism websites.

In this study, the conceptual framework based on place branding and conscientious branding theory guided the data collection and analysis, helping the study examine how the integration of these concepts can be understood in the context of Saltstraumen. The conceptual framework was developed with the help of the literature review and according to Perry (1998), in a case study thesis the existing theory helps shape what data should be collected by identifying main research issues at the end of the literature review. The conceptual framework for this study showcases the suggested conscientious place-branding framework and the four research questions for the thesis all grounded in the literature review.

There is no fixed number of cases that should be included in a study, but there are time and budget limitations that shape research (Perry, 1998). Case studies can either be single- or multiple-case designs with a holistic or embedded design. Multiple case studies contain more than one case compared to single cases which is just one case and a holistic design has a single unit of analysis whereas an embedded design has multiple units of analysis (Yin, 1994). The thesis followed a single-case study design. Single cases are suitable when the aim is to explore or extend theory within a specific context which meet conditions for using the theory (Yin, 1994). Saltstraumen was selected as a relevant case for exploring the research, as it is a small tourism-dependent community experiencing growing tourism pressures while still being at an early stage of development. This made it possible to explore how place branding processes may develop before tourism-related challenges become more severe. While the case includes some distinctive characteristics, such as its marine protected area where fishing is still permitted, it is not considered an extreme or critical case (Yin, 1994). Instead it can be seen as a representative example of a tourism-dependent community facing emerging sustainability challenges.

A single-case design has certain limitations compared to multiple-case designs, as evidence drawn from several cases is often more compelling which contributes to a stronger overall study, but at the same time multiple case studies may require considerable time and resources beyond what is feasible (Yin, 1994). As the study's aim was to explore how a conscientious place branding perspective could be understood in a small tourism-dependent community, focusing on only Saltstarumen as one case made it possible to examine stakeholder perspectives and local conditions in more detail than what would have been possible across multiple cases.

The study followed a holistic case study design, which means it focused on a single unit of analysis. When a case includes several identifiable subunits, it is instead defined as an embedded design with multiple units of analysis (Yin, 1994). The unit of analysis in this study was Saltstraumen as a community. Internal stakeholders, including residents, local businesses and public actors, were treated as sources of data rather than separate units of analysis. Although these stakeholder groups may have different perspectives, the purpose of the study was not to compare them systematically, but to understand how their views together contribute to the overall understanding of Saltstraumen and its potential branding development. By including multiple stakeholder perspectives, the study captured the case

from several angles (Moore et al., 2011), which was important for exploring how a conscientious place branding perspective may support the development of place brands in Saltstraumen. If stakeholder groups are given too much attention as separate subunits it could shift the study away from its overall purpose by drawing attention away from the case as a whole and its larger unit of analysis (Yin, 1994).

A further feature of the case warrants flagging. Saltstraumen does not have a deliberately constituted place brand in the sense the place-branding literature uses the term: no brand owner at the village scale, no articulated identity statement, no positioning work, no stakeholder process producing a brand. The destination communication that surrounds the place is distributed across three sources of authorship, none of which sits at the village scale: regional and national destination marketing (principally Visit Bodø and Visit Norway), commercial communication attached to a single operator-branded fishing site (Saltstraumen Brygge), and an informal sport-fishing reputation produced and circulated by anglers themselves through online platforms, travel blogs, and word of mouth (e.g., Fishbrain, n.d.; Dutch Anglers, 2016). The village engages with all three as inherited rather than as authored. The thesis treats this condition as analytically productive rather than as a limitation of the case. Conscientious place branding, in the form developed in the literature review, is a normative-prescriptive framework that articulates what a place brand should be answerable to if one were to be deliberately constituted; it does not require that a brand already exist for the framework to be applicable. At Saltstraumen the constituents of a place brand (identity, fairness, sustainability, organisational openness, transparency and accountability, economic orientation) are present and contested in the data, while the apparatus of branding is not. On this reading the case becomes a productive site for asking what any future conscientious place brand at Saltstraumen would have to be answerable to, and what tensions among those constituents the analysis surfaces. The gap between an absent brand and present constituents is itself reportable; it is the condition under which one of the chapter's data-driven findings, the Multi-level governance and accountability gaps sub-theme under Transparency and Accountability, is legible at all.

3.4 Data collection

There are several data collection methods and case studies according to Yin (1994) has six common sources of evidence: interviews, documentation, direct observation, participant-observation, archival records and physical artifacts. Additional sources in case studies can also be photographs, films and projective techniques. This study used interviews to collect primary data and the secondary data collected was maps of the area, pictures taken by the researchers at the place, formal/legal documents and official government/tourism portals sources of evidence.

Case study interviews can take the form of being fully open-ended, focused or a formal survey with structured questions (Yin, 1994). The primary data for the study was collected through focused, semi-structured interviews with key local stakeholders in Saltstraumen. Focused interviews last for about an hour, are open-ended while still being derived from a

protocol with set questions (Yin, 1994). Semi-structured interviewing style is appropriate in qualitative inquiry because it supports rich accounts of meanings while allowing flexibility to probe emerging issues during the conversation (Schensul, 2011; Moore et al., 2011). Interviews are an important source of evidence in case study research because case studies focus on human experiences. These human experiences are best understood through the perspectives of those involved where participants with relevant knowledge contribute insights into the situation studied (Yin, 1994).

The interview guide used for the study was developed based on McCracken's (1988) method (for interview guide see Appendix A). First an extensive review of the literature on place branding and conscientious branding was conducted as the literature review contributes to defining the research problem and also guiding the development of the interview guide. It sets the scope of what the interviews will focus on, identifies categories and relationships in the data while it also helps the researcher know both what questions to ask and what to pay attention to in the interview responses (McCracken, 1988).

In the next step the interview instrument was developed. First the biographical questions related to name, age and job positions were asked as they provide basic descriptive information about the respondent. These details provide context for the interview and help the researcher interpret the respondent's answers in relation to their background during the analysis (McCracken, 1988). The interview guide consisted of six main questions with the first questions about an overall description of Saltstraumen as a "grand tour" introductory question. The rest of the five questions were mini tour questions further connected to Saltstraumen. One question covered each of the framework's four dimensions; transformative public purpose, stakeholder fairness and shared well-being, temporal and ecological responsibility, participatory openness and co-creation and a fifth question covered the cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability. The grand and mini tour questions were open-ended and non-directive that allowed respondents to describe their experiences in their own words. The aim is to encourage participants to speak freely, without restricting the content or direction of their responses as the questions should not imply the direction of the answer (McCracken, 1988).

All of the tour questions had probing questions included to make sure that important aspects from existing theory were covered. It is useful to prepare follow-up probing questions on key research issues in case they are not brought up during the answer to the more open-ended questions of the interview (Perry, 1998). McCracken (1988) explains that frequently important themes from the literature review do not always come up on their own in interviews and in these cases the interviewer would take a more active role and use planned prompts to bring these topics into the discussion. The planned prompts were only asked if the respondent did not already provide the answers for them in the main tour questions. The prompts included category-based questions, asking participants about key actors such as residents, businesses, the community, the environment, the economy and tourism, as well as exceptional incident prompts that asked respondents to recall specific situations as examples related to the questions. The interview guide also had floating prompts used throughout the interview such

as “Could you tell me more about that?” or “Can you give me an example?” as these prompts used in combination with the tour questions could be enough to help generate responses that are detailed enough without needing to ask all the planned prompt questions (McCracken, 1988).

The interview guide was piloted with the first respondent (R6) in version 1.0 and revised once before being used with the remaining respondents. After the pilot interview, in discussion with the supervisor, an explicit prompt about the marine protected area was added to the second mini-tour question, on the basis that R6 had raised the MPA spontaneously and at length and that subsequent interviews would benefit from a planned cue if the topic did not emerge on its own. No other changes were made. The revised guide (version 1.1) was used from R11 to R13 without further amendment and is reproduced as Appendix A. R6's interview was retained in the analysed dataset because the substantive content the new prompt was designed to elicit was already present in the pilot transcript.

The interview guide was informed by the synthesised theoretical framework on conscientious place branding, while remaining open-ended so participants could introduce locally meaningful issues beyond those anticipated in the literature (Lapan et al., 2011; Schensul, 2011). This design also reflected an abductive research approach in which surprising or puzzling observations from the field are used to refine and elaborate the conceptualisation of conscientious place branding through iterative movement between data and theory (Braun & Clarke, 2019).

The researchers approached Saltstraumen largely as outsiders to the community, while access was eased through the partner dive centre NORD&NE. This positioning carried both advantages and limits for the interviews. Following McCracken's (1988) argument that a degree of distance from the culture under study helps the interviewer treat as strange what members treat as self-evident, the researchers' relative unfamiliarity made it easier to question taken-for-granted local meanings rather than read past them. The same distance could also reduce rapport and limit access to local knowledge, and the connection to NORD&NE may have shaped how some respondents positioned themselves in relation to the topics raised. These dynamics were treated reflexively during fieldwork and analysis rather than as a bias to be eliminated, consistent with the reflexive stance set out in sections 3.6 and 3.7.

3.4.1 Secondary data collection

In line with case study methodology, the interviews were complemented by additional secondary data case materials such as municipal planning and strategy documents, marketing materials, secondary interviews, websites, researcher field notes, newspaper articles and maps of the area. These supplementary materials were not analysed in the same depth as the interview transcripts, but supported triangulation by comparing stakeholder accounts with institutional and public-facing narratives about the place (Moore et al., 2011). Based on Yin (1994) the additional case study data from the six sources of evidence were field observation, documentation, archival records and complementary interviews.

Field Observation: Alongside the documentary and interview material, the fieldwork included a period of direct field observation during the researchers' visit to Saltstraumen. Yin (1994) lists direct observation and participant observation among the six sources of evidence available to case study research, and Mulhall (2003) describes observation in qualitative inquiry as a way of attending to the physical setting, the use of space, and the everyday conduct of a place that interviews alone do not capture. The visit took place over approximately three days in April, before the main tourist season, so systematic observation across the seasonal cycle was not feasible: many businesses and the local museum were closed, and the level of visitor activity was low. Within these limits, the researchers walked the site, documented its geography and built environment photographically, and recorded reflexive field notes on the layout of the place, its signage and visitor infrastructure, and the social patterns observable during the visit. One researcher also dived the maelstrom, the natural feature on which the site's tourism rests, which afforded a brief but direct experience of the principal visitor activity and is reported here as participant observation to a limited extent.

Consistent with the study's social constructivist orientation and its reflexive analytic stance (section 3.5), these observations are treated as the situated readings of the researchers rather than as objective records of the setting. They are used to orient and corroborate the interview analysis rather than to carry findings on their own, and points drawn from them are flagged as observational where they appear in chapters 4 and 5.

Documentation: Examples of documentations are administrative documents, letters, formal studies and evaluations, agendas and newspaper articles from mass media. Documentation in case study research is often used to support and strengthen evidence collected from other data sources. They may contribute contextual information or clarify details that emerge during interviews and observations. However, documentary material cannot automatically be treated as fully objective evidence of an event, since documents are often revised or altered before publication (Yin, 1994).

The thesis used government reports, official laws and regulations regarding the marine protected area, tourist websites with promotion material and visitor information, business reports and newspaper articles as documentational secondary evidence. The researchers are aware that websites, promotional materials and visitor information documentation has been created partly to present Saltstraumen in particular ways and because of this they may emphasise selected priorities and/or official narratives that leave out tensions or critical perspectives. For this reason, the documents were not treated as completely neutral descriptions of reality, they were compared and complemented with interview data throughout the analysis. Websites used for finding secondary data were for example Visit Norway, Visit Bodø, governmental websites, community websites and fishing forums.

Archival records: Archival records may include different forms of material such as service records, survey data, maps and charts, personal records, organizational records and lists. Their

value in case study research depends on the purpose and context of the individual study. In some cases, archival material can play a central role in the analysis, while in others it may only function as supplementary background information. Since archival records are usually created for particular purposes and audiences rather than for research itself, these original contexts need to be considered critically when evaluating how useful and reliable the material is for the study (Yin, 1994).

The archival record used in this study was maps of Saltstraumen and the marine protected area, and a statistical list of current population count in Saltstraumen. The Saltstraumen map was based on Open Street Map and official governmental documents defining the marine protected area boundaries, while the population statistics were retrieved from Norway's national statistical institute. Although these materials were not originally produced for research purposes, they were considered suitable for the study because they provided geographical and demographic background information that supported the analysis of Saltstraumen's community structure and the marine protected area discussed by respondents during the interviews.

Complementary interviews: According to Yin (1994), focused interviews can be useful for confirming or clarifying information that has already emerged during the research process, rather than only for exploring entirely new broad themes. But at the same time researchers need to be careful not to rely too heavily on a single key informant, since close interaction with one participant may influence how the researcher interprets the case. To reduce this risk information provided by key informants should be compared with other sources of evidence and contrasted with perspectives that may challenge or differ from their accounts. Interviews were the main source of data collection in the study and the respondents formed the primary interview sample. A complementary interview was used in this study as an additional interview conducted to clarify topics that had emerged during earlier interviews and to obtain information that the main respondents were unable to explain in sufficient detail. The complementary interview therefore functioned as a supplementary source of information rather than as part of the main interview process. The original interview guide was not followed during the complementary interview, as the questions were developed directly from topics and uncertainties that had emerged during previous interviews.

The complementary interview was conducted jointly with two representatives of the regional administration in Nordland Fylkeskommune, via video call, after the main fieldwork had concluded. The topics covered included the formal mandate and composition of the Ressursgruppe, the status of the marine protected area regulation, the regional position on cruise tourism, and the provenance of the regenerative tourism strategy that Nordland Fylkeskommune is currently the first county in Norway to develop. The interview was recorded with the respondents' permission. No individuals are identified by name, and where the material is drawn on in chapters 4, 5 and 6 it is attributed to "representatives of the regional administration." The audio recording and a verbatim transcription are retained with the rest of the study data. While having two participants present reduced the risk of relying on a single informant, both representatives worked within the same regional administration and

may therefore have shared similar perspectives on the topics discussed. This interview was used primarily to clarify procedural and governance-related questions rather than as a stand-alone source of evidence. Where the same topics appeared elsewhere in the material, the information was compared with documentary sources and the accounts provided by the main respondents.

3.4.2 Sample selection

Different sampling techniques can be used when choosing the appropriate section of a population that is to be studied. First of the two main techniques are probability sampling, which is based on random selection and allows researchers to draw conclusions about the broader population based on the sample, and includes for example cluster sampling, simple random sampling, multiphase and multistage sampling. Non-probability sampling refers to methods where participants are not selected randomly, therefore not everyone has an equal chance of being included and that could result in a biased sample. Common non-probability sampling techniques are convenience/purposive sampling, quota sampling and snowball sampling (Acharya et al., 2013). The study used non-probability sampling, combining purposive sampling with snowball recruitment to reach information-rich participants who can speak to Saltstraumen's identity, tourism development and sustainability tensions.

Purposive or convenience sampling is a commonly used method where the sample participants are selected based on their availability and ease of access to the researcher. A limitation of this sampling method is that bias cannot be measured or controlled and the results are not generalisable to the wider population (Acharya et al., 2013). Purposive sampling was appropriate because the research questions focused on stakeholders who are centrally involved in, or affected by, tourism development and place branding in Saltstraumen, rather than on statistical representation of the wider population (Schensul, 2011; Moore et al., 2011).

On this basis, initial participants were deliberately selected from several stakeholder internal categories, including tourism entrepreneurs (such as the partner firm NORD&NE), residents, representatives of local associations and municipal officials with responsibility for tourism, planning or environmental management. The purposive criteria emphasised heterogeneity across stakeholder roles while maintaining a shared connection to the case: all interviewees had to be at least 18 years old, live in or have a strong ongoing involvement with Saltstraumen, and have some direct experience of tourism or community activities in the area. Within these boundaries, attention was paid to gender balance, a spread of ages and variation in length of residency so that both long-term residents and newer arrivals were heard, including at least one participant from a younger adult age group (Schensul, 2011). This heterogeneous yet case-bound sample was consistent with the emphasis on participatory co-creation in the theoretical framework, where multiple stakeholder perspectives are seen as central to negotiating the place brand.

For this single-case, exploratory study the target was around 12–20 semi-structured interviews, with the final number determined by ongoing judgement of saturation and information power rather than a fixed quota. In reflexive thematic analysis, Braun and Clarke (2019, 2021) caution against treating saturation as a simple numerical endpoint and distinguish between data saturation (no new information appearing in transcripts), thematic or code saturation (no new codes or themes emerging) and meaning saturation (a deepening, rather than expanding, understanding of existing themes). The present study monitored all three: data collection continued until interviews repeatedly surfaced familiar accounts of the place and its tourism dynamics, no substantively new codes were being generated, and further interviews were adding depth and nuance to existing themes rather than opening new ones.

Saturation in this sense is sensitive to the composition of the sample. Malterud et al. (2016) argue that the number of interviews required depends on the information power of the data, which is higher when the study aim is narrow, the sample is specific to that aim, the theoretical framing is well established, the dialogue quality is strong and the analytic strategy is case-focused. Sample homogeneity matters in both directions: a more homogeneous sample tends to reach saturation with fewer interviews because participants draw on shared frames of reference, while a deliberately heterogeneous sample, as in this study, generates a wider range of perspectives and therefore typically requires more interviews before redundancy sets in (Malterud et al., 2016; Braun & Clarke, 2021). The sampling strategy used here was heterogeneous across stakeholder roles (residents, tourism operators, municipal officials, association representatives) but homogeneous in case attachment (all participants had a direct, ongoing connection to Saltstraumen and its tourism). A target of 12–20 interviews was therefore judged appropriate: broad enough to capture variation across stakeholder positions, but bounded by the shared case context which concentrated information power (Malterud et al., 2016; Moore et al., 2011; Schensul, 2011).

Snowball sampling was applied to expand the sample, with initial interviewees invited to suggest additional participants who met the criteria and represented perspectives that may otherwise be difficult for the researcher to access. Snowball sampling is a pragmatic strategy in qualitative research for reaching additional relevant participants through existing social networks, especially where the population is small and locally embedded (Parker et al., 2019). A limitation of snowball sampling is that it may introduce bias, as participants are recruited through existing networks and are therefore not independent and it makes it difficult to generalise the results (Acharya et al., 2013). The partner NORD&NE played a key role as a gatekeeper by facilitating contact with other tourism operators, residents and local officials in their network, while care was taken to avoid over-reliance on a single social circle by deliberately seeking referrals/entry points from several different starting points. Data collection continued until additional interviews produced largely redundant insights relative to the study aims, often discussed as saturation or informational redundancy in qualitative case study work (Moore et al., 2011; Schensul, 2011).

3.5 Data analysis

All interviews were audio-recorded with participants' consent and transcribed verbatim to preserve the detail of stakeholders' accounts. The textual data was then analysed using reflexive thematic analysis (TA) as outlined by Braun and Clarke, which provided a flexible and systematic approach for identifying and interpreting patterns of meaning across a qualitative data set (Braun & Clarke, 2006). This method was well suited to an exploratory case study because it can accommodate both descriptive summaries of participants' views and more interpretative analysis of underlying assumptions about community, sustainability and branding.

Reflexive TA was selected after a deliberate comparison with other qualitative approaches that could plausibly have been applied to interview data on Saltstraumen's identity, sustainability and tourism. Following Braun and Clarke's (2021) guidance that researchers should make a "knowing" methodological choice rather than default to the most familiar "off-the-shelf" methodology, three alternatives were considered and ultimately rejected: interpretative phenomenological analysis (IPA), grounded theory (GT) and qualitative content analysis (QCA).

IPA was considered because it is widely used for interview-based studies of meaning-making, but it was judged a poor fit on several grounds. IPA commits the researcher to a phenomenological framework focused on the personal lived experience and sense-making of a small, demographically homogeneous sample, with detailed analysis of each case before any cross-case comparison (Braun & Clarke, 2021). The present study, by contrast, deliberately recruited a heterogeneous stakeholder group of residents, local business owners and city officials in order to surface convergence and divergence in their desired place image, and is interested in patterns across this group rather than the unique experience of any one participant. Braun and Clarke (2021) recommend reflexive TA over IPA when the sample is heterogeneous, when the analytic focus is solely on cross-case themes, and when the research question reaches beyond personal sense (making) into a wider socio-cultural context, all factors which apply here.

Grounded theory was rejected for a different reason. GT is a methodology, not just a method, and it commits the researcher to constructing a substantive theory of a social process from the data by deferring engagement with existing literature to avoid "contaminating" emergent categories (Timmermans & Tavory, 2012). The aim of this thesis is not to build a new substantive theory of stakeholder behaviour but to test, refine and extend an existing theoretical framework, conscientious place branding, against stakeholders' accounts. Working within GT's inductive logic would have been inconsistent with that aim, and Timmermans and Tavory (2012) note that strict adherence to GT's inductive precept has in fact rarely delivered the theoretical innovation it promises. Reflexive TA, in contrast, is theoretically flexible and allows codes and themes to be informed by prior theory alongside data-driven readings (Braun & Clarke, 2019; Braun & Clarke, 2021).

Qualitative content analysis was also considered and rejected. QCA overlaps with TA in technique but is typically presented as atheoretical and tends to produce descriptive topic summaries, often with an emphasis on coding reliability and inter-coder agreement between independent coders (Braun & Clarke, 2021). Although this study was conducted by two researchers, their joint involvement was not used to establish reliability through measured agreement; rather, both researchers' subjectivities were treated as analytic resources, with discussion and disagreement serving to deepen interpretation rather than to discipline it toward a single "accurate" coding — a stance consistent with reflexive TA but at odds with the (post) positivist orientation that frequently underpins QCA (Braun & Clarke, 2021). Braun and Clarke (2021) advocate TA over QCA on the grounds that TA forces the theoretical bases of the analysis to be made explicit, which suits a study that draws on conscientious tourism, place branding and stakeholder theory as sensitising frameworks.

Reflexive TA was therefore chosen because it offered the best methodological "fit" with the project's research questions, its heterogeneous stakeholder sample, its abductive engagement with existing theory, and a two-researcher reflexive design in which both analysts' interpretations are treated as analytic resources (Braun & Clarke, 2021).

3.5.1 Procedure: Braun and Clarke's six phases

The analysis followed Braun and Clarke's six recursive phases: familiarisation with the data, systematic coding, generating initial themes, reviewing themes against the data set, defining and naming themes, and producing the analytic narrative (Braun & Clarke, 2006). First, the researchers read and re-read the transcripts and associated field notes, noting initial impressions and potential connections to the theoretical concepts. Second, segments of text relating to perceptions of Saltstraumen's identity, sustainability, tourism development, stakeholder roles and future visions were coded line-by-line, combining inductive codes that arose from the data with more theory-informed codes linked to conscientious tourism and place branding.

In the subsequent phases, related codes were clustered into candidate themes (for example, shared values around protecting nature, tensions between economic growth and ecological limits, or practices of everyday stewardship), which were then refined by checking whether they coherently captured the coded extracts and whether they meaningfully addressed the research questions. The final set of themes was written up with illustrative quotations and analytic commentary that linked individual narratives to broader discussions about conscientious place branding and stakeholder alignment.

3.5.2 How reflexive thematic analysis accommodates the abductive research approach

The choice of reflexive TA is consistent with the abductive logic behind this study. Following Timmermans and Tavory (2012), abduction is treated as the primary mode of inference rather than a secondary check on inductive findings. Theoretical insight is generated by recognising surprising or anomalous features of the data against a background of existing theories, and by

puzzling out which theoretical framing best accounts for what stakeholders actually say. This orientation requires a method that is theoretically flexible, that treats the researcher's prior theoretical knowledge as a resource rather than a contaminant, and that builds in repeated, reflective re-engagement with the data, all of which are characteristics that distinguish reflexive TA from both inductively oriented GT and atheoretical QCA (Braun & Clarke, 2019; Braun & Clarke, 2021).

Three features of reflexive TA make it a particularly suitable analytic vehicle for abductive analysis as Timmermans and Tavory (2012) describe it. First, their notion of revisiting the phenomenon which is the idea that meaning "overflows" any single encounter with the data and is reconstituted through repeated re-readings, finds synergy with Braun and Clarke's six-phase procedure, in which familiarisation, coding, theme generation and theme review are iterative rather than linear (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Braun & Clarke, 2019). In practice, transcripts were revisited multiple times, with codes evolving as the researchers' understandings of stakeholders' accounts deepened and as different theoretical lenses (place branding, conscientious tourism, stakeholder alignment) were brought to bear.

Second, Timmermans and Tavory's (2012) principle of defamiliarization: using inscription, transcription and coding to surface the taken-for-granted, is achieved through reflexive TA's position on coding as a subjectively mediated act rather than a labelling exercise (Braun & Clarke, 2019). Verbatim transcription and line-by-line coding slowed engagement with the material and made it possible to question assumptions about, for example, what "sustainability" or "community" meant to different Saltstraumen stakeholders, rather than treating these terms as self-evident.

Third, Timmermans and Tavory (2012) argue that abductive analysis depends on alternative casing: working through the same data excerpt in light of several theoretical frameworks to see which best illuminates it and where existing theory falls short. Reflexive TA accommodates this through its acceptance that codes and themes can be inductively grounded in the data and deductively informed by theory simultaneously, and through Braun and Clarke's (2019) insistence that themes are generated by the analyst rather than passively "emerging" from the data.

The abductive stance was operationalised through continual movement between empirical themes and the theoretical framework. Where stakeholders' accounts aligned with existing concepts of place branding and conscientious tourism, the framework helped organise and interpret the data; where their accounts departed from these concepts, those departures were treated as analytically productive rather than as noise. Following Timmermans and Tavory's (2012) logic of *alternative casing*: repeatedly asking which theoretical framing best accounts for a given excerpt, such departures were first documented and discussed in their own right, and then used as a basis for proposing refinements to the conscientious place branding framework so that it more faithfully reflects the local reality of Saltstraumen (Braun & Clarke, 2019; Timmermans & Tavory, 2012). In this way, reflexive TA provided the

methodological scaffolding through which abductive theoretical refinement could be carried out in a transparent manner.

3.5.3 From pre-interview to post-interview codebook

The pre-interview codebook (Appendix D) was developed from the literature review and the conceptual framework, before fieldwork, as the orienting move that an abductive design requires (Tavory & Timmermans, 2014; Timmermans & Tavory, 2012). It set out five themes (Identity; Fairness and Inclusion; Sustainability; Organisational Openness; Transparency and Accountability) with sub-themes and a small number of broad codes derived from the theory. The codes were generated as categories the framework would expect a conscientious place brand to be answerable to, not as predictions about what respondents would say. The function of the codebook was to orient the analyst's reading of the data, not to fix the analysis in advance (Braun & Clarke, 2019). The analysis presents each sub-theme through several respondent voices read alongside each other, treating the multi-voice composition as a form of triangulation by data source (Fusch et al., 2018). The register device used in the analysis chapter to organise multi-voice material draws on narrative-analytic readings of thematic, structural, and performance dimensions of accounts (Meraz et al., 2019).

The post-interview codebook (Appendix E) that emerged from the data records the analytic movement that followed. Three kinds of change between the two documents are visible and are reported here as evidence of the abductive design. First, a new sub-theme, Multi-level governance and accountability gaps, was generated under Transparency and Accountability. The sub-theme names a structural pattern in the data in which responsibility dissolves as decisions cross legal layers (constitution, state, county, municipality, local board), and brings together coded material on the absence of follow-up, departments avoiding responsibility, actors pointing at each other, processes that are transparent but slow, and information that is published but not findable. The pre-interview codebook had Responsibility / Clarity of roles as the closest equivalent, which framed accountability in single-actor terms. The post-interview sub-theme names a pattern the single-actor framing would not have produced, and the analytic category is one the data forced.

Second, the Organisational Openness theme was restructured. The pre-interview codebook organised the theme into six sub-themes (Formal participation; Everyday participation; Influence and efficacy; Governance style; Co-creation and cooperation; Aspirations); the post-interview codebook re-organises the same theme along three sub-themes (Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer); Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities); Influence and aspirations). The restructure is not a renaming: it consolidates the data along a horizontal-versus-vertical axis that the pre-interview categories did not articulate, and folds Influence and Aspirations into one sub-theme because the data did not separate them as the theory expected. Third, a sixth theme, Economic Orientation, emerged in the post-interview codebook that the pre-interview document did not provide; the theme was generated because a body of coded material accumulated across interviews that none of the existing five themes accommodated. One Economic Orientation extract is dual-tagged across Distribution of

economic benefit and the Sustainability sub-theme Balancing dimensions; the theme total of 58 therefore exceeds the four sub-theme figures (22 + 19 + 12 + 4 = 57) by one.

The relationship between the pre-interview and the post-interview codebooks should not be read as a record of how many pre-interview codes were "used". The pre-interview codebook was a starting orientation; the analytic work was the abductive movement from that orientation through the data to the categories that the analysis chapter reports. The relevant tests of the design are threefold. First, whether the data produced material the theory did not anticipate, it did, in the form of new codes across all six themes, the new Multi-level governance and accountability gaps sub-theme, and the new Economic Orientation theme. Second, whether pre-existing categories were held open to revision in light of the data, they were; the restructure of Organisational Openness and the non-survival of Opportunity structures as a named sub-theme are the visible cases. Third, whether the final categories are defensible against the data, the post-interview codebook and the analysis chapter together carry that argument. On all three tests the design behaves as an abductive design is meant to behave (Braun & Clarke, 2019; Tavory & Timmermans, 2014) and the analysis holds tensions in the data open rather than resolving them where the data does not support resolution (Tracy, 2010).

A related design point should be flagged. One organisation in the village (the local Coop Prix) declined to participate, with staff at the store declining on the grounds that they do not live in Saltstraumen. The refusal is treated in chapter 4 as a finding about who is entitled to speak for the place, not as a recruitment failure. Reading non-participation as evidence is consistent with the abductive design's commitment to letting the data form the categories the analysis reports.

3.6 Trustworthiness: credibility, transferability, confirmability and dependability

To ensure the quality of the qualitative findings, the study addressed four commonly used criteria of trustworthiness in qualitative research; credibility, transferability, confirmability and dependability, which are widely recommended as alternatives to quantitative notions of validity and reliability in qualitative inquiry (Braun & Clarke, 2019).

Credibility concerns the plausibility and believability of the interpretations from the perspective of participants and knowledgeable readers. In this study, credibility was enhanced through triangulation of multiple data sources (interviews, policy documents, promotional materials and field observations), careful attention to diversity within the stakeholder sample and an iterative analytic process that checked emerging themes against the full data set rather than a small number of illustrative quotes (Moore et al., 2011; Mertens, 2011). The study used member-checking at two stages (Birt et al., 2016). During interviews, the researchers routinely paraphrased and summarised respondents' accounts back to them in real time, asking whether the summary captured what they had said before moving on; this surfaced and corrected several minor misunderstandings as they arose. After the main fieldwork, a

complementary interview with representatives of the regional administration (see section 3.4.1) functioned as a further form of member-checking, allowing emerging interpretations about the Ressursgruppe, the marine protected area regulation and the regional regenerative tourism strategy to be tested against an institutional perspective that had not been part of the primary sample.

Transferability is supported through thick description of the case context and participants so readers can judge the relevance of the findings for other settings (Moore et al., 2011; Mertens, 2011). The thesis therefore provided an in-depth description of Saltstraumen's ecological, social and tourism context, the characteristics of the participants and the specificities of the local branding and governance arrangements.

As set out in chapter 1, Saltstraumen sits within a wider class of settings where tourism is economically important but environmentally and socially sensitive: small Nordic coastal communities experiencing tourism growth (Bogason et al., 2025), nature-based destinations with fragile ecosystems and few alternative revenue streams such as Lofoten (Thomas, 2025), and places with formal conservation status that coexists with active tourism use, as in Saltstraumen's marine protected area. It is also at an earlier stage of tourism development than large-scale settings such as Fujiyoshima (McPhee, 2026) or Barcelona (Elorrieta et al., 2022), where over-tourism has already crystallised into a recognised public issue.

That difference in stage matters for transferability: in Saltstraumen the direction of tourism development is still being shaped, which offers more scope for branding and governance choices to influence outcomes before pressures become difficult to reverse. The findings are therefore likely to be most informative for communities sharing some combination of these features: small scale, nature-based appeal, sensitive ecosystems and a stage of development in which place-branding choices can still shape rather than only react to tourism pressure. Readers working in larger urban destinations, or in communities where tourism is marginal to the local economy, will need to read the findings with greater caution, since the stakeholder configurations and the public-value stakes are likely to differ in kind, not only in scale.

Confirmability relates to the degree to which the findings are grounded in the data rather than in the researcher’s prior assumptions or interests. To support confirmability, the research process was supported by a clear chain of evidence including sampling decisions, versions of the interview guide, coding frameworks, theme development and reflections on the researcher’s positionality and collaboration with NORD&NE and how these may have shaped what was observed and reported (Mertens, 2011; Schensul, 2011). The analytic narrative consistently linked interpretations to specific excerpts from the data, making clear how claims about conscientious place branding and stakeholder alignment were supported by participants’ own accounts.

Dependability addresses the consistency and transparency of the research process over time. Dependability was supported by maintaining an audit trail documenting recruitment, data collection procedures, changes to the interview guide and analytic decisions over time, so that

the logic of the study could, in principle, be followed or adapted by other researchers (Lapan et al., 2011). Regular discussions with the thesis supervisor and, where relevant, peers function as a form of peer debriefing, helped to question taken-for-granted interpretations and to ensure that methodological choices remained aligned with the research questions and the abductive, qualitative case-study approach.

3.7 Ethics

Ethical considerations are central to this qualitative case study, particularly because it involves in-depth interviews about participants' experiences of community, tourism and sustainability in a small place where people and organisations are often well known to each other. All participants received clear written information about the purpose of the study, what participation involved, how their data would be used, and their right to withdraw at any time without negative consequences (Appendix B). They then gave written informed consent (Appendix C) before being interviewed, in accordance with established research ethics guidelines. For participants under 18, only adults were interviewed, so informed consent was obtained directly from the participants themselves. The information sheet and consent form differed in some details. Participants signed an earlier version of the consent form (Appendix C) that carried a working title; the title has since been harmonised across the project. The information sheet (Appendix B) advised participants of an interview length of about 30 to 60 minutes; the consent form carried an earlier draft range of approximately 60 to 90 minutes, and in practice the shorter range was used when scheduling and conducting interviews. The consent form included consent to video as well as audio recording: in-person interviews were audio-recorded only, while online interviews on Zoom or Teams were captured with both audio and video by default; video files were used only as an aid to transcription and were not retained.

To protect privacy and confidentiality, all interview recordings were stored securely on password-protected devices, transcripts were anonymised, and any potentially identifying details (such as names of individuals, small businesses or specific properties) were altered or omitted in the thesis and any subsequent publications. Given the small-community context, extra care was taken to avoid deductive disclosure by aggregating details where necessary and by checking that composite descriptions did not unintentionally reveal individuals. Participants were reminded that they could decline to answer any question they found uncomfortable, and that their decision to participate or not participate would not be shared with local authorities or other stakeholders. In line with reflexive approaches to qualitative research and thematic analysis, the researchers treated ethics as an ongoing, relational process rather than a one-off approval step, continuously reflecting on their own roles, assumptions and relationships with local actors when collecting and interpreting data. A reflexive journal and supervision discussions were used to document ethical decisions "in the moment", for example when balancing participants' wishes to be heard with the need to protect them from potential harms, and when navigating dual roles such as working with a partner organisation that also acts as a gatekeeper.

4. Research results

This chapter presents the empirical results of the study. Section 4.1 describes the interview sample and the secondary data sources. Section 4.2 sets out the thematic analysis across six themes: five drawn from the conscientious place-branding framework, and one (Economic Orientation) generated from the data through the abductive movement described in chapter 3.

4.1 Study information

For this study data were collected through semi-structured interviews as well as secondary sources, following Yin's (1994) common sources of evidence for case study research. A total of 17 interviews were conducted with residents from different stakeholder groups and occupations both within and outside the tourism industry. As noted by Moore et al. (2011), qualitative case study research generally continues data collection across multiple sources until saturation is reached, meaning that additional data generates fewer new insights. After 17 interviews, saturation was indicated as the interviews increasingly produced repeated patterns and only a limited number of new codes emerged during the thematic analysis, suggesting that the sample size was sufficient for the purposes of the study. This section provides a detailed overview of the interview sample and the secondary sources used in the study.

Of the 17 interviews included in the study, ten took place at Saltstraumen in Norway between 21 and 24 April 2026. The remaining interviews were held online through Zoom or Teams. Two of these were completed before the Saltstraumen visit, between 17 and 20 April, while the remaining interviews were carried out between 27 April and 6 May 2026. Table 3 provides an overview of the respondents included in the study.

Table 3

Interview respondent information

Respondent	Stakeholder group	Role/responsibility	Length
R1	Resident/Business owner	Does not work directly in tourism industry	57 min
R2	Resident	Work within tourism industry	1 h 6 min
R3	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	1 h and 7 min
R4	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	34 min
R5	Municipal official	Work within tourism industry	29 min
R6	Business owner	Work within tourism industry	1 h and 16 min
R7	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	48 min

Respondent	Stakeholder group	Role/responsibility	Length
R8	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	48 min
R9	Business owner	Work within tourism industry	40 min
R10	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	1 h and 6 min
R11	Business owner	Work within tourism industry	1 h and 14 min
R12	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	1 h and 12 min
R13	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	42 min
R14	Municipal official	Does not work directly in tourism industry	27 min
R15	Business owner	Work within tourism industry	24 min
R16	Business owner	Work within tourism industry	53 min
R17	Resident	Does not work directly in tourism industry	37 min

All interviews were conducted in English and were intended to last between 45 minutes up to one hour. Some of the respondents made it clear that they were busy and only had a limited amount of time (approximately 30 minutes) to do the interview. Therefore the researchers had to adapt the interviews to ensure that the five main topics were covered within the available time by omitting some of the probing questions. Which probing questions were omitted from each interview was decided during each interview based on how the conversation developed and the interviewees' responses. It is worth noting that the two shortest interviews in the sample (R5, 29 minutes, and R14, 27 minutes) were both conducted with municipal officials, the only stakeholder group represented by just two respondents. Both respondents indicated limited availability at the outset, which likely reflects the time pressures commonly associated with public sector work and may partly explain the difficulty of recruiting additional municipal officials. Although the five main topics were covered in both interviews, the small group size and shorter duration mean that the municipal perspective is less developed in the empirical material compared to residents and business owners. This may affect how transferable the findings are to contexts where municipal governance is central, since the governance perspective is based on fewer and shorter interviews than the other stakeholder groups. To address this the interviews were supplemented with secondary data, including official documents and other governance-related sources, which provided additional context for topics that could not be explored in depth during the interviews.

Including respondents both working within (or with) the tourism industry and those who did not have jobs directly connected to tourism was important to capture diverse perspectives on Saltstraumen and its current situation. There were also respondents with direct connection to marine research and to the municipality for more research based and institutional perspectives.

In total eight women and nine men were interviewed across different age groups. The respondents ranged in age from 23-83 years old, with three respondents aged 20-40, ten respondents between 41-60 and four respondents aged 61-85. The age group 41–60 showed the most interest in participating in the study and therefore accounted for approximately half of the respondents, which meant that perspectives from this age group became more dominant in the final sample. The researchers attempted to reach more respondents within both the younger and older age groups but encountered some challenges during the recruitment process.

Among younger residents aged 20–40, several individuals either declined participation or did not respond to interview requests due to not being interested to participate although there may also have been practical reasons for non-response, such as limited time. This may indicate varying levels of engagement with the local community in Saltstraumen and/or weaker place attachment among younger residents compared to the older generations. Some respondents in the interviews described younger residents as generally less involved in local community discussions and more likely to move away from Saltstraumen, which may partly explain the lower participation from this age group. However, these things cannot be fully concluded from this data sample alone.

For the oldest age group, similar efforts were made to find additional respondents, but the language became a challenge for some of them. Since the interviews were conducted in English in a country where Norwegian is the native language, some older residents were less comfortable participating in longer formal interviews. This likely influenced which perspectives became more visible in the study and certain perspectives connected to longer experiences of Saltstraumen could therefore have become less visible than others. The language choice therefore became a methodological limitation, as it affected participation across age groups differently.

Apart from the sample showcased in the table, additional business owners in Saltstraumen were approached directly by the researcher and invited to participate in the interview study. Two agreed to participate, while two business owners declined. Both of those who declined stated lack of time due to busy work schedule as the reason for not taking part. This non-response reflects the conditions under which the fieldwork was conducted, where business owners often combine several roles and have limited time available for participation in research interviews. It could also suggest that participation in the study was more appealing or accessible to those already more engaged in local tourism discussions, while others chose not to prioritise involvement. Since the only reason provided was lack of time, no further interpretation about underlying motivations can be made.

4.1.1 Secondary data info

The secondary data were used as supplementary material to strengthen triangulation and provide additional background for topics discussed during the interviews. All secondary

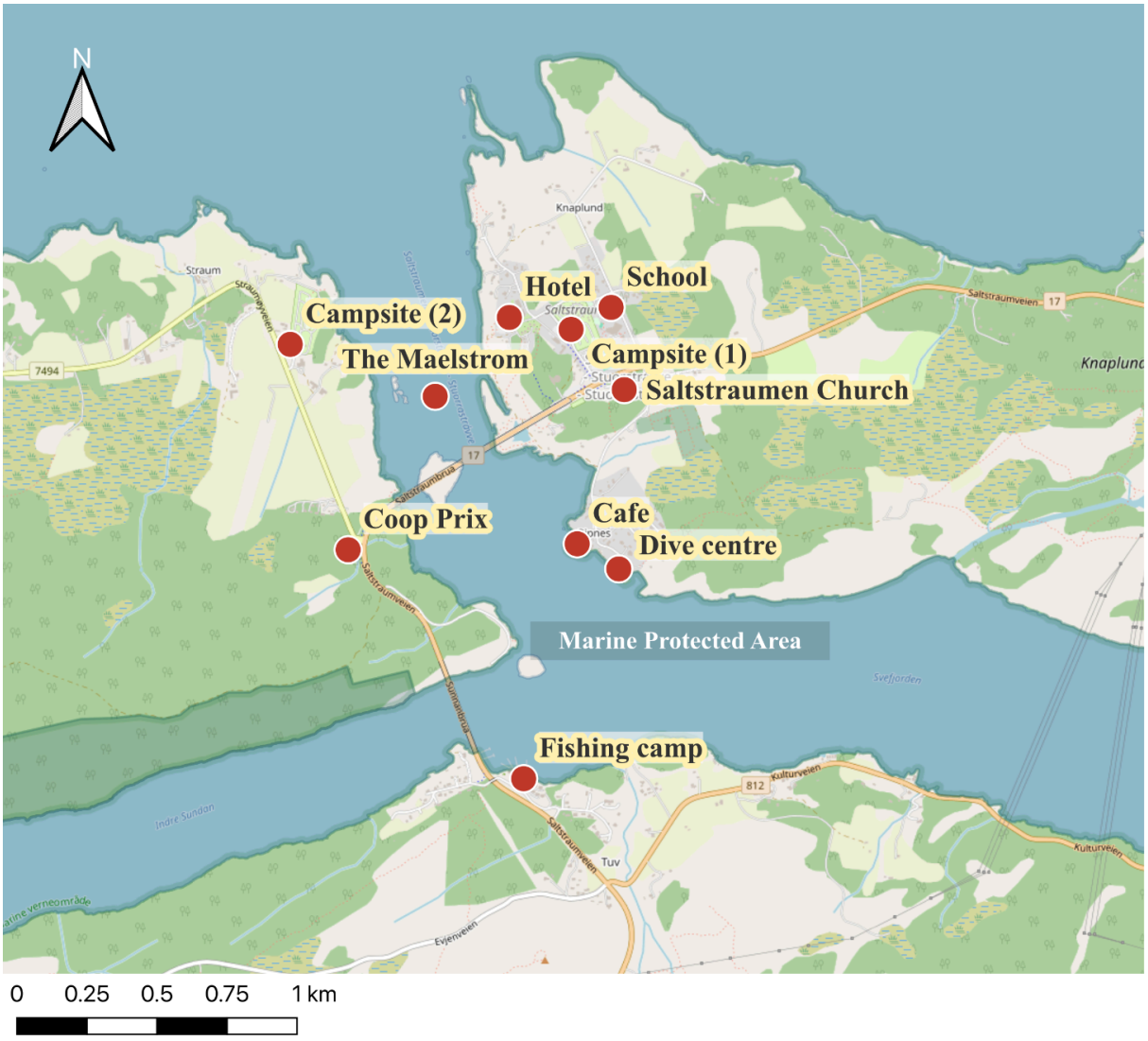
sources were incorporated into the thematic analysis under relevant themes either to support information discussed by respondents or to provide further details important for understanding the case. The secondary material included maps of Saltstraumen and the marine protected area, official regulations and governmental documents connected to the marine protected area, news articles related to events mentioned by respondents, references to official websites (for example Visit Bodø, Visit Norway and governmental webpages), as well as population statistics. An additional complementary interview was also done as part of secondary data.

4.1.2 Saltstraumen case information

Saltstraumen refers both to the strait located between Saltfjorden and Svetfjorden, and to the village situated on the eastern side of the strait. The Saltstraumen bridge (Saltstraumbrua) connects the eastern and western sides of the area (Google Maps, n.d.a). Figure 1 on the following page illustrates the area and consists of a main image and a smaller inset image.

Figure 1

Map of Saltstraumen



Note. Map produced by the authors using QGIS. Basemap: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL). Projection: ETRS89 LAEA Europe (EPSG:3035).



Map of Saltstraumen showing key sites referenced in the analysis, with locator inset (Europe).

Saltstraumen sits within a marine protected area designated by the Norwegian Environment Agency. The protected zone extends several kilometres beyond the frame of this map, covering the broader tidal current system and surrounding waters. The dot pattern shown over land is a basemap convention indicating forest cover and is not part of the analysis.

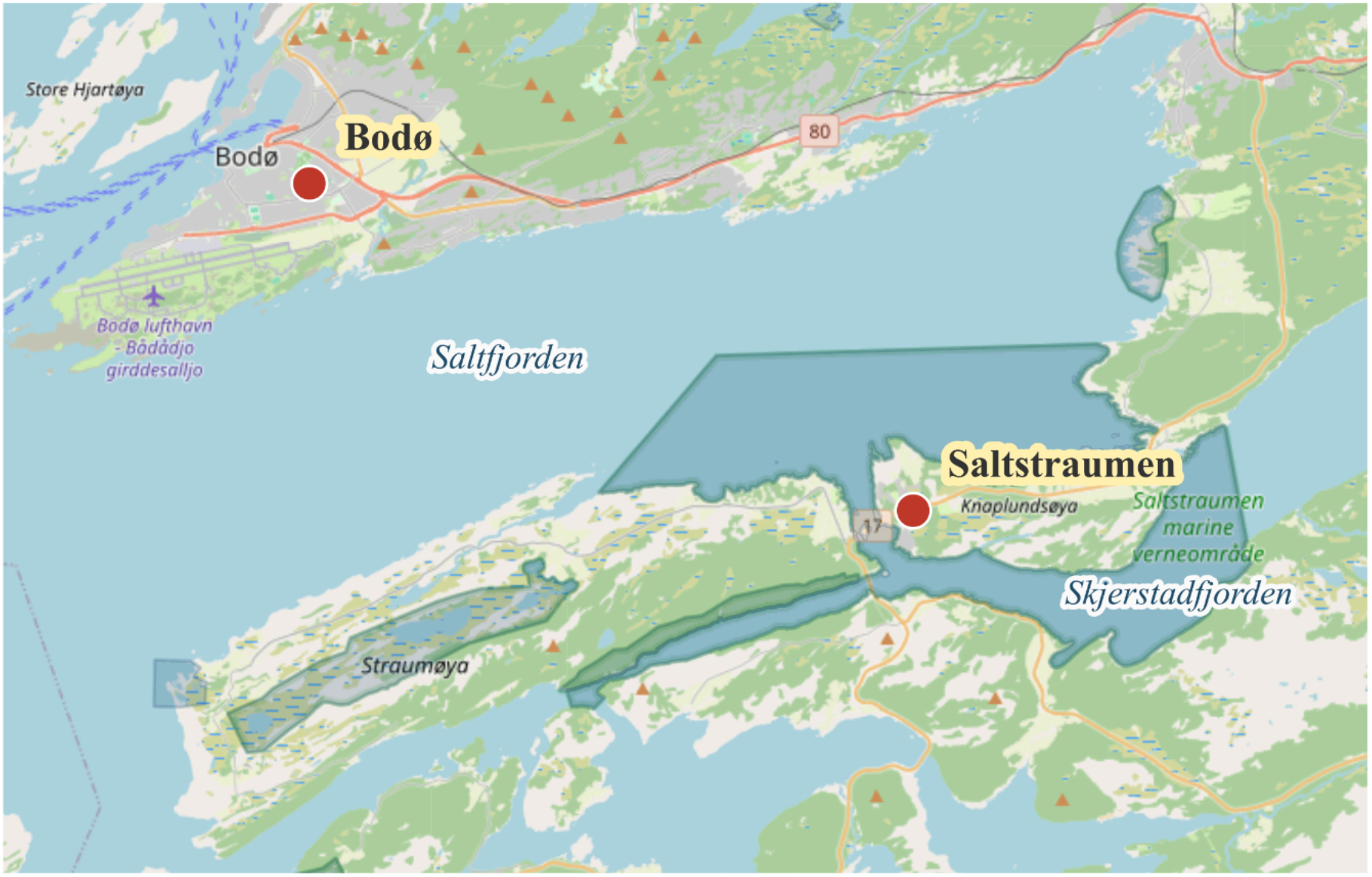
The village of Saltstraumen is a small community located on the eastern side of the strait and includes basic public facilities such as a school, kindergarten, church and a small local museum. Tourism and small-scale businesses are distributed across both sides of the strait. On the eastern side, the Saltstraumen Hotel is located in close proximity to Pluscamp Saltstraumen Camping. On the opposite side of the main road (Kystriksveien) running through the villages, additional businesses include the café Kjelen, the dive centre NORD&NE and Saltbrygga Arctic Salt, a local salt production business operating in the same building complex as the dive centre.

Although official mapping and geographical references often distinguish the village core as being located on the eastern side, several businesses on the western side also use "Saltstraumen" in their postal address, including the local grocery store Coop Prix. The western side also contains additional tourism-related accommodation and activity providers, such as camping Saltstraumen–Elvegård, the fishing camp Saltstraumen Brygge, and Tuvsjyen, which offers experience-based accommodation linked to local stone age history.

Saltstraumen has been designated as a marine protected area since 2013 (Lovdata, 2013). The protected zone covers the strait and extends into parts of Saltfjorden and Skjerstadfjorden (see Figure 2).

Figure 2

Saltstraumen marine protected area zone



Note. Map produced by the authors using QGIS. Basemap: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL). MPA polygon: Geonorge / Miljødirektoratet. Projection: ETRS89 LAEA Europe (EPSG:3035).

Since the marine protected area was established, there have been disagreements in the local community about fishing and the protection of marine life. Positions on protection do not line up neatly with which side of the strait an operator is on: across the community they range from an emphasis on continued access for fishing tourism to support for catch limits, seasonal closures and restrictions on commercial extraction. Tourism and small-scale businesses are distributed across both sides of the strait rather than concentrated on one side, and the two banks tend to gather different orientations toward the place: actors on the eastern side tend toward a more collaboratory approach, while the western side gathers more actors oriented toward their own enterprise, the Coop among them as the clearest instance of a business operating on its own terms at a scale beyond the village. This reading of the layout is offered as a reflexive field observation rather than a measured spatial analysis, but it is consistent with the relational understanding of place adopted in this study, in which a place is constituted through the practices and positions of those who use it rather than given as a single fixed location (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015). These differing positions contribute to ongoing discussions within the local community, which are further explored in the thematic analysis together with other findings. The local conditions in Saltstraumen shaped many of the discussions that emerged during the interviews and are therefore important for understanding the thematic analysis in the following section.

4.2 Thematic analysis

The thematic analysis is organised around the conscientious place branding framework set out in chapter 2: four dimensions and a cross-cutting fifth. The chapter's structure follows the framework's elements in order, with the cross-cutting dimension last. The sub-themes used in this chapter are those produced by the abductive movement from the pre-interview codebook through the data; the methodology chapter (section 3.5.3) records the relationship between the two codebooks. The analysis presents each sub-theme through several respondent voices read alongside each other, treating the multi-voice composition as a form of triangulation by data source rather than as redundancy (Fusch et al., 2018). Readers seeking the full code inventory should consult the post interview codebook (Appendix E).

The five labels map onto the framework as follows. Identity corresponds to Transformative public purpose. Fairness and Inclusion corresponds to Stakeholder fairness and shared well-being. Sustainability corresponds to Temporal and ecological responsibility. Organisational Openness corresponds to Participatory openness and co-creation. Transparency and Accountability is the cross-cutting label for what chapter 2 names Integrity and accountability.

Two outputs of the abductive movement should be flagged here. First, one sub-theme of Transparency and Accountability, Multi-level governance and accountability gaps, was generated from the data and was not in the pre-interview codebook; it appears in section 4.2.5. Second, a sixth theme, Economic Orientation, emerged from the data and is addressed in section 4.2.6, after the five dimensional sections, with its theoretical implications taken up in chapter 5. Where pre-interview sub-themes did not survive the abductive movement in

their original form, the relevant material is addressed under the theme to which the data took it, and the analytic decision is recorded in the methodology and noted at the point in the analysis where it is relevant.

Table 4 on the next page presents an overview of the thematic structure used in the analysis by presenting examples of codes connected to each sub theme and main theme. The table is intended to illustrate the analytical process rather than provide a complete overview of all codes used in the study.

Table 4

Table of quotes with their codes and themes from the thematic analysis

Overall theme	Subtheme	Code	Quote
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for residents/locals	For me, Saltstraumen is the local people who live here. The tourists are here a short time of years, a few weeks in the summer. (R1)
	What is it for?	Place for everyday life	For me Saltstraumen is first of all a place to live, not just a tourist attraction. (R9)
	More-than-human place	Place identity vs ecosystem identity	Looking at Saltstraumen as a tourist attraction is one thing, looking at Saltstraumen as an ecosystem is another thing, which requires very different measures and restrictions in terms of who owns Saltstraumen or for whom it is. (R13)
	Historical identity and traditions	Historical identity (Local history)	It's a very rich society regarding… We have tracks after human beings here for more than twenty thousand years. From the Stone Age. The older Stone Age. So it's a very interesting place. (R12)
	Resident identity	Local community: Small community services	It's a small community and we have the services that the small community needs, we have our school, we have our kindergarten. There are shops and what do you call… old people's homes? (R1)

Overall theme	Subtheme	Code	Quote
	Emotional meanings	Place attachment	This is the place you can breathe. For me this is the best place to be. I run the [nearby business], but it's here my heart is. (R15)
	Place image and brand	Supporting external place brand (unwillingly)	What we are really angry at is that Bodø kommune uses Saltstraumen as an attraction to get tourists to Bodø because this is one of the main extra attractions in the whole area. (R6)
Fairness and inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders not listened to	We can say what we think, but in the end others decide what happens here. (R9)
	Access and Inclusion	“Allemannsretten” (the right to roam)	It is for everyone, of course, and that's Norwegian law, right? So, you can always go to the coast wherever you are. (R13)
	Distribution of benefits	Business owners benefitting	I believe it's the local businesses; they benefit with the guests visiting them. (R5)
	Distribution of burdens	Locals vs tourists	It's been too much now... they are going into their garden and they see all these boats fishing all the time. (R15)
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fear of losing fishing rights (and way of life)	I don't want it to be forbidden for us to take one fish for dinner which we have done for hundreds, thousands of years. (R2)
	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing quota and/or boat limits/gear regulations	The people that makes hooks, fishing hooks and fishing line are coming now

Overall theme	Subtheme	Code	Quote
			with a new generation, soon the lead is gone, so it is not gonna be a big problem in the future. (R9)
Organisational openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Collaboration among local businesses	You have to take people in there who do not agree with you. (R8)
	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Collaboration between local actors and external authorities	So without those two, it would have been only Bodø kommune and the businesses and the local people. I think it would have been as all the other years, talk, talk, talk, and then nothing. So this different system working together is definitely a big difference. (R6)
	Influence and aspirations	Gatekeepers and brokers	We need to clearly write down and agree about what is the goal of Saltstraumen and then we need to hold it up for the businesses and the politicians. (R6)
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of action from politicians	We've had folk meetings, asking for toilets, more information; five years later nothing has happened. (R11)
	Communication	Information readily available	It's on Facebook. It's in the Saltströmmen group and it's in the media. (R10)
	Regulations and restrictions	No free camping/parking anymore	We are working really hard in this area to have no free camping spaces… not to sleep on the beach, not to sleep in the private areas because we have a lot of other things we want to protect.

Overall theme	Subtheme	Code	Quote
			(R16)
	How and what is measured	Fish stock/population: no long-term studies/ research	There are no systematic studies of fish in Saltstraumen. I knew I couldn't tell or show anything about cod population. The long-term systematic studies of this observational and population studies aren't there. (R3)
	Responsibility	New plan defines responsibility	It is an action plan to identify resources needed and who is responsible, etc. So yeah, it will definitely be debated at least. (R14)
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Residents source of incomes	Most of the people in Saltstraumen are working in Bodø. (R17)
	Limits to growth	Manageable tourism	We don't have, like, overly much tourism. (R4)
	Prosperity through continuity	Indicators of successful development	We'd see it in what kind of tourists come here, do they stay longer. (R11)
	Business oriented future	Further business development	I hope the companies have grown and been more… I know they work a lot with sustainability, but I also hope they work with growing in their own time, like they need to grow. (R5)

The six main themes and corresponding sub themes identified in the thematic analysis are presented in the following section. The quotes included in Table 4 serve as illustrative examples of the empirical material connected to each theme and subtheme. A more comprehensive overview of themes, sub themes and codes is available in Appendix E.

4.2.1 Identity

Dimension 1: Transformative Public Purpose

Identity was one of the main themes connected to the overall place identity of Salstaturmen and consists of three sub themes connected to the theoretical framework: Who is it for?, What is it for? and Emotional meanings, and four sub themes emerged abductively for the study: Historical identity and traditions, Resident identity, More-than-human place and Place image and brand. Historical identity and resident identity sub themes have been combined under one headline to show the progression from back in the days to more modern times. Together these sub themes reflected how the respondents perceived the identity of the place through the users (of the place), the functions it has and the emotional associations attached to it.

4.2.1.1 Who is it for?

The "Who is it for?" The sub theme had codes connected to it such as Place for residents/locals, Place for visitors/tourists, place for nature, place for business and place for everyone. Some respondents described the place as it is mainly for the residents "Oh, for the people who live here, I think… first of all it's for the people who have always" (R15) and R5 as specifically for people who enjoy nature:

> Well, people live in Saltstraumen because of the nature and because of the beautiful surroundings that they have, and of course the people living there they want to stay there because they most probably don't want to stay in an urban small city like Bodø, they want to stay close to nature. (R5)

R8 also connected the place with people who desire a nature connection: "They are living here? They need nature, and they have chosen this place because it was supposed to be quiet.". Other respondents discussed Saltstraumen as a place that is also for tourists "But also it's for tourists to come there and enjoy it." (R6), "When it's lots of tourists and the sun is up… you just feel the energy." (R4) and "The tourism is good for Saltstraumen too. Of course, people should come. We go into Gran Canaria and Sweden and everywhere. Why shouldn't the tourists come to us and see a beautiful place?". Some respondents compare residents to tourists (as Saltstraumen is a big summertime tourist destination in Norway), as that is Salstarumen is not a place for tourists in comparison to residents: "For me, Saltstraumen is the local people who live here. The tourists are here a short time of years, a few weeks in the summer." (R1), "Saltstraumen is for the people that are living here. Saltstaumen was never thought about as a tourist magnet. Never, it's never been made for that" (R16). These responses indicates that Salstarumen's place identity is mainly for the local community people living there instead of a more tourism-oriented place, while tourists

are welcome at the place according to some respondents, the main “who” the place is for according to these respondents would be a resident or local that stay there every day compared to visitors who mainly come there during the summer months.

Read together, the "Who is it for?" material proposes that Saltstraumen is for residents and for visitors at once, and that participants do not regard this as a contradiction so long as the visitor presence remains within limits the residents themselves define. The tension that remains unresolved is therefore not who the place is for, but who decides where those limits sit, and how the formal answer of "everyone" translates into practical conditions of inclusion. Several participants articulate the formal answer with conviction. R1 anchors it constitutionally: "It's a constitutional right to fish. And to say that you cannot fish in Saltstraumen, then you are doing something, and then you have to start a work with changing the law, you have to change the constitution." R3 reaches for the same register through the right to roam: "There's not a lot of places where you can't fish because it is free to fish basically everywhere. And that's basically one of the fundamental principles of living in Norway." R13, reflecting from an outsider-resident position, repeats the formal answer in almost the same words: the place is "for everyone, of course, and that's Norwegian law."

The practical answer is offered, by a different set of voices, as a series of conditions the formal answer assumes but does not produce. R7, working from years of selling fishing equipment to incoming tourists, notes that the formal right is misread in practice ("tourists that come to Norway don't believe what they hear. It's free to fish everywhere, it's allemannsretten. You can go fish in the ocean. You don't have to pay for a licence") and that, when the right is actually exercised at scale, the conditions it produces cut against the residents whose constitutional right it formally is. The same respondent describes a stretch of the maelstrom in summer he no longer fishes himself: "I'm kind of scared, or that I as a fisherman... if it's like this in summertime with all the fishery, I don't go there and fish. I go to other places. I would have a nice time, recreational time. I wouldn't be in this mess of boats and the Germans shouting at each other." R12 describes inclusion as something that happens for groups whose interest is recognised in advance ("they are specially invited if we know that there are questions that have special interest for the businesses"), which works for some constituencies and not others. R11 and R10, on different registers, point to the conditions that make the formal answer hold or fail: signage that is not built for blind or deaf users; alcohol prices that empty the evening events; public transport that stops short of the village. R13, again, ties these threads together at the level of daily life: "if you do not have a car, it's almost impossible to live here. This is very different ten kilometres further in, so where the bus connections are absolutely perfect, more or less, but it stops there." Across the data, the formal answer of "for everyone" and the practical conditions that determine who counts as part of that "everyone" are articulated by different participants and not reconciled with one another.

Following Braun and Clarke's (2019) reflexive stance, the gap between formal universality and practical inclusion is not closed at this point in the analysis. It returns under Dimension 2 (Stakeholder fairness and shared well-being) as a question of distribution, and under

Dimension 4 (Participatory openness and co-creation) as a question of who is recognised as part of the community for the purposes of consultation.

4.2.1.2 What is it for?

Where "Who is it for?" elicited a clear two-part answer of residents and visitors, "What is it for?" returns a plural and overlapping set of registers. Participants name Saltstraumen as a place for everyday life, for fishing, for nature, for history, and for the experience of the maelstrom as a natural phenomenon. These registers are held in parallel rather than ranked, and the same participant frequently moves between them across the course of an interview.

The everyday-life register frames the place as somewhere people live and work, and tourism is secondary to that fact. R1 names this register directly: people in Saltstraumen "work all day, come home, get children in school, kindergarten, make dinner, bring the kids to soccer training or swimming or ballet or shooting or whatever. So it's a normal life." R9 reinforces the same framing in fewer words ("For me Saltstraumen is first of all a place to live, not just a tourist attraction"), and R13, working from an outsider-resident position, holds the two together while keeping the everyday-life register primary: "Saltstraumen is still for the residents here and it's shaped by the residents here, but of course they are also making their money with the tourists." Several participants name the small but functioning community services (the school, the meeting places, the church-organised activities for elderly and young) as part of what the place is for, while also noting their reduction. R7 describes the cutting of the upper school grades as "a setback for the area, for the inhabitants," and R13 puts the same pattern in present-continuous terms: the school "is reduced in terms of the ages they are teaching because there are too few people. All is reduced in a way." What the place is for, on this register, includes its own continuity as an inhabited settlement, a continuity participants describe as under quiet pressure rather than under active negotiation.

The fishing register names Saltstraumen as a place for fishing in several non-equivalent senses. Participants distinguish fishing for food, fishing as a lifestyle, fishing as a residents' practice, fishing for trophies, fishing for re-selling and profit, and tourist fishing as a once-in-a-lifetime experience attached to the maelstrom's reputation. R1 holds the historical weight of the practice: "fishing from water, from the land and fishing from both have been an identity of Saltstraumen, as long as there have been people there. So you cannot just overnight say, 'you cannot do this anymore'." R11 traces the same line forward into the present: "historically wise, this has been the main food source... most people living here are generational living and want to continue that because of the closeness to nature." Several participants then distinguish this resident practice from incoming tourist fishing. R6 names the food-oriented practice approvingly ("I see the value of people who come here, fish, and really stop when they have got the two fish they need for dinner that day, and really enjoy the environment and really eat the whole fish") and contrasts it with trophy practice ("they see that uh fish and they just wreck it all and throw it into the water or just leave it half dead on the fjord because that was not the fish they wanted"). R16 distinguishes commercial-scale extraction from anything that could be called subsistence ("the problem is when tourism comes here with a freezer and big trucks, and takes 1000, 2000, 3000 kilos out. That is

nothing for eating, that's for selling"). R13, separating the trophy and experiential strands cleanly, adds a further distinction: "it's people who are fishing, who probably never have done it before, but they think we need to do it here because it's a special place." The codebook reflects this internal variety: the "What is it for?" sub-theme contains the largest number of unique codes of any sub-theme under Identity, and a substantial proportion of these codes name fishing in some form. The analytic implication is not yet developed here; this is one of the asymmetries the analysis returns to under the fifth, cross-cutting dimension (Transparency and Accountability), where the contrast between the registers participants use and the registers the official brand uses becomes the focal point.

The experiential register, in which the place is for short visits to witness the maelstrom, is the register the official destination communication has largely settled on. Several respondents describe this register from the resident side, often with mild frustration at its narrowness. R11 names the pattern explicitly: "a lot of them pop in to see the whirlpools, bucket-list people, stay for one or two hours, jump off a bus, go over the bridge, look at 'whoa', and they don't really understand what they're seeing." R7 echoes the same scene ("it's a lot of tourists in Saltstraumen that just ships in on the bus and they go around taking pictures and they're gone again"), R12 describes the cruise-ship variant of it ("if you have a very short time, come from a cruise ship, they just walk down to the sea"), and R13 places the visitor on the bridge as the typical move. Documentary analysis (Bowen, 2009) of the Visit Bodø (n.d.a) and Visit Norway (n.d.a) destination pages shows the maelstrom framing as the dominant and in places exclusive descriptor: Visit Bodø lists Saltstraumen under "Main attractions" as "the world's strongest maelstrom" (see Figure 3), and Visit Norway describes it as a "nature experience" defined by "powerful forces in the water between two fjords." Neither page foregrounds the fishing, everyday-life, or history registers participants articulate. The experiential register is therefore the one most consistently shared between residents and the official brand, while the other registers participants name are present in the interview data and largely absent from the official communication.

Figure 3

Saltstraumen Maelstrom Calendar sign



Note. Visit Bodø signage on the door of Saltstraumen Hotel directing visitors to a tide-based "calendar" of optimal viewing times for the maelstrom (visitbodo.com/en/destination/saltstraumen) via QR code. The sign also carries the "Sustainable Destination" certification mark. Photograph by N. Sibly, April 2026 during field work.

The proposition this sub-theme supports is therefore that Saltstraumen's purpose, as articulated by residents, is plural rather than shared, and that the framework's dimension of transformative public purpose finds in this case a contested rather than a coordinated field. Two tensions remain open at the close of this sub-theme. The first is internal to the data: participants articulate several purposes for the place without proposing how they should be reconciled in practice, and decisions taken in any one register (regulation of fishing, development of new accommodation, environmental protection) will tend to advance one purpose at the expense of others. The second is external: the gap between the registers participants articulate and the register the official brand uses is not framed by either side as a disagreement, and the absence of disagreement is itself something the analysis returns to under the cross-cutting dimension.

4.2.1.3 More-than-human place

A sub-theme that emerged in the interviews was the understanding of Saltstraumen as a place with ecological value beyond human use and activity. It was not discussed as frequently as themes connected to residents, traditions or tourism, but it still appeared in several interviews, among respondents with diving experience or strong interest in marine life. A knowledgeable respondent regarding waterlife described Saltstraumen as:

> I would describe it as a wonderful place. It's a very, what I would call, ecological rich area. That's nothing like what people are used to being associated with marine or coastal life and environment because the currents are so strong. So it's really, it's both a sight to behold, but also with the amount of life it brings in and the productivity of the place, it would be like an ecological hotspot that also serves as a source of wonder and kind of amazement of what nature does right in front of your eyes. (R3)

This quote describes Saltstraumen primarily through the ecological processes and marine life existing within the current itself, rather than through human activity connected to the place.

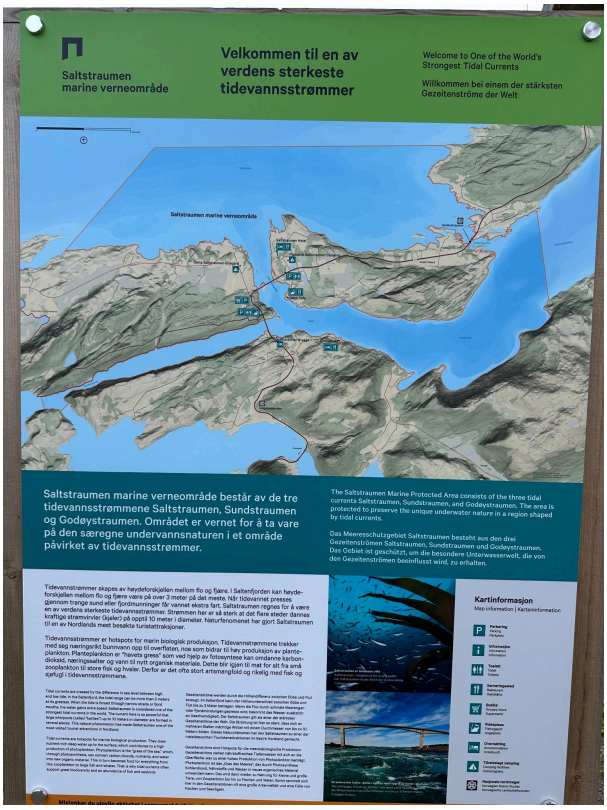
The respondent focused on the richness and productivity of the ecosystem and presented the area as something valuable in its own right.

The ecological significance of Saltstraumen is also documented in secondary sources. Saltstraumen is a narrow strait approximately 150 metres wide at its narrowest point and around 31 metres deep, connecting Saltfjorden and the outer archipelago with Svefjorden and Skjærstadfjorden. The current itself stretches for around three kilometres. Saltstraumen is considered the world's strongest tidal current because enormous volumes of water are forced through the narrow strait four times daily as tidal differences are balanced between the outer sea and the inner fjord system. These large water movements mean that little sedimentation occurs and that there is therefore a large proportion of hard bottom. The water movements carry plankton and other organic particles that provide the basis for a uniquely rich life of sessile organisms that benefit from the large amount of nutrients flowing past (Fagerli et al., 2015).

The marine protected area was established in 2013 with the primary purpose of protecting the seabed and underwater ecological communities (Lovdata, 2013; see Figure 4).

Figure 4

Trilingual welcome sign for Saltstraumen Marine Protected Area



Note. Information board produced for the Saltstraumen marine verneområde, presenting the three tidal currents (Saltstraumen, Sundstraumen, Godøystraumen) that comprise the protected area, an annotated map of the protected zone, and trilingual descriptive text (Norwegian, English, German). The lower right legend lists tourism-related amenities (parking, information, toilets, restaurants, camping, fishing locations, accommodation, scenic routes) within the protected area boundary. Photograph by N. Sibly, April 2026 during fieldwork.

According to Fagerli et al. (2015), an important criterion for the protection of Saltstraumen is that it is a completely unique natural area. The hard-bottom areas with dense biological growth are considered of special value. These tidal current conditions contribute to a very special lush wildlife that is hardly found elsewhere as strong ocean currents transport nutrient-rich particles that sustain abundant marine life. The report describes dense concentrations of sponges, sea anemones, corals, hydroids, molluscs and echinoderms covering large parts of the rocky seabed at varying depths. Rather than focusing

mainly on endangered species in Saltstraumen, the protection is directed toward preserving the unusually rich and productive underwater habitats created by the current system itself.

This ecological focus is also visible in the legal regulation for the marine protected area. Paragraph 1 of the protection regulation states:

> The purpose of the Saltstraumen Marine Protected Area is to preserve an area that contains threatened, rare and vulnerable nature, represents specific types of nature and has special natural scientific value. The goal is to maintain the conservation values without a major degree of external influence, and the area should be able to serve as a reference area for research and monitoring. (…….) The area has a rich fauna, including sessile forms such as sea anemones, shells, sponges and corals. The special current conditions are determined by the geological structures, and are of great importance for the flora and fauna in the area. The protection objective is related to the seabed. (Lovdata, 2013)

The purpose of the marine protected area therefore places ecological value and underwater life at the centre of the protection measures. The regulations frame Saltstraumen as a marine ecosystem considered important to preserve because of its unique biological conditions, beyond being a tourist destination.

The ecological richness of Saltstraumen extends beyond the seabed itself. According to secondary sources, the area contains a wide variety of marine species including cod, halibut, coalfish, wolffish and monkfish, along with shellfish, crustaceans, snails, starfish, bristle worms, seabirds and sightings of marine mammals such as orcas (Haugskott, 2014; Visit Norway, n.d.d). During the field visit, the researchers were also informed by residents about occasional orca sightings in the current, although none were observed directly during the stay. Respondent R3 also described the wider animal life connected to the area: “There's a lot of bird life, a lot of seabirds. There's smaller whales, orcas coming from time to time. And yeah, a lot of things happen at Saltstraumen and I have seen that.”

Business owner R16 described a personal experience connected to the marine life:

> You can stay out here. Then you see the sea wake up. You can see 1000s of fish eating. Down here. They came up. There's bubbles everywhere. And if you want to try fishing, you never get something. ..... I am a scuba diver myself. And we have seen a lot of different things, but like that? No. (R16)

The respondents described encounters with marine life as something extraordinary and difficult to compare with other places. These descriptions were less focused on tourism consumption and more on admiration for the natural processes and biodiversity connected to the current. At the same time, some respondents believed that the ecological significance of Saltstraumen received less public attention than the dramatic visual image of the maelstrom itself. Resident R13 explained:

> At the moment, it's mainly seen as an attraction to see the forces of nature, not so much the biodiversity of nature, as it maybe also should be acknowledged for. People visiting here are looking at the force of the currents and the gyres and everything, the whirlpools, without knowing much about what's underneath. (R13)

The underwater ecosystem was therefore described as partly invisible in the current public understanding of Saltstraumen. Visitors are mainly exposed to the visible power of the current above the surface, while the marine biodiversity below the water receives less attention in tourism narratives and visitor experiences. This perspective became visible in discussions regarding who Saltstraumen is for by business owner R6: “I think the place is for the nature underwater and I think it's for them, and it's for the birds.”

Resident R13 similarly distinguished between Saltstraumen as a tourism attraction and Saltstraumen as an ecosystem: “Looking at Saltstraumen as a tourist attraction is one thing, looking at Saltstraumen as an ecosystem is another thing, which requires very different measures and restrictions in terms of who owns Saltstraumen or for whom it is.

To summarize, several respondents described Saltstraumen as a place whose value was not limited to human use, tourism or local economic activity. The ecological richness of the currents and seabed was instead discussed as something important in itself and something that should continue to exist regardless of tourism development or human interests. In these accounts, marine life, seabirds, underwater habitats and ecological processes became part of the identity of the place itself.

Taking this type of identity into account also changes how questions about tourism and development are understood. If Saltstraumen is viewed primarily as an ecosystem instead of only a tourism attraction, then discussions about use, regulation and the future development become closely connected to questions of environmental responsibility and protection.

4.2.1.4 Historical identity and traditions, and resident identity

A view that emerged strongly during the interviews was the depth of historical knowledge connected to Saltstraumen and its importance to the local community. Participants from different stakeholder groups described Saltstraumen as a place with a long history tied to settlements and fishing in the area. A respondent with extensive historical knowledge described Saltstraumen as: “It's a very rich society regarding… We have tracks after human beings here for more than twenty thousand years. From the Stone Age. The older Stone Age. So it's a very interesting place.” (R12). Business owner R11 also referred to the historical importance of the area: “The Scandinavian oldest music instrument is found here… this ‘brummer’, a small stone… 5000 or 6,000 years old.”

There were respondents who connected this historical depth to the identity of the present-day community. According to resident R12, older generations are viewed as important carriers of local traditions and knowledge:

> Of course we have, like everywhere in Norway, we have an elderly.. a lot of elderly people. More of them and they have all this traditional knowledge, you know. So that's one very interesting part of our interest, to get all these old stories and to keep this old traditional knowledge. (R12)

Fishing was a couple times brought up historically central to both survival and settlement in the area. Respondents from both the pro-fishing and more critical perspectives discussed fishing as part of the historical identity of Saltstraumen. One respondent explained: “when you have current there is always a lot of life in the water and also a lot of life on top of water. So people could find food here from the first people that come here. And since then people have been living here.” (R6). Another business owner stated: “Historically-wise, this has been the main food source for quite a lot of people.” (R11).

Over time, fishing was described as developing from a survival activity into a local tradition and cultural practice connected to everyday life and community identity. Fishing-interested respondent R7 explained: “It's an important place to catch coalfish. It's both tradition and also, many that do not depend, but it's a good resource for quality food on the table.” A municipal official similarly reflected on fishing as part of growing up locally: “Yeah, as a local, we have gone fishing there for ages. I've been there as a kid with my father and we used to go there.” (R5). For these respondents fishing was connected to everyday life and family traditions that had been passed down over generations.

Tourism in Saltstraumen also has a long history, respondents described tourism today as different from earlier times. Business owner R6 stated that “there have been tourists here since hundreds of years ago” (R6), and business owner R16 described how tourism practices have changed over time:

> People came to see nature because at this time, like if you think about 20 years ago, there was… the tourism in this area was not like that. This place here was made for fishing, fisherman's, the fishing families. There was a lot more about fishing in this area before, but it's like time goes, fishing going more and more back. Now, the tourists love fishing. You have people that have never been fishing. (R16)

The quote pointed toward a perceived shift in the identity of the place, where fishing increasingly has become connected to tourism rather than local traditional fishing. Business owner R6 was also critical towards how tourist fishing differs from traditional local practices: “It's so completely against the traditional way of taking care of nature. So fishing is so different here.” The concern expressed by some respondents was not necessarily fishing itself. It was more connected to how fishing is practiced and commercialised through tourism.

Traditional fishermen appear several times in respondents' descriptions of what represents Saltstraumen today. One resident described "The old fisherman. Maybe you have met him? X, he's an old sailor. He has a lot of local history… he is an open history book about this area. So, I really do like him." (R8). Fishing-experienced respondent R3 similarly described local fishers as connected to older traditions and practices:

> I've only talked with a few locals when I've been there. And most of them seem to have this more traditional vibe to them. They do fishing in what I've seen also with the local fishermen and boats there. They do very traditional fishing. They fish for safe with hand lines and not necessarily using fishing rods. And so many of them live this more simple traditional life and at least the fishermen. (R3)

Respondents also described resident identity in broader terms beyond fishing traditions. R10 referred to the residents as "tough-skinned" and "very typical northern Scandinavian." The same respondent connected the older generation to history and fishing traditions, while younger generations were associated more with car interests. These descriptions show how respondents connected resident identity both to older traditions and to everyday community life today.

Several respondents described Saltstraumen in terms of a small community: "It's a small community and we have the services that the small community needs, we have our school, we have our kindergarten. There are shops and what do you call… old people's homes?" (R1). According to Statistisk sentralbyrå (n.d.) approximately 387 inhabitants lived within the official Saltstraumen area code (7504) in 2024. There are other population count measuring pages that estimate it to be over 1200 inhabitants in Saltstraumen such as Kartanalys (n.d.), but they are likely to include inhabitants living nearby Saltstraumen, but just outside of the specific Saltstraumen area code.

At the same time, some respondents described the community as socially difficult to enter for newcomers. A resident who had not lived in Saltstraumen all their life explained:

> It's a very Norwegian community, of course. People usually live here for a relatively long time, at least the ones I know. So it's not that it's very much populated by all kinds of people who moved to Bodø or to the region. It's more the local population here. It is a community. It's a very small community. And sometimes also difficult to be part of. (R13)

The findings suggest that community identity in Saltstraumen was connected to, apart from old traditions, long-term belonging to the specific place and social embeddedness. R10 described that new residents who had moved into the area who had a connection to local institutions, such as schools, would increase social integration within the community. The importance of local services, in particular the school, emerged repeatedly in discussions about community and the future of Saltstraumen. Resident R7 explained "It was, like, very optimistic and young adults established and built their homes here and suddenly… partially

the school time for the kids was lost here. So they have to commute to Tverlandet. And that's important for people settling down (to have a school in the community).”

Several respondents mentioned concerns regarding population decline and the gradual reduction of local services. Bodø municipality decided in 2024 to move the local “ungdomstrinnet” (Bodø Kommune, n.d.; Bodø Nu, 2024), corresponding approximately to lower secondary school, to a nearby community. These types of changes affect how attractive Saltstraumen is for families considering settling in the area. Resident R13 stated: “The tendency, what happens here right now is that the community, that school, the school for example is reduced in terms of the ages they are teaching because there are too few people.”

The reduction of local services could be connected to a gradual weakening of community life and local identity. There were participants that described how Saltstraumen previously had more social meeting places and activities than today. Resident R17 explained: “There is not a pub anymore. Just the hotel and cafe in the summertime. No, it's almost nothing.” and also: “It's nothing to do for children and nothing… no swimming, no mini golf, no.” During the researchers’ visit, both the hotel facilities (apart from the cafe/bar area) and local café were closed outside the tourist season, together with the small local museum. The seasonal opening patterns suggest a perception that many activities in Saltstraumen mostly are organised around summer tourism rather than to have a year-round active community life.

At the same time, several respondents viewed tourism as important for maintaining the community both economically and socially. Business owner R6 thinks that tourism can have an important role in for the people and its community:

> That's one of the really important things I think tourists can build… the identity of the people living there can be more… We can see it clearly. What do we have here.. people want to come to see what it is we have. We have this and that’s special, you can only get that in Saltstraumen. (R6)

Identity co-creation by the people living at Saltstraumen together with the help of tourists. Tourism has the possibility to strengthen awareness of what makes Saltstraumen unique. In this perspective identity would not be fixed as it could be something continuously shaped through interactions between residents and the visitors. However, tensions would also appear between preserving local traditions and adapting identity to the tourism development, regarding fishing and the possibly changing use of the place.

While residents discussed Saltstraumen primarily through identity connected to history and traditions, and their everyday life, respondents also reflected on how visitors are made to perceive the area from the outside. These external perceptions relate more closely to place image than place identity and formed another dimension of how Saltstraumen was understood and represented.

4.2.1.5 Emotional meanings

The emotional-meanings sub-theme captures the registers in which participants describe what Saltstraumen means to them as a place, beyond its functional purposes. Three patterns recur across the data.

The first is place attachment expressed through care. Several participants describe a sense that residents look after the place because they love it, and that this care is constitutive of the place's identity rather than a consequence of its management. R6 articulates this in a form that several other respondents echo: "I think people here are really like their place. They love it and they care for it." R9 captures the affective register in fewer words ("people here are proud of Saltstraumen, they react when someone treats it badly"), and R16 frames the same attachment as a claim on stewardship: "let us, in the area, take care of the area. Let us who live here, take care of this area. Not Bodø kommune or something different, but we people living here, we can take good care of it." R15 grounds the care in specific places within the wider site, describing the pier rather than the bridge as the place where attachment is most intensely felt: "this is the place you can breathe. For me this is the best place to be. I run the [nearby business], but it's here my heart is." Care, in this register, is a felt obligation rather than a policy outcome, and the participants who articulate it tend to be those most engaged in local business or community life.

The second is local pride understood through the recognition of others. Several participants describe a circular relationship between tourism and pride: visitor interest renders the place visible to residents who might otherwise take it for granted, and that visibility produces or reinforces a sense of value. R6: "I think tourism can open the eyes for the people 'wow, we have this, we live in this', and then you also start being more proud and you want to protect it and take care of it. So I think that's a good circle." R1 articulates the inverse and equally telling pattern, in which residents do not see what visitors see: "I live 100 metres from here, but I don't see it. Because it's there, it's always been there all my life. So for me it's okay. That's how people in Saltstraumen think about it. For them it's nothing extraordinary. When tourists come and say 'wow' I think they react differently." Within the same data, a countercurrent is visible: the pride participants describe is partial and uneven, and respondents articulate frustration that the place's recognition by outsiders has not translated into recognition by decision-makers. R6 names this gap in terms of a felt distance from those who decide: "I feel we are far from them, and some of them really don't understand. They have never been to [our places], they have never been to the exhibition, they have never been to the hotel." The tension between pride-through-recognition and being-overlooked by recognition's most consequential audiences is something the analysis returns to under Dimension 2.

The third is a felt sense of impermanence. Several participants articulate, in different registers, a worry that the place as they know it is changing in ways they have not been asked about. The registers differ across speakers (decline of community services, demographic change, increase in holiday homes, ageing of long-term residents, reduction in the school's

age range) but the underlying register is the same: a place participants love is in flux, and the flux is described in the past or future tense rather than as a present project. R7 names the school reduction in those terms ("it's kind of a setback that we had a full school here in Saltstraumen from the first to tenth grade. But they cut off the youth, the eight, ninth, and tenth grade they moved"), R2 articulates the housing variant ("unfortunately some of the houses get to be holiday houses, we are very happy when young couples come with their children and settle down here"), and R13 holds both the long view and the resident's prediction in the same breath: that the school "is reduced in terms of ages they are teaching because there are too few people" and that, overall, "it will not change much." R13's prediction sits in tension with the same respondent's account of community-life reductions: the felt sense is that the place's external presentation will hold while its internal substance erodes.

Two tensions remain open at the close of this sub-theme. The first is the relationship between place attachment as care and place attachment as anxiety: the participants who describe the strongest emotional attachment to Saltstraumen also describe the strongest sense that it is being eroded, and the framework does not yet have language for whether the second is a corollary of the first or a separate finding. The second is the relationship between emotional meaning as articulated by residents and emotional meaning as represented in the official communication: the destination pages name the maelstrom's force and spectacle but do not name the care, pride, or impermanence registers participants articulate, and the asymmetry between affective registers in the data and affective registers in the brand is something the analysis returns to under the cross-cutting dimension.

4.2.1.6 Place image and brand

Place image and brand sub-theme concerned how Saltstraumen was presented to visitors such as what kinds of experiences were promoted and also who benefited from those representations. Discussions about marketing were connected to tensions between tourism development in the overall area and local interests.

Saltstraumen is known internationally to be a fishing destination. Business owner R6 argued that this image is actively promoted: “They are marketing it as a perfect place to fish. Yeah. And they are… of course also because it's been a protected area, lots more people come from other places in the world to fish.” Resident R3 connected this directly to earlier commercial branding strategies:

> It has also earlier been branded and commercialized this way by fishing, like “come and fish in this great marine protected area”. I've seen tons of commercialization with, like, the biggest fish, the best fishing destination in the world, yada, yada, all this. So it for sure also channels people to it, without ever maybe thinking how… what's the current capacity of this whole ecosystem in general, nobody knows. So yeah, in a certain way, it is a little bit Texas. (R3)

R3 has personal experience with fishing practices in the area and reflected critically on how fishing tourism had been promoted without much discussion regarding environmental limits. The respondent's description of Saltstraumen as "a little bit Texas" reflected perceptions of weak regulation and increasing tourism pressure connected to fishing activities. These findings indicate that earlier branding and marketing contributed to strengthening Saltstraumen's image as a fishing destination. At the same time, there were respondents describing attempts to move away from this profile. Municipal official R14 explained: "They don't want to profile it as a fishing place because of the pollution stuff." and they further explained that "The fishing profile is there and it's all over, and it's always going to be there." (R14). Fishing has been going on for years in Saltstraumen both by locals and currently also by tourists based on the data provided in the Historical identity and resident identity sub-theme section, so there is an established fishing identity in Saltstraumen that used to be marked and now there is a newer sustainability-oriented marketing approach.

The current marketing presented on the official Visit Norway website reflects this shift in positioning. Fishing is largely absent from their Saltstraumen page and instead the website promotes the maelstrom itself, diving and snorkelling experiences, local food, shops and historical attractions such as the "stone-age experience" (Visit Norway, n.d.a). The website also includes the following statement:

> Keep in mind: The marine life in Saltstraumen is fragile, and it's recommended to refrain from fishing in the current. The professional divers in the area spend lots of time removing old fishing hooks and lines from the water. If you want to go fishing in the area, go further away from the current, ask locals for tips on the best spots to fish. (Visit Norway, n.d.a)

The current marketing therefore differs from the image several respondents associated with earlier tourism promotion. Rather than presenting Saltstraumen mainly as a fishing destination, the official communication focuses on nature experiences and environmental responsibility connected to Saltstraumen being a marine protected area.

This direction is also connected to broader national tourism strategies. Visit Norway operates under Innovation Norway (special legalisation enterprise owned by the government), which has been assigned responsibility by the Ministry of Trade, Industry and Fisheries in the Norwegian government for promoting Norway as a tourism destination (Woxholt, 2025; Visit Norway, n.d.b). On the website, Visit Norway states that its vision is "to make it easy to choose Norway as a travel destination and to promote a more sustainable form of travel" (Visit Norway, n.d.b). The reduced focus on fishing tourism can therefore be connected to wider sustainability goals within national tourism marketing. This confirms R14 statement about the marketing profiling and similar perspectives appeared in the interviews with municipal connected respondent R5 which described how "responsible marketing" had become increasingly important:

> Responsible marketing is something X work a lot with, so X are concerned about what we market and how we do it. X don't want to give the wrong impression of what Saltstraumen is. So the photos used are quite important for us… that we show the correct story. X don't want to give people the impression that they (the visitors) can do something in Saltstraumen that it's dangerous or that they can destroy it. X want to preserve it so we give the correct information about what to do, when to do it, where to do it, how to do it, and things like that. (R5)

Here, marketing was discussed as a way of influencing visitor behaviour. The interviews with R5 and R14 suggest that parts of the official communication around Saltstraumen increasingly attempt to balance tourism promotion with effort to reduce environmental pressure connected to tourism activities in the area. The marketing has been moving away from the previous fishing profiling to a more experienced based one due to sustainability visions on a government level. However, at the same time, residents and business owners in the local community discussed another side of Saltstraumen's image: its role within Bodø's wider tourism branding. Several respondents argued that Saltstraumen functioned as one of the municipality's main attractions without local communities necessarily receiving equal benefits from tourism growth. Resident R1 covered their perspective of how this began:

> It started with the Bodø kommune. Who has said that we want to have more cruise ships come to Bodø. With cruise ships, you get 1000s and 1000s of people. And to have something for them to do, you have to drive them with buses, to Saltstraumen, or you get on a fast boat, to Saltstraumen, because Bodø doesn't have much. You have Saltstraumen and you have some mountains, the hotel.. or you can go and look at the view. But it's not Lofoten, it's not Tromsø. It's Bodø and it's a hub. You come to Bodø and you stay a little and… and in that short time you have to get to Saltstraumen and see Saltstraumen. (R1)

Bodø is the nearest city to Saltstraumen, about 3 miles away with a population of 43 504 inhabitants, and functions as an important transport hub with both airport and harbour access (Google Maps, n.d.b; Statistisk sentralbyrå, 2025). By looking at official websites it shows that Saltstraumen is prominently featured within Bodø's tourism promotion. On the Visit Norway webpage for Bodø, Saltstraumen is presented as a nearby attraction and "the world's strongest maelstrom" (Visit Norway, n.d.c). Similar presentations appear on Visit Bodø's official website, where Saltstraumen is promoted as one of the area's main attractions "Experience the world's strongest maelstrom – Saltstraumen" (Visit Bodø, n.d.a). And the specific Bodø city page on the website has links related to taking a cruise or boat tour to Saltstraumen (Visit Bodø, n.d.b). Resident R8 mentioned Saltstraumen is one of the places that Bodø benefits from: "These two places, Kjerringøy and Saltstraumen, Bodø City is benefitting a lot from these two places because they are visited a lot, because they are spectacular in their different ways.", and according to business owner R6 the locals are not happy about being used in the branding of Bodø: "What we are really angry at is that Bodø kommune uses Saltstraumen as an attraction to get tourists to Bodø because this is one of the main extra attractions in the whole area."

There were respondents questioning whether Saltstraumen itself benefited economically from this branding relationship. Resident R8 stated: “And I think the city of Bodø is the place that takes most of the money from tourism on these two places. And that's unfair.” This respondent also mentioned that most people who come to view the maelstrom are staying in hotels in Bodø, indicating they are not spending their money in Saltstraumen. Concerns were also raised regarding infrastructure and investment according to a business owner: “They are using Saltstraumen as a selling point… but investment in toilets, signs and information out here has been on the back burner.” (R11). These discussions reveal tensions connected to tourism development and place branding. While Saltstraumen contributes to Bodø’s image as a tourism destination, several respondents felt that the local area carries tourism pressure from Bodø without receiving equal investment or economic return for that. The issue was therefore not tourism itself, but how tourism benefits and responsibilities were distributed.

The findings show that place image and branding in Saltstraumen are shaped by several competing perspectives. Official tourism communication increasingly promotes sustainability and experience-based tourism. At the same time, respondents described tensions connected to fishing tourism and the relationship between Saltstraumen and Bodø, as they felt used by the latter for their benefit. This foreshadows the connection to other main themes such as fairness and inclusion where the questions of who benefits and whose voices are heard and prioritized is central, and also the main theme of economic orientation that covers specifically economic benefits and prosperity. It also connects to broader questions regarding sustainability and governance. Visit Norway mentioned that Bodø has received the certified “Sustainable Destination” and states that the destination works to strengthen “positive ripple effects” from tourism while reducing negative impacts (Visit Norway, n.d.c). However, the accounts from local respondents indicate that these positive effects are not always experienced equally within Saltstraumen itself.

4.2.1.7 Summary and link forward

The overall data in the identity theme sections show that the identity of Saltstraumen is understood in multiple and sometimes competing ways. Respondents described the place as a home and everyday living environment, a historical fishing community, a tourism destination, and an ecologically valuable marine ecosystem. These different understandings existed alongside one another rather than as a single shared identity. Several respondents accepted tourism as an important part of the place, but tensions emerged regarding tourism pressure for the environment and worries about the local community's survival. There were also tensions regarding how Saltstraumen is marketed by external actors such as Bodø. The current official tourism image of Saltstraumen captures parts of what was conveyed as the place’s identity, but the interviews show a broader and more layered understanding of what the place means to the people connected to it.

Read across the sub-themes, three tensions organise the identity of Saltstraumen rather than one. The first is between identity as plural and identity as shared: participants articulate the place as home, fishing community, tourism destination and marine ecosystem, and hold these

registers in parallel without proposing how they should be ranked or reconciled, so that any decision taken in one register tends to advance it at the expense of the others. The second is between the formal openness of the place and the practical conditions of belonging to it: the place is constitutionally and culturally "for everyone," yet who counts as part of that everyone is set by limits residents themselves define and by material conditions, transport, signage, the cost of attending events, that participants name but do not see reconciled. The third is between the identity residents articulate and the identity the official communication represents: the brand has settled on the maelstrom as spectacle, while the care, pride, impermanence, historical and ecological registers participants voice are largely absent from it, and neither side frames this asymmetry as a disagreement. These tensions are not resolved within the theme. The first returns under economic orientation as a question of which register attracts investment, the second under fairness and inclusion as a question of distribution and recognition, and the third under the cross-cutting dimension of transparency and accountability as a question of whose account of the place is allowed to stand.

4.2.2 Fairness and inclusion

Dimension 2: Stakeholder fairness and shared well-being

Dimension 2 concerns how the benefits and burdens of a place's branding are distributed across the groups who have a stake in it, and which of those groups can shape the conversation about the place. A conscientious treatment of this dimension would expect to find a reasonably even distribution of benefit and burden across residents, visitors, commercial actors and the non-human environment, and to find that the channels through which decisions about the place are made are open to the people affected by them. The data on Saltstraumen does not present this picture. It presents a set of asymmetries that participants name and live with, sometimes in propositional voice and sometimes flatly, but rarely as a settled state of affairs. Fairness and inclusion is the third most heavily coded of the six themes in the post-interview codebook, with 142 extracts drawn from all seventeen interviews and distributed across four sub-themes: power and voice, access and inclusion, distribution of benefits, and distribution of burdens.

Opportunity structures, a sub-theme of Fairness and Inclusion in the pre-interview codebook, is not retained here; the relevant material is addressed in section 4.2.4 (Organisational Openness), where the data placed it. The analytic decision is recorded in section 3.5.3.

4.2.2.1 Power and voice

Participants do not converge on a single account of who is heard when decisions about Saltstraumen are made. What stands out is that several disagreeing accounts coexist inside the same set of structures. The most commonly articulated position is that voice operates and is heard. R16 reports that "people around here are being heard" and that "the local community is heard". R1 describes a working pipeline from the local council to the city council, an open city council meeting that is streamed on web TV, public meetings in the hotel about the marine protected area, and the principle that "your voice is being heard" even when the outcome is unfavourable. R12 describes the local board as having "a lot of possibilities to be

heard", including the right to forward hearings to the municipality and to inform residents about cases on which they should comment. R5 names the larger commercial actors, the hotel and other businesses, as participants who are "quite active to try to be heard". R10 frames the principle in collective terms: "we do collect as one community with every single person", and notes that the school question was eventually answered after several years of pressing. By this account, voice in Saltstraumen runs through the *velforening*, the local board, the city council, and the kommunal hearing procedure, and the channels do their work.

A second account, articulated by a different group of respondents, holds that voice is exercised but does not translate into outcomes. R9: "We can say what we think, but in the end others decide what happens here." R17: "the community in Bodø will have the last word", and what happens after the hearing "is another case". R2: "When people feel heard you also get more engagement; if you don't feel seen or heard, you just give up." R15: at the moment "the residents are on the losing side of that balance". R8 names the same pattern from a different angle, describing local actors who "do mostly agree on the things, but the politicians in Bodø and in Oslo say no". The two accounts are not contradictory; the first is about whether the channels exist and function procedurally, and the second is about whether the channels produce decisions that respondents recognise as theirs.

The accounts converge again on a third register: that some voices are quieter than others by design. R11's account of elite economic networks is the most developed: "the bigger the business, the more money you have and local connections, the more advantages you get"; "if you are a man and part of certain orders and can sit and talk over a brandy with the tourist chief, that shouldn't be how it works, but it is"; "Norway has no lobby register, you can go in and talk whatever you want". R1 corroborates: "they called it corruption, but kind of. It's very easy to get tempted... in Norway, we are very blue-eyed. We don't see it." R7 and R8 each name strong actors who work to be heard and whose activity tilts the conversation: R7 sees "strong actors that work for prohibiting fishing" who are "better than others at making themselves heard", and R8 describes meetings held discreetly because participants "didn't want these loud people to know" they were meeting. The pattern across R11, R7, R8 and R1 is not a generalised distrust of governance; it is a specific account of how economic position translates into voice in a way the formal channels do not register.

A third position appears alongside the heard / not-heard pair and complicates it. R13, asked which voices are most commonly heard when important decisions are made, answers, "I have no idea". Read in the spirit in which it is offered, the answer is an honest report of opacity rather than apathy: not an account of being excluded from a process the speaker can see, but an account of a process the speaker cannot see. R6's "the strongest voices are as always the one on the most outer part" and R8's account of an "outside voice" sit at the same register; both describe a process whose participants are not clearly identifiable from inside the village. Three positions therefore appear in the data: voice is heard and functions; voice is exercised but does not translate into outcomes; voice operates in channels that the speaker cannot see.

The voices participants name as least heard are not, on closer reading, evenly under-heard. R6 and R1 raise the position of older residents and of children respectively, as groups whose perspectives are under-registered. R10 and R3 describe long-term residents as overlooked: the school question was answered after a decade of pressing; locals "feel pushed out" and feel that tourism "puts pressure on the entire area and on their home". The under-heard groups occupy three different registers (life stage, length of residence, structural position) that a single under-heard category would flatten.

The non-response of the local Coop Prix to the research invitation sits inside this sub-theme as a finding in its own right. Staff at the store declined to participate on the grounds that they do not live in Saltstraumen. The refusal is itself a position on who is entitled to speak for the place: non-residence is offered, by people who work in the village daily, as a reason not to be heard about it. The criterion is not contested from the other side either, since the participating residents articulate a similar residence-based account of voice. The local conversation about Saltstraumen is, by this account, bounded by a definition of "local" that the data does not interrogate.

The proposition that follows from the sub-theme is that the heard / not-heard / cannot-see distribution in the data should be read as itself a finding about the conditions under which voice operates in Saltstraumen, rather than as a failure of method to elicit a settled account. A conscientious brand for the place would need to register all three positions, not adjudicate between them.

4.2.2.2 Access and Inclusion

Access and inclusion in the data run along two registers that are connected to each other but do not coincide. The first is the formal-rights register. Allemannsretten, the right to roam, is invoked by R1, R3 and R13 as the legal and constitutional basis on which the coast and the maelstrom are available to anyone in Norway; R3 frames the right as "one of the fundamental principles of living in Norway and living in Sweden", and R13 puts it cleanly: "It is for everyone, of course, and that's Norwegian law, right? So, you can always go to the coast wherever you are." A parallel formal claim attaches to fishing as a local right: R6, R2 and R3 describe the right to fish for the household as a tradition that residents understand themselves to hold. The formal answer holds the place open in principle.

The second register is the material-conditions one. R7, R12, R10 and R13 all name public transport as the practical constraint that thins out the formal openness. R7: "very poor connections, like public transportation, for example from here to Bodø, terrible". R12: "the transport system is not developed for tourists; many foreigners come, they must have a rented car or take a taxi at more than two thousand kroner". R10: "the buses, the transport around there, the public transport is not the greatest". R13 returns to the same point from a residential angle, noting that without a car it is "almost impossible to live here" and that the situation is materially different ten kilometres inland where bus connections are adequate. R10 adds alcohol prices as a further practical condition, and R11 names signage that visitors do not read

or do not heed, with R7 reporting from his years selling fishing equipment that tourists "don't believe what they hear, that it's free to fish everywhere", reading the formal right in their own terms once they arrive.

Housing sits at the same boundary between the formal and the practical, and is named by R11 and R2 as the place where the material register threatens to redraw the formal one. R11 reports that local housing is scarce and expensive and that the village "would need to build some more houses". R2 notes that "some of the houses get to be holiday houses" and pairs this with a positive valence about families settling, suggesting that the issue is not housing per se but housing turning over to non-residential use.

The formal-practical gap was introduced under Dimension 1 in relation to the question of who Saltstraumen is for. Under Dimension 2 it recurs in a different register: not as a question about purpose but as a question about the operating conditions of access. The two readings are not equivalent. The Dimension 1 reading is about who the place is constructed as being for; the Dimension 2 reading is about who can in practice be there. A conscientious brand would be expected to register both. The official destination communication, in the version available on Visit Bodø and Visit Norway, does not register either (Visit Bodø, n.d.a; Visit Norway, n.d.a.; Bowen, 2009).

4.2.2.3 Distribution of benefits

Participants converge on the proposition that the benefits of Saltstraumen's place identity, in its branded form, are concentrated rather than diffuse, and they name the beneficiaries consistently across the corpus. R5 puts it briefly: "I believe it's the local businesses; they benefit with the guests visiting them." R3 names the camping operators, who "are filled to the brim with recreational vehicles every summer", and the tourism fishing operators, who, R3 has heard, "have just built up and built up and built up and they are buying more". R1 names "the owners of the establishments" and contrasts the position with that of residents who work in Bodø and "don't economically benefit". R11 names the local Coop as "one of the most profitable in Norway", attributing the volume to passing maelstrom traffic. R10 names "local business winners" without elaboration. R8 and R16 add the dive operators and the hotel and campsite operators to the same picture. The participants do not contest the legitimacy of the commercial beneficiaries; they describe the distribution as a fact about how the place's brand operates.

R1 and R13 each add a distinction that sharpens the picture. R1 frames it as a question of who the brand reaches: residents and those who work in Bodø are not on the inside of the commercial circuit even when they live in the village. R13 frames it as a question of what residents get out of the brand at all: residents benefit from Saltstraumen "in a way that this is a very nice place to be and to live and to enjoy living here, that we, of course, we benefit from that. Apart from that, probably not so much." Read together, the two framings draw a line between amenity benefit (the value of living in a place that is pleasant) and economic benefit

(the value of a commercial position in a branded place), and locate residents on the amenity side and the named operators on the economic side.

The local Coop Prix is a department of Coop Nordland SA, the regional cooperative headquartered in Bodø, rather than a Saltstraumen-level entity (Coop Nordland SA, 2024; Regnskapstall, n.d.). Coop Nordland is genuinely member-owned and distributes surplus to its members across the Nordland region. The cooperative form is therefore not absentee in the conventional sense. What it is, in relation to Saltstraumen, is regional rather than village-scale. The "local" at which member ownership and the redistribution of surplus actually operate is a different local from the village at which the store is sited and at which R11's profitability observation is made. The amenity-versus-economic distinction sharpens when read against this ownership scale: residents' benefit from the place is local in the village sense; the principal economic beneficiary's local is local in the regional-cooperative sense; the brand does not register the difference.

4.2.2.4 Distribution of burdens

Burdens are distributed in a pattern that is, by participants' own accounts, the inverse of the benefits picture, and the corroboration is broad. Ten respondents (R6, R11, R7, R2, R8, R15, R4, R9, R17, R14) speak to the residents-versus-tourists burden in some form. R11 reports residents' reluctance to receive tourists "who don't leave anything, they just fish out the food". R8 describes the noise of fishing boats "going in out, in out, in out" twenty-four hours a day, year-round. R15: "It's been too much now... they are going into their garden and they see all these boats fishing all the time." R9: "Sometimes there are so many tourists fishing that locals feel they have no space left." R7 describes residents with ordinary jobs in town who experience tourism as "a pressure all the time". R14 names a strand of resident sentiment that "is pretty negative towards tourism". The corroboration is consistent across the corpus and across the kinds of resident the corpus contains, though not unanimous or always sharp.

A second strand of the burdens picture concerns tourists misbehaving, with seven respondents (R6, R2, R15, R4, R16, R17, R5) naming variants. R2 has seen "toilet paper in the maelstrom" and tents and caravans in the churchyard. R15 describes garbage left and people using "the nature's toilet". R16 describes tourists who "park where they want to park" and "give a shit about the rules". R17 names rubbish dumped in the sea, with the comment that the community took over waste handling from the municipality in 1962. R5 notes that the boundary between residents' homes and where visitors walk and stay "is not always a strict line". R4 reports parking under the bridge that "fills up in the summer and nobody's doing anything about it". The pattern across these respondents is not a single confrontation but an accumulation of small encroachments on the village's residential character.

A third strand, less remarked on in the official destination communication, concerns unregulated accommodation. Six respondents (R6, R11, R2, R12, R1, R10) raise Airbnb and informal camping as a burden that the brand does not register. R6: "AirBnB, a lot of private people, started to rent out their cottages, empty houses; so it's hard for the hotel and the

camping places to survive." R11 names a Tromsø comparison case in which "locals can't find housing because everyone wants to make money off Airbnb and second homes" and warns that "something similar could happen here", with a separate observation that Airbnb operators have instructed guests to dump trash in the restaurant's bins so that the restaurant has to pay for it. R2 describes cabins sold to "business people who are only on Airbnb". R10 reports renting out part of the family home and the difficulty of placing the line between commercial and personal use. R12 reports the practice as present but not yet at the Tromsø scale; R1 says the same. The picture is of a market that the village is exposed to without the regulatory or service infrastructure to mediate it.

Pressure on facilities and infrastructure is named directly by R11, R1, R16 and R5. R11 reports that the sewage system is "measured for 2,500 to 3,000 people, but if 300,000 people pop in for one day, the system is not prepared for that", and observes that "Norway has begged for exceptions from EU sewage regulations". R1 names "many people in a short space of time" and the absence of "parking, toilet facilities, waste management, everything around to facilitate that large number of people". R16 names parking; R5 names toilets and bus arrivals; R14 names the more general condition that the village is "not really set up for tourists". The burdens are borne in the village; the benefits, on R1's and R13's reading and on the ownership picture set out above, are not all of them.

R13's observation that the marine protected area is "not much of a protection, actually", under pressure from recreational fishers "taking out underwater life quite a lot without any restriction", places the non-human environment in the burdens picture as well. The point will be returned to under Dimension 3, where it sits as the analytic centre of the temporal and ecological responsibility component; under Dimension 2 it registers as the proposition that the burdens picture, on the data as it stands, includes a non-human stakeholder whose representation in the branding conversation is absent.

The closing proposition for the sub-theme is that the data presents a concentrated-benefits, diffuse-burdens distribution that the conscientious place branding framework developed in chapter 2 would expect a brand for the place to register and to address. The official destination communication, in the version available at the time of this study, presents Saltstraumen as a maelstrom and a nature experience and does not register either the distribution or its asymmetry (Visit Bodø, n.d.a; Visit Norway, n.d.a; Bowen, 2009).

4.2.2.5 Summary and link forward

Fairness and inclusion in the data presents three findings that the analysis holds in tension rather than resolves.

The first concerns voice. Participants articulate three positions in the local conversation about Saltstraumen: voice that is heard and functioning; voice that is exercised but does not translate into outcomes; and voice that operates in channels the speaker cannot see. The data records the three positions but does not adjudicate between them. A fourth pattern is visible in the economic-networks register and runs alongside all three.

The second concerns access. Formal rights of access are held open while material conditions constrain who can use them, and the formal-practical gap first surfaced under identity recurs here in a different register.

The third concerns the distribution of benefits and burdens. Benefits flow asymmetrically across residents, named commercial operators and the non-human environment. The largest single named beneficiary, Coop Nordland, sits outside the village at the ownership scale at which the local cooperative actually operates. At the burden end, an unregulated short-term accommodation market exposes the village to pressures that the official destination communication does not register.

Sustainability picks up the non-human stakeholder thread and asks what the data says about Saltstraumen's temporal and ecological responsibilities. Organisational openness then returns to voice, and asks what would have to be true about Saltstraumen for the heard / not-heard / cannot-see distribution to shift.

4.2.3 Sustainability

Dimension 3: Temporal and Ecological Responsibility

Sustainability was one of the most prominent themes identified in the thematic analysis, with 146 coded extracts across the two subthemes balancing dimensions and long-term/short-term futures. Discussions related to sustainability appeared throughout many of the interviews and were often connected to tensions between environmental protection, tourism and economic development, and the long-term future of the community.

4.2.3.1 Balancing dimensions

Balancing dimensions relates to tensions between environmental protection, economic survival and the social continuity of the local community in Saltstraumen. A central issue within this discussion concerned the marine protected area established in Saltstraumen in 2013 (Lovdata, 2013). Several respondents, particularly those critical of current fishing practices in the area, questioned whether the protection was functioning effectively in practice. One respondent stated that “Nothing is regulated at this moment… nothing is really protected in this marine protected area.” (R11), while another described it as a “paper park”:

> Bullshit. It's a paper park. Yeah. So it doesn't function. And it's several reasons for that because everything is allowed to take… And they do nothing about the pollution from the fishing, they do nothing about the fishing equipment that.. destroying the protected marine life. So it doesn't function at all as a protected area. So it's a paper park. (R8)

The expression “paper park” appeared across several interviews and reflected a view that marine protection exists formally through legislation but it lacks practical enforcement and general ecological protection/preservation. Respondents connected this criticism to environmental concerns and also to the lack of governance and enforcement. As one respondent explained:

> You don't have a firm hand that really regulates anything. Like you protect something on the paper and that's also why they have been called paper protections. It doesn't really matter what happens there 'cause there will never be any policeman coming out saying you can't do that or you can't do this. It's not enforced in any way. (R3)

These respondents framed the issue as a disconnect between official sustainability "talk" that is being done "for show" and actual environmental management practices. The criticism emerged both among environmentally concerned residents and among respondents with strong local knowledge of marine ecosystems, suggesting that scepticism toward the current governance model extended beyond a specific stakeholder category. A knowledgeable resident in relation to marine parks discussed that there currently very few actual protection measured except for building and fauna/flora related:

> There are hardly any protection measures, except that they draw a line on a map and say this is now our protected area. You can do virtually whatever you want to do in there, except of building at the waterline or in the water, and you should not remove any attached fauna and flora or whatever. You can fish, you can do whatever you want, except for that. And so, the protection measures are very weak. (R13)

This shows an important tension within the interviews regarding differing understandings and opinions of what the marine protected area is intended to protect. Official regulations primarily focus on the seabed ecosystem, including the kelp forests, marine vegetation and other seabed-associated species (Lovdata, 2013). Fishing itself largely remains permitted within the area, with wolffish becoming one of the few protected fish species in 2024 (Lovdata, 2024). This created differing interpretations regarding whether the protected area was actually "failing" or whether public expectations simply exceeded the legal scope of the current protection. Some respondents perceived the protected area as ineffective because fishing still occurs, while others recognised that the area may still technically function according to its legal framework even if their expectations of what protection should be are broader.

There are groups of residents (and business owners not depend on fishing) in Saltstraumen who would desire much stronger protection with fishing being restricted in the area, therefore lots of problems related to fishing were brought up by a these respondents, for example: "We saw seven wolffish… we unfortunately had to cut one free from a fishing hook… it was like a spider net of fishing lines… he was hanging there." (R11), "Sometimes there are so many fishermen that do not know where to fish, so you have angles along the shore in many places and both birds and fishes are… it's not good for them" (R12) and:

> It also destroys so much. That's the problem. It really also destroys… this is destruction, this massive destruction of marine life. ..... And that's why also more and more the local people come to us and say: 'Yeah, we better stop fishing here because it's too much pollution'. (R6)

The respondents who expressed stronger environmental concerns often associated tourist fishing with ecological pressure and pollution and the general disturbance to marine life. Tourists that fish, specifically, emerged as a source of frustration in several interviews. A big portion of the respondents distinguished between local fishing traditions and visiting tourists' fishing behaviour. A business owner: "Some of the guest fisher people don't respect the place, they leave fish remains and gear" (R9) and another business owner contrasted local and tourist fishing practices economically and morally: "We take one fish up. The tourists come here, take all the loins, get rid of the rest and can take eight, fifteen kilos out of the country. We sell our nature for free." (R2).

These accounts suggest that sustainability concerns in Saltstraumen can be connected to the perceived fairness and legitimacy regarding who benefits from natural resources and who bears responsibility for protecting them. Several of the respondents with a generally negative view on fishing in the protect are portrayed tourist fighting as more extractive and commercially oriented, while local fishing was framed as culturally knowledgeable and historically connected to the community's identity. This ties the sustainability theme back to both of the two main themes previously discussed, identity and fairness and inclusion. The interviews revealed there was a divide between respondents directly connected to fishing and respondents more strongly aligned with environmental protection concerns. However, this divide was not entirely polarised. Even several respondents who were critical of fishing tourism simultaneously defended local cultural fishing traditions. As discussed in section 4.2.1 Identity, fishing was repeatedly described as part of Saltstraumen's historical identity and everyday way of life. This reflected tensions between the balance of environmental concerns and the preservation of local traditions and rights. There is a fear that if fishing were to be forbidden in the marine protected area, the locals would lose a tradition that is centuries old. "Should I not be allowed to catch coal fish living here?" (R7) and "I don't want it to be forbidden for us to take one fish for dinner which we have done for hundreds, thousands of years." (R2),

The issue of balance is broader than whether fishing should be allowed or not, it also incorporates who should be allowed to fish, how, and under what conditions. Respondents attempted to balance environmental protection with cultural continuity and the local populations rights in their answers and resident R1 advocated a form of middle-ground balance solution rather than complete restriction or unrestricted tourism: Some people are concerned that they cannot, in the future, take the boat out. That they have done for generations. So it has to be a balance if you cannot say "stop it's not allowed". It's difficult... You have to balance it and find a middle. (R1).

The idea of balance also reflected differing stakeholder relationships to the place. Some respondents connected to tourism businesses discussed more the economic importance of tourism for the survival of the local community, and the environmentally focused respondents more strongly emphasised ecological fragility of life underwater. Sustainability in the interview was not only seen from an environmental lens. A business owner explained: "Because it's like this, tourism for us is really important. For this area, because if we lay down

the camps, we lay down… about a lot of the other places around here. Then the school is going to go down, the shops are going down." (R16). As discussed in the identity theme section, the school is already a tense topic after the closure of three grades. Further closure would add to concerns about the declining attractiveness of Saltstraumen as a place to settle and raise families. A couple of respondents also acknowledged that stricter environmental protection could negatively affect local businesses and employment opportunities in a relatively small and economically vulnerable community. One business owner argued: "We protect the wolffish, but there is also room for running business, you know. I think that if you protect everything, then you protect yourself out of business." (R9).

One respondent summarised the overall dilemma of the balance between environmental protection, local economy and community sustainability:

> I think putting a hard stop to fishing there would put maybe a lot of people out of business really quickly. If they cannot find ways to adapt to it in any way or a trade-off, right? Which would also be negative for like local economics or local you have… it's very small scale, it's very small towns over there. There's not a lot happening at all. So having these business hubs in a way can be a good thing for the local community, but it should not be in a way that severely damages or impacts nature that it cannot recover ever again. (R3)

The findings therefore suggest that sustainability in Saltstraumen would be a continuous balancing process between environmental protection, economic survival and preservation of local identity and its traditions. Respondents rarely positioned themselves as fully "for" or "against" tourism or fishing. Several had a middle ground where tourism and environmental protection could coexist without fundamentally undermining either community life or marine ecosystems, with some were more heavily toward prohibiting fishing. These tensions also shaped how respondents viewed the long-term future of Saltstraumen, which is explored further in the following section.

4.2.3.2 Long-term/short-term futures

Long-term and short-term futures emerged as a recurring concern throughout the interviews and respondents expressed different expectations and worries regarding what the future development of Saltstraumen should look like. The environmental dimension remained yet again central, especially among respondents with stronger ecological knowledge or environmental concerns. R3, who demonstrated a more detailed understanding of marine ecosystems, described a possible long-term ecological scenario if environmental pressures continue:

> So for me, that could be probably the worst case scenario that the whole ecology of Saltstraumen just stops working because apex predators start thinning out and then you have other species and other organisms taking control or pushing out other organisms. And then you suddenly don't have the traditional ecosystem as it once was and could maybe never be that way again. (R3)

This quote captures a fear that environmental damage within the marine protected area could become irreversible over time. Mentions of possibly declining fish stocks were raised by respondents across different stakeholder positions, including both respondents who were critical of fishing tourism and respondents more supportive of continued fishing practices. Respondents who were more negative towards tourist fishing argued that increasing fishing pressure was already affecting marine life: “They also worry because they see that the amount of fish is going down, because they see a massive, huge tourist fishing going on. So it's less and less fish.” (R6) and the more positive toward fishing: “You hear more and more that there are less fish than before.” (R9). At the same time, other residents questioned whether fish stocks were actually declining. A resident who did not position themselves strongly within either the fishing or anti-fishing perspective argued: “And I don't think it's so big, you see that somebody has dramatised it very, very much. It's not so much… this thing has gone on in 50 years, and the fish is the same” (R17) Similarly, resident R1 discussed the uncertainty surrounding local observations of fish populations and emphasised the difficulty of proving long-term ecological change in an open marine system:

> It's not scientifically. You cannot say that.. you don't know what it was like 10 years or 20 years ago. Because 30 years ago, there were many more people fishing. On the shore. But they have different equipment. But to say that fishing.. the number of fish has gone down. Is not.. you cannot say it, because it's open water, fish go in, they go out. There should be a way to measure it, but there isn't. Because it's not a closed environment. It's open. Two ways and it moves in and out and the cod is swimming large distances, sei is swimming large distances. So, you can have a feeling about it or you can have thoughts about it… (R1)

The authors of the thesis did look for any studies or secondary information regarding fish stocks, but as mentioned in some of the interviews, no proof of these claims was found. This uncertainty regarding declining fish stocks was also expressed by this respondent who otherwise supported stronger restrictions on tourist fishing. And it suggests that some environmental concerns were not necessarily grounded in scientific facts, they were connected to the lived experiences and observations regarding the future of the marine environment, which of course is colored by whether the respondents are more inclined to support fishing or not in the marine protected area.

Fishing emerged as one of the most contested long-term sustainability issues across the interviews. The tensions were between different understandings of what sustainability itself should prioritise in the future. Respondents advocating for stronger environmental protection often framed the marine protected area as something that should function primarily as ecological preservation for future generations: “From environmental and future things, if you want to have food in the water, we need marine protected areas… it should not be for fishermen… they should fish on the outside. We should protect this area” (R11). A municipal official similarly connected the future of Saltstraumen to long-term ecological preservation:

> It is important to preserve life underneath the surface, and there are so many species that are rare. And also I have heard, I have never dived there myself, but I've heard that it's a diverse paradise because of the colors and all the species and everything. So we want to protect that and to keep it for the future generations, of course. (R5)

Across stakeholder groups there was broad agreement that the marine environment should be preserved long term, although respondents differed regarding how this should be achieved. The suggested solutions often reflected respondents' relationships to the place and to whether they used the area as fishing or not. The more environmentally concerned respondents more frequently advocated stronger restrictions, while the fishing-oriented respondents generally supported forms of regulation connected to gears or limits rather than outright prohibition. R7 mentioned having specific areas for fishing and separate diving areas. Also seasonal fishing: "Because maybe they could have prohibited fishing in the summertime where it's a lot of pressure from tourism. The best fishing, in fact, is in the wintertime, where it's no tourists. So that could be a solution" (R7) and also fishing quotas or boat limits.

This respondent proposed compromise-based solutions intended to balance environmental protection with a continued use of the area. Other respondents suggested mandatory fishing licenses (R12), fishing fees for only tourists (R2) or requiring visitors to fish only with local guides (R6). These proposals reflected attempts to reconcile environmental concerns with local fishing traditions, together with the tourism activity and economic dependence for fishing-related businesses. However, not all respondents viewed stricter environmental regulation as necessary. R9 from the more pro-fishing perspective expressed greater confidence in nature's ability to recover over time: "But it… nature will also fix itself". This was a perspective that reflected a longer historical understanding of Saltstraumen as a place where fishing and nature have coexisted for generations. The same respondent also argued that environmental problems associated with fishing equipment would likely improve in the future because of technological developments: "The people that makes hooks, fishing hooks and fishing line is coming now with a new generation, soon the lead is gone, so it is not gonna be a big problem in the future" (R9)

Other residents expressed more negative expectations regarding future tourism development in general. Some respondents feared that increased tourism pressure would gradually decline parts of the community: "It has been taken some steps to make it clean… but the more tourists, the more garbage… if I imagine more tourists, I imagine more garbage" (R4). Several other respondents, for example business owner R11, connected Saltstraumen's future to more extreme examples of tourism pressure already visible elsewhere in northern Norway: "There (Lofoten/Tromsø), people have died because tourists don't know how to drive on snow and ice… and locals and students can't find housing." (R11).

At the same time, the respondents had different visions for what tourism development in Saltstraumen ideally should become in the future. Respondents who were more critical towards the current fishing tourism often imagined a slower and more experience-oriented form of tourism focused on connection and appreciation of nature: "That people coming here

also could listen to the wind and the water, the sound of the water passing by and take part in nature. To feel that we are a part of nature" (R12), "If you come here and stay for a day or two, you can experience the current not only when it's strongest… it's as cool when it's absolutely flat and turns." (R11). Resident R1 described this as a shift away from harvesting-based tourism toward "experience tourism": "Brand the experience. Not the harvesting part of it. Not come here to take the big fish, or catch and release. Come here to look at Saltatraumen, maybe get... what you call it, the midnight sun and nordlys (aurora)"

The overall future visions reflected different understandings of what Saltstraumen should become as a tourism destination. For some respondents, as reflected in the quotes above, the long-term value of the place was increasingly connected to environmental experience, slower tourism and greater environmental preservation rather than resource extraction. However, respondents with stronger connections to fishing traditions sometimes viewed this type of future differently. Fishing-experienced respondent R7 discussed that it would be a loss if Saltstraumen only became a "postcard" destination that people simply observe rather than actively use. The current marketing of Saltstraumen by Visit Norway reflects several of these experience-oriented elements, including the maelstrom itself, diving and snorkelling activities, local food experiences and small local shops (Visit Norway, n.d.a). This shows that tourism in Saltstraumen is already partly positioned around nature experiences rather than only extraction-based activities such as fishing.

4.2.3.3 Summary and link forward

The sustainability theme has shown that environmental responsibility in Saltstraumen was understood in different and sometimes conflicting ways depending on respondents' relationships to the place. For some respondents, long-term sustainability primarily meant stronger environmental protection and a transition toward less extractive and more experience-oriented types of tourism. For others sustainability also involved maintaining local fishing traditions and the economic activities necessary for the survival of the community. The findings therefore indicate that the long-term/short-term future in Saltstraumen is shaped by ongoing negotiations between environmental preservation, economic continuity and the local identity, reflecting the same dimensions of balance discussed in the previous subtheme. The tensions demonstrate wider questions regarding what kind of place Saltstraumen should become in the future and whose vision of sustainability will shape that development. It also illustrates the difficulty of balancing environmental preservation with social and economic continuity within a small tourism-dependent community such as Saltstraumen. For local residents to actively participate in shaping this future development, a degree of organisational openness is required. Questions regarding participation and involvement therefore become central, which leads into the next main theme of the thematic analysis: organisational openness.

Read across the two sub-themes, sustainability in Saltstraumen organises three tensions that the analysis surfaces rather than settles. The first is between protection as a legal fact and protection as a lived expectation. The marine protected area functions within its legislated scope, which is directed at the seabed, yet respondents who call it a "paper park" measure it

against a broader expectation of enforcement and ecological care that the regulation does not claim to deliver, so the same area is read as functioning and as failing at once. The second is between environmental protection and the cultural and economic continuity of the community. Respondents decline the for-and-against framing and reach instead for a middle ground, regulation by gear, season, quota, licence or local guiding rather than prohibition, but no shared mechanism exists for deciding where that balance should sit, and decisions taken in one direction are felt as losses in the other. The third is between ecological claims as lived observation and ecological claims as evidential fact. Concern about declining fish stocks is strongly felt and widely voiced, yet respondents themselves note it cannot be demonstrated in an open marine system, and the search for secondary evidence returned none, so competing visions of the place's future rest on perceptions that are shaped by each respondent's relationship to fishing. These tensions are not resolved within the theme. The first returns under transparency and accountability as a question of what the brand is accountable to, the second under economic orientation as a question of what the place's continuity is worth and to whom, and the third under organisational openness as a question of whose reading of the environment is allowed to count.

4.2.4 Organisational openness

Dimension 4: Participatory openness & co-creation

Organizational openness is a main theme that incorporates three subthemes: Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer), Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities) and Influence and aspirations. The overall theme was a smaller theme with 40 extracts concerned how local actors, such as residents and businesses, and public authorities interacted around tourism development and local questions in Saltstraumen. Discussions in the interviews covered both informal collaboration between businesses and residents, and more formal communication channels connected to municipalities and public meetings. Respondents also reflected on who actually participates in these discussions and whether some groups have greater influence than others.

4.2.4.1 Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)

The subtheme Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer) concerned how local actors and residents in Saltstraumen worked together around tourism and community-related issues. Several respondents described how tourism-related businesses had organised themselves into a local network where issues connected to tourism development and the local community were discussed collectively. Business owner R6 described the group: “We have started to make a connection, a network, we call it, between our businesses who do work with tourism. All our tourism businesses… and we have regular meetings around the winter time at least every 14 days.”

According to resident R8, this type of local business cooperation is relatively unusual in Norway. The respondent explained that the group consists of businesses with different interests and opinions regarding tourism development and local priorities, and that disagreement is considered necessary for meaningful discussions: “You have to take people in

there who do not agree with you." (R8). If there were people who only had the same opinions and agreed with each other it would be a "bullshit group" according to the respondent.

Therefore, the business network was not built around complete agreement between members. The presence of disagreement was described as something productive rather than problematic, because it created discussions between businesses with different priorities and experiences: "You don't feel the other is stupid because you understand more of their perspective." (R6). The respondent further explained that the group attempts to include as many business actors as possible and make as many voices as possible heard. The diversity of businesses involved was believed by resident R12 to make cooperation easier, as the actors involved offered different services rather than directly competing with one another. That also made the collaboration less dependent on everyone sharing the same interests or business goals.

The cooperation is connected to wider questions regarding the future of Saltstraumen. Business owner R16 described the purpose of the group in the following way:

> This group we're talking about is people around tourism, how we can make it better, something like that. So we are some few business partners talking together. We are not partners in that sense, but in that way we are partners who discuss what we can do to make Saltstraumen better, what we can do to make the tourism better, what we can offer the tourism. (R16)

Respondents R16 also mentioned that the network functioned as a collective voice when communicating with municipal authorities. Resident R8 explained: "They have a local politician kind of thing in Saltstraumen. And they have a lot of things to say to the politicians in Bodø, in the city." The collaboration therefore appeared to extend beyond business interests alone and into attempts to influence local political decisions connected to tourism and development in Saltstraumen. Business owner R2 expressed this directly: "When businesses get together, we get things done." Both respondents R6 and R2 also mentioned that the businesses join together to help the local community with picking up rubbish around Saltstraumen to reduce visible pollution and demonstrate that they take their responsibility towards the local community.

However, not all respondents viewed business cooperation as equally necessary or important. Business owner R9 presented a more individualistic perspective:

> And they say that they… 'we want to do this together'… but it's a little bit like, you know, in the business world, focus on yourself. Don't be too focused on all the others. Then you run a good business. If you focus too much on others, then you will lose your business. (R9)

This perspective differed from several other respondents who stressed cooperation and regular meetings. This respondent viewed business success primarily as an individual

responsibility and suggested that too much focus on collaboration could negatively affect one's own business. The interviews therefore showed that cooperation in Saltstraumen was not understood in the same way by all business actors.

Apart from business collaboration, respondents also described more open community meetings where residents could participate regardless of business involvement. R6 explained: "We have some folk meeting where we invite everybody..... where people can say what they mean. There have been a lot of meetings. All people are invited, businesses and local people living there, to discuss these problems and how to find a solution."

Resident R1 described these meetings as open and accessible, suggesting that business owners were willing to listen to concerns and perspectives from other members of the local community. Municipal-connected respondent R5 also acknowledged that some residents may still feel unheard, but it is on them to choose to engage themselves:

> I'm sure there are some residents there as well who want to be heard in a better way. I'm not quite sure how they can engage. I know there have been some workshops and some things like that. So I mean… you need to engage yourself or else you won't be heard. It's like that all over. (R5)

This indicates that opportunities for participation may formally exist, while actual participation still depends on residents having the confidence, interest or even the ability to engage in these processes, which may make it easier for some groups/people to engage than others. The subtheme overall showed that horizontal cooperation in Saltstraumen involved both collaboration and disagreement between local actors. Tourism businesses appeared to share an interest in discussing the future of the area, even when their opinions differed regarding tourism development and local priorities. Residents were also invited to meetings and hearings where they could express concerns and opinions regarding local development. This type of local cooperation also connected directly to wider communication processes with municipal authorities, which leads into the next subtheme concerning vertical communication channels between the community and decision-makers.

4.2.4.2 Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)

The Vertical channels sub-theme relates to the relationships and communication between the local community in Saltstraumen and different public authorities connected to tourism development and local planning. Business owner R6 described how local actors in Saltstraumen had worked together with Bodø kommune, Nordland Fylkeskommune and Statsforvalteren regarding the development of a visitor strategy ("besöksstrategi") for Saltstraumen. The coordinating venue for this work is the Ressursgruppe, a body convened by the kommune that brings these actors together with Visit Bodø; its composition and current role are taken up in section 6.2.4. Nordland Fylkeskommune is the regional county authority in Northern Norway and Statsforvalteren functions as the state's representative at county level who is responsible for following up on decisions, goals and guidelines from Stortinget (Norwegian parliament) and the government (Nordland Fylkeskommune, n.d.;

Statsforvalteren i Nordland, 2025a). Respondent R6 further explained that Nordland Fylkeskommune mainly contributed with support during the process, while Statsforvalteren played a more active role in initiating the work, providing funding and helping structure the process:

> So without those two, it would have been only Bodø kommune and the businesses and the local people. I think it would have been as all the other years, talk, talk, talk, and then nothing. So this different system working together is definitely a big difference. (R6)

A follow-up conversation with representatives of the regional administration added further detail on how the Ressursgruppe itself came into being. The group originated at state level, with Statsforvalteren convening it in connection with the marine management plan for Saltstraumen, at a point when prohibitions on fishing in the area were being considered. Statsforvalteren recognised that a process structured only around state-level regulation would not be sufficient and brought Bodø Kommune into the work, which in turn drew in the local business network and the *kommunedelsutvalg* (the local political board for Saltstraumen). The group began with three or four people and has since expanded as the visitor strategy work has developed (representatives of the regional administration, personal communication, May 26, 2026). This genesis is relevant because it shows that the coordinating venue described by R6 was not a locally initiated structure that authorities later joined, but a state-initiated structure that was widened downwards to include the kommune, business actors and the local board.

The respondent perceived earlier discussions regarding tourism and development as lacking concrete outcomes. Cooperation between local actors and additional public authorities was therefore described as important for moving discussions into actual planning and implementation. The visitor strategy itself also placed local actors into direct dialogue with authorities regarding tourism development in Saltstraumen, indicating that the different levels of stakeholders are taking part in co-creation. The interviews did not make clear to what extent local residents (non-business associated) were involved in the development of the visitor strategy, or whether participation mainly occurred through business actors and organised stakeholders.

In general, residents are invited to take part and say what they think, as already mentioned in the previous sub-theme, by open forms of participation through public meetings and hearings: “We, once in a while we have a hearing about what's going on in Saltstraumen, what should be improved in Saltstraumen, and I like that very much in the Norwegian society.” (R13). Municipal official R14 similarly described meetings arranged in Saltstraumen together: “So yesterday we had this public meeting, open door session at six o'clock at the hotel. And it was in collaboration between the county governor and the municipality.” (R14). These meetings create formal opportunities for residents to participate in discussions concerning tourism and local planning. The channels were viewed positively because they allowed community members to express concerns and opinions directly to decision-makers.

Documentation from around the time period when Saltstraumen became a marine protected area shows that different local actors, including residents, a local business and university professors specialising in marine biology, were consulted during the development of the management plan for the area (Fylkesmannen i Nordland, n.d.). This suggests that local participation in discussions with authorities has been part of planning processes in Saltstraumen for several years, as the marine protected area was officially established in 2013.

Apart from meetings and hearings organised locally, respondents also described more formal ways of communicating concerns to authorities and political institutions. Resident R8 explained:

> We have something that's called "sivilombudet". And it is above the government. So if you have some complaints, you could send it as a person to sivilombudet and they will take a look at it. This week, I will send them a letter and complain about the way the government is taking care of the marine park. So, we try. (R8)

The quote shows that some residents actively attempt to influence decisions connected to Saltstraumen through formal complaint systems and state institutions. Disagreements regarding the management of the marine protected area extend beyond local discussions and into higher political levels.

Another channel discussed by respondents was the local board representing Saltstraumen within Bodø municipality. A representative from the local board can attend meetings at the municipality level and speak on behalf of Saltstraumen, although without voting rights. Resident R12 viewed this arrangement as highly important for maintaining local representation:

> I think these local boards, as long as we keep them. But I'm afraid it would be taken away. That would be really catastrophic I think. It costs a little money, but it's so important to have this balance between the locals and all decision makers. So I think it's so important to keep it. (R12)

The respondent connected the future of the local board to wider concerns regarding ongoing centralisation and talks about saving money from the municipality. According to R12, removing these structures would weaken Saltstraumen's ability to communicate directly with municipal decision-makers in Bodø. Several respondents across previous themes described frustrations regarding decisions being made further away from the local community itself. Examples included Bodø using Saltstraumen in their destination marketing while local infrastructure such as toilets and parking areas were perceived as neglected

The subtheme showed that communication between Saltstraumen and public authorities takes place through several formal channels, including hearings, meetings, collaborative planning processes and local representation boards. At the same time, uncertainty was expressed

regarding how strong and stable these channels would remain in the future if local representation becomes more centralised or reduced.

4.2.4.3 Influence and aspirations

This subtheme concerned influence over local decisions and developments for Saltstraumen. There has already been discussion under the fairness and inclusion main themes that money and governmental connection can give influence. For this theme, there were respondents who described how influence within the community was connected to political access and also participation in meetings and involvement in local networks. There were also differences between respondents regarding who actually participated in these discussions and whose aspirations became visible.

Resident R8 mentioned that local politicians were part of the tourism business network discussed earlier under the horizontal cooperation subtheme. The respondent also believed that political influence may extend beyond the local level: “Think the county governor of Nordland is in this group. So they do get their meanings all the way up to the top.” (R8). It suggests that some actors connected to tourism businesses in Saltstraumen may have closer access to political decision-makers and communication channels than ordinary residents outside these networks.

Respondent R6 described influence in relation to creating a shared direction for Saltstraumen’s future development: “We need to clearly write down and agree about what is the goal of Saltstraumen and then we need to hold it up for the businesses and the politicians.” The aspiration described by R6 concerned creating a clearer shared direction for how Saltstraumen should develop in the future. Based on the respondent, local actors and politicians needed to agree more clearly on what kind of place Saltstraumen should become in the future.

There were also respondents who described aspirations that they did not feel received enough attention. Respondent R9 argued that more practical action should be taken regarding pollution and waste in the marine protected area instead of repeated complaints:

> When you're in Stockholm, they sell kebab in the evening, but there's always some people cleaning it up after you when you throw it on the ground in the morning. So I'm thinking like this, why not focus more on cleaning up? (R9)

The quote suggests frustration regarding how environmental problems are discussed locally. Rather than focusing primarily on criticism and conflict, the respondent wanted greater attention placed on practical clean-up efforts and direct action. This also shows that people did not always agree on how local environmental problems should be approached or prioritised. Some aspirations within the community may receive less attention than others, especially when they differ from dominant discussions surrounding tourism pressure and environmental protection.

The interviews also indicated that not everyone in Saltstraumen participated equally in local discussions or attempted to influence local development. Young people were described by business owner R6 as largely absent from public meetings and hearings:

> You don't hear much from the young people, I think. They're… really young. They are very seldom at these meetings. It's more older people who are at meetings... They (the young) don't come to meetings like that. They don't come to public meetings. It's boring. (R6)

Municipal-connected respondent R14 similarly mentioned that most people attending one local meeting they also attended were estimated to between 40-80 years old. Together, these accounts suggest that participation in local discussions was dominated more by older residents. Younger residents therefore appeared less visible in local decision-making spaces connected to tourism and community development.

Some businesses were also described as more detached from local cooperation and collective discussions. Earlier in the horizontal cooperation subtheme, certain respondents discussed the idea that businesses should mainly focus on themselves rather than collaborate extensively with others. Business owner R16 described their own position in the following way:

> We are working for ourselves. We have not so much to do with people around here because we have been here only X years. So we have only time for us, to make up our places. So we are not talking too much with people around. (R16)

The respondent described a relatively independent relationship toward the wider community and local business networks. Participation in local cooperation appeared to depend partly on personal priorities and the extent to which respondents felt connected to the local community. This meant that influence within Saltstraumen was unevenly distributed, shaped by both engagement and access to political and collaborative networks. As a result, some businesses and residents were more visible in local discussions and decision-making processes, while others, such as the younger residents and some more independently operating businesses, were less present in these arenas.

4.2.4.4 Summary and link forward

The organisational openness theme illustrated that Saltstraumen contains several active forms of local cooperation and participation connected to tourism and community development. Businesses, residents and public authorities interacted through networks, meetings, hearings and collaborative planning processes, and many respondents viewed these forms of dialogue as important for influencing the future of the area. But participation and influence did not appear equally distributed across the community. Some actors were more connected to political channels and collaborative networks than others, while younger residents and less engaged community members appeared less visible in local discussions. The findings of the theme suggest that organisational openness in Saltstraumen is characterised both by relatively

strong local involvement and by ongoing questions regarding representation and whose aspirations are prioritised in local development processes.

Read across the three sub-themes, organisational openness in Saltstraumen organises three tensions the analysis surfaces rather than settles. The first is between cooperation as a collective good and business as an individual concern. The tourism network treats disagreement as productive and works to make as many voices heard as possible, yet other operators hold that attending to others costs a business its focus, and some remain deliberately detached, so the cooperation on which openness depends is itself optional and unevenly taken up. The second is between the formal availability of participation and the conditions required to use it. Meetings and hearings are open to all, but turning that openness into actual participation depends on confidence, interest and the capacity to engage, and the same processes that are formally inclusive are in practice attended by a narrower set of residents, with younger residents almost absent. The third concerns where the openness originates. The coordinating venue that brings local actors into dialogue with authorities, and that reads from inside the village as local co-creation, was not a locally initiated structure that authorities later joined but a state-initiated one, convened by Statsforvalteren and widened downward to the kommune, the business network and the local board, and no local actor holds the convening role. These tensions are not resolved within the theme. The first and second return under transparency and accountability as a question of whose participation the brand is answerable for, and the third is taken up in the discussion, where the question of who carries the facilitating role that participatory openness depends on is examined against the framework.

4.2.5 Transparency and Accountability

Dimension 5: Cross-cutting dimension

The fifth, cross-cutting dimension of the conscientious place branding framework concerns whether the integrity claims attached to a place's brand are visible, verifiable, and answerable to the people the place affects. A conscientious treatment would expect to find clear lines of responsibility, accessible information about decisions and their grounds, and some form of monitoring against which claims can be checked. Transparency and Accountability is the fourth most heavily coded of the six themes in the post-interview codebook, with 94 extracts distributed across five sub-themes: multi-level governance and accountability gaps (32), communication (23), regulations and restrictions (19), how and what is measured (11), and responsibility (9).

Multi-level governance and accountability gaps was not present in the pre-interview codebook and was generated from the data, in the abductive movement from theory through data that the design provides for (Timmermans & Tavory, 2012); the analytic decision to admit it as a sub-theme is recorded in section 3.5.3.

4.2.5.1 Multi-level governance and accountability gaps

The sub-theme that the data produces most heavily under the cross-cutting dimension is also the one the pre-interview codebook did not anticipate. Fifteen of the seventeen respondents

speak to it, and the pattern they describe is consistent across the corpus: decisions about Saltstraumen pass through several levels of authority (the *velforening*, Bodø kommune, *Statsforvalteren*, the national government), and at each level participants identify either a slowdown, an absence of follow-up, or a referral elsewhere. The proposition the data supports is that the joins between levels are where accountability dissipates.

The slow-decision register is articulated across the data. R10 describes a fifteen-year fight for a safe walking route to the school, finally beginning to be built. R13 generalises the same pattern: "problems are raised and the solving of the problem usually takes decades and not weeks." R1 names slowness as a feature of the system rather than a failure of it: "It's transparent, but it's slow." R6 traces the slowness to its material cause ("it comes to the money and there's no money"), and R11 reports the lived effect: "we've had folk meetings, asking for toilets, more information; five years later nothing has happened." R6 closes the register with the resident response to it: "people are tired of it… we say and say again what the problem is, and nothing happened."

The no-one-following-up register sits alongside the slow-decision one and is articulated most sharply about the marine protected area. R2: "no one is following it up. They made it a protected area and everything stopped. It feels like no one is following it up. The state and the local community are pointing at each other, 'you are responsible'." R3, from a marine-research position, corroborates: "back somewhere around 2012-2013. But after that, not much has been going on. There hasn't been any particular follow-up of the place." R13 makes the structural observation that ties the two registers together: "if I do not have protection measures or objectives that are related to protection, I don't need to monitor anything." The marine protected area is therefore a documented case in which a formal designation exists, follow-up does not, and the participants who notice the absence are not the ones positioned to repair it.

The referral-elsewhere register is articulated by R5, R17, and R16. R5 describes the municipal pattern in plain terms: "it's not my table. Ask someone else… they're trying to push it to someone else and in the end it's the politicians who need to decide." R17 names language as a barrier: "the language by the officials often is not very easy to understand. I think they use terms what's not usual for people." R16 puts the resident-municipality distance in non-pathological terms: "Bodø kommune can be a hard nut. They can be a hard place to get through something, but it's the same all over the place." R12 names a related condition that the data treats as cause rather than effect: declining local political participation. "We don't have many people in the local society today active in political parties. So we have very few from all local societies representing us on the board. It was more of that before."

A fourth register, distinct from the three above, runs through R7, R8 and R13 and concerns the visibility of the decision pathway itself. R8 describes information as published but practically hidden: "it's not obvious that I could find it… I took a phone call to my friends who are in the politics in Bodø and they will find it. They find it because they know the system. But it's there. Hidden." R7 names a specific case in which informal connections

appear to have done the substantive work: "it was interest here that got the connections with politicians in Bodø that fancied the idea of this and took it further." R13, on the longest reach, declines to claim insight he does not have: "but how that is further transferred into the decision making, I have not very good insights into the Norwegian local politics, to be honest." Read together, the three voices articulate not a corrupt system but an opaque one: a system in which formal openness coexists with practical illegibility.

The proposition the sub-theme supports is therefore that accountability in Saltstraumen is distributed across several levels in a way that allows it to dissipate at the joins. The conscientious place branding framework would expect a brand for the place to register this distribution; the data does not contain evidence that the official destination communication does so. The point sits in tension with the communication sub-theme below, where the same respondents describe information as in principle available, and the analysis returns to that tension at the close of the dimension.

4.2.5.2 Communication

Communication in the data runs along a line that the respondents themselves draw: information is, as a matter of formal availability, public and on the record; information is, as a matter of practical access, scattered, language-dependent, and reliant on contact with knowledgeable locals. The two readings are held by overlapping rather than opposing sets of respondents, and several participants articulate both within the same interview.

The formal-availability register is articulated by R12, R1, R16, R10 and R13. R12: "you can go to the website for the municipality and you can find everything. They have referrat after all meetings. All voting is presented at their website." R1: "the plans are public. You can go and download it from the website to the local council. The bigger general plans are open for everyone to come and see." R10: "it's on Facebook. It's in the Saltströmmen group and it's in the media." R13: "the information is always made available. It's very public. It's not that people cannot get information if they want to have it." The picture is of a municipality and a community that publish; nothing in the data contradicts this register. The municipal and resident channels are documented; the official destination communication, by contrast, does not register the gap between formal availability and practical retrievability that follows, a contrast the documentary cross-check makes legible (Bowen, 2009; Visit Bodø, n.d.a; Visit Norway, n.d.a).

The practical-retrievability register, articulated by some of the same respondents and by others, complicates the first. R13, having affirmed that information is public, adds the lived experience of trying to use it: "I had difficulties to find information that is related to that, to be honest, which is probably 95% because of my impatience of scrolling through websites… one very frustrating experience was when I was meeting [neighbour], and they quickly showed me where to find some piece of information about Saltstraumen. When I was home one hour later, I was already not able to find this pathway again." R13 also names language as a constraint that the formal-availability claim does not register: "all contact with the

authorities is usually done in Norwegian. So that's not so international." The same respondent describes the workaround the practical register produces: "people like [neighbour], they know exactly where to look that up. So, usually I ask them when I want to know something." Information pathway dependency on key locals, here, is the resident-level corrective to a formal availability that does not by itself produce access.

The two registers cohere if read as descriptions of different stages in the same process. R8's earlier observation, recorded under multi-level governance, that information is "there. Hidden", names the same condition; R7's observation that there is no platform on which regulations can be communicated to those who need them ("you don't have a platform to communicate. The same for the tourists or the inhabitants") names the system-level absence the resident-level workaround is filling. The sub-theme contains several suggested solutions that respond to this gap. R1 proposes a cross-border SMS analogue: "when you come here, you get an SMS saying you have to follow these and these rules." R16 and R5 both name visitor centres and information boards; R5 notes that the existing visitor centre is closed. R13 proposes a locality-focused information node ("a kind of nodule that you can go to and find all the related aspects covered about Saltstraumen") that would do at the village level what the kommune-level websites do at municipal scale.

A small counter-current sits inside the data. R10 articulates a generational shift in how information is consumed ("So I refuse to pay" for newspapers) that the formal-availability register does not register either. The kommune publishes through channels (referrat, website, paper-and-digital newspapers) that some residents read habitually and others do not. The communication sub-theme therefore proposes that, in addition to the join-level gaps identified in the previous sub-theme, the brand inherits a channel-fit problem that the participants articulate as solvable but unaddressed.

The communication picture at the village scale should be read alongside a parallel observation about brand-level communication, surfaced in section 3.3. The communication about Saltstraumen that reaches the outside world is distributed across three sources of authorship: regional and national destination marketing (Visit Bodø, Visit Norway), commercial communication attached to a single operator-branded fishing site (Saltstraumen Brygge) that markets the place as a sea-fishing destination (Saltstraumen Brygge, n.d.; see Figure 5 and Figure 6 on the next page), and an informal sport-fishing reputation produced and circulated by anglers themselves through online platforms, travel blogs, and word of mouth (e.g., Fishbrain, n.d.; Dutch Anglers, 2016).

Figure 5

Rental boats at Saltstraumen Brygge co-branded with Savage Gear



Note. Rental boats at Saltstraumen Brygge (sfc.no) carrying co-branded livery from the predator-fishing tackle manufacturer Savage Gear ("it's a savage world"), with rod-holders and fishing rods fitted as standard. The operator markets the place as a sea-fishing destination across its fleet. Photograph by N. Sibly, April 2026 during fieldwork.

Figure 6

Savage Gear promotional poster



Note. Marketing poster from the predator-fishing tackle manufacturer Savage Gear, depicting fishermen riding a lure to hunt a giant pike. The poster was mounted on the inside of a guest room door at Saltstraumen Brygge during the fieldwork stay, extending the operator's co-branded sport-fishing identity from the fleet (Figure 5) into the accommodation. Photograph by N. Sibly, April 2026 during fieldwork.

The three external layers and the village-level communication infrastructure described above run in parallel, and the participants articulate practical-retrievability gaps at the village scale that the external layers, by their authorship position, are not equipped to register. This observation is taken up again in the discussion chapter as part of the open question about layered accountability.

4.2.5.3 Regulations and restrictions

The regulations and restrictions sub-theme assembles the rules under which actors in Saltstraumen act, and the work it does in the chapter is to show how transparency and accountability operate not in abstract but in the specific cases participants describe. Three clusters are visible.

The first is building. R16, R17, R7, R12, R1 and R11 all describe the 100-metre coastal building belt as a binding constraint that residents have, in R12's phrasing, "accepted… that they have taken big areas from us. That's old stuff today." Participants describe the constraint without contesting it, but they do note its differential application: R12 names neighbouring areas that received *dispensasjon* to build closer to the shore, and R1 reports that a specific owner has "problems just to make something, balconies outside, very problematic, but there you can expand" in another location. R11 sets the constraint in democratic context: "there are places you can't build on because it's historic land, and nature… and we do have a limited amount of land… it takes time, that's why we live in a democracy. It's frustrating." The transparency element here is the rule and its application; the accountability element is the dispensasjon process and how it is justified at the site.

The second cluster is fishing. R3 articulates the deepest analysis of the rule-conflict structure: "you have the outdoor life law and the law that everybody can harvest from nature and that implies fishing as well… so you can fish as much as you like and that also makes you able to fish inside a marine protected area, because the marine protected area, the law and the paragraph says nothing about fishing at all. It just says that the bottom… should not be destroyed or harmed in any way. And how you interpret that is, yeah, that's the thing." R3 returns to the institutional split that makes the conflict difficult to resolve: "the state governor, but they don't have the authority to do anything about fishing. Fishing is another department in itself. So you have to get all of these to actually agree on the issue." R16 names the operational form of the rule (closed seasons for halibut), and R3 articulates the change-of-laws horizon: the kind of intervention that would close the gap would be "very radical… we have a law that guarantees fishing for all people and not having a zone in the sea in Norway where you can't fish is very radical in a way." The transparency claim attached to the marine protected area is therefore complicated by a rule-structure that, on R3's account, places fishing outside the protection.

The third cluster is camping and parking. R16 articulates the resident position most fully: "we are working really hard in this area to have no free camping spaces… not to sleep on the beach, not to sleep in the private areas because we have a lot of other things we want to protect." The same respondent contrasts Norwegian practice with neighbouring countries' ("Norway is one of the few countries… in Sweden it's not allowed, Denmark is not allowed"). R8 adds the design dimension: "I've been a lot on the west coast of the US… when I was walking down one of the beaches, it said 'you have to go on this path' because it was obvious." R12 names tourist tax as a proposed institutional solution: "the municipalities say they are so poor… we hope that there will be this solution with a tax, a tourist tax. So they could get money to take care of the landscape." R6 names the underlying constraint: "it takes money to put up the signs… and then it comes to money to change something and this is not… no money this year."

The proposition the sub-theme supports is that the regulatory infrastructure surrounding Saltstraumen exists, is articulable by residents, and operates unevenly across rule-types and across actors. The transparency required to describe the rules is present; the accountability

required to apply them consistently or to amend them where they conflict is, on the data, only partially present.

4.2.5.4 How and what is measured

The smallest of the T&A sub-themes after Responsibility, and the one with the narrowest respondent spread (3 respondents: R1, R3, R13, with R3 carrying seven of the eleven extracts), is also the one that supports the most definite finding. The proposition is factual rather than perceptual: there is no systematic long-term monitoring of fish populations in Saltstraumen, and in the absence of monitoring no claim about ecological pressure can be evidentiarily settled. The voice articulating the finding is narrow, but the finding itself is an absence and absences do not require broad corroboration to hold.

R3, working from a marine-research position, articulates the position most fully. On long-term studies: "they don't exist. The fishing is going on and it's hard to tell how much it actually does." On methodology: "there are no systematic studies of fish in Saltstraumen. I knew I couldn't tell or show anything about cod population. The long-term systematic studies of this observational and population studies aren't there." On what is measured instead: "they look at the bottom fauna and benthic environment. They look at the plants, they look at the kelp, they look at a lot of other things that can indicate that fisheries might be suffering as well." R13, also from a research-adjacent position, corroborates: "no one is really doing any monitoring of this system. There's no scientific or ecosystem management monitoring in place that would allow for some sort of educated estimate whether this is an effective MPA or not." On the same point, R13 names the dependency: "we lack a lot of data about that… [marine researcher 1] and [marine researcher 2], they did a first study on looking into that a little bit further. But it's also only a first, first to get a first idea."

R1 sits at a slightly different angle and articulates what is measurable with available means. "We are counting the seabirds. Yearly counting to see if going up or down. You should have some measuring stations, maybe underwater. But counting seabirds is easy. But you can count the number of rental boats." The point is propositional rather than ironic: indirect indicators are tractable, direct fish-population indicators are not, and the brand-relevant claims (the marine protected area is doing what its designation suggests) sit on the side of the tractable indicators rather than the direct ones.

R3 articulates the design constraint that connects the empirical claim to the institutional one: "calling it a defined Saltstraumen population would also be difficult because you would have to look at, well, how do we know it's the same cod we saw before… did it migrate towards the sea to spawn?" R13 makes the same connection in the framework register: "as long as you do not have a plan of this kind of protection, the measures cannot be in place. Or the monitoring cannot be in place. It always depends on why you have this MPA. What do you want to protect with that?" The empirical absence and the institutional absence are, on this account, two faces of the same gap.

The narrowness of the respondent spread is itself worth registering. The participants who articulate this finding are those whose professional or research positions place them in contact with the methodological question; the residents who do not articulate it are silent because the question is at a remove from their daily experience of the place, not because they disagree. The finding rests on the disciplinary positioning of the voices that hold it, and the analysis treats that positioning as a condition of the finding rather than as a limit on it.

4.2.5.5 Responsibility

The smallest sub-theme under Dimension 5 collects what participants say about who is responsible for what, and it sits alongside Multi-level governance and accountability gaps as a related but distinct register: where the governance sub-theme describes how responsibility distributes and dissipates between institutions, this sub-theme describes how responsibility is attributed and accepted by named actors and roles. Both registers concern accountability; they were retained as separate sub-themes because the governance material reads as analytical (how the system works) while the responsibility material reads as positional (who, in the participant's account, ought to be doing what). Across nine extracts and eight respondents, the data assembles three positional registers without proposing a hierarchy among them.

The first is the business-owner-and-resident-as-informal-enforcer register, articulated by R8 and R16. R8: "I do think a lot of the locals living here will be some kind of police going down and saying 'Hey, you are not allowed to do this. Piss off.' Because they are fed-up." R16 describes the same position from inside it: "if I see something *knock, knock* 'Here you cannot stay.' It's the same as the camp down there." The position is offered without enthusiasm; it is the response participants articulate to the absence of formal enforcement, not a preferred state.

The second is the citizen-responsibility-for-seeking-information register, articulated by R6, R2 and R1. R2: "all the meetings are broadcasted… everything is public… you can find building plans, strategies on Bodø kommune's website; it's just about going there and finding it yourself." R1: "if you want the information, it's there. It's not pushed to you, but you have to seek it, but it's easy to find. It's not hidden." R6 names the same principle and adds the friction: "you need to just read the referat then. But you don't. You need to be active in finding it. It doesn't come to you so very easily." The register sits in tension with the practical-retrievability findings in 4.2.5.2: the same condition is articulated by R2 and R1 as a citizen responsibility and by R13 and R8 as a system-level opacity. The data does not adjudicate between the two readings.

The third is the institutional-responsibility register, articulated by R5 and R14. R5 names the designated municipal contact: "they do have their own person who works in the municipality who is supposed to give them this information. She has the authority and she's supposed to share information if there is news to the residents that they need to be aware of." R14 names the formal mechanism through which institutional responsibility is being clarified at the time of the interviews: "it is an action plan to identify resources needed and who is responsible,

etc. So yeah, it will definitely be debated at least." R3 closes the register with a tourist-side counterpart: extra signage and information have been put out, and "if you don't know that it's a marine protected area, it's because you probably chose to ignore it."

R1 provides the register that connects the three positions: "you have to go slowly, take small steps and speak with people, get information out, pictures so that you can see. What are we doing today? We are destroying the bottom. Yeah, killing seabirds under water. And when you get out information to people and then they see, oh, is it this bad? And then it's easier." The register is propositional and prospective rather than descriptive: responsibility, on this account, is produced through the work of making the conditions of the place legible.

The proposition the sub-theme supports is that responsibility in Saltstraumen is articulated in three positional registers that are not reconciled in the data. A conscientious brand for the place would need to register all three, and would in particular need to consider whether the citizen-responsibility register is sustainable when read against the practical-retrievability findings articulated by the same respondents elsewhere.

4.2.5.6 Summary and link forward

Transparency and accountability in the data presents a picture in which transparency, in the formal sense of information being on the record, is present, and accountability, in the operational sense of decisions being followed up and outcomes monitored, is partial. The five sub-themes hold together as a single proposition: multi-level governance produces gaps that the communication infrastructure does not bridge, the regulations residents articulate are unevenly applied at the joins, the empirical basis for the brand's central ecological claim is absent, and responsibility distributes across positions that do not align. The official destination communication, in the version available at the time of this study, addresses none of these conditions (Visit Bodø, n.d.a; Visit Norway, n.d.a; Bowen, 2009). The analysis holds these tensions open rather than resolving them at chapter scale (Tracy, 2010).

Two threads run forward into the final dimensional section and into chapter 5. The first is the relationship between the marine protected area's formal status and the absence of monitoring against which the status could be assessed; this thread sits at the intersection of Dimensions 3 and 5 and is taken up in the discussion. The second is the relationship between the directional and pace-of-growth questions that participants raise under transparency and accountability (tourist tax, slow travel, "experience tourism" as a proposed shift) and the economic-orientation material that follows. The next section addresses that material directly.

4.2.6 Economic Orientation

Emergent theme from the data

Economic Orientation was not part of the pre-interview codebook and was generated from the abductive movement through the data (Timmermans & Tavory, 2012). It is the sixth theme the analysis produces; its relation to the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth is taken up in

§5.2.1 and §6.1. Economic Orientation accounts for 58 extracts across four sub-themes: distribution of economic benefit (23), limits to growth (19), prosperity through continuity (12), and business oriented future (4).

The relationship between this theme and Dimension 2 (Stakeholder fairness and shared well-being) warrants a brief orientation. Dimension 2 reads the economic life of the place through the lens of *distribution*: who benefits and who bears the burden of the current arrangement. Economic Orientation reads it through the lens of *direction and pace*: what kind of economic activity participants describe as the right kind for Saltstraumen, and at what scale. The two themes overlap and the participants who articulate them are sometimes the same; what distinguishes them is the question each puts to the data. The discussion in chapter 5 returns to how the two readings hold together.

4.2.6.1 Distribution of economic benefit

Where 4.2.2.3 reads the distribution of benefits as concentrated and asymmetric, 4.2.6.1 reads the same economic life through a different question: how do participants describe the dependency between residents and the tourism economy that Saltstraumen sits inside? The picture the data assembles is one of *mutual dependence*, described in propositional rather than celebratory terms.

R2 puts the mutual-dependence claim most directly: "without the tourists, Saltstraumen is nothing, because the half year of summer and the tourist season is what keep all the business here alive." R15 holds the same position with the limit included: "if it's not tourism here, we haven't been here and the population had gone down. It's like, yeah, we need each other for this one, but we have to keep the balance." R16 traces the dependency through the operational logic of running a place-based business: "we need tourism to make this area for us much better, because all we do here is for tourism. And not only tourism from other countries." R12 names the same dependency in the residents-as-employees register: "the businesses need the locals and the locals, they are friends with all the businesses. They think it's good, some people can have their work locally." R1 adds the small-scale dimension that the concentrated-benefits reading in Dimension 2 does not foreground: "it generates value for the businesses, and the shops, and people rent boats, have cottages, and not only the big established ones, but you have a small rent outer room or a camper." The mutual-dependence register is articulated by participants across the sample and is not contested by other voices in the corpus.

A second register sits alongside the first and qualifies it. R8, R1 and R17 all describe Saltstraumen as a residential settlement whose working population is largely employed outside the village. R8: "most of the people in Saltstraumen do not work in Saltstraumen, they work in Bodø, because it's only 25 minutes to drive to the town." R17: "most of the people in Saltstraumen are working in Bodø." R1: "we don't have a strong work market. You have teachers and home care, people working in the shop. So it's limited. Many people stay here, but work in Bodø, so you have people who commute every day." The two registers cohere if

read as descriptions of different populations: the mutual-dependence register holds for residents who run or work in tourism-facing businesses, and the commuting register holds for residents who do not. R6 names both populations in the same sentence: "some of them work here in the tourist business, some work in the ordinary shop business, some work in Bodø or other places, in kindergarten, in schools." The village contains both, and the economic orientation the brand might be expected to register is therefore not a single one.

R11's account of who comes to Saltstraumen and what they spend introduces a third register: the question of which kinds of tourists actually leave money behind. "They say 200 to maybe 300,000 people park in Saltstraumen a year… a lot of them pop in to see the whirlpools." On fishing tourists: "coming for a week, fishing a lot, lot, lot." On divers: "we attract quite a lot of divers, 100-120 a year, 200 snorkelers… some of them stay for a long time, some of them pop in for a dive on a tour." On older campervan tourists: "often don't leave that much money behind, they have everything in the car." The same respondent's earlier observation about the Coop's profitability ("the Co-op is one of the most profitable co-op businesses in Norway because it's so many tourists and so many people driving toward the cabins") names the volume; the segment-by-segment account names the variation in what that volume produces. R4 reduces the seasonal dependency to its barest form: "I work in the tourism business, we only like, depend on the tourists in the summer."

R14's flat observation that no group benefits particularly ("I don't think anyone are particularly benefited because, I mean, the different groups have very different needs and very different purposes") sits at an angle to the other voices and is offered as a settled rather than a developed position. The respondent does not contest the mutual-dependence register articulated elsewhere; the register R14 articulates is about whether any single group is the principal beneficiary, and on that question the participant declines to nominate one.

The proposition supported is that the economic life of Saltstraumen is described by participants as a mutual-dependence relationship between residents and tourism, qualified by the empirical fact that a substantial proportion of residents do not work in tourism and a further qualification that not all tourist segments contribute equivalently to the village economy. The distinction between this proposition and the concentrated-benefits proposition in 4.2.2.3 is not that one is correct and the other wrong; both readings sit in the data, and the analysis returns to their relationship in chapter 5.

4.2.6.2 Limits to growth

The limits-to-growth sub-theme assembles what participants say about how much, what kind, and at what pace tourism should expand in Saltstraumen. Three positions appear, articulated by overlapping rather than separate groups of respondents.

The first is that Saltstraumen is not yet over-touristed and could in principle take more, provided the kind and the distribution of the additional tourism are right. R12: "I think we could take more tourists because they could have different offers in different places, so they

don't have to go in big queues." R12 again: "I would not say that in Saltstraumen [it is overcrowded], because there are different businesses in different places and with different products." R4 names the same condition more briefly: "we don't have, like, overly much tourism." R5 adds the explicit limit ("they also need to not grow too much because we don't want to overcrowd Saltstraumen"), and R1 conditions the further capacity on infrastructure: "if it's the correct type of tourist, if it's tourism for experience, they are more than welcome. But we have to make a system, we have to have parking for the buses, toilets, accommodations, paths… But to come and experience this, I think we have capacity to increase. But we don't have the capacity to increase fishing in the way that's done today." R1's distinction (room to grow for one kind of tourism, no room for another) names what the rest of the sub-theme then develops.

The second position is that the kind of tourism the place receives is shifting and should continue to shift away from fishing and toward what several respondents call experience or low-impact tourism. R6 articulates the shift most fully: "the community say marketing Saltstraumen as a place not to come to fish but to enjoy nature… we are switching in a way now for more and more people guiding people coming to learn about the history, looking at the current. So that switch is good for both nature, the local people and everybody." R1 names the same shift in the framework register: "it's a different kind of tourism, not fishing tourism. It will be experience tourism, if you can call it that they come to see. When they use their eyes to experience it." R8 names the same population by behaviour: "all the tourists who are not polluting… the people who are just walking by and take a look at the photos outside, go on the bridge and go to a hotel and eat their lunch." R13 articulates the shift as an aspiration not yet realised: "what I would also like to see is that Saltstraumen is finally able to inform and visualize and guide tourists in terms of what they could see underwater"; "that's what I hope would be more in the focus in 10 years time rather than the fishing." The shift is articulated as both descriptive (it is happening) and normative (it should happen further), and the same respondents move between the two registers.

R12 contributes a related but distinct proposition: that the shift should be toward longer stays and richer programmes. "I should have one wish, that we could direct to tourists who would like slow travel. I think we tried to develop together, different businesses here, with the cooperation with the museum, we tried to develop a program for one week, stopping up one week in Saltstraumen." R5 names the same direction without the development apparatus: "Saltstraumen is at most a half day experience… We definitely know that there is potential to see Saltstraumen as in a longer perspective with more activities. Hopefully that will be something we can speak more about in the future, as a day trip with an overnight stay as well."

The third position is structural and sits underneath the other two. R3 articulates it: "if things are as they are now, there will be more people, but not more people living there necessarily, but there will be more tourists. Saltstraumen is getting discovered by more and more people." R3 again: "with people getting more and more wealthy around the world, every society is coming to a point where you can actually pay for vacation. There will be more and more

people coming to Saltstraumen." The structural proposition is that more tourism is the default outcome of conditions external to the village (rising global wealth, increasing visibility of northern Norway as a destination, the duplication pattern that Tromsø has already exhibited). The first and second positions therefore sit inside the third: the question is which direction the growth will run, and the participants articulate a directional preference (experience-led, slow, low-impact, longer stays) that the default outcome will not produce on its own.

R6 articulates the counter-position to growth on a marketing register: "why we need to market Saltstraumen in a way to attract that kind of people, and we make regulations to stop the overflowing thing. You just destroy and make people angry." The position is that marketing and regulation are levers that, applied wrongly, will produce the opposite of the intended effect. R8's report of the hotels withdrawing fishing-rod rental ("they did hire out these rods, but they stopped") names a small operational case in which the direction-of-tourism shift is already being made by individual businesses through micro-decisions.

The proposition the sub-theme supports is that the limits to growth in Saltstraumen are articulated not as a ceiling on volume but as a constraint on kind. A conscientious brand for the place would, on the participants' accounts, be expected to support the directional shift several of them describe, and to resist the default trajectory in which growth in volume substitutes for growth in fit.

4.2.6.3 Prosperity through continuity

The prosperity-through-continuity sub-theme assembles what participants say about long-term prospects for the place, and the data falls into three registers that do not cohere into a single forecast. The sub-theme is held together not by an agreed projection but by an agreed *frame*: that prosperity in Saltstraumen, however defined, is a question of continuity (of community, of business, of the place's character) rather than of growth in volume.

The first register is the indicators-of-success one, articulated most fully by R11 and R12. R11 names three observable outcomes: "we'd see the result physically with less trash here and there… and tourists saying 'this was easy to find out' because information and parking rules are in place"; "we'd see it in what kind of tourists come here, do they stay longer?"; "more accommodation per night, more money into hotel and restaurants." R12 names a paired set: "I would look after [the businesses'] possibilities and I am also very interested in taking care of nature. I would look after that"; and "I think it's very important with the research. In the marine area I think we need more research on the situation and under the water. We lack a lot of knowledge, still." Between them, R11 and R12 produce a short list of indicators (cleanliness, ease-of-navigation, tourist quality, business density, knowledge base) that would be visible without aggregation.

The second register is the negative-outlook one, articulated by R8, R14 and R13. R8: "in the next 10 years, I do not think we will get a better place. I think it will be worse every year. But in the end, it must turn." R14: "In 10, 20 years time, it can be even worse than some describe

the situation today." R13, on the same horizon, articulates the no-change variant: "it will not change much." The three voices do not produce the same forecast (worsening followed by a turn, continued worsening, continuity of the present) and they are offered without elaboration. What they share is the register, not the projection: the negative outlook is propositional, not despairing, and R8's "in the end, it must turn" is the form the register takes when it includes a horizon.

The third register is the seasonality-and-population one, articulated by R4, R10 and R16. R10: "in the winter it's just too cold and dark and depressing, so nobody comes. In the summer, it's just completely packed. And then in the winter, there's nothing." R4: "when it's lots of tourists and the sun is up… in the winter there's nobody here." R16 names a different continuity claim: "the area coming to growing up, but it's coming much more people from Bodø. Maybe more, but then they have to sell more areas if that's going to happen." Seasonality, on R10 and R4's account, names a structural feature the brand cannot remove; the population-growth-from-Bodø proposition R16 articulates names a different continuity (the village as suburb) that the participants do not return to but that sits in the data.

The proposition the sub-theme supports is that prosperity in Saltstraumen is articulated as continuity (of population, of business, of place-character) rather than as growth, and that the forecasts participants offer span a range that the brand does not currently address.

4.2.6.4 Business oriented future

The smallest sub-theme in the post-interview codebook (4 extracts, 2 respondents) is also the one with the narrowest position to support. R5 carries three of the four extracts and articulates a position that overlaps with the directional-shift material in 4.2.6.2 but takes a different posture toward it. "We need to be focused more on the companies present in Saltstraumen… we work with the companies trying to make them more visible to have kind of a one-day experience in Saltstraumen, not only to explore what is happening on the sea in the stream but also what you can do on the land side." R5 again: "I hope the companies have grown and been more… I know they work a lot with sustainability, but I also hope they work with growing in their own time, like they need to grow." R5 a third time: "grow in every phase I guess both in activities, accommodation and for restaurants as well, but not too much because I want it to be… I want the residents to have a saying in it all also."

R12 articulates a paired position: "I think and I hope that it could be developed further, that the businesses here could have good possibilities to earn their money and if they work in the same way as before, I think it's of interest for all people here."

The narrow respondent spread is worth registering. The position the sub-theme articulates (that the companies in the village should be supported to grow within limits and within a residents-having-a-say frame) is consistent with the directional-shift material in 4.2.6.2 but is articulated chiefly by a respondent whose professional position in tourism development places this question at the centre of their work. The sub-theme is retained as a separate code

because the posture it carries (business growth as a constructive aspiration, qualified by resident consent) is distinct enough from the limits-to-growth material to read separately, and because the qualification ("not too much… I want the residents to have a saying in it all") is the kind of qualification that the directional-shift material assumes but does not articulate as explicitly.

4.2.6.5 Summary and link forward

Economic Orientation in the data presents Saltstraumen's economic life along four lines. It is a mutual-dependence relationship between residents and tourism, qualified by the substantial commuting population that does not depend on tourism directly. It is a question of direction and kind rather than volume, with a directional preference among many participants for experience-led, slow, low-impact, longer-stay tourism. It is a continuity question rather than a growth question, against a range of forecasts the brand does not currently address. And it is a constrained-growth question for the village's businesses, articulated chiefly by respondents whose professional positions place that question at the centre of their work. The official destination communication, in the version available at the time of this study, addresses the volume and the spectacle of Saltstraumen but does not register the directional shift, the continuity frame, or the residents-having-a-say qualification (Visit Bodø, n.d.a; Visit Norway, n.d.a; Bowen, 2009).

Two threads carry forward into chapter 5. The first is the relationship between the concentrated-benefits proposition (4.2.2.3) and the mutual-dependence proposition (4.2.6.1): both sit in the data, articulated by overlapping voices, and the discussion considers how they hold together. The second is the relationship between the directional-shift material that runs across sustainability, transparency and accountability, and the present theme: experience-led tourism, slow travel, knowledge-based visitor engagement, and the supporting infrastructure for them are articulated as a coherent direction by several participants, and the discussion considers what it would mean for a conscientious brand for Saltstraumen to support that direction rather than the default trajectory. The two propositions held alongside each other (concentrated benefits and mutual dependence) are carried forward as a tension to be discussed rather than resolved at this stage (Tracy, 2010).

5. Discussion of results

This chapter takes the analysis from chapter 4 into dialogue with the conscientious place branding framework from section 2.6 and the literature it draws on. The framework was the study's entry point, not its conclusion: the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth organised the interview guide and the pre-interview codebook, and the data then revised what they could hold. The chapter reports productive friction rather than a confirmation exercise.

The story runs in three movements and closes on two qualifications. Section 5.1 takes the four sub-research questions in turn, then the cross-cutting dimension. The case supports the framework's central claim that a place needs a sufficiently shared public purpose, but it shows that purpose in Saltstraumen as negotiated rather than settled, and it shows the framework's assumption of a brand actor answerable at the place scale straining at the points where fairness, participation and accountability are actually decided. Section 5.2 develops the two contributions this friction produces: Economic Orientation, named as the motivational ground the framework's commitments are built on rather than a residual of them, advanced as an extension; and Layered Accountability, the condition of a place communicated by several external sources of authorship with no actor answerable at the village scale, sharpened as an open question. Section 5.3 takes the remaining findings forward as discrete propositions, with the first carrying the most direct implications for conscientious place branding and the rest sharpening tensions the framework should be in a position to recognise. Section 5.4 then reads the findings back as one picture, and section 5.5 states the limits on what the propositions can carry, since held-open tensions are themselves findings (Tracy, 2010).

5.1 The four sub-research questions and the cross-cutting dimension

The first four sub-sections address one sub-research question each, showing what the Saltstraumen data reveals about that dimension and where the case confirms or strains the framework's assumptions. The fifth addresses the cross-cutting dimension of integrity and accountability, which runs across all four rather than belonging to any single one.

5.1.1 Transformative public purpose (RQ1)

According to the conscientious place branding framework used in this thesis, transformative public purpose refers to *a shared public purpose beyond competitiveness, where tourism and development are guided toward community and ecological well-being rather than growth alone*. Based on the findings in the data, the residents and local authorities in Saltstraumen did not express one completely shared understanding of what Saltstraumen’s identity and purpose should be. Instead, the data showed several overlapping and sometimes conflicting understandings connected to environmental protection, local community survival, Saltstraumen's historical identity and economic sustainability. This confirms that it is difficult to reduce a place to a single identity as they are not static (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015), the identity may change depending on who is asked and when they are asked. Apart from the conflicting understanding, there were also some similarities across these perspectives,

especially regarding the importance of having a balance of protecting nature, maintaining the local community while also avoiding forms of tourism development that were viewed as too harmful or too excessive. Part of the current public purpose therefore was connected more to maintaining the place and its qualities than to have competitiveness or destination growth.

Saltstraumen was mostly described by many respondents as a living community for residents rather than only a tourist destination. Several respondents talked about the importance of nature and that Saltstraumen was for everyday life. The maelstrom was central in how respondents described Saltstraumen, as almost all respondents mentioned it in some way during the interviews, usually as something unique and important for the place, which indicates that parts of the identity of Saltstraumen for residents was strongly connected to the nature in Saltstraumen. Tourism was not generally described as the core purpose and identity of Saltstraumen itself, it was something that rather existed alongside the community and the natural environment.

At the same time, tourism was also viewed as economically necessary for the survival of the local community. Several respondents explained that tourism supports local businesses during the summer season (several businesses were only open in the summertime), and this confirms what Handler (2026) found, that tourism plays a role in supporting local businesses and giving employment opportunities. That would help keep services, such as the school and workplaces in the area. There were concerns in the local community regarding the local services shutting down (partially the school) and younger people moving away instead of staying. That is why tourism was viewed by some respondents as important for keeping Saltstraumen alive as a community; it was connected to the continuity and survival of the community itself. The tourist attraction identity had only been more visible in the last 20 years or so as tourists coming to camp and fish in Saltstraumen before were not on the same level as it is today. What a place represents for the people can change over time as it is constantly evolving as it is both defined by history and physical location (Matlovičová, 2024). The physical environment of Saltstraumen remains the same, but the meaning and identity attached to the place are gradually changing.

However, while tourism was viewed as important for the local economy, respondents also connected tourism to several negative effects. Respondents described lots of garbage lying around in the community, tourists parking everywhere without any consideration and overcrowding the general public space and the waters without consideration for residents or the environment (Back et al., 2025; Koens et al., 2018). Some respondents expressed frustration that large numbers of tourists visited Saltstraumen without contributing much back to the local community. Tourism in Saltstraumen was economically necessary for the continuation of the local community, while simultaneously creating pressure on both the environment and everyday life in the village. It was not conceptualised as an unquestioned public good, but it was something that constantly needed to be balanced against the well-being of residents and the protection of the local environment.

This became especially visible in discussions regarding fishing tourism and the marine protected area. Fishing was one of the clear examples of how respondents conceptualised the purpose of Saltstraumen differently. Some respondents viewed stronger environmental protection and restrictions on fishing as necessary to protect biodiversity and the marine ecosystem. They described pollution, hooks and fishing lines damaging underwater life and fishing being the overall cause of pressure on the marine ecosystem. Tourism was viewed as more acceptable if it focused on experiencing nature rather than using or extracting resources from it. Respondents who depended more directly on fishing tourism economically were generally more critical toward additional restrictions. At the same time, there were also respondents who described fishing as something that had always existed in Saltstraumen and as part of local traditions and ways of life long before the recent tourism growth. These findings are in line with Kageyama et al. (2025), who discussed that stakeholders connected to marine protected areas value these environments differently depending on their priorities and interests. The study did show that respondents distinguished between historical local fishing traditions and the more recent growth of commercialised fishing tourism. Several respondents described how fishing in the past had been connected to survival and local life, and contemporary fishing was mostly recreational for the locals and increasingly connected to commercial activity aimed at visitors. There were concerns that restrictions on fishing could eventually remove rights and traditions that local people had always had. Even respondents who did not actively fish themselves still expressed this view about losing the right to fish. This yet again connected to a place that is defined by its history over time (Matlovičová, 2024), the methods and scale of fishing may have changed, but the symbolic importance attached to fishing remained significant for several respondents. The conflict surrounding fishing therefore reflected a broader disagreement regarding what Saltstraumen should become in the future and what parts of its identity should be prioritised or protected.

The were findings that also described the ecosystem itself as something having value beyond human use. Some respondents discussed underwater life and biodiversity in ways that moved beyond tourism, residents or economic benefit altogether. Protection of the ecosystem was therefore not framed as important because nature attracts tourists or supports the local economy. The marine environment itself was viewed as something worth protecting and this reflects an understanding of nature as having value independently of human use or economic usefulness, which would relate to seeing the environment/nature as a stakeholder in itself (Kortetmäki et al., 2023).

These different perspectives show that Saltstraumen's transformative public purpose is understood in different ways depending on what is emphasised:

- The perspective that focused on more environmental protection, because of the marine protected area, would conceptualize the purpose as the protection of nature and biodiversity to preserve the marine ecosystem, and growth should therefore be limited and not compromise the environment. Tourism is okay as long as they focus on experiencing and views, instead of using the resources.

- The perspective who were more business oriented would conceptualise the transformative purpose of Saltstruamen as there need to be a balance between protection of the place and economic survival. The continuity of the local community needs tourism and fishing because it would be necessary for maintaining workplaces, services and community life. This reflects discussion within conscientious branding regarding whether consciousness can be achieved without having negative impacts on business success and profitability (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Markovic et al., 2023)
- A third perspective focuses on conceptualising it as preservation of the local identity and the traditions that have always been there. Keeping the school and local services alive is important for the community as it is part of their identity. Tourism was considered necessary to maintain the community economically, while fishing should still be allowed to some extent because it had existed in Saltstraumen for generations and remained symbolically important even if not everyone still actively fished for themselves. But no over tourism or over fishing that would cause harm to both the local community above water and life underwater. This position reflected more of a balancing perspective between environmental protection and economic continuity, corresponding to balance of profitability with long-term environmental and social improvement (Tjandra et al., 2025).

For a conscientious place brand to function, and a transformative public purpose to be developed, there would need to be some degree of reconciliation between these different understandings of Saltstraumen's purpose. Based on Tjandra et al. (2025), the purpose of conscientious brands has to be a core to identity and strategy consistent over time for it to be viewed as credible, which would also apply to conscientious place branding if the place brand is expected to be viewed as authentic and trustworthy by visitors.

And although respondents differed in how they conceptualised Saltstraumen, the findings still showed some broader similarities across the different perspectives. Respondents were generally not arguing for large-scale or uncontrolled tourism growth. Instead, many respondents, including the ones desiring stronger protection, spoke positively about forms of tourism that fit better with the local community and had considerations for the environment, such as nature experiences or slower tourism. They also discussed the importance of protecting the local environment and keeping Saltstraumen as a functioning local living community rather than turning it completely into a tourist site. The respondent desired having some type of balance between protection for underwater life and the level of fishing that should happen in the marine protected area. This indicates that there indeed is somewhat a shared public purpose beyond competitiveness alone (controlled growth/amount of tourism preferred) and consideration for development toward community and ecological well-being. The disagreements were less about whether Saltstraumen should develop and more about where the limits of acceptable development should be placed.

The disagreements did not run only between stakeholder groups; they also ran within them. This echoes Marzano and Scott's (2009) observation that influence in place branding is

unevenly distributed, a pattern visible in Saltstraumen both between and within stakeholder categories. Within the business group, respondents differed considerably in their views on cooperation: some described regular collaboration and a shared responsibility towards the community, while others took more individualistic positions, treating business success as a matter of individual effort rather than collective coordination. Business respondents and residents alike held contrasting views on the marine protected area, disagreeing over whether it was functioning as intended and providing sufficient environmental protection, and over how that situation should be interpreted. This adds a further layer to the transformative public purpose: developing a shared purpose becomes harder still when stakeholders are divided not only across groups but within them, on the questions of tourism development and environmental protection that bear on the destination's future direction.

To summarise, there was not one fully shared understanding of Saltstraumen's transformative public purpose, and the divisions ran within stakeholder groups as well as between them. The purpose appeared fragmented depending on whether respondents prioritised environmental protection, economic survival or cultural and historical continuity most strongly. But the findings still showed shared concerns across these perspectives, especially regarding maintaining Saltstraumen as a functioning local community and avoiding forms of tourism viewed as harmful to both the environment and everyday life in the village. Saltstraumen’s transformative public purpose therefore appeared negotiated rather than fully shared. Saltstraumen’s identity also appeared fragmented between the older maelstrom fishing-based identity connected to local traditions and the newer tourist destination identity connected to nature experiences and tourism development in fishing. This finding is consistent with Kavaratzis and Hatch (2013) and the dynamic place identity being socially constructed through stakeholders dialogues. As a vision of a place is flexible and ongoing, reconsideration is happening between the interactions of internal and external stakeholders, the increased number of tourists in Saltstraumen has started this interaction process in which the place identity is slowly being renegotiated.

The overall findings relate to the framework’s first dimension in an important way. First the case supports what the dimension already suggests: a place without a relatively shared public purpose will struggle to develop a coherent conscientious place brand. In Saltstraumen respondents described different and sometimes conflicting ideas about what the place is for and what should be prioritised in the future. Rather than showing one unified understanding of the place, the findings point toward an ongoing negotiation between environmental protection, tourism development, local traditions and community survival. This supports the framework’s argument that transformative public purpose needs to be sufficiently shared in order for a place brand to appear consistent and credible over time (Tjandra et al., 2025). Where the purpose remains fragmented, the foundation for a coherent conscientious place brand also remains uncertain. The case also extends the framework’s first dimension. In Saltstraumen the main challenge was not developing a place brand itself, but first negotiating local identity and future direction. This suggests that some degree of shared understanding between stakeholders is needed before conscientious place branding can fully function.

5.1.2 Stakeholder fairness and shared well-being (RQ2)

According to the conscientious place branding framework used in this thesis, stakeholder fairness and shared well-being refers to *the balancing of competing claims among residents, visitors, businesses and other stakeholders through explicit trade-offs that the place brand can be held to account for* (section 2.6 Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025). The framework's second dimension, drawing on the stakeholder branding literature (Tjandra et al., 2025), assumes a brand actor responsible for surfacing the trade-offs and making them legible to the stakeholders affected. The second sub-research question asked how respondents in Saltstraumen prioritise and balance such fairness considerations. Two findings from chapter 4 bear on this dimension. The first concerns the formal-practical gap in allemannsretten, the universal right of access that organises who Saltstraumen is for. The second concerns the Coop Prix Saltstraumen episode, a non-response to research participation that surfaces a question about ownership scale and the meaning of local.

The Who-is-it-for material carries two non-equivalent answers to "for whom" the place exists; one formal and the other practical. The formal answer is articulated by respondents who reference the Norwegian constitution, the right-to-roam (allemannsretten), and Norwegian law as the basis for an inclusive understanding of access: Saltstraumen is, in principle, open to anyone. The practical answer is articulated by respondents speaking from everyday experience, and it qualifies the formal answer in ways the formal right does not address. Some respondents describe visitors misreading the right as licence rather than responsibility: summer crowding, noise from foreign anglers, behaviour residents experience as intrusive. Others describe infrastructure conditions, signage gaps, transport limits, and parking pressure, that constrains who can practically reach the place and on what terms. Others again describe economic conditions, cross-border alcohol prices in particular, that drive informal behaviour shaping the local experience of who the place is for. Sandell and Fredman (2010) note that the right of public access in the Nordic countries has physical, legal, and social-psychological aspects that interact to determine whether a landscape is in practice accessible to a given person in a given situation. The data here reads as a case in point: the legal aspect holds the place open in principle, while the physical aspect (infrastructure, transport) and the social-psychological aspect (cultural understanding of how the right is exercised) close it off in practice. Different respondents voice the formal and practical answers, with little overlap between them, and no respondent reconciles the two. The gap between the universal right and its practical conditions is present in the data but is not voiced by participants as a contradiction.

The Coop episode sits in the same dimension but surfaces a different issue. We approached the local Coop Prix in Saltstraumen twice with research requests and were refused both times by staff on non-residence grounds (chapter 4, section 4.2.2). The refusal is a finding in its own right: non-residence is offered, by people who work in the village daily, as a reason not to be heard about the place. The participating residents articulate a similar residence-based account of voice, so the criterion is not contested from the other side either. The store is a department of Coop Nordland SA, the regional cooperative based in Bodø, not a

Saltstraumen-level entity. Novkovic (2008) argues that the cooperative difference is not reducible to ownership and control structure but rests on the seven international cooperative principles, of which the seventh, Concern for Community, holds that "co-operatives work for the sustainable development of their communities through policies approved by their members" (ICA, 1995, in Novkovic, 2008, p. 2170). On the principle-level account, community orientation is constitutive of cooperative identity. The case complicates a clean reading of that principle. Coop Nordland's member-and-benefit structure, and presumably its policies of community-oriented development, operate at the Nordland scale; village-level engagement at Saltstraumen, on the evidence available, does not appear to operate at the village scale. Community orientation at the regional scale coexists with the absence of village-level voice the principle would expect community orientation to produce.

Both findings sit inside the framework's second dimension and both strain it. The allemannsretten gap puts the framework's second and fourth dimensions in tension with each other: stakeholder fairness and participatory openness are both supposed to be addressed by some actor responsible for the brand, but in Saltstraumen the universal commitment to access is constitutional rather than brand-authored, and the question of who would hold the gap to account does not have an addressee in the case. The framework treats stakeholder fairness as the balancing of competing claims through explicit trade-offs; the case shows the universal commitment in place, the trade-offs implicit in everyday life, and no actor making them explicit. The Coop episode strains the dimension from a different angle. The framework's account of fair distribution of benefits assumes that ownership scale and place scale align, or at least that the framework can read benefit distribution at the place-brand level. The case shows the scale at which a cooperative is locally member-owned sitting above the scale at which the place brand is claimed, with no language in the framework for the mismatch.

The proposition is twofold. Where universal access norms are statutory rather than brand-claimed, conscientious place branding should expect a formal-practical drift between the universal commitment and the practical conditions of inclusion, and should not expect participants to thematise the drift as a contradiction. Where cooperative or regionally owned commercial structures operate at scales above the village while the place brand is claimed at the village scale, conscientious place branding should differentiate ownership scale from claimed place scale rather than reading any community ownership as consistent with conscientious practice. The case can carry both moves at the level of pattern identification, not at the level of strong claims about Coop Nordland's behaviour or the wider distribution of the drift; testing them at empirical scale would need document analysis of the cooperative's Årsmelding, comparison with samvirkelag elsewhere, and further fieldwork on statutory-access cases. Section 5.3.5 takes this gap forward as a discrete proposition alongside the marine protected area finding under RQ3; section 5.3.4 takes ownership scale forward as a discrete proposition. The first dimension of stakeholder fairness in conscientious place branding, on this reading, names the territory the case sits in but does not yet have language for two of the ways the territory is shaped.

5.1.3 Temporal and ecological responsibility (RQ3)

According to the conscientious place branding framework used in this thesis, temporal and ecological responsibility refers to *the obligation of the place brand to connect short-term branding activity to long-term outcomes for the place's ecological and cultural carrying capacity, with the brand answerable for the connection over time* (section 2.6). The framework's third dimension assumes a place brand actor that can be held to long-term consequences, and an ecological horizon the actor can be made responsible toward. The third sub-research question asked how respondents in Saltstraumen connect short-term branding and tourism to long-term sustainable development. Sustainability is the second-heaviest theme in the corpus (146 extracts) and the substantive subject of section 4.2.3. Four findings from that section bear on this dimension. The first concerns the marine protected area as a formal instrument without practical enforcement. The second concerns the gap between the legal scope of formal protection and what respondents expect such protection to cover. The third concerns a braiding of sustainability with identity, fairness and economic orientation in respondent voice. The fourth concerns a contest over ecological recoverability.

The paper park finding carries the formal-practical pattern already surfaced under RQ2 for allemannsretten. The Saltstraumen marine protected area exists formally as a legal instrument (Lovdata, 2013) without enforcement of the kind respondents understand sustainability to require. R8's "It's a paper park" recurs across the corpus, with other respondents converging on the same proposition without using the phrase. The dynamic is structurally identical to the drift in section 5.1.2: a formal universal commitment exists, practical conditions diverge from it, no respondent voice treats the gap as a problem at the framework's level. The wider conservation literature has named the paper park pattern as a recurring outcome of marine protected area designation: Pike et al. (2024), assessing the world's largest 100 MPAs against the MPA Guide framework, found that one-quarter of the assessed area remained unimplemented, existing in law without active conservation measures on the water. Two instances of the same dynamic in two dimensions strengthen the underlying observation in Saltstraumen. Conscientious place branding should expect this drift not only for statutory access norms but for any formal protection instrument the brand inherits without authoring; where the place brand has not authored the instrument, the framework has no actor to hold the drift to.

The official-versus-perceived protection scope finding sits inside the same dimension but surfaces a different mismatch. The marine protected area legally protects the seabed ecosystem (kelp, marine vegetation, attached fauna, building restrictions); fishing remained largely permitted within it until wolffish gained protection in 2024 (Lovdata, 2024). Respondents read the area as failing because their expectations of what sustainability protection should cover, fish stocks, ecosystem-wide pressure, tourist behaviour, exceed the legal scope of the instrument. R13 names the mismatch directly: "they draw a line on a map and say this is now our protected area. You can do virtually whatever you want to do in there." Garcia Rodrigues et al. (2024) report a structurally similar pattern from the Litoral Norte MPA in Portugal, finding that fishers, fish vendors, tourism operators and scientists

held substantially more negative views of MPA governance than managers, with the mismatch centred on perceived failure to deliver outcomes such as increased fish abundance and meaningful community participation. The Saltstraumen case reads as the same dynamic from the residents' side: respondents speak about the MPA in the language of integrated ecosystem protection while the instrument itself is a more circumscribed legal designation. The framework treats sustainability as a dimension to be balanced through explicit trade-offs; the case shows respondents reading formal protection instruments against expectations the instruments were never designed to meet, with no actor in the case to attach the mismatch to.

The harvesting-versus-experience axis surfaces a different shape of complication. R1 puts the shift most directly: "Brand the experience. Not the harvesting part of it. Not come here to take the big fish, or catch and release. Come here to look at Saltstraumen, maybe get the midnight sun and nordlys." R2 voices the same shift from the other end: "We sell our nature for free." R7 holds the counter-position, that the place would lose something if it became a postcard destination people only observe. The tourist-extractive-versus-local-knowledgeable distinction running through 4.2.3 sits alongside the same axis. The braiding is what matters. Identity, fairness, sustainability and economic orientation are voiced as one composite in respondent talk about how Saltstraumen should be approached. The framework treats them as separate dimensions to be balanced. The case shows respondents constructing sustainability claims through identity, fairness and economic orientation simultaneously, with no respondent partitioning the four in the way the framework does. The pattern is the mirror image of the finding section 5.1.4 surfaces under RQ4: where 5.1.4 records a partition the data does not carry (stakeholder fairness versus participatory openness, both spoken as one thing), 5.1.3 records a braiding the data does carry (sustainability voiced through three other dimensions at once). Both findings raise the same question about the framework's dimensional separation, from opposite directions.

The resilience contest closes the four-finding sequence. The framework's third dimension assumes ecological recoverability is something a place brand can be responsible for. The case shows the assumption contested in respondent voice. R9 articulates the recovery position: "nature will also fix itself", with technological improvement, lead-free fishing gear cited as the example, as the mechanism by which current pressures resolve over time. R3 articulates the irreversibility position: apex predators thinning, ecosystem state-change, "the whole ecology of Saltstraumen just stops working... could maybe never be that way again." The two positions are voiced by different respondents and not reconciled in the data. The empirical basis on which respondents form views about long-term ecological change is, as 4.2.3 notes, often not scientifically grounded; secondary information on fish stocks was sought during the research and not found. The framework treats temporal responsibility as a dimension a place brand can be answerable to; the case shows what counts as the temporal horizon at stake is itself contested at the level of recoverability assumption, on an empirical basis that is in significant part observational rather than evidential. We leave the contest open.

All four findings sit inside the framework's third dimension and each strains it. The paper park finding surfaces a formal-practical drift the framework's actor-centred reading has no

language for. The protection scope finding surfaces the same drift in a second register: the legal scope of formal protection sits below what respondents expect such protection to cover. The braiding finding surfaces a dimensional separation the data does not carry. The resilience contest surfaces an assumption about ecological recoverability that respondents contest at the level of empirical basis as much as at the level of temporal horizon. The dimension's framework treatment, drawing on the SDG-oriented place branding literature (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Aguilera-Cora & Fernández-Cavia, 2025), assumes a brand actor accountable for connecting short-term branding to long-term outcomes, and an ecological horizon to which the actor can be made answerable. The case shows the actor missing, the formal instruments inherited rather than authored, the dimensional separation that organises the framework not reflected in respondent voice, and the ecological horizon itself a site of empirical contest.

The proposition is twofold. First, where formal protection instruments are inherited by the place rather than authored by it, conscientious place branding should expect a formal-practical drift between what the instrument legally protects and what residents and visitors expect such an instrument to cover. The Saltstraumen finding is parallel to the statutory access drift surfaced in section 5.1.2, and the two instances together suggest the drift is a feature of inherited formal commitments more generally than of any one instrument. Pike et al. (2024) document the same pattern globally, finding that a quarter of the world's largest MPAs remain unimplemented; Garcia Rodrigues et al. (2024) report the perception side of the same dynamic from Litoral Norte, where stakeholder views of governance and outcomes diverge sharply from those of managers. Second, where respondents braid sustainability with identity, fairness and economic orientation as a single composite at the place scale, conscientious place branding should differentiate its analytic partition of dimensions from how respondents construct sustainability claims, rather than reading the framework's partition back into the data.

The case can carry both moves at the level of pattern identification. It cannot carry strong claims about the global distribution of paper park dynamics or the universality of dimensional braiding in tourism-dependent communities; testing those would need comparative work across statutory protection cases, and across cases where respondents are asked to partition the dimensions explicitly. Section 5.3.5 takes the formal-practical gap forward as a discrete proposition alongside the allemannsretten finding from section 5.1.2. Section 5.2.1 develops the way Economic Orientation carries long-term language in the corpus that the framework would expect to find under Sustainability; this is one of the points at which the third dimension and the sixth theme cross. The third dimension of conscientious place branding, on this reading, names the territory the case sits in, but does not yet have language for three of the case's features: the inheritance of formal protection instruments the brand has not authored, the braiding of sustainability with identity, fairness and economic orientation in respondent voice, and the contest over what ecological recoverability the place brand can be answerable to.

5.1.4 Participatory openness and co-creation (RQ4)

Research question number four examines to what extent the inhabitants and local authorities expect organisational openness and participatory co-creation in place-branding governance, both in the dialogue and the power-sharing they expect in shaping brand policies and narratives. In the conscientious place-branding framework, participatory openness and co-creation is defined as *residents/actors helping shape brand meaning and related policy directions through ongoing, meaningful participation (not just consultation).*

Based on the findings, there were mixed expectations regarding openness and participation in Saltstraumen, and no completely shared expectation regarding how much influence residents should have in tourism development or place-branding decision-making. Different stakeholders have different interests in participation in decisions, with some expecting municipalities or tourism authorities to hold primary responsibility for development decisions such as branding (Källström & Siljeklint, 2024). Resident participation in local governance processes did happen, as respondents described meetings and hearings connected to tourism development and other projects both in Saltstraumen and in the town hall in Bodø. However, most respondents who were ordinary residents and not connected to tourism businesses mainly discussed participation in relation to concrete local issues that affected everyday life in the community, such as fishing regulations and the marine protected area, tourism pressure and community development. They did not generally refer to participation in any formal place-branding processes themselves.

This suggests that openness in Saltstraumen currently is mainly expected in relation to practical local issues rather than participation in branding and/or destination marketing processes. A clear example of this was how respondents discussed tourism-related problems such as garbage everywhere, overcrowding of spaces and parking issues. When residents talked about these issues, they were described as direct disruptions to everyday life rather than as branding or image-related concerns. As tourism is generally found to have a negative effect on the community, this aligns with research showing that tourism impacts are often experienced first at the local level (Back et al., 2025; Koens et al., 2018), which can shape how residents prioritise governance issues. As there currently are no current place-branding development processes going on in Saltstraumen, there is also no official structure or process set up where the stakeholder groups can participate in this.

The findings showed differences between stakeholder groups regarding the level of participation and influence they appeared to have in the current questions that were being discussed in Saltstraumen. Several respondents described both informal and formal cooperation between tourism businesses themselves and with Bodø kommune. According to respondents R6 and R16, some local businesses participated in an informal tourism-related network where issues connected to tourism and local development were discussed before being brought forward to politicians in Bodø. A more formal group was also connected to the visitor strategy for Saltstraumen, in which selected businesses and Bodø kommune worked together to develop this strategy. Although this process was not directly described as place branding, it still involved shaping how Saltstraumen should develop as a destination and what kind of tourism should be prioritised in the future. This co-creation of the visitor strategy by

businesses together with the local authorities indicates participatory openness in practice. This type of arrangement reflects what Ripoll González and Gale (2020) describe as participatory branding processes, even when the situation is not formally a branding process, but it works in a similar way. It also aligns with Kavaratzis and Kalandides (2015), who discuss that place-related decision-making may take the form of selective political process, where municipalities maintain strong influence over who is included in governance processes, as mostly including business as the stakeholder group would be a selective process by the government.

The visitor strategy group indicates that there is openness to participation for the business stakeholders in Saltstraumen, but there is no clear indication in the data to what level the resident stakeholder group, without tourism business connection, is allowed to openly participate in the process. According to respondents R14, residents were able to attend certain open meetings and express opinions about the visitor strategy, but there was no evidence in the data that they participated continuously throughout the whole process in the same way as business stakeholders involved in the visitor strategy work. Participation opportunities were uneven between stakeholder groups, where business-related actors appeared to have closer access to ongoing dialogue and development discussions with the municipality, therefore a higher level of influence compared to ordinary residents (Reynolds et al., 2022; Hay, 2022). The business group's role was understood to be to carry the requests/opinions from the local community further to the local politicians in the kommune. As residents mainly participated through meetings and hearings where they could express opinions, it would be an indication of the residents having had more of a consultation role, while the business representatives have ongoing meaningful participation. While there are elements of bottom-up input, decision-making authority remains largely top-down, even if stakeholder input is integrated into strategic discussion of Saltstraumen (Ind et al., 2013; Iglesias & Ind, 2020), as the final decisions are made in the kommune, limiting the co-decision role for the ordinary residents in Saltstraumen. Within the conscientious place-branding framework, meaningful co-creation requires involvement in shaping decisions rather than only being consulted.

Despite these differences, there is no strong indication in the interviews that residents felt excluded from participation processes. None of the resident respondents explicitly expressed frustration, or unfairness, regarding their level of involvement in tourism-related decision-making, which could indicate that residents do not necessarily expect equal involvement in all governance or development processes (Källström & Siljeklint, 2024), even if their participation is mainly limited to consultation-based formats such as meetings and hearings. There was also no evidence of more structured multilogue mechanisms such as resident panels or formal co-creation forums.

The data indicates that participation and stakeholder fairness were closely linked in practice. Respondents would overall connect fairness in terms of being included in discussions and being able to express opinions, rather than in terms of formal decision-making power. In this sense participation itself would be understood as part of what was considered fair treatment, even if this did not fully match the deeper co-creation described in the conscientious

place-branding framework. Residents equate fairness with being heard in local issues, not with formal co-creation in branding governance. This suggests that fairness and participatory openness are not clearly separated in the local understanding, even though the conscientious place-branding framework treats them as distinct dimensions. In Saltstraumen these concepts appear to overlap in practice, with a possibility that the framework may need some clarifications or updates of the possibility of these two dimensions being closely connected to each other.

An additional important finding is that participation also appeared uneven across age groups. Most of the business owners and active stakeholders involved in tourism-related processes were middle-aged and older, while younger residents were less visible both in the interviews and in discussions about local development. Some respondents connected this to lower engagement among younger residents in local community issues. This influences which perspectives become visible in tourism governance and suggests that younger residents currently have limited participation in co-creation processes related to place development. This uneven participation influences which perspectives become most visible in tourism and development processes. It also suggests that certain stakeholder groups may have more influence over place-related decisions due to their economic role or positioning (Marzano & Scott, 2009), rather than purely demographic representation. Young people may not understand what they can do in their participation in political processes (Sveningsson, 2016), which also limits their participation, of course based on the assumption that young people are invited to participate in co-creation groups from the beginning, such as the visitor strategy group.

The case partly confirms the fourth dimension, as participatory structures do exist in Saltstraumen. Business stakeholders, in particular, have ongoing involvement in the visitor strategy process, which reflects the type of co-creation described in the framework. But the findings also challenge the dimension. The framework presents participatory openness as something that should involve the wider stakeholder community, including residents without business connections and younger groups. However in Saltstraumen participation was unevenly distributed. Business-connected and middle-aged stakeholders appeared to have more continuous involvement, while ordinary residents mainly participated through consultation processes such as meetings and hearings. The framework does not fully explain this uneven distribution of participation beyond a simple distinction between co-creation and non-participation. The findings also give questions about how clearly the framework separates fairness and participation as two distinct dimensions. In the interviews the residents often described being heard and included in discussions as part of what fair treatment meant. Participation and fairness were therefore closely connected in how respondents understood local governance processes. This suggests that the distinction between stakeholder fairness and participatory openness may be less clear in practice than the framework assumes. The findings support the importance of participatory structures in conscientious place branding, while also showing that participation may be unevenly distributed and closely tied to local understandings of fairness. But overall for a conscientious place branding discussion and process to begin to happen, there needs to first be a clear sense of the identity of the place and

the overall purpose, that was shown in RQ1 is currently fragmented. This would require setting up channels and structure for participatory openness for the general local population in Saltstraumen to take part in co-creating, and not just the local businesses that are currently very involved in tourism related decisions and processes.

5.1.5 Cross-cutting (Integrity and Accountability)

The conscientious place branding framework treats integrity and accountability as a cross-cutting fifth dimension. The Transparency and Accountability theme in chapter 4 (section 4.2.5) is the data-side label for this same dimension; the chapter follows that convention. The dimension refers to aligning stated values with everyday practice, being transparent about hard trade-offs between stakeholders and over time, and using outcome measures that can be tracked rather than aspirational claims (section 2.6; Tjandra et al., 2025). The framework treats this dimension as the condition under which the other four can be held to account, and it assumes a brand actor who can be made answerable. It is not a separate research question; it shadows the other four (section 2.6.1), and is taken up here through that theme (94 extracts, the fourth-heaviest theme). Four findings bear on the dimension: accountability dissipates at the joins between governance levels; information is formally available but not practically findable; there is no monitoring against which the marine protected area's central claim can be assessed; and responsibility is distributed across positions respondents do not reconcile.

The first finding is the heaviest in the theme, and it was not in the pre-interview codebook; the abductive movement through the data produced it (Timmermans & Tavory, 2012). Fifteen of the seventeen respondents speak to it. Decisions about Saltstraumen pass through the velforening, Bodø kommune, Statsforvalteren and the national government, and at each level participants report slowness, an absence of follow-up, or referral elsewhere. R10 describes a fifteen-year fight for a safe walking route to the school, and R11 reports repeated folk meetings, then "five years later nothing has happened." R6 names the effect: "people are tired of it… we say and say again what the problem is, and nothing happened." R5 names the municipal pattern plainly: "it's not my table. Ask someone else… they're trying to push it to someone else and in the end it's the politicians who need to decide." R2 puts it most sharply, about the marine protected area: "no one is following it up. They made it a protected area and everything stopped… the state and the local community are pointing at each other, 'you are responsible'." No single level is failing; accountability dissipates at the joins between them.

This finding meets the place branding literature directly. Eshuis and Edwards (2013) frame place branding as a mode of governance with its own conditions of democratic legitimacy, name accountability as a norm of output legitimacy, and argue that branding conflicts with accountability where there are no mechanisms for monitoring whether a brand's promises are realised and for holding the responsible actors to them (p. 1072). Saltstraumen extends their argument rather than simply confirming it. They develop it from two cases in Rotterdam, where a municipal authority authors the brand and can be held to it; Saltstraumen has no such authoring authority at the village scale, so the mechanisms they expect are not weak but

absent. The case says back to them that the deficit they describe deepens where no actor authors the brand at all.

The second finding runs parallel to the paper-park finding in section 5.1.3 and the allemannsretten finding in section 5.1.2. Information is, as several respondents put it, public and on the record: R12 notes that "you can go to the website for the municipality and you can find everything. They have referrat after all meetings. All voting is presented at their website," and R1 confirms that "the plans are public. You can go and download it from the website to the local council." In practice it is harder to reach. R8 describes it as published but hidden: "it's not obvious that I could find it… I take a phone call to my friends who are in the politics in Bodø and they will find it. They find it because they know the system. But it's there. Hidden." R13 affirms the information is public, then recalls a piece shown by a neighbour that was unfindable an hour later; R17 names language as a barrier, "the language by the officials often are very not very easy to understand. They use terms what's not usual for people"; and R7 names the missing channel, "you don't have a platform to communicate. The same for the tourists or the inhabitants." Bowen's (2009) treatment of documentary evidence as one part of a triangulated reading helps here: checking what respondents say about public information against the municipal record confirms that the information is genuinely published, which locates the finding not in whether it exists but in whether residents can reach it. Visibility holds at the level of publication and fails at the level of retrieval.

The third finding sits in a narrow respondent spread but supports a definite proposition. There is no systematic long-term monitoring of fish populations in Saltstraumen, and without it no claim about ecological pressure tied to the marine protected area can be settled on evidence. R3, from a marine-research position, articulates the gap, "they don't exist. The fishing is going on and it's hard to tell how much it actually does," and R13 corroborates, "there's no scientific or ecosystem management monitoring in place that would allow for some sort of educated estimate whether this is an effective MPA or not." R3 ties the empirical absence to the institutional one: with no plan of protection, the measures such a plan would specify cannot be in place. R1 sets out what is tractable now, including seabird counts and counts of rental boats, as indirect indicators the brand could use while direct fish-population measures remain absent. The narrow spread is itself part of the finding: those who name the absence are positioned professionally to meet the methodological question, while residents are silent because it is at a remove from daily life, not because they disagree.

The fourth finding closes the sequence. Across nine extracts and eight respondents, three positions are voiced with no hierarchy among them. The first is the resident as informal enforcer, offered without enthusiasm in the absence of formal enforcement, as R16 puts it: "if I see something knock, knock 'Here you cannot stay'." The second is the citizen as responsible for seeking information; R2 holds that "everything is public… you can find building plans, strategies on Bodø kommune's website; it's just about going there and finding it yourself," and R1 that "if you want the information, it's there. It's not pushed to you, but you have to seek it." The third is institutional responsibility, with R5 and R14 naming the designated municipal

contact and the formal mechanism through which it is being clarified. The citizen-responsibility position sits in tension with the findability accounts from R13 and R8, and the data does not adjudicate between them; responsibility does not converge on a single actor, or on a single account of who should do what.

Read across the four, each finding strains the dimension differently. The joins finding surfaces a multi-level dissipation the framework's brand-actor reading has no language for. The (information) findability finding repeats, in a third register of information access, a pattern already seen with allemannsretten (5.1.2) and the paper park (5.1.3): where the place inherits formal commitments rather than authoring them, a drift opens between commitment and practice, and respondents do not name it as a contradiction. The monitoring finding shows the framework's call for trackable outcome measures unmet here, with the brand's central ecological claim resting on observation rather than evidence. The responsibility finding shows a fan of positions rather than the single brand actor the dimension assumes. The layered cross-cutting tag in the corpus (56 extracts; 32 of them under Transparency and Accountability) registers the same condition from another angle: respondents speak about Saltstraumen in ways that touch more than one source of authorship at once, without any one being answerable at the village scale.

The proposition is twofold. First, where transparency and accountability rest on formal commitments the place has inherited rather than authored, conscientious place branding should expect a drift between commitment and practice in each register the commitments are voiced in, and should not expect participants to name that drift as a contradiction. The three instances across sections 5.1.2, 5.1.3 and the present section read as one pattern, and the wider literature on accountability deficits in governance-mode branding reads the same way (Eshuis & Edwards, 2013).

Second, the framework should hold to the distinction its own definition makes, between a meaningful impact measure and an aspirational claim. In Saltstraumen the brand's central ecological claim rests on observation rather than monitoring, so a stated commitment to protection is present while a measure that could track it is not. The framework should read the commitment as a statement, not mistake it for a measure in practice. The same caution applies where responsibility is distributed across positions respondents do not reconcile: no single actor can be held to the commitment, so the question of who would produce such a measure is itself open.

The case can carry both moves as patterns observed in one community, not as strong claims about how cross-cutting accountability would work in other small, tourism-dependent places. Testing them would need comparison along two lines: between cases where formal commitments are authored at the place scale and cases where they are inherited, and between cases where an impact measure is in place and cases where it is absent. Section 5.2.2 carries the layered-authorship condition forward as an open question, with the cross-cutting dimension as the one it bears on most directly.

5.2 Two contributions

This section develops two contributions. The first is a proposition: Economic Orientation as a framework extension. The second is an open question with a sharpened formulation: how the framework travels into cases without a single brand actor at the place scale.

5.2.1 Economic Orientation as a framework extension

The first contribution proposes a framework extension. Section 4.2.6 reported a sixth theme that was not in the pre-interview codebook and emerged from the abductive movement through the data: Economic Orientation, accounting for 58 extracts across four sub-themes (Distribution of economic benefit, 23; Limits to growth, 19; Prosperity through continuity, 12; Business oriented future, 4). The conscientious place branding framework set out in chapter 2 names four dimensions and a cross-cutting fifth (integrity and accountability). It does not name an economic register at the theme level, treating economic activity instead as an object the framework's commitments are supposed to redirect. The case shows residents and operators in Saltstraumen voicing economic continuity as the precondition on which the framework's commitments are voiced at all. The proposition is that the framework reads the case more faithfully when Economic Orientation is named alongside the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth, rather than treated as a residual of any one of them.

The sub-themes carry the precondition load in different registers. Distribution of economic benefit (23 extracts) appears closest to the framework's second dimension, but the overlap is partial: where the fairness dimension reads benefit as something shared more or less fairly among present stakeholders, respondents voice it as livelihood, a flow with a direction that the dimension does not track: R2 puts the dependence plainly, "Without the tourists, Saltstraumen is nothing, because the half year of summer and the tourist season is what keep all the business here alive"; R15 voices the same dependence from the resident side, "If it's not tourism here, we haven't been here and the population had gone down… we need each other for this one, but we have to keep the balance"; R11 catalogues the village's economic life in detail, "Tourist business, we have a hotel, a fishing camp, dive center… café restaurants… local co-op grocery store… school, daycare, elder care." Limits to growth (19 extracts) appears closest to the framework's third dimension, but again the overlap is partial: respondents voice it as a question of the scale and kind of tourism the economy can carry, not as the ecological horizon the dimension assumes. R1 names the distinction: "if it's the correct type of tourist. if it's tourism for experience. They are more than welcome. But we have to make a system, we have to have a place for them." R12 makes the same move: "I would direct to tourists who would like slow travel." R3 names the underlying pressure, "Saltstraumen is getting discovered by more and more people." Prosperity through continuity (12 extracts) and Business oriented future (4 extracts) carry registers the framework does not place. R10 voices the seasonal rhythm, "in the summer, it's just completely packed. And then in the winter, there's nothing." R5 voices the deliberate-growth register, "But they also need to not grow too much because they need to be aware where they are and we don't want to overcrowd Saltstraumen so we want it to be enough space for the residents but also good

activities for the ones visiting." The first two sub-themes are partial overlaps with existing dimensions. The second two are data-driven content the framework does not anticipate.

Read together, the sub-themes describe an economy in motion rather than a static backdrop. Tourist spend in the short summer season sustains the businesses, which sustain the employment and the resident population, which in turn sustain the services that make the village liveable: as R11 catalogues them, the hotel, fishing camp, dive centre, cafés, the local co-op grocery store, the school, daycare and elder care. R2 names the dependence at the head of this flow, "Without the tourists, Saltstraumen is nothing, because the half year of summer and the tourist season is what keep all the business here alive," and R15 names its purpose at the other end, the retention of a population that would otherwise decline. This is the circulation the framework's commitments rest on: continuity is what lets identity, fairness, sustainability and openness be voiced at all. But the flow is not wholly retained in the village. In at least two instances the benefit is realised outside the community. The local Coop is a department of the regional cooperative Coop Nordland SA, whose member ownership and surplus operate at the Nordland scale rather than the village scale (section 5.3.4; Coop Nordland SA, 2024). A non-locally-owned operator captures a further share of the tourism economy, while still employing local people, so labour stays in the village even as profit is realised elsewhere. The framework's dimensions register benefit as present or absent and as fairly or unfairly shared, but they have no coordinate for whether benefit is retained in the place or flows out of it. Economic Orientation makes that distinction visible, and it is one the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth do not carry.

The framework treats conscientious commitments as foreground and economic activity as background to be governed. The case shows respondents treating economic continuity as the precondition that lets conscientious commitments be voiced at all. What changes is the staging. The case does not collapse the dimensions into a single economic logic; the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth remain distinct in the data, and the four discussion sections above record each one. Economic Orientation should be named as the motivational ground that makes the other commitments livable, not treated as a residual of sustainability or fairness.

Three literature voices anchor the proposition. The conscientious corporate branding literature (Tjandra et al., 2025) carries the same distinction in corporate form: conscientious commitments are negotiated within an economic frame the brand depends on. The framework, in translating that literature to a place context, leaves the economic frame implicit; the Saltstraumen case forces it back to the surface. The SDG-oriented place branding literature (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Aguilera-Cora & Fernández-Cavia, 2025) treats economic, social and environmental sustainability as parallel pillars to be balanced. The case suggests an asymmetry: residents and operators voice economic continuity as the precondition that lets social and environmental concerns be voiced at all, and treating it as one of three understates its position. The co-creator literature (Aitken & Campelo, 2011; Braun et al., 2013) treats resident voice as the source of authentic brand meaning. The case shows the resident voice the literature anticipates is voiced through livelihood continuity in a

register the framework has no language for; recovering the voice requires adding the language.

The proposition is twofold. First, Economic Orientation should be named in the framework as a theme alongside the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth, on the grounds that the case carries 58 extracts of material the existing dimensions absorb only partially. Second, the case reads most faithfully when Economic Orientation is placed as the substrate beneath the four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth, rather than as a sixth dimension parallel to them: respondents voice economic continuity not as one more commitment to be balanced against the others, but as the precondition that lets the others be voiced at all, and they track economic life as a flow that sustains the community in part and is realised outside it in part, in a register the dimensions do not carry. Figure 7 depicts this substrate relationship, with the economy underpinning the framework and a share of its benefit realised elsewhere. Section 6.1 develops what placing Economic Orientation as a substrate implies for how the framework should be read. The contribution is claimed at the level of this case; what it cannot yet claim is the empirical reach of the substrate relationship across other tourism-dependent communities, where economic continuity may or may not be the precondition on which conscientious commitments rest. The framework, on this reading, names four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth that describe what conscientious place branding commits to; the case adds a sixth theme that describes what those commitments are built on.

5.2.2 Layered Accountability as an open question

The second contribution sharpens an open question rather than resolving it. Section 3.3 records the no-brand-owner condition: Saltstraumen has no deliberately constituted place brand authored at the village scale. The absence is not an absence of brand-like communication. Section 4.2.5, and resident-and-operator voice in 4.2.1 and 4.2.2, surfaced three external sources of authorship that communicate the place, none of them answerable at the village scale.

The three layers, visible in the corpus and the documentary evidence:

- Regional and national destination marketing (Visit Bodø; Visit Norway), which communicates the place in an experiential framing organised around the maelstrom.
- Commercial communication around a single operator-branded fishing site (Saltstraumen Brygge, and the associated fishing camp), which packages the place as a sport-fishing destination (Saltstraumen Brygge, n.d.).
- An informal sport-fishing reputation produced and circulated by anglers themselves through online platforms, travel blogs, and word of mouth (e.g., Fishbrain, n.d.; Dutch Anglers, 2016).

The three layers position the place under three different value-frames: general nature tourism; packaged sport-fishing destination; angler-produced world-class fishing reputation. The Layered cross-cutting tag in the corpus (56 extracts) collects the material where respondents speak in ways that touch more than one layer.

The framework's fifth, cross-cutting dimension, integrity and accountability, assumes a single brand actor against whom accountability is claimed. The case shows layered brand-like communication without the brand actor the dimension assumes. Two readings are possible. We do not adjudicate between them.

The first reading is a productive extension. The accountability literature is specific about what a place brand should be answerable through, and the case shows those requirements unmet. Eshuis and Edwards (2013) hold that branding is in conflict with accountability where there are no mechanisms for monitoring whether a brand's promises are realised and for holding the responsible actors to them; Tjandra et al. (2025) require that stated values align with everyday practice and that impact be measurable enough for stakeholders to observe. At Saltstraumen neither requirement is met at the village scale: the place is communicated through three external layers, none of which carries a monitoring mechanism, an observation point residents can use, or an actor who can be held to the promises the communication makes. Conscientious place branding should therefore specify what accountability looks like in cases of distributed authorship: which of the three layers a conscientious place brand at Saltstraumen would be answerable to, on what terms, and with what mechanisms. The place-brand-versus-destination-brand distinction (Govers, 2011; Hanna & Rowley, 2015) carries the territory-versus-marketed-product axis the case partly maps onto, but does not by itself carry the multi-layer pattern. The co-creator literature assumes a brand to co-create into; the case shows co-creation readiness in respondent voice without a brand at the village scale to receive it.

The second reading is limited. The framework's fifth dimension may be answering a different question than the case poses. Conscientious place branding may presuppose, as a scope condition, that a brand actor at the place scale exists. Saltstraumen would then map a boundary rather than populate new territory inside the framework.

The presentation framed this as putting the question on the table without resolving it. The chapter inherits that framing and adds one sharpening. The question is not whether conscientious place branding survives the absence of a single brand actor. The question is whether the framework can or should articulate accountability across three external sources of authorship that, in this case, communicate the place in incompatible value-frames without being answerable at the village scale.

Section 6.2 develops this as the theoretical contribution we name Layered Accountability: a condition in which integrity commitments hold within each governance layer but do not aggregate into accountability that residents can address as a whole.

5.3 Additional findings

Additional findings of the study that surfaced in the analysis are taken up in this section as discrete propositions. The first, on Bodø's marketing and branding, has the most direct

implications for conscientious place branding; the rest sharpen tensions the framework, properly elaborated, should be in a position to recognise.

5.3.1 Bodø marketing and branding

An important additional finding is that respondents discussed how Saltstraumen is used within Bodø's tourism branding to attract visitors to the municipality. R1 described how this relates to the municipality's aim of increasing cruise tourism and in this sense Saltstraumen functions as part of a wider destination system where Bodø operates as a main gateway for tourism flows in the region.

However, this relationship was not described as neutral by respondents. R6 expressed frustration that Saltstraumen is used in Bodø's tourism promotion, and respondents, for example R11, expressed concern that Saltstraumen is used as a selling point without a corresponding say in how it is represented. This relates to the "Not in our Name" situation described by Zenker and Petersen (2014), where top-down place branding was not fully supported or recognised by local communities. In this case, Saltstraumen is used within the branding narrative of Bodø, a powerful external stakeholder, despite local dissatisfaction with how their place is represented, creating a "Not in our Name" situation for a brand marketing other than their own.

The findings also indicate that Saltstraumen is already incorporated into a broader place branding narrative led at the municipal level. This relationship has a recognised shape in the place branding literature. Brand architecture, the structure that specifies the roles brands play and the relationships between them (Aaker & Joachimsthaler, 2000), distinguishes a branded house, in which a single master brand spans a set of offerings that operate as descriptive sub-brands carrying little driving role of their own (Aaker & Joachimsthaler, 2000). In the geographical reading of this architecture, a larger territory functions as the master brand and a smaller territory as the sub-brand (Zelenskaya & Elkanova, 2021). Saltstraumen sits in the sub-brand position: it supplies content to a Bodø master brand while exercising little control over how the place is represented. This reflects uneven power relations between local communities and larger destination authorities, where smaller places can become integrated into wider regional tourism marketing (Jeuring, 2016) without local communities necessarily experiencing equal control over branding processes or equivalent economic returns. At the same time, the data does not show a clearly defined role for Saltstraumen in this process from a local governance perspective, particularly in terms of how local priorities were included in wider branding or marketing decisions of Bodø. Saltstraumen functions as part of a broader marketing and brand connected to Bodø and tourism promotion, while local agreement on identity and long-term purpose remains fragmented and under negotiation. Bodø has already to some extent incorporated Saltstraumen into its tourism narrative, while Saltstraumen itself has had very limited opportunity to develop an independent place brand.

From this a potential tension emerges between external destination marketing and any future attempt to develop a more locally grounded and conscientious place brand in Saltstraumen. Several respondents emphasised the importance of balance and limits to tourism pressure, as

well as protection of both the local community and the natural environment. With Bodø pursuing continued tourism growth, and Saltstraumen already experiencing relatively high visitor pressure, external marketing that increases demand could conflict with local expectations regarding capacity and sustainability. If external branding from Bodø continues to prioritise tourism growth while Saltstraumen attempts to move toward a more restrained conscientious place branding approach, this may reduce the effectiveness of a conscientious place brand in practice and risk weakening the credibility. This does not necessarily indicate that the relationship between Bodø and Saltstraumen is negative in itself. However, it suggests that the effectiveness of a conscientious place brand depends on alignment between external destination marketing and local expectations over time.

The brand architecture literature describes this subordination as a strategic choice. The relationship between master brand and sub-brand is presented as a structure to be designed with insight and subtlety (Aaker & Joachimsthaler, 2000), and the dissolution of a smaller brand into a larger one is named as a risk of overlap and dilution for the brand manager to balance and negotiate (Zelenskaya & Elkanova, 2021). That literature is not blind to the local concern: the critique of a "one size fits all" brand holds that an overarching master brand flattens the legitimate meanings of a place's parts, and that sub-brands should be built from stakeholders' own associations rather than imposed (Zenker & Braun, 2017). Its remedy, however, keeps a marketing end, a brand that is more authentic and more credible. Based on what respondents described, the subordination of Saltstraumen registers in a different key. It is experienced not as a portfolio question but as a loss of identity and economic agency, where the place carries the visible pressure while the value and the branding decisions settle in Bodø. The literature equips the study to name the structure; it is more cautious about the distributive and lived stakes of that structure. This is where conscientious place branding does distinct work, holding the relationship answerable to the fairness owed to those being branded rather than to the coherence of the portfolio.

5.3.2 Realisation of economic benefits

The findings can also be related to earlier work in the tourism political economy. Britton (1982) argued that tourism destinations may experience a situation where the costs associated with tourism remain concentrated in the destination itself, while parts of the economic benefits are realised elsewhere through organisations and actors located outside the community. Although Saltstraumen differs considerably from the contexts Britton discussed, a similar pattern was visible in the findings. Several respondents described tourism activity and its associated pressures as experienced locally, including overcrowding in public spaces, parking difficulties, and limited infrastructure such as toilets and visitor facilities, while parts of the economic benefit connected to tourism were perceived to gather outside the community. These concerns surfaced in discussions about visitor flows and the distribution of economic benefits linked to tourism development, and they suggest that questions of economic benefit involve not only how much is generated but where it is realised geographically.

In Saltstraumen this question took a specific, regional form. Respondents described a perceived imbalance between where tourism is promoted and where its effects are experienced: Saltstraumen contributes significantly to Bodø's attractiveness as a destination but does not necessarily receive equivalent investment or local benefit in return. Much of the tourist spending and overnight stays take place in Bodø rather than in Saltstraumen itself, leaving residents with a perception that economic benefits and decision-making power are unevenly distributed. The dynamic appears at a regional scale, where Saltstraumen carries a large share of tourism pressure while Bodø captures a larger share of economic value through accommodation and destination branding. This resembles arguments in tourism geography and political economy, where pressures from tourism are experienced at one destination while economic benefits are concentrated elsewhere (Britton, 1982).

This does not mean Britton's model can be applied directly to the case. The findings do, however, indicate that the location and distribution of economic benefits are relevant when considering fairness and responsibility within conscientious place branding, and that the question of who benefits is partly a question of where the benefit lands.

5.3.3 The inhabited-continuity silence

The framework rests on inhabited continuity as the unit of analysis without naming it. The case makes the assumption visible by being under pressure on it. Decline signals run through the corpus; neither respondents nor the brand interrogate whether continuity should be the goal. We do not answer the question. The proposition: conscientious place branding has an unstated premise of inhabited continuity, which cases like Saltstraumen surface and which the framework, properly elaborated, should name. Naming the premise is the contribution; the underlying question of whether continuity should be the goal is left where the data leaves it, open.

5.3.4 Ownership scale and the meaning of local

The Coop case was taken up under RQ2 (section 5.1.2). The local Coop Prix in Saltstraumen is a department of Coop Nordland SA, the regional cooperative based in Bodø; staff at the store refused our research requests on non-residence grounds, while community-oriented commitments operate at the Nordland scale rather than the village scale. As a discrete proposition: conscientious place branding under-specifies what counts as local in cooperative or regionally owned commercial structures. Ownership scale and claimed place scale are not identical, and the framework should differentiate them. The case can carry the conceptual point but not a strong empirical claim about Coop Nordland's behaviour at the village scale. The proposition is held at the conceptual level it can bear.

The scale question raised here runs parallel to the brand-architecture tension discussed in 5.3.1: just as ownership scale and claimed place scale need not coincide, a smaller place brand can be absorbed into a larger one without its distinct identity or returns being preserved.

5.3.5 The formal-practical gap in allemannsretten

The gap was taken up under RQ2. As a discrete proposition: where universal access norms are statutory rather than brand-claimed, conscientious place branding should expect a formal-practical drift between the universal commitment and the practical conditions of inclusion, and should not expect that drift to surface as a contradiction to participants. The case shows the drift without participants thematising it. The framework, elaborated, would name the drift as a category of accountability gap the fifth dimension should expect.

Read more closely, allemannsretten is better understood not as a fixed feature of the place but as a shared meaning in transition. The right is part of what Saltstraumen is known for, open nature and the freedom to roam and fish, so it functions as part of the place brand rather than only as a legal norm. That meaning is under renegotiation in the present. The pressures respondents describe in section 5.1.2, visitors reading the right as licence rather than responsibility, foreign anglers in numbers, commercial-scale extraction, did not bear on the right when its local understanding settled, and they are reshaping what the right means in practice now. The right is therefore not fixed in time; it is being remade as the conditions around it change.

Nor is it fixed in space. The same right is lived differently in different parts of the place: R7 describes a stretch of the maelstrom he no longer fishes in summer, "this mess of boats," while continuing to fish elsewhere, and R13 notes that life without a car is "almost impossible" in the village while bus connections are "absolutely perfect" ten kilometres inland (section 5.1.2). The single universal right fractures into uneven local conditions, open in principle everywhere, practically available only in some places, at some times, to some people. For conscientious place branding the implication is that an inherited access norm is not a stable asset a place brand can simply rest on. It is a meaning in transition and local fracture that a brand would have to steward rather than assume, and the case offers no such steward.

5.3.6 Tourist co-creating place identity

An interview participant (R6) mentioned the possibility that tourists may also contribute to how residents understand and reflect on the identity of Saltstraumen itself. The respondent discussed how visitors can help residents “open their eyes” to qualities of the place that may otherwise be taken for granted in everyday life, suggesting that tourism may increase awareness of what makes Saltstraumen unique. In this sense, place identity could partly be co-created through interactions between local residents and visitors.

Kavaratzis and Hatch (2013) describe place identity as something shaped through ongoing dialogue between internal and external stakeholders, where meanings connected to place are continuously negotiated and reconstructed. This additional finding supports that perspective, as encounters between residents and tourists may influence how Saltstraumen is understood and valued over time. The dialogue between local and external actors can therefore also be considered as a form of co-creation, where meanings connected to the place are shaped

through ongoing social interaction. It does not mean that tourists automatically influence place identity in positive ways. Other findings in the study showed that tourism was also connected to overcrowding and pressure on the local community. But the findings suggest that interactions between residents and visitors can contribute to reflection and renegotiation of place identity, where both positive and negative tourism experiences influence how the place is understood over time.

This finding lies outside the primary scope of the study, as tourist perspectives themselves were not directly investigated. However, it emerged as an additional finding in the interviews and contributes to understanding how local identity may develop through continuing interaction between inhabitants connected to the place and those visiting it.

5.3.7 A truly conscientious place brand?

An additional reflection emerging from the findings concerns how environmental responsibility was discussed in relation to fishing in the marine protected area. Several respondents discussed tensions connected to fishing in the marine protected area and suggested that fishing activities causing environmental damage should instead take place outside of the protected zone. Respondents mentioned problems such as fishing equipment being left in the water, including hooks, lines and such that could damage marine life and underwater vegetation. While this solution may reduce environmental pressure inside the marine protected area itself, it also shifts environmental responsibility geographically. Moving fishing activities outside the protected zone would not necessarily remove the environmental impact altogether, but could instead relocate it to surrounding marine areas. This creates a situation where environmental protection becomes strongly connected to the formal borders of the protected area itself.

This observation is relevant to conscientious place branding because the framework emphasises ecological responsibility and long-term sustainable development. The findings therefore raise questions about whether sustainability efforts are fully conscientious if environmental pressure is primarily shifted elsewhere rather than reduced overall. The discussion extends beyond protection of a single designated area and relates to how nature actually is valued and managed within tourism development processes.

At the same time the data does not suggest that respondents viewed nature outside the marine protected area as unimportant. But the discussions showed that environmental protection in Saltstraumen was mainly focused on the marine protected area itself, while surrounding areas received less attention in discussions about sustainability. This does not mean that a conscientious place brand is impossible in Saltstraumen. However, the findings suggest that achieving a fully conscientious place branding approach may be difficult if sustainability measures mainly redistribute environmental pressure instead of addressing the broader environmental impacts connected to tourism and recreational activity more generally.

5.4 The findings as one picture

Sections 5.1 to 5.3 reported the case dimension by dimension, named two contributions, and set out six additional propositions. Read together, they describe one situation rather than several.

The four dimensions of the framework all surface in Saltstraumen, and each one strains against the framework's language in a particular way. Three of them (stakeholder fairness, temporal and ecological responsibility, integrity and accountability) carry the same recurring shape: a formal commitment inherited by the place (allemannsretten, the marine protected area, public information availability) sits alongside practical conditions that diverge from it, and respondents do not voice the gap as a contradiction. The formal-practical drift is therefore not local to any one dimension but a pattern that runs across them, surfacing wherever the place inherits commitments it has not itself authored.

Underneath the four dimensions sits Economic Orientation. Residents and operators do not voice livelihood continuity as a fifth concern alongside identity, fairness, sustainability and participation. They voice it as the precondition on which those commitments become possible to hold. The framework reads the case more faithfully when Economic Orientation is named as the substrate the other dimensions rest on, rather than treated as a residual of any one of them.

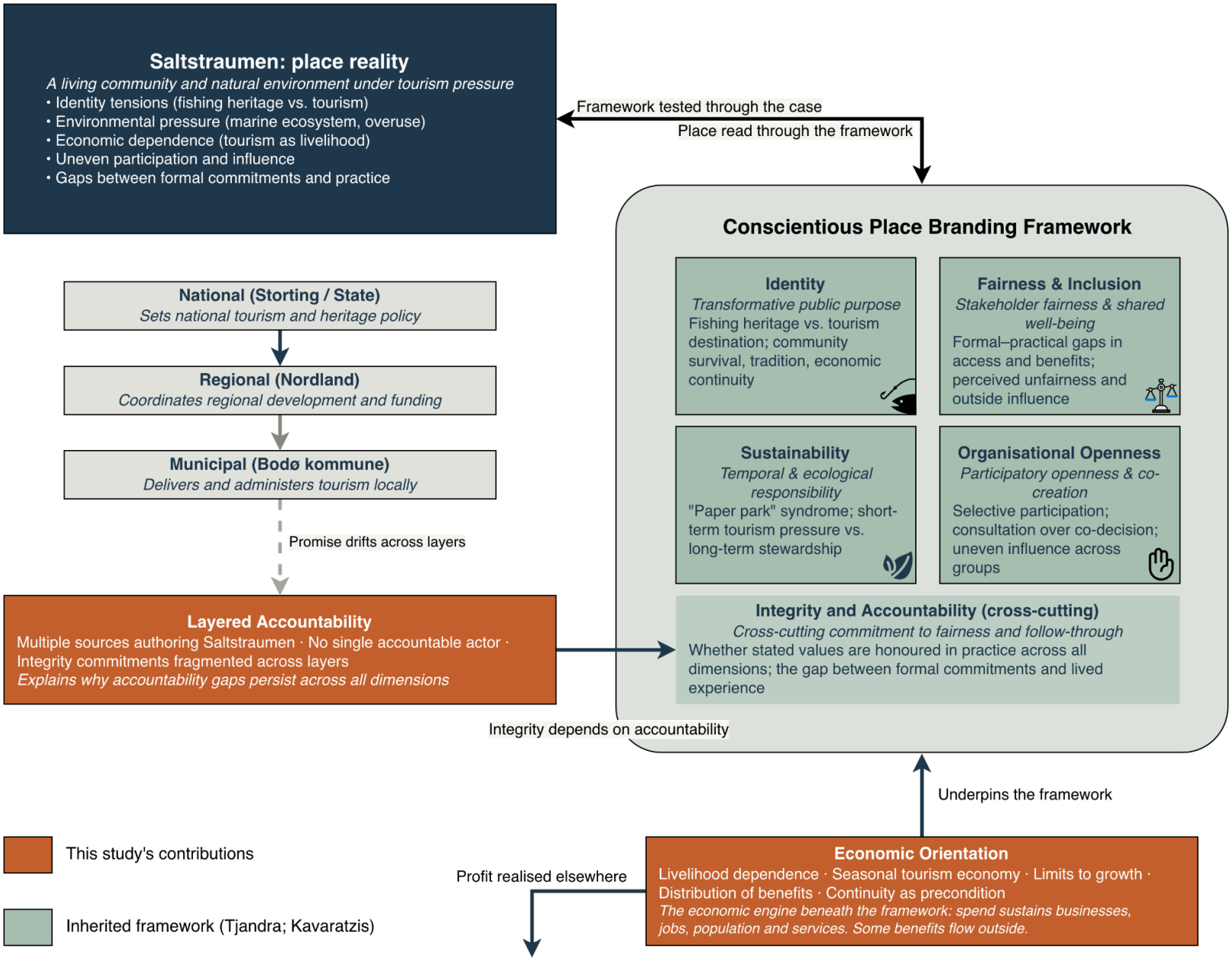
Cross-cutting the dimensions sits the question of who is answerable. The framework's cross-cutting fifth dimension, integrity and accountability, assumes a brand actor at the place scale. Saltstraumen has no such actor. Instead, the place is communicated through three external layers (regional and national destination marketing, single-operator commercial communication, and an angler-produced reputation produced through online platforms) none of which is answerable at the village scale. Layered Accountability names that condition. It is the open question the case puts on the table rather than a finding the case resolves.

The additional propositions in section 5.3 sit at the edge of this picture rather than inside it. Each one identifies a discrete tension the framework, properly elaborated, should recognise: the relationship between Saltstraumen and Bodø's destination marketing, the unstated premise of inhabited continuity, the under-specification of what counts as local in cooperative ownership, the formal-practical drift in statutory access norms, the role of tourists in co-creating place identity, and the geographic redistribution of environmental pressure. They do not extend the framework in the way Economic Orientation and Layered Accountability do, but they identify territory the framework should be aware of.

Figure 7 on the following page sets out these relationships. The four dimensions and the cross-cutting fifth describe what conscientious place branding commits to.

Figure 7

An integrating view of the chapter 5 findings.



The four dimensions of the conscientious place branding framework rest on Economic Orientation, the substrate of economic flows that both motivates the commitments and shapes whether they can be voiced at all. The cross-cutting fifth dimension, Integrity and Accountability, is shown above the four dimensions. Layered Accountability is shown as the condition under which the cross-cutting fifth has to be specified differently when no single brand actor exists at the place scale. Formal–practical drift is tagged on the dimensions in which it surfaces in the case. The additional propositions from section 5.3 sit at the edge as related but discrete contributions.

5.5 Limits on the propositions

Several limits should be named so the propositions are read at the weight the data supports. The corpus is small: 17 interviews, 687 extracts. The propositions above are conceptual rather than statistical. They identify patterns and tensions the framework should recognise, not frequencies that warrant generalisation.

The case is a no-brand-owner case. Several propositions depend on that scope condition: the Layered Accountability question is sharpened by it; the co-creation-readiness-without-brand pattern depends on it; the formal-practical gap in allemannsretten is heightened by the absence of a brand actor. Whether the propositions generalise to cases with a deliberately constituted place brand at the village scale is a question for further work.

The documentary evidence used to specify the three layers of distributed brand authorship was triangulated against the interview corpus but is not itself the object of the thematic analysis. The Layered Accountability question identifies a pattern across the three layers; specifying accountability across them would need further empirical work on each. We end with two contributions: Economic Orientation as an extension; Layered Accountability as a sharpened open question. Three further candidates are developed at the weight the data supports. Tensions the analysis surfaced are held open.

6. Conclusion and recommendations

The chapter begins by presenting the overall conclusions in relation to the research questions. It then sets out the theoretical implications of the study, followed by the practical implications for tourism-dependent communities facing similar challenges, and then the specific recommendations for Saltstraumen. The chapter concludes with the limitations of the study and suggestions for future research.

6.1 Overall Conclusions

The purpose of this thesis was to explore how conscientious branding theory can be applied to place branding in small tourism communities. Using Saltstraumen in northern Norway as a case study, the research examined local stakeholder perceptions of tourism development, place identity and stakeholder participation in order to assess what a conscientious place branding perspective can contribute to communities shaped by tourism. This thesis's overall research question asked in what way a conscientious place branding perspective can support the development of place brands in tourism-dependent communities. Saltstraumen offers an answer, and it is one the framework helped surface but did not, on its own, predict.

A conscientious place branding perspective supports development in tourism-dependent communities by recognising economic continuity as the motivational ground on which its other commitments become livable. Residents in Saltstraumen do not treat livelihood as background or context to the brand. They treat it as part of what makes the brand worth caring about. The community the brand represents is the same community whose continuation depends on tourism working in a particular way: at a particular pace, with particular kinds of visitors, in ways that do not hollow out the place the brand points to. Across 58 interview extracts, economic orientation appeared not as a separate concern weighed against fairness or ecological responsibility, but as the ground on which those commitments rest. Without livelihood continuity, residents could not sustain the other commitments the framework names. With it, the other commitments become possible to hold.

This finding cuts against a common framing in the SDG-oriented place branding literature, which treats economic, social and environmental sustainability as parallel pillars to be balanced (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Aguilera-Cora & Fernández-Cavia, 2025). The case suggests an asymmetry. In a tourism-dependent community, economic continuity does not sit alongside the social and environmental commitments as a third pillar of equal standing. It sits beneath them as the condition that makes them possible to sustain. In a well-resourced context, that condition might stay implicit, a background the framework can take for granted. In Saltstraumen, it surfaces as an explicit consideration residents articulate, prioritise and defend.

The framework's four dimensions still apply, and the case showed each of them at work: residents in Saltstraumen articulated a transformative public purpose for the brand, weighed stakeholder fairness across visitors, businesses and locals, connected short-term branding

initiatives to long-term outcomes for the place, and expected participatory openness from those governing the brand on their behalf. But what made these commitments coherent for residents was the underlying confidence that the place, economically, materially and as a community, would still be there to host them.

This has a practical consequence for how conscientious place branding is used. It is a perspective whose dimensions become meaningful against a substrate that the framework, as currently stated, does not name. Naming the substrate changes how the framework reads. The four dimensions, together with cross-cutting integrity and accountability, describe what conscientious place branding *commits to*. Economic orientation describes what those commitments are built on.

The case also showed that a conscientious place brand cannot be developed before a shared understanding of place identity has been established. In Saltstraumen the transformative public purpose appeared negotiated rather than fully shared, as residents described the place through environmental protection, economic survival and cultural continuity at the same time, without these perspectives fully aligning into one common purpose. This should not be understood as a general weakness of the community, it is a normal condition of a living place still negotiating its future direction in relation to tourism. The findings therefore suggest that identity negotiation is a necessary step before a conscientious place brand can fully develop. If the place branding is developed too early, it risks communicating an identity that parts of the community do not yet recognise as their own.

The case also showed the framework reaching the limit of its vocabulary at one particular point: where the cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability meets distributed governance. The theoretical implications that follow take up both of these, the substrate the framework rests on and the limit it reaches.

6.2 Theoretical Implications

The first, set out in the conclusions above, is economic orientation: the substrate the other commitments are built on, which the case proposes as a named part of the framework. Where the conclusions positioned this against the SDG literature's parallel-pillars framing, it bears equally on the benefit-distribution tension Chapter 2 left unresolved (Marzano & Scott, 2009; Reynolds et al., 2022; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020): that literature treats uneven local benefit as a fairness problem to be balanced, whereas the case reads economic continuity as the substrate the fairness commitment itself depends on. The second contribution concerns where the framework reaches the limit of its vocabulary, and the discussion below builds toward it by reading the findings against the literature set out in Chapter 2, strand by strand, to show where they confirm it, where they extend it, and where they contrast with it.

On place identity, the findings confirm the literature set out in Chapter 2. Kavaratzis and Hatch (2013) argue that place identity develops through ongoing dialogue between internal and external stakeholders, and a similar pattern was visible in Saltstraumen. Stakeholders

shared an attachment to the place, but they did not always agree on what aspects of it were most important or what role tourism should play in its future. Environmental protection, economic opportunity and local tradition were emphasised differently by different participants. The geography sharpens the point. Saltstraumen is not a single point of view that a brand can speak for; it is constituted relationally, through the practices and positions of actors distributed across the strait, who do not orient toward the place in the same way (section 4.1.2). The eastern and western banks gather different dispositions toward the common interest, and a brand built as though the community spoke with one voice would misrepresent that plurality rather than hold it together. This aligns with Kavaratzis and Kalandides' (2015) argument that places cannot easily be reduced to a single, unified identity, and it suggests the framework's task is to help a brand built across a contested geography remain answerable to the different ways the place is used and valued, rather than to settle those differences in advance.

On the conscientious branding core, the findings again confirm the literature but begin to press against it. Chapter 2 described conscientious brands as guided by a clear purpose that is embedded in identity and reflected in practice over time (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Tjandra et al., 2025). Across stakeholder groups in Saltstraumen there was broad agreement that the area's environmental qualities and community character should be protected, and these themes recurred in discussions about tourism and the future of the destination. The findings therefore reinforce the argument that shared values and a clear sense of purpose are foundations for branding to be done conscientiously. Chapter 2 also noted the risk of a gap between a brand's stated purpose and its actual practice (Biedenbach, 2025; Vredenburg et al., 2020), and similar risks were visible here, particularly around sustainability and environmental responsibility. The point of contrast is that this tradition was developed for organisations with identifiable leadership, internal communication channels and the capacity to be held accountable as a unit (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Tjandra et al., 2025). Saltstraumen surfaces a problem that this corporate heritage does not anticipate: where no single actor owns the place brand, the challenge is less about communicating a purpose consistently and more about reaching agreement on what the transformative public purpose of a conscientious place brand should be in the first place.

On stakeholder representativeness and participation, the findings confirm the literature and then extend it. Chapter 2 pointed to how networks and access to resources shape whose perspectives carry weight (Marzano & Scott, 2009; Reynolds et al., 2022). The same was visible in Saltstraumen: stakeholders did not participate in tourism-related processes in the same way or to the same extent, and access to ongoing discussion differed between groups. Business-connected stakeholders had standing access to the visitor strategy process, while ordinary residents participated mainly through consultative hearings and meetings, reflecting what Reynolds et al. (2022) described as influence shaped by economic position and network access rather than fully democratic representation. The case extends this in one respect. Chapter 2 framed the participation problem as one of inclusion, ensuring weaker-voiced stakeholders are brought into processes dominated by stronger ones. In Saltstraumen the problem has an additional structural dimension: even where inclusion is formally offered, the

governance structure distributes authorship across levels in a way that makes the overall process difficult to hold to account as a whole. Inclusion within a layer does not produce accountability across layers, and questions of accountability therefore deserve greater attention within participatory place branding, especially within a conscientious place brand, in destinations where development involves multiple organisations and layers of governance.

On co-creation, the findings confirm the literature and point to a dimension it underplays. Chapter 2 described place branding as a collaborative process in which multiple stakeholders shape the brand, with public authorities and destination managers increasingly taking facilitative rather than directive roles (Hatch & Schultz, 2010; Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). The Saltstraumen case supports this: no single actor was the sole author of the destination's trajectory, and discussions about tourism and future priorities drew contributions from several groups. But the case draws attention to a challenge the co-creation literature gives less weight. Bringing actors into the process is only one part of co-creation; a second concerns how priorities, commitments and decisions move between the organisations involved once they have been discussed. Saltstraumen's development involved several actors operating at different levels, each responsible for a part of the wider process, which makes it difficult to treat co-creation as a single process within a single arena. Co-creation in conscientious place branding may therefore involve a coordination dimension beyond participation itself: where existing work focuses on how actors contribute, the case indicates that attention is also needed for how shared priorities are carried across the organisations responsible for implementing them.

This sequence of contrasts converges on the framework's own limit. Conscientious place branding was developed as an integrative framework, drawing on conscientious corporate branding (Tjandra et al., 2025; Markovic et al., 2023) and governance-oriented place branding scholarship (Kavaratzis & Kalandides, 2015; Klijn et al., 2012; Ripoll González & Gale, 2020). Its four dimensions, transformative public purpose, stakeholder fairness and shared well-being, temporal and ecological responsibility, and participatory openness and co-creation, are held together by a cross-cutting commitment to integrity and accountability. That commitment carries the framework's corporate heritage most directly, because it assumes a brand with an author who can be held to its promises. Saltstraumen does not have one.

In Saltstraumen the place brand has no single author. It is shaped in parallel by Bodø Kommune, Nordland Fylkeskommune, Visit Bodø, Statsforvalteren, private operators and residents themselves, each operating with their own remit, timelines and accountability structures. None of them speaks for the brand as a whole. Residents seeking transparency about decisions affecting the brand encountered this directly: information sat in different places, decisions were made at different levels, and no single layer could answer for the others. R6 and R8 described trying to find out who was deciding what, and finding the question itself had no clear addressee.

Chapter 5 took up Eshuis and Edwards' (2013) formulation that branding is in conflict with accountability when no mechanisms exist for monitoring the realisation of a brand's promises

and for holding the responsible actors to them. Saltstraumen shows a more specific version of that conflict. The accountability is not absent; it is layered, present at each level but not legible across them.

This is the contribution the case offers to the framework. The integrity and accountability commitment, as currently stated, assumes that openness can be directed at an author: someone or something that can be opened up to scrutiny, aligned with stated values, and held to its trade-offs. When authorship is distributed across layers of governance that do not coordinate publicly, the commitment has no clear target.

We name this pattern Layered Accountability: a condition in which integrity commitments hold within each governance layer but do not aggregate into accountability that residents can address as a whole. The framework's cross-cutting integrity and accountability commitment remains intact. What Layered Accountability adds is vocabulary for what that commitment has to do when the brand has multiple authors operating in parallel rather than one author operating internally. This also gives the framework purchase on a risk Chapter 2 anticipated: that a conscientious or SDG-oriented purpose can become a symbolic overlay, or facilitate greenwashing, when it is not tied to concrete accountability mechanisms (Aguilera-Cora et al., 2025; Liu & Park, 2025; Tjandra et al., 2025). Layered Accountability locates where that risk actually bites in a place setting: not in the absence of commitment, but in authorship distributed across layers that cannot be addressed as a whole.

This connects to a body of work on public-governance place branding that the framework drew from but did not fully absorb on this point. Klijn et al. (2012) established that stakeholder involvement materially affects place-branding effectiveness when branding is conducted under public authority. Ripoll et al. (2023) showed that participation predicts brand citizenship behaviour: residents' willingness to act on behalf of the brand depends on whether they had a voice in its making. Gulisova (2026), working on a Danish public-private partnership case, develops the legitimacy question through an input, throughput and output legitimacy triad that maps closely onto what residents in Saltstraumen were asking for: input legitimacy through voice into the process, throughput legitimacy through transparency within it, and output legitimacy through accountability for its results. Where the conscientious branding tradition reads legitimacy as a property of a single brand actor who can be aligned with stakeholder expectations (Tjandra et al., 2025; Iglesias & Ind, 2020), the input, throughput and output triad reads legitimacy as a property of the governance process through which the brand is made. These contributions sit upstream of the conscientious framework rather than within it, and the case suggests they belong inside the framework's account of integrity and accountability when the brand is publicly governed and distributed in authorship.

The corporate tradition reaches the same edge from the other side. Work on operationalising conscientious commitments within firms ties their delivery to participatory mechanisms that align an internal workforce with the brand's promises (Liewendahl et al., 2025), mechanisms that presuppose the single internal author Saltstraumen does not have. Read together, the public-governance and corporate literatures converge on what the case makes visible:

integrity and accountability depend on an addressable author, and Layered Accountability is the name for what that commitment requires when no such author exists.

The framework's diagnostic reach is the case's evidence for its usefulness as proposed. As the conclusions set out, all four dimensions proved legible in the interview data, making commitments visible that would otherwise have stayed implicit. That the framework surfaces these commitments without prompting is the practical case for adopting them.

Three further candidates from section 5.3 sit at the edge of the framework rather than inside it, and the conditions under which each would be advanced beyond a single case can be named. The inhabited-continuity silence (5.3.3) would need cases where the premise is contested by participants rather than only by external decline signals. The ownership-scale proposition (5.3.4) would need cases where cooperatively or regionally owned commercial structures act at the village scale on terms the framework would be asked to evaluate. The formal-practical gap in allemannsretten (5.3.5) would need cases where the drift between statutory universal access and the practical conditions of inclusion has become thematised by participants. None of these is advanced as a contribution of the present study; they are propositions the framework, properly elaborated, should be in a position to address.

6.3 Practical Implications

This study provides several practical implications for local communities working with place branding, tourism businesses, destination management organisations and municipalities. The implications are drawn directly from the findings of the case and are intended to be transferable beyond Saltstraumen.

6.3.1 Resident identity as the foundation of place branding

The findings show that branding processes in tourism-dependent communities are closely connected to local identity and resident experiences. In Saltstraumen and similar destinations, it is difficult to separate tourism branding from discussions about everyday life and the future direction of the community, as the legitimacy of place branding depends on resident recognition and acceptance. When community identity is fragmented or not collectively articulated, attempts to develop a coherent external brand may risk communicating an image that local residents do not fully recognise or support. In Saltstraumen, residents described the place through everyday practices such as fishing traditions, while parts of the external tourism image appeared more strongly associated with visitor-oriented representations (for example, the maelstrom rather than everyday local use of the area).

When elements that have played a central role in shaping the contemporary identity of a place are removed or marginalised in branding and marketing processes, tensions may arise in the tourism communities as externally communicated images diverge from locally grounded views of place identity. For practitioners, this indicates that involving residents in identity formation processes is essential for effective (conscientious) place branding. A place brand

that reflects a collectively established understanding of identity is more likely to be supported and co-produced by all residents than one developed without such a foundation.

6.3.2 Ecological knowledge and the limits of sustainability claims

Environmental concerns were closely connected to discussions about tourism development in the case. The marine environment formed part of both the local identity and the tourism attractiveness of Saltstraumen, while concerns regarding environmental pressure and long-term sustainability were raised across stakeholder groups. The case also highlighted questions related to ecological knowledge and responsibility in tourism development. Discussions surrounding fishing tourism revealed uncertainty regarding local fish stocks and the long-term ecological effects of increasing tourism activity. At the same time recreational fishing constituted an important part of both the tourism economy and the identity of the destination. For tourism businesses and destinations that depend on natural resources, limited or uncertain ecological knowledge may create challenges for developing and communicating sustainability-oriented or conscientious branding strategies. In the Saltstraumen case ecological uncertainty became closely linked to the questions of long-term tourism development versus responsibility toward the local environment.

The findings suggest that destinations whose tourism activities rely directly on natural resources may experience increasing pressure to document and monitor the environmental conditions that support tourism activity. This became evident in discussions on fishing tourism, where stakeholders expressed concerns about long-term sustainability while also acknowledging uncertainty about the actual state of local fish stocks. The case illustrates how environmental uncertainty itself can become part of tourism governance and branding discussions in nature-based destinations. For destinations seeking to position themselves around sustainability or conscientious development, environmental responsibility is therefore not limited to branding communication, because it is also closely connected to how tourism activities are monitored and managed over time.

6.3.3 Positioning small destinations within regional brands

The case of Saltstraumen indicates a broader practical issue in destination branding concerning how smaller tourism destinations are positioned within larger regional brands. Small destinations can be marketed as part of a wider destination structure, which can provide advantages such as shared resources and already established marketing channels. However, the findings suggest that tensions may arise when local stakeholders perceive an imbalance between the contribution of the local destination to the wider brand and the benefits or influence they receive in return, and also in relation to shaping their own place identity. At the same time, full brand independence may not be realistic for many small destinations due to limited resources and reliance on regional tourism organisations.

This indicates that place branding strategies in similar contexts should carefully balance resource efficiency with local identity representation, and ensure that stakeholders from smaller destinations are meaningfully involved in all decisions regarding how their place is

positioned both within their own local place brand narrative and within broader regional destination brands. If a community contributes to a wider destination's attractiveness, it should also have a meaningful role in shaping what it receives in return.

6.3.4 From consultation to co-creation in branding governance

The study found that participation in branding-adjacent governance in the case community was unevenly distributed. Businesses with ongoing access to decision-making discussions had more continuous involvement, while residents mainly participated through public meetings and hearings related to tourism development and visitor strategy work, including having a representation through a locally representative as a part of the Ressursgruppe.

The practical implication is not that consultation processes lack value, but that practitioners should clearly define what participation entails at different stages of governance. Consultation can create opportunities for dialogue, but the final decision-making and coordination often remain concentrated within institutional structures. Residents and local tourism operators were primarily involved through consultative rather than permanent governance roles. Co-creation, in the sense the conscientious place branding intends, implies stakeholder involvement that extends beyond consultation and includes shared influence over all of the parts in the decision-making processes. With an aim to develop a place brand grounded in community identity and resident perspectives, this distinction becomes important.

The case also illustrates that participation in tourism development involves more than whether stakeholders are invited to contribute opinions. Governance structures shape which actors participate continuously, which actors participate occasionally and how different perspectives are carried forward into decision-making processes. For destinations applying more conscientious, participatory approaches to place branding, the point of uneven participation and limited influence becomes especially important when tourism affects everyday life and the long-term future of the community.

6.3.5 Aligning brand promises with what the place can deliver

The study shows that commitments such as protection rules, access arrangements and sustainability goals are often decided at institutional level rather than by the local community. This can create a gap between what a destination brand promises and what can actually be delivered in practice and this gap is not always clearly visible to residents or visitors. The practical implication is then that brand practitioners should see the match between brand communication and what the place can realistically deliver, rather than assuming this is settled at the point of launch. Sustainability claims for example should be supported by ways to monitor and report what is actually happening. If a conscientious place brand communicates promises that the place cannot realistically meet, it risks losing credibility over time as the difference between expectations and reality becomes more visible.

6.3.6 Making accountability legible across governance levels

Lastly, a recurring finding across the study is that accountability in multi-level governance systems tends to function within individual governance layers, but becomes less clear when responsibility moves between local, municipal, regional and the national levels. From a resident perspective, it is often possible to identify who may be responsible at each level, but less clear how decisions and commitments are carried across levels in practice. For practitioners this would suggest that conscientious branding commitments cannot rely solely on each governance actor being accountable within their own institutional remit. In layered governance contexts, accountability needs to be made explicit across levels as well. This may require mechanisms such as a coordinator working across levels of government, a joint group with clear responsibility across institutions or shared reporting systems that make collective commitments easier to follow and understand instead of being spread across separate administrative levels.

6.4 Recommendations for Saltstraumen

This section sets out what the case suggests for those working on the place brand of Saltstraumen, and for tourism-dependent communities facing similar questions. The recommendations are grounded in what residents said, what the framework helped surface, and what the broader research literature supports. None of them require accepting every part of the theoretical contribution in section 6.2 to be useful.

6.4.1 Fishing in brand communication

Fishing is part of how residents understand Saltstraumen. It is also, from the perspective of the regional administration, the principal pressure on the marine area the protected status was designed to safeguard. It has been central to the community for generations, it shapes local identity, and it appears across the interview data as a settled point of reference rather than a contested one. The absence of fishing from any deliberate brand strategy does not mean it is absent from the brand. It means the brand's account of fishing is being shaped by other actors, including tourism operators with their own commercial reasons for emphasising particular kinds of fishing experience.

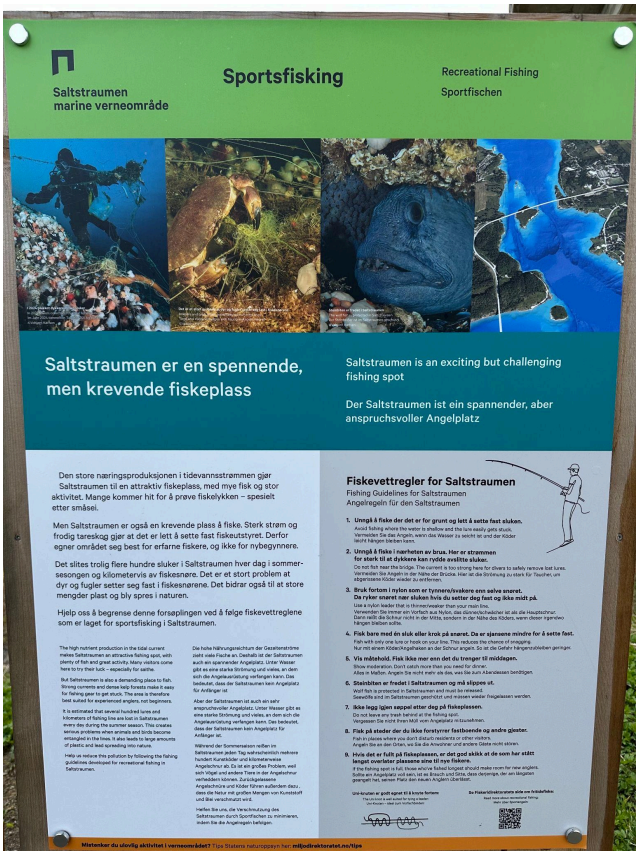
Bringing fishing into brand communication has two practical benefits. First, it lets the place speak about fishing on its own terms, as part of who Saltstraumen is, rather than ceding that ground to whoever speaks loudest. Second, fishing tourism tends to attract long-stay visitors who return repeatedly and engage with the community over time. Several respondents distinguished this pattern from the cruise and bus arrivals that dominate the high season, and most preferred it. A brand strategy that recognises fishing as identity-constitutive can also recognise the kind of visitor that brings.

The recommendation is not made in a vacuum. The regional administration's preferred direction is, on the public record, to constrain rather than amplify sport fishing in

Saltstraumen. The forvaltningsplan adopted by Statsforvalteren i Nordland on 10 February 2025 sets out the management framework for the marine protected area and includes a visitor strategy specifically for shore-based sport fishers (Statsforvalteren i Nordland, 2025a). In November 2025 Statsforvalteren announced that signage had been put in place at named fishing locations to steer sport fishers away from shallow, kelp-rich and high-current areas (see Figure 8), and that the agency had asked Miljødirektoratet to initiate a dialogue with the fisheries authorities about regulating sport fishing in Saltstraumen, with a fishing-licence (fiskekort) system identified as a possible mechanism (Statsforvalteren i Nordland, 2025b).

Figure 8

Interpretive sign for sport fishers at Saltstraumen marine protected area



Note. The signage referred to here was put in place by Statens Naturoppsyn and Statsforvalteren i Nordland in autumn 2025 (Statsforvalteren i Nordland, 2025b). Photograph by N. Sibly, April 2026 during fieldwork.

The sign sets out eight fiskevettregler (fishing guidelines) in Norwegian, English and German, including avoiding shallow water and the area immediately under the bridge, using a single hook on a thinner leader, taking only as much as needed, releasing wolf fish (a protected species in Saltstraumen), and not disturbing other residents or visitors. The sign also reports that an estimated several hundred lures and kilometres of fishing line are lost in Saltstraumen each day during the summer season, creating entanglement and plastic-and-lead pollution problems for wildlife.

The follow-up conversation with representatives of the regional administration described the same direction of travel in more concrete terms, including a phased approach beginning with prohibitions in the most sensitive areas and moving towards a licence system with designated areas and times, and noted that the process is expected to take years to complete (representatives of the regional administration, personal communication, May 26, 2026).

The recommendation above and this administrative direction therefore disagree on the same point: whether fishing should be addressed in brand communication on its own terms, as residents and many operators describe it, or addressed instead by being moved out of brand communication while regulatory mechanisms catch up with the conservation concern. The

case in this thesis supports the first reading on the grounds set out above, but the second reading is not unreasonable and should be visible alongside it. A conscientious brand cannot quietly take fishing's side or quietly take the marine area's side without making the choice it has made visible to the people who live with the consequences. The practical implication is that brand communication about fishing should be developed in coordination with the regulatory process rather than in parallel to it, so that what the brand says about fishing and what the regulation allows about fishing move into alignment over time rather than into open contradiction.

6.4.2 Cruise tourism and the resident-preferred way forward

Cruise arrivals appear in the data as a tension. Several respondents described the arrival of cruise passengers in terms that emphasised volume over engagement, and the way these visits interact with infrastructure, traffic, and the experience of the place for residents and longer-stay visitors. The Saltstraumen experience these respondents describe valuing is the slow one: the maelstrom watched at the right tide, fishing on a quiet day, places used at human scale. This is not, in general, the visitor cruise itineraries deliver.

This reading is consistent with the position taken by the regional administration. In a complementary interview, representatives of the regional administration described the current direction on cruise tourism as misaligned with the regenerative perspective the county is pursuing. Bodø harbour and the relevant master plan currently anticipate cruise traffic, but the question of how to host it well has not been worked through (representatives of the regional administration, personal communication, May 26, 2026). They also observed that local businesses are beginning to organise around setting their own terms for cruise engagement, including limits on the number of buses arriving at a time. The administrative view, the resident view recorded in the interviews, and the business view emerging in practice converge: cruise tourism in Saltstraumen needs to be designed rather than absorbed.

The case does not show that cruise tourism is incompatible with the brand the community would want. It shows that residents and local businesses see the way forward differently from how cruise tourism is currently structured. That difference is the kind of question the visitor strategy work is well positioned to take up. Working through it openly, with explicit attention to what kind of visitor the brand is for, would address one of the clearer points of unresolved tension in the data.

6.4.3 Operating without knowing is incompatible with conscientious commitments

Section 5.1.3 surfaced an empirical contest over ecological recoverability that the case leaves open, on a basis that is in significant part observational rather than evidential. This recommendation gives a name to the pattern: operating without knowing is incompatible with conscientious commitments. The framework's commitment to temporal and ecological responsibility implies that tourism businesses dependent on a natural resource cannot operate as if the state of that resource is someone else's concern. In Saltstraumen, the relevant

resource is the fish stock that supports recreational fishing tourism, and the relevant question is whether that stock is under pressure from the activities a successful fishing tourism brand would intensify.

The honest answer is that the question is empirically open in the Saltstraumen area specifically. It is not open in the Norwegian peer-reviewed literature more broadly. Kleiven et al. (2016) found, working with tag-recovery data on Skagerrak coastal cod, that recreational rod-and-line fishing accounted for 33.7% of total cod mortality, compared with 15.1% for commercial fisheries. This does not mean the same proportions apply in Saltstraumen, which sits in the northern coastal cod stock complex rather than the Skagerrak system. It does mean that the proposition that recreational fishing pressure is negligible cannot be assumed without local evidence.

Precedents elsewhere illustrate why the question deserves to be taken seriously. The Atlantic cod fishery on Georges Bank collapsed in the early 1990s after decades of intensifying pressure, and parts of the bank remain closed to commercial fishing more than thirty years later (Fogarty & Murawski, 1998). Closer to home, the Atlantic cod population in the Oslofjord has been declining for decades and is now considered to have collapsed, with large areas of the fjord closed to all fishing as of 2024 (Langangen et al., 2026). The closure was implemented in conditions of substantial scientific uncertainty about the precise contribution of each pressure on the stock. The lesson from both cases is not that Saltstraumen is on the same trajectory. It is that unknowns can resolve badly, and that waiting for full scientific certainty before acting is the wrong default.

This carries a direct business risk for tourism operators whose model depends on recreational fishing. The Norwegian Directorate of Fisheries has both the authority and a record of closing areas to fishing when stocks are judged to be at risk, as the Oslofjord ban makes plain. A closure applies to all fishing, recreational included, and offers no compensation route for an operator whose business is built on the activity continuing. The exposure is asymmetric. An operator who tracks the state of local stocks, contributes to credible assessment of pressures on them, and adjusts the business accordingly retains some capacity to respond before a closure becomes the only option available to a regulator. An operator who does not is in the same position as the operator who did, when the closure comes, with less warning and fewer choices. The prudential case for taking these questions seriously does not depend on accepting the framework's moral case. It runs alongside it.

This is the principle the Food and Agriculture Organization formulated as the precautionary approach to capture fisheries, in which the absence of full scientific information shall not be used as a reason for postponing measures to prevent overexploitation (FAO, 1996). The principle is widely adopted in international fisheries management. Its translation into a brand strategy is the position that a fishing tourism business cannot defend a claim to conscientious operation if it has not taken its own responsibility for knowing what its activities cost. Ignorance about the state of local stocks is a position. It is the position of operating as if the question does not apply.

There is a further consideration. Larger commercial fishing pressure on stocks shared with the Saltstraumen area is set at higher levels of government than the kommune. Local fishing tourism operators have direct exposure to those decisions through their dependence on the same fish populations. They also have standing, as commercially significant local actors, to advocate at the level where those decisions are made. Using that standing to press for credible assessment of pressures on local stocks is consistent with the conscientious commitments the brand would claim. Operating without knowing is not.

6.4.4 The Ressursgruppe as a step forward, and what it does not yet do

The visitor strategy work now led by the kommune through the Ressursgruppe is a positive development. It establishes a venue for coordinated work across Bodø Kommune, Nordland Fylkeskommune, Visit Bodø, and Statsforvalteren, and it uses participatory language (*samskaping*, *forankring*) that aligns with the framework's commitments to participatory openness and co-creation. The process has included three rounds of public consultation, the most recent of which took place shortly after the fieldwork for this thesis was completed, alongside separate engagement with residents whose knowledge of the place is most relevant to the strategy. The kommune is acting as a facilitator in the way the framework would recommend.

The Ressursgruppe's origin is itself part of the story this section is telling. As section 4.2.4.2 sets out, the group was initiated by Statsforvalteren in connection with the marine management plan and was then widened to include Bodø Kommune, the local business network and the kommunedelsutvalg, with the kommune taking on the day-to-day coordinating role from that point. The shift in leadership from a state convenor to a municipal one matters here because the framework's reading of place branding as a municipal responsibility (Eshuis & Edwards, 2013) is supported by the current arrangement but was not the arrangement at the start. Reading the Ressursgruppe as a kommune-led participatory venue, which the visitor strategy materials and most respondent accounts do, is accurate as a description of how it now works, but it understates the extent to which a state-level concern about the marine area is part of what brought the venue into being. The framework's framing of the kommune as the place authority best positioned to coordinate the brand still holds; the genesis simply makes clear that the kommune is exercising a coordinating role on a process that did not originate inside the kommune's own remit.

Among the questions the Ressursgruppe is positioned to take up is whether Saltstraumen should continue to sit under the Bodø place brand or be developed in its own voice. Residents describe Saltstraumen and Bodø as different places with different relationships to visitors and different concerns about growth, and the strongest pull on the brand from outside, the maelstrom and the fishing, are Saltstraumen's rather than Bodø's; the question is properly for the kommune and the Ressursgruppe to weigh, ideally with explicit input from residents on the question itself rather than only on what the brand should say.

The Ressursgruppe's work also sits inside a wider policy frame that is worth making visible here, because it shapes the vocabulary the venue uses. Nordland Fylkeskommune has adopted a regional tourism strategy oriented around regenerative tourism, drawing on the lineage outlined by Bellato and Pollock (2025), and Saltstraumen has been used as a worked example in the strategy's development (representatives of the regional administration, personal communication, May 26, 2026). This positions the Ressursgruppe's coordinating work not only as a local-level participatory venue but as one instance of how a regenerative tourism strategy is being translated into practice at destination scale. The framework reading in this chapter does not depend on the strategy's success or failure on its own terms, but reading the venue alongside the strategy clarifies why the language of samskaping and forankring recurs so naturally in the venue's documents and why the venue treats participatory consultation as a substantive commitment rather than a procedural step.

What the Ressursgruppe does not yet do is constitute residents and local operators as standing members of the governance group itself, rather than as consulted parties whose input feeds in at defined points. This is a smaller observation than it sounds. Consultation has happened and is happening, and the substance of what residents have said appears to be reaching the process. The structural point is that the Ressursgruppe's composition currently coordinates across governance layers, which is one part of what section 5.2.2 named as Layered Accountability. The layered character of accountability is not fully resolved by coordinating the layers, even with active consultation alongside. It is also resolved by ensuring that the residents and operators whose lives are shaped by the brand are present in the room where decisions are weighed, not only present in the record of what was heard before the decisions were taken.

The kommune has the standing as place authority to extend the Ressursgruppe's composition or to constitute a parallel resident and operator body whose voice carries through to the decision stage as a matter of structure rather than as a matter of consultation practice. The choice between these and other arrangements is proper for the kommune and the Ressursgruppe to make. The observation here is only that consultation, however well conducted, is a different kind of inclusion than membership, and that the framework's commitment to participatory openness and co-creation reads most strongly when membership and consultation reinforce one another.

6.4.5 Resources and the gap between aspiration and practice

Several of the recommendations above, and several of the suggestions raised by respondents in the data, depend on resources the kommune has not committed and a national tourism funding picture that does not currently underwrite them. A fishing host or fishing guide role, suggested in the interviews as a way to help visitors fish responsibly and as a way of operationalising the recommendation in section 6.4.1 above, is a practical, locally generated idea that would require funding to deliver. Infrastructure for visitor flow management, signage in multiple languages, sanitation, parking, and the basic operational substrate of hosting large numbers of visitors at peak times are all matters where the gap between what the

place can offer and what visitors expect is filled, at present, by the goodwill of residents and the operating margins of small businesses.

This points to a practical implication that sits at the boundary between branding and policy. A brand that promises a conscientious visitor experience and an authentic engagement with a working community needs to be supported by investment that lets the community deliver on that promise. Without it, the brand makes commitments the place is not equipped to keep, and the gap between communication and lived practice becomes the place where authenticity is lost. Eshuis and Edwards (2013) put this as the conflict between branding and accountability when mechanisms to deliver on what is communicated are absent. The conscientious branding tradition makes the same point as the requirement that commitments be enacted rather than declared (Tjandra et al., 2025).

6.4.6 Closing position

Two principles draw the practical implications together. Branding without responsibility is inauthentic. Rules without consequences are irrelevant. The first applies to the businesses, including tourism operators, whose communication shapes how Saltstraumen is encountered. The second applies to the public actors whose decisions shape what is possible to do in and around the place. Conscientious place branding asks both to take their commitments seriously enough that the place still resembles what the brand says about it ten and twenty years from now.

The case shows a community that already takes these questions seriously. The work of branding Saltstraumen conscientiously is not work that needs to begin. It is work that needs to be matched with the resources, the inclusion and the willingness to act under uncertainty that the framework, and the residents who articulated its commitments before the framework named them, both call for.

6.5 Limitations

This thesis is a single-case study of Saltstraumen and the findings are not intended to generalise statistically to other places. The depth that a case study offers comes at a cost in breadth, and the conclusions drawn here should be read as analytically transferable to comparable settings rather than universally applicable (Yin, 1994). Several additional limitations should be acknowledged.

The authors were not fluent in Norwegian. One author is a fluent Swedish speaker, which carried some cross-linguistic comprehension into the Norwegian context, but neither of us could conduct interviews in the respondents' first language. The interviews were therefore held in English. The authors worked carefully with respondents to confirm understanding during and after the conversations, but minor misinterpretations or shifts in nuance cannot be ruled out. It is also possible that two or three potential respondents who declined or did not attend scheduled interviews were deterred by the language requirement, although this may

equally have produced a positive selection effect in that those who did participate were comfortable articulating their views in English.

The authors approached the study with their own positions, which inform how data were heard and interpreted. The first author is Australian by birth, education and main professional experience, and arrives at Norwegian consensus politics and at the structures of Norwegian municipal and regional governance as an outsider. The same author is an experienced scuba diver, and recreational diving as a community is generally aligned with a marine conservation orientation; this position was likely to predispose us towards the perspective of the dive operator and similar conservation-minded respondents. The second author was born in Sweden and is therefore relatively familiar with the structure of Norwegian political system and the broader societal context. Such insider familiarity may lead certain conditions to appear self-evident rather than noteworthy, and it is possible that some structural features of the Norwegian context were taken for granted, where a researcher without this background might have examined them more closely. The same author had no prior experience with diving, very limited experience with fishing and no prior knowledge of marine protected areas or conservation.

Tourists were not interviewed. This was partly a function of season, fieldwork was conducted outside the main tourism season, and partly a function of where Saltstraumen sits in its branding process: visitor management is currently being developed, and the question of what kind of tourism the community wants is not yet settled in a way that would have given tourists a stable thing to respond to. Tourists are nonetheless part of the co-creation process in any conscientious place branding framing, and their absence from the dataset is a limitation we acknowledge directly.

Our partner organisation was NORD&NE, a dive centre and the same organisation through which the first author has a long-standing personal connection to Saltstraumen. This connection facilitated access to the field but introduced a risk of skewing the sample toward conservation-aligned and east-side perspectives. This was mitigated through snowball sampling outwards from the initial contact, and the final set of seventeen respondents spans east and west sides of the strait and a range of business types and stances. The risk was reduced rather than eliminated.

A further methodological limitation is the mixed way the data was collected. Ten interviews were done in person in Saltstraumen, while seven were done online through Zoom or Teams. Online interviews can be affected by technical issues such as unstable internet, which may interrupt the conversation or lead to missing parts of it. They also provide fewer non-verbal cues that can make it harder to build rapport and respond to pauses or hesitation. Although no major technical problems occurred, some nuance may still have been lost compared to the in-person interviews.

The sample composition is itself worth noting. Most respondents held more than one role in the community: business owner, resident, and in some cases also a member of the

Ressursgruppe or local political body. The roles were generally not separated in the analysis, partly because doing so would risk identifying individual respondents and partly because the respondents themselves did not consistently separate them when speaking. Four respondents had no tourism business connection, but to protect their anonymity we have not flagged this distinction in the respondent table. The reader should therefore be aware that the authors have data from non-business community voices, but cannot point to specific instances of it without compromising the anonymisation promised.

The conscientious place branding framework also has theoretical limitations. The framework draws on two bodies of literature: conscientious corporate branding and governance-oriented place branding, which were developed in different institutional settings and with different main concerns. The synthesis presented in Chapter 2 is based on conceptual similarities between the two fields. While both literatures address issues related to concepts such as purpose, stakeholder relationships, sustainability and governance, there is still limited empirical research examining how these concepts interact when brought together within a single place branding framework. Parts of the framework, such as transformative public purpose, are taken from conscientious branding research that has mainly been developed in corporate and organisational settings. These ideas may not carry the same meaning or operate in the same way when applied to other place branding contexts and it calls for the comparative and multi-context testing of the framework.

Finally, the data are a time-bound snapshot. Saltstraumen was mid-process during fieldwork: the Ressursgruppe was active, the management plan was being drafted, and the marine protected area regulation was being revisited. A follow-up conversation with representatives of the regional administration, conducted after the main fieldwork (see section 3.4), confirmed that several of the processes described by respondents have since moved forward. The conclusions drawn here are therefore a reading of Saltstraumen at a particular moment, and the picture will continue to develop after this thesis is submitted.

6.6 Future research

Future research on this topic could involve a larger quantitative study of Saltstraumen in which a broader section of the population is surveyed regarding tourism development and conscientious place branding. Such a study could provide a wider range of perspectives across different stakeholder groups and age categories. The present study focused primarily on internal stakeholders, including residents, business owners and municipal officials directly connected to Saltstraumen. Future research could therefore examine external stakeholder perspectives, such as tourists and visitors from Bodø, other parts of Norway and international destinations. External business owners who own properties and/or Airbnb accommodations in Saltstraumen, but do not live within the local community, would also represent an important stakeholder group for further investigation.

The data collection for this study was conducted during a relatively short period of three days in Saltstraumen during April, while additional interviews were conducted digitally from

Sweden. The study therefore captures Saltstraumen at a specific point in time. Future research could involve longer periods of fieldwork within the community, extending the situated observations made here into more sustained and systematic direct and participatory observation across multiple visits and seasons. Research carried out during the peak summer tourism season would also complement the present study, as stakeholder perspectives, especially among residents and business owners, may change when visitor pressure is at its highest. Such research could also include tourists as a stakeholder group, allowing the views of visitors and residents to be studied together during periods of high interaction. Longitudinal studies conducted before and after the implementation of future visitor strategies or tourism plans could also help evaluate how effective such measures are over time and how stakeholder perceptions change throughout these processes.

This study was conducted as a single case study focused on one small tourism community. Future studies could apply the conscientious place branding framework to other small tourism destinations facing similar tensions between tourism development, local communities and environmental sustainability, both within Norway and internationally. Further research could also explore how conscientious place branding functions in larger destinations and urban contexts. Future studies could also examine the practical implementation of conscientious place branding by municipalities and governmental actors. This may include investigating which governance structures currently support the conscientious place branding approach, what barriers exist in practice and what political or organisational changes may be necessary for conscientious place branding to be implemented more fully.

From a theoretical point of view future research could apply the conscientious place branding framework in a wider range of contexts to explore which of its dimensions are stable and which depend on local conditions. This study was conducted in a small, rural community within a high-trust Nordic governance setting. The dimensions of the framework may operate differently in places with lower institutional trust, stronger year-round dependence on tourism, weaker government systems or tourism organisations with a predominantly market-driven approach. Research in these settings could help clarify which parts of the framework are context-dependent and which can be applied more broadly across tourism-dependent communities.

The idea of layered accountability concept identified in this thesis could be examined in other contexts where governance is spread across multiple levels. Future research could investigate whether a similar pattern appears in other destinations, where responsibilities are relatively clear within individual organisations but become more difficult to trace across governance levels also appears in other places where tourism development involves several public and semi-public actors working with different responsibilities and timelines. This would help develop the concept beyond this single case and strengthen its relevance for research on conscientious place branding in contexts where tourism and development are managed through collaboration between different public sector organisations.

Future research could also focus more specifically on marine protected areas, both in Saltstraumen and elsewhere, in order to examine how marine protection measures are enforced in practice and whether they function effectively. Further studies concerning fish populations and fish stock development within marine protected areas in tourism destinations would also be valuable, given the limited amount of existing research identified during this study.

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Appendix A: Interview guide

The interview guide below is version 1.1, the version used from the second interview onwards. Version 1.0 was used for the pilot interview with R6; the revisions made after that interview are summarised in Section 3.4. The guide is semi-structured: the questions set the territory but the order and emphasis varied with each conversation, and follow-up probes were used to pursue lines the participant opened.

Interview Guide v1.1

From Overtourism to Responsible Branding: Developing Conscientious Place Brands in Coastal Communities

Opening script

"Thank you for agreeing to take part in this interview. We are interested in how people who are connected to Saltstraumen experience this place, especially in relation to tourism, community life and sustainability. There are no right or wrong answers. I'm interested in your experiences and views, in your own words.

With your permission, I'll record the interview so I don't miss anything. Everything you say will be treated confidentially and any reports will use pseudonyms so you cannot be personally identified. You can skip any question or stop the interview at any time. Do you have any questions before we begin? Is it okay if I start recording now?"

(Confirm consent and then start recording.)

Preliminary questions

Name:

Gender:

Age:

Occupation:

Living in (house, apartment etc.):

(Date and interview time):

Floating prompts (used throughout the interview, as needed)

- Could you tell me more about that?
- What do you mean by…?
- Can you give me an example?

- How did that feel for you?

Periodically check understanding of what the respondent has said.

Introductory Grand Tour question (Saltstraumen as a place)

1. If a friend who had never been here asked you to explain what Saltstraumen is like, how would you describe it to them?

Prompts questions (if needed)

- Who are the main kinds of people you think about when you picture Saltstraumen? *(probing: for example residents, visitors, businesses, others)*
- What kinds of things do people mainly do here? *(probing: in everyday life and when they visit)*

❖ Can you think of a particular moment or day that, for you, really captures what Saltstraumen is? Could you tell me about it?

Identity of the place: Who/what is it for?

Mini-tour questions

2. Thinking about everyday life here, who do you feel Saltstraumen is mostly for?
(probing: what makes you say/think that?)

Prompts

- Do you have any thoughts about Saltstraumen as a Marine Protected Area?
- How is it a place for residents?
- In what ways is it a place for tourists or visitors? Two different types.
- How is it a place for local businesses?
- Are there people or groups you feel it is not really for at the moment? Tell me more about that?
- If Saltstraumen were organised mainly for residents instead of tourists (or vice versa), how do you think it would look or feel different?

Fairness and inclusion

3. From your point of view, who benefits most from the way Saltstraumen is currently developed? *(probing: and promoted?)*

Prompts

- Residents? In what ways do they benefit?
- What about local businesses, or people whose work depends on tourism?
- Do you think the natural environment benefits, or is put under pressure? Tell me more about… that?
- What about differences between age groups or life stages? *(probe: for example younger adults, families, older residents)*

❖ What kinds of trade-offs do you see between different needs here? *(probe: for example between housing, tourism, access to the natural environment)*

❖ When important decisions are made about Saltstraumen, which voices are the most common? *(probe: and which voices are seldom heard?)*

❖ Can you describe a particular meeting, decision or conflict that, for you, showed how power or influence works here?

Sustainability: short- and long-term futures

4. If we imagine Saltstraumen 10 or 20 years from now, what kind of future would you see?

Prompts

- What would you hope for in terms of community and social life?
- What about local culture/ traditions?
- How would you like the natural environment and ecosystems to be in that future?
- What should the local economy look like?
- What about tourism?

❖ If there are current tensions mentioned by the respondent: Where do you see the main tensions between economic welfare and environmental welfare here? *(probe: how are these tensions handled now)*

Organisational openness and participation

5. How would you describe the way different people are involved in decisions about Saltstraumen? *(probe: for example residents, businesses, politicians and others).*

Prompts

- Can you think of ways residents are invited to participate or give input?
- How are tourism operators or other businesses involved?

- What role do local or regional authorities play?
- What about the environment? *(How are the environment taken into account?, who is responsible for that etc.)*
- Is there anyone else who should be involved, but usually is not? *(why)*

❖ From what you have seen, do decision-making processes here feel more like open conversations that are facilitated, or more like decisions that are already made and then communicated? *(probe: Can you give an example)*

❖ *(Questions based on the answer that stakeholders are not fully involved in the decisions)* If the decision process were truly collaborative (with stakeholders), how do you imagine it would work differently from today?

Transparency and accountability

6. When decisions are made about development or tourism in Saltstraumen, how easy is it for you to *see/(find information about)* what has been decided? *(probe: and why)*

Prompts

- What kinds of information or documentation do you know about? *(probe: for example plans, strategies, reports)* What do they contain?
- How is this information usually communicated to people? *(probe: and who actually gets to see it?)*
- Do you have a sense of who is responsible for following up and making sure promises are kept? *(why or why not)*

❖ If you were designing a way to check whether development in Saltstraumen is on the right track, what kinds of things would you want to measure/pay attention to?

❖ Can you recall a time when you felt the process was particularly transparent? *(probe: or not transparent at all? what happened?)*

❖ **Or** else could you talk us through a major/minor or common decisions. *(probe for how information was shared, shown, communicated etc.)*

Closing questions

7. Is there anything important about Saltstraumen that we haven't talked about yet, but that you think should be part of this conversation? *(possible probes: tourism, or the future of this place)*

8. If you had the chance to give one piece of advice to those responsible for branding and developing Saltstraumen, what would it be?

Those are all my planned questions. Is there anything else you would like to add before we finish? Thank you very much for sharing your experiences and views!

Appendix B: Information sheet

The information sheet below was provided to each participant in advance of the interview, together with the consent form in Appendix C. It sets out the purpose of the study, what participation involved, how data would be stored and used, and the participant's right to withdraw. The handling of personal data followed the procedures described in Section 3.6.

Project title: From Overtourism to Responsible Branding: Developing Conscientious Place Brands in Coastal Communities
Researchers: Ellinor Ramstedt and Nathan Sibly, Master's students in International Business, Luleå University of Technology
Supervisor: Kerry Chipp, Senior Lecturer, Business Administration and Industrial Engineering, Department of Social Sciences, Technology and Arts

About the study

We would like to invite you to take part in a research study about how people connected to Saltstraumen experience this place, especially in relation to tourism, community life and sustainability. The study is part of our Master's thesis at Luleå University of Technology.

The purpose of the project is to understand how different local stakeholders (such as residents, tourism businesses and public officials) see the identity and future of Saltstraumen, and how tourism and place branding can be developed in a more "conscientious" and sustainable way. The results will be presented in a Master's thesis and may be used in presentations or academic publications.

Why have you been asked?

You are being asked because you live in, work in, or have another important connection to Saltstraumen and its tourism development. Your experiences mean you can help us understand how changes in the area affect people and nature. We aim to interview approximately 14 people from different stakeholder groups.

What does participation involve?

If you choose to participate, we will invite you to a single interview of about 30–60 minutes. The interview will be semi-structured and feel like a guided conversation. We will ask open questions about what Saltstraumen means to you, how you experience tourism and development, and how you see the future of the area. With your permission, the interview will be audio-recorded so we can transcribe it accurately.

You can choose whether the interview takes place in person in Saltstraumen, online (for example via Zoom/Teams), or by phone, at a time that suits you. You may decline to answer any question you do not wish to answer, and you can stop the interview at any time.

Voluntary participation and right to withdraw

Taking part in this study is completely voluntary. It is your choice whether or not to participate, and saying no will have no negative consequences for you now or in the future. If you agree to take part, you can withdraw at any time during the interview without giving a reason. After the interview, you may request that your data be removed up until the data have been anonymised and included in the final thesis (estimated 7 May 2026). After that point, it may no longer be possible to remove individual contributions from the analysed material.

Confidentiality and handling of personal data

All information you provide will be treated confidentially. Only the student researchers and the supervisor will have access to the full recordings and transcripts. We will remove or change names and other directly identifying details in the transcripts, and we will not name you or your organisation in the thesis without your explicit permission. In a small community like Saltstraumen, it can sometimes be possible to guess who has said what, so we will take extra care to combine details in a way that reduces the risk of recognition as far as possible.

Audio files and transcripts will be stored securely on password-protected university systems, in accordance with Luleå University of Technology's rules for handling personal data and the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). The material will be kept only as long as necessary for the thesis project and any required archiving, and will then be deleted or archived according to university guidelines. No commercial company will have access to your raw data.

Possible risks and benefits

We do not expect any major risks from participating. Some people may find it emotionally engaging to talk about changes in the community or conflicts around tourism. You are always free to move on to another topic or stop the interview if you become uncomfortable. You will not receive payment for participation. However, your contribution may help local actors and future researchers better understand how tourism and branding can support both community well-being and environmental protection in Saltstraumen.

Who is responsible for the study and how can you get more information?

The study is conducted by students at Luleå University of Technology under the supervision of Kerry Chipp. Luleå University of Technology is the data controller for the processing of personal data in this project.

If you have questions or would like more information, please contact:

- **Researchers:** Ellinor Ramstedt, (email)

Nathan Sibly, (email)

- **Supervisor:** Kerry Chipp, (email)

If you are willing to participate, we will ask you to sign a separate consent form before the interview starts.

Appendix C: Consent form

The consent form below was signed by each participant before the interview began. It records informed consent to participate, to be recorded, and to have anonymised extracts used in the thesis and any resulting publications. The full procedure is described in Section 3.6.

Luleå University of Technology – Consent form for participation in interview study

Project title: From Overtourism to Responsible Branding: Developing Conscientious Place Brands in Coastal Communities
Researchers: Ellinor Ramstedt and Nathan Sibly, Master's students in International Business, Luleå University of Technology
Supervisor: Kerry Chipp, Senior Lecturer, Business Administration and Industrial Engineering, Department of Social Sciences, Technology and Arts

1. Confirmation of information

Please read each statement and tick the box if you agree.

☐ I confirm that I have received and read the written information sheet about this study and have had the opportunity to ask questions.
☐ I understand the purpose of the study, what participation involves, and how my personal data will be handled as described in the information sheet.

2. Voluntary participation and right to withdraw

☐ I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I may withdraw from the study at any time, without giving a reason and without any negative consequences for me.
☐ I understand that I can request that my interview data be withdrawn up until the data has been anonymised and included in the final thesis (estimated May 7, 2026). After that point, it may no longer be possible to remove my individual contribution from the analysed material.

3. Interview and recording

☐ I agree to take part in a semi-structured interview for this study (approx. 60–90 minutes, in person or online).
☐ I consent to the interview being video and/or audio recorded for the purpose of accurate transcription and analysis.
☐ I understand that only the student researchers and their supervisor will have access to the full recordings and transcripts, and that recordings will be stored securely and deleted when no longer needed for the project (estimated June 30, 2026).

4. Use of my words in the thesis and publications

☐ I understand that my name and other directly identifying details will be removed or changed, and that anonymised quotations from my interview may be used in the Master's

thesis and in any related academic presentations or publications.
☐ I understand that the results may be reported in a way that examples from my interview cannot reasonably be traced back to me as an individual.

5. Consent to processing of personal data

☐ I consent to Luleå University of Technology processing my personal data (including any sensitive personal data that I choose to share) for the purposes of this research project, in the manner described in the information sheet and in accordance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).
☐ I understand that I can withdraw this consent at any time by contacting the researcher(s), but that data already anonymised and included in analyses may not be possible to remove.

Participant

Name (block letters):

Signature:

Place and date:

Researcher (person obtaining consent)

Name (block letters):

Signature:

Place and date:

Appendix D: Pre-analysis code book

The pre-analysis code book was developed from the literature review and the conceptual framework before fieldwork, as the orienting move that an abductive design requires. It sets out the categories the framework would expect a conscientious place brand to be answerable to, with sub-themes and a small number of broad codes derived from the theory. Several sub-themes are deliberately listed without codes: the framework opened the slot but the codes were to be generated from the data rather than predicted in advance. The analytic movement from this orientation to the post-analysis code book is recorded in Appendix F.

Table 5

Pre-analysis code book

Theme	Sub-theme	Code
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for residents
		Place for visitors/tourists
		Place for business/work
		Place for nature
	What is it for?	Everyday life and lifestyle
		Leisure and recreation
		Learning and knowledge
	Emotional meanings	Place attachment and pride
	Place image and brand	
	Historical identity and traditions	
	Resident identity	
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Economic benefits distribution
		Social and cultural benefits distribution
		Environmental benefits
	Distribution of burdens	Economic burdens

		Social burdens
		Environmental burdens
	Access and inclusion	Access to housing
		Access to environment
		Inclusion/exclusion of groups
	Power and voice	Visible powerholders
		Groups with little or no power
		Perceived fairness/justice
	Opportunity structures	Opportunities for participation and benefit
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Desired future scenarios
		Fears and risks
	Short-term pressures	Short-term gains
		Short-term costs
	Balancing dimensions	Environment-economy trade-offs
		Social sustainability and community viability
		Cultural continuity and change
	Conditions for visibility	Preconditions for sustainable future
Organisational Openness	Formal participation	Formal arenas and channels
		Inclusion of stakeholder diversity
	Everyday participation	Informal contact and dialogue

		Community initiatives
	Influence and efficacy	Perceived influence
		Gatekeepers and brokers
	Governance style	Openness and facilitation
		Direction and control
	Co-creation and cooperation	
	Aspirations	Imagined better participation
Transparency and Accountability	What is measured	Indicators and KPIs
		Perceived measurement gaps
	How it is measured	Systems and methods
	Documentation	Plans, policies and records
	Communication	Accessibility of information
		Targeting and inclusiveness
	Responsibility	Clarity of roles
		Accountability mechanisms
	Evidence and trust	Use of evidence
		Trust/mistrust in institutions
	Frustration with bureaucracy	
	Regulations/restrictions	

Appendix E: Post-analysis code book

One row per unique code, grouped by theme and sub-theme. The Extracts column shows how many coded extracts from interviews R1–R17 map to each code. The analytic movement from pre-analysis to post-analysis (including codes added during the final iteration) is documented in Appendix F. The table contains 6 themes, 25 sub-themes, 316 unique codes, 687 coded extracts.

Table 6

Post analysis code book

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Fishing without place connection (tourists)	1
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Local business struggles	2
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Local community: Business owners living in local community	2
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Local pride (connected to tourism)	1
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Natural beauty	12
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Not a special/spectacular/extraordinary place	1
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Place attachment (Spatially specific place)	1
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Residents (locals) care for place	8
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Residents (locals) care for place (Educating visitors about respectful behaviour)	1
Identity	Emotional meaning (place attachment)	Unique natural phenomenon identity	15
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Historical culture	2
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Historical identity (fishing)	4
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Historical identity (Local history)	10
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Historical identity (residents)	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Historical identity (toursim)	1
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Local (traditional) fishing identity	6
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Local traditions/culture	1
Identity	Historical identity and traditions	Local tradtions/culture	1
Identity	More-than-human place	Ecologically rich area: marine and birdlife	4
Identity	More-than-human place	Ecologically rich area: productivity due to currents	1
Identity	More-than-human place	Ecologically rich area: wildlife	1
Identity	More-than-human place	Place for nature	2
Identity	More-than-human place	Place identity vs ecosystem identity (dual framing)	1
Identity	More-than-human place	Summertime experiences	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Maelstrom important for tourists	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Marketing and information	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Marketing: Attractive fishing conditions	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Marketing: Avoid fishing branding	2
Identity	Place image and brand	Marketing: Lack of marketing/signange for activities and companies	2
Identity	Place image and brand	Marketing: Marine protected area	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Markting: Responsible marketing	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Supporting external place brand	1
Identity	Place image and brand	Supporting external place brand (unwillingly)	5
Identity	Resident identity	Identity co-creation*	1
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: connection (external stakeholders)	1
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Decline in community life/services	5
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Disconnection (newcomer)	2
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Disconnection between internal and external stakeholders	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Disconnection local community/environment and government/policians	2
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Lack of entertainment (adult)	2
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Lack of entertainment (children)	1
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Norwegian community	1
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: School as social bridge	1
Identity	Resident identity	Local community: Small community services	1
Identity	Resident identity	Local knowledge about safe behaviour around the current	2
Identity	Resident identity	Place representative person/group	3
Identity	What is it for?	Diverse activities/interests: what people do	3
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing and maelstrom	2
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing as key local identity	3
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing purpose (re-selling and profit)	1
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing purpose (food)	3
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing purpose (lifestyle)	2
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing purpose (residents/locals)	1
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing purpose (tourism)	6
Identity	What is it for?	Fishing purpose (trophy)	2
Identity	What is it for?	Generational difference (fishing interest)	1
Identity	What is it for?	Maelstrom as main tourist attraction	5
Identity	What is it for?	Outdoor activity interests	3
Identity	What is it for?	Outdoor activity interests (Hiking locals/tourists)	2
Identity	What is it for?	Place for everyday life	3
Identity	What is it for?	Place for fishing	3
Identity	What is it for?	Place for fishing and nature people	1
Identity	What is it for?	Place for Local history	2
Identity	What is it for?	Sea change residents	2
Identity	What is it for?	Short-stay tourism (picture purpose) / “bucket-list” tourism	8
Identity	Who is it for?	Local history for tourists	3
Identity	Who is it for?	Loss of local identity	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Identity	Who is it for?	Loss of local identity (connection to the place)	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for businesses	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for children	3
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for everyone	6
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for everyone (visitors/tourists)	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for residents/locals	8
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for residents/locals (farmers, divers and old fishermen as core)	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for residents/locals (older)	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for residents/locals (who enjoy nature)	2
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for visitors/tourists	5
Identity	Who is it for?	Place for visitors/tourists (fishing)	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place not for Youth (bored)	1
Identity	Who is it for?	Place not for “destroyers”	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Balanced environmental pressure	4
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Cultural continuity	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Decline in community services/life without tourism	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Development restrictions	3
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Economic interests in focus	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Economic: Lack of funding	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Economic: Lack of funding (from municipality)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Enviroment does not benefit	2
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Environmental preservation	3
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fear of losing community and services	4
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fear of losing fishing rights (and way of life)	5
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing connection vs desctructions	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing described as destructive	6
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing described as destructive)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing tensions and pressure	10
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing tensions and pressure (rejection of overfishing tourist)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing tensions and pressure (Wild fishing)	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Fishing vs bird life	4
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area (barrier vs protection)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area (park rangers)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area (reservation for war/crisis times)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area (specifically attracting fishermen	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area (Stronger marine protection)	3
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area lacks defined aims	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area MPA under revision	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area poorly enforced and ineffective	10
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Marine protected area Spillover effect from protected area	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Place not made for tourism	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Recreational fishing pressure unregulated and unsustainable	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Shifting fishing outside of the main straight	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Shifting tourist fishing outside main straight	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Shifting tourist fishing outside marine protected area	6
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Summer (Perceived environmental tipping point in summer)	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Trade-offs: Fishing vs economy	1
Sustainability	Balancing dimensions	Trade-offs: Fishing vs preservation	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Avoiding mass-tourism problems	5
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Avoiding mass-tourism problems (worst case scenario)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Concern about future garbage with more tourists	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Desired future and nature focus	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Desired future and shift towards active community life	2

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Desired future and shift towards nature oriented tourism	8
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Desired future and shift towards nature oriented tourism (midnight sun, aurora)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fear and risks	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fish stock/population (Claims of diminishing fish stock)	5
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fish stock/population (Claims of diminishing fish/bird stock)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fish stock/population: population crashes	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fish stocks/population (Oslo fjord)	2
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fish stocks/population (Subjective opinions)	2
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing (Guided vs wild tourist fishing)	3
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing license/card	4
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing quota and/or boat limits/gear regulations	4
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing restrictions regarding size/weight	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing Seasonal fishing limits/ban)	3
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Fishing: lack of information regarding banned fish species	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Long-term environmental protection (for future generation)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Nature will self-repair	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Regulations vs fishing rights	5
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Regulations vs fishing rights (MPA)	2
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Strategy inadequate for future plans	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Suggested solutions for tensions (park ranger)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Suggested solutions for tensions (specific diving area)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Tension over fishing rights and regulation	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Winter: Desire for winter events and activities	2
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Winter: Desire for winter events and activities (community initiative to create winter meeting place)	1
Sustainability	Long-term/short-term futures	Youth perspectives on staying or leaving	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Accessibility and inclusion for people with disabilities	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Alchohol expensive	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Lacking public transportation	4
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Meetings between locals and tourists	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Right to fish: Locals	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Right to fish: Tourist	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Rigt to fish: constitutional	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Stakeholder exclusion (outside voices)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Stakeholder exclusion (young forgotten)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Stakeholder inclusion (businesses)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	Stakeholder inclusion (young/children)	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	“Allemannsretten” (the right to roam	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	“Allemannsretten” (the right to roam)	3
Fairness and Inclusion	Access and inclusion	“Allemannsretten” (the right to roam) limited for tourists	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Business owners benefitting	6
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Environment better/benefits	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Lack of economic power (Saltstraumen small economy)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Local business winners	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Perception of fair contribution from tourists	2

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Residents benefit only from amenity	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Resources for both tourists and residents	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Stakeholder groups fighting for the same (local) resources	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Youth benefiting from tourism	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of benefits	Youth benefiting from tourism/Youth as local tourism stewards (informants)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Ecosystem wide fish problem (suggested)	3
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Ecosystem wide fish/bird problem (suggested)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Enviromental burdens	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Holiday homes	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Holiday homes replacing family houses	3
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Housing market (cheap)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Housing market (no pressure)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Housing market (shortage and affordability pressures)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Local tensions*	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Locals vs tourists	10
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Locals vs tourists and businesses	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Pressure on facilities and infrastructure/lack of needed tourist service	5
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Pressure on facilities and infrastructure/lack of needed tourist service (not set up for tourists)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Residents as losers in current fairness balance	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Tourism tensions (too much in the summer)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Tourism tensions (tourists misbehaving)	7
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Tourism tensions (tourists misbehaving) wild diving/divers	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Distribution of burdens	Unregulated accommodation (Airbnb/camping)	9
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Elite economic networks and opaque lobbying power	4
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Future generation voices	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Local community feel ignored and/or not listened to by politicans	2

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Local community feel ignored and/or not listened to by politicians	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Local representative/local board	9
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Local representative/local board (Strengthening power of local advisory board)	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Power and influence resulting in economic benefits	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Power and influence resulting in economic benefits	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholder groups overlooked/set aside	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholder groups overlooked/set aside (fishermen)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholder groups overlooked/set aside (residents)	3
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders /people has equal voice	7
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders not listened to / lack of internal stakeholder inclusion by external politicians	5
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders underrepresentation (key stakeholder)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders with strong influence/ loud voices	4
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders with strong influence/ loud voices (businesses)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders with strong influence/ loud voices (fishing businesses)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders with strong influence/ loud voices (Perception of louder voices in decision-making)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders with strong influence/ loud voices (residents)	1
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders with unequal influence: young and old stakeholders	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders: External stakeholder influence	2
Fairness and Inclusion	Power and voice	Stakeholders: No awareness	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Advice for policymakers/leader	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information available only in Norwegian	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information for tourists	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information pathway dependency on key locals	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information readily available	2
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: Documentation found online	3
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: hard to find / scattered across agencies	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: newspaper (case)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: newspaper (youth will not pay for media)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: newspapers	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: poster/website about marine protection	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: social media groups	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Information: Word of mouth	2
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Locality-focused information platform (suggested solution)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Platform for discussion	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Pop-up/text messages (suggested solution for tensions)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Visitor centres and info boards (is not functioning)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Communication	Visitor centres and info boards (Suggested solutions for tensions)	2
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Fish stock/population: fish counting system	1
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Fish stock/population: no long-term studies/ research	4
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Fish stock/population: no one keep tracks of it	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Fish stock/population: no proof of decline	2
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Systems and methods	1
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Systems and methods (birds, boats)	1
Transparency and Accountability	How and what is measured	Systems and methods (depends on protection aims)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Decisionmaking: Slow response	2
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Decisionmaking: Transparant (but slow)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Economic restrictions	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Governmental responsibility for reinforce and following-up and decisions	3
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Governmental responsibility for reinforce and following-up and decisions)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Governmental responsibility for reinforcing and following-up and decisions	3
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of action from politicians	3
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/ transparency	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/transparancy	4
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/transparancy (in finding information)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/transparancy (Marine protected area)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/transparancy (municipality departments avoiding responsibility)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/transparancy (No one responsible for follow-up)	5
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of clarity/responsibility/transparency (decision pathway)	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of communication system (by government)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Lack of political involvement/interest among locals	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Local community disagree with the politicians	1
Transparency and Accountability	Multi-level governance and accountability gaps	Politics congruent with absence of protection	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Better signage and paths (suggested soultion for tension)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Building restrictions and exceptions	7
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Building restrictions and exceptions (Bureaucratic restriction)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Governmental laws/regulations ("specialised case")	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Governmental laws/regulations (Fishing closed seasons)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Governmental laws/regulations (fishing)	2
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Governmental laws/regulations (radical laws)	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Governmental template	1
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	No free camping/parking anymore (suggested solution for tension)	2
Transparency and Accountability	Regulations and restrictions	Tourist tax (suggested solution for tension)	2
Transparency and Accountability	Responsibility	Business owners/locals responsibility to enforce rules/regulations	2
Transparency and Accountability	Responsibility	Citizen responsibility	3
Transparency and Accountability	Responsibility	Decisionmaking: Step-by-step change/changes takes long time	1
Transparency and Accountability	Responsibility	Governmental responsibility for giving information	1
Transparency and Accountability	Responsibility	New plan defines responsibility	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Transparency and Accountability	Responsibility	Tourist responsibilty	1
Economic Orientation	Business oriented future	Further business development	4
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Mutual benefitting (Businesses and tourism)	2
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Mutual benefitting (locals and businesses)	1
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Mutual benefitting/dependence of residents and tourism	1
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Mutual benefitting/dependence of residents and tourism (same quote twice)	1
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	No-one benefits	1
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Residents source of income	3
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Residents source of incomes	7
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Residents' source of incomes	3
Economic Orientation	Distribution of economic benefit	Tourist segments and spending patterns	4
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Company growth/business growth	1
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Increased tourism/more future tourism	4
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Local business support	1
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Managable tourism (Perception that tourism is not yet excessive)	2
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Marketing: shift in purpose of tourism	2
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in purpose of tourism	1
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in purpose of tourism ("expereience tourism")	1
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in purpose of tourism (from half-day experience to overnight trip)).	1
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in purpose of tourism (low impact tourism)	2
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in purpose of tourism (nature)	2
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in purpose of tourism (no rental fishing gear)	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Economic Orientation	Limits to growth	Shift in the purpose of tourism ("slow travel", history etc.)	1
Economic Orientation	Prosperity through continuity	Increased future population	1
Economic Orientation	Prosperity through continuity	Indicators of successful development	5
Economic Orientation	Prosperity through continuity	Negative outlook for future	3
Economic Orientation	Prosperity through continuity	Seasonal business	3
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Business individualism / focus on own business*	1
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Citizen participation	4
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Collaboration among local actors	1
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Collaboration among local businesses	1
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Collaboration among local businesses	1
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Collaboration among local tourism businesses	8
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Collaboration among local tourism businesses (local business should work together)	1
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Mutual business dialogue/discussion	2
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Mutual business dialogue/discussion (including everybody)	1
Organisational Openness	Horizontal cooperation (peer-to-peer)	Open conversations	1
Organisational Openness	Influence and aspirations	Frustration with talk over action on environmental issues	1
Organisational Openness	Influence and aspirations	Gatekeepers and brokers	2
Organisational Openness	Influence and aspirations	Young people not intrested/engaged	1
Organisational Openness	Influence and aspirations	“Detached” from local community (business owner)	1

Theme	Sub-theme	Code	N
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Collaboration between local actors and external aurhorities	3
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Collaboration between local actors and external authorities	2
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Communication systems to influencing governments	1
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Fear of community losing voice	2
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Key person/facilitator	1
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Open meetings/consultation	2
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Saltstraumen as a preceder for other local areas	1
Organisational Openness	Vertical channels (community ↔ authorities)	Town hall meeting	2

Appendix F: Codebook provenance

The codebook passed through four saved states between the start of analysis and v5.1. Documenting the audit chain matters because the version transitions carried the abductive movement of the analysis: each transition records a specific kind of analytic work, and the file structure changed alongside the conceptual structure.

The original working file held per-respondent coding tabs for eight of the early interviews (R11, R2, R15, R4, R9, R17, R10, R14), a consolidated extracts sheet covering R6 through R4, a working sheet on which theme and sub-theme assignments were tested against the six prefigured categories from the pre-interview codebook, a Theme summary sheet with extract counts by theme and sub-theme, and a short notes sheet. The notes sheet is significant: it proposed several new sub-themes and one new theme (Economic Orientation) on the basis of what the early interviews had produced. v3 was a clean rebuild. It consolidated coding across R6 to R14 into a single Coded extracts sheet of 648 extracts, carried the Theme summary forward unchanged, adopted the new sub-themes and the Economic Orientation theme that the notes sheet had proposed, and added a Codebook sheet listing each unique code with its theme, sub-theme, and extract count. v4 added R13, which contributed 42 further extracts and brought the total to 687 across all 17 interviews. v4 also added one further sub-theme under Transparency and Accountability (Multi-level governance and accountability gaps, capturing the structural responsibility-dissolution pattern that R13 made most visible but that earlier interviews had already produced), and introduced a cross-cutting Layered tag so that extracts exhibiting the layered-accountability pattern could be traced across themes without disturbing the six-theme structure.

The transitions between versions were deliberate. The move from per-respondent tabs to a consolidated sheet enabled cross-respondent comparison, which the per-tab structure had made awkward. The adoption of the notes-sheet proposals into v3 is the documentary origin of the Economic Orientation theme and of the sub-theme reorganisations that survive into v4. The v3 to v4 move was strictly additive: no extracts from R6 to R14 were recoded; R13 contributed the full 42-extract delta; and the new Transparency and Accountability sub-theme drew on codes already present in R6 to R14 that R13 brought into clearer view. The addition of Multi-level governance and accountability gaps is the clearest single piece of abductive evidence in the version history: the sub-theme was not in the pre-interview codebook, the interview guide did not ask for it directly, and the codes that compose it had been generated across multiple interviews before R13 brought the pattern into focus.

The v4 to v5 transition was a review-and-consolidation pass rather than an additive one. Four sub-themes that v4 had carried as single-extract or low-extract holdings were dissolved into adjacent material where the data supported a cleaner reading. Frustration with bureaucracy (Transparency and Accountability, three extracts in v4) was removed and its extracts redistributed to Multi-level governance and accountability gaps, Regulations and restrictions, and one further sub-theme of the same theme; the analytic argument was that the frustration the extracts named was already carried by the structural categories that the data had produced more fully. Conditions for visibility (Sustainability, one extract in v4) was removed and the

extract recoded under Balancing dimensions, where the sustaining-condition reading was already supported by neighbouring material. Co-creation and co-decision (Organisational Openness, two extracts in v4) was removed; one extract moved to Vertical channels and one to a related sub-theme, on the basis that the v4 codes did not in fact mark a distinct co-decision register. External stakeholders and future revenue (Economic Orientation, one extract in v4) was removed and the extract recoded as Identity / Place image and brand, where the data placed it more honestly. Three codes were added to Transparency and Accountability sub-themes during the same pass to record material that the redistributions had brought into view. No new sub-themes or themes were generated in v5.

The v5 to v5.1 transition was housekeeping rather than analytic work. Three empty rows that had been left orphaned by earlier code shifts (IDs 200, 348 and 392) were removed. The Identity sub-theme Place for nature was renamed More-than-human place to resolve a name collision with a code inside the sub-theme; the rename preserves the analytic content and brings the label into line with the more-than-human register used in the framework chapter. The Identity sub-theme What is it for had appeared in two forms (with and without the question mark) and was unified under What is it for?; two extracts that had been carried under the unpunctuated version moved across. The Theme summary sheet was rebuilt with live COUNTIF and COUNTIFS formulas referring to the Coded extracts sheet so that editing the extract sheet now updates the summary automatically; v5 and earlier versions had carried hand-maintained counts that were prone to drift. The underlying analysis and the six-theme, twenty-eight sub-theme structure did not change between v5 and v5.1.

At v5.1 the codebook reported 687 coded extracts across 17 interviews, organised into six themes (Identity 207, Sustainability 146, Fairness and Inclusion 142, Transparency and Accountability 94, Economic Orientation 58, Organisational Openness 40) and twenty-eight sub-themes, with 56 extracts flagged for the cross-cutting layered-accountability pattern. The full codebook is reproduced as Appendix E.

v5.1-v5.2: v5.2 is a single-record fix that reconciles the Economic Orientation sub-theme totals with the theme total. v5.1 carried one extract (ID 542, code "Residents source of incomes", interview R9) under a dual sub-theme label "Distribution of economic benefit / balancing dimensions". This produced two visible artefacts: the Economic Orientation theme total of 58 and the sub-theme sum of 57 did not reconcile, and the Theme summary COUNTIFS double-counted the record under Balancing dimensions. The dual label was an artefact of an earlier note rather than a coding decision. The change applied: ID 542 sub-theme reassigned to "Distribution of economic benefit" (under Economic Orientation, where the theme assignment already placed it). No theme change. No other extracts touched. The recalculated Theme summary reconciles: Distribution of economic benefit 23, Limits to growth 19, Prosperity through continuity 12, Business oriented future 4, summing to 58. Theme totals and the 687 grand total are unchanged.

The Codebook tab in the earlier v5 series was a manually maintained summary that fell behind edits made directly to the Coded extracts sheet. The Codebook's Extracts column summed to 660 while the Coded extracts sheet contained 687 records, a 27-extract drift that

varied across themes. Theme totals quoted in the thesis prose (Identity 207, Sustainability 146, Fairness and Inclusion 142, Transparency and Accountability 94, Economic Orientation 58, Organisational Openness 40, total 687) are computed live from the Coded extracts sheet via COUNTIF and COUNTIFS formulas in the Theme summary tab and were not affected by the drift. The drift was therefore a workbook-internal consistency issue, not a thesis-counts issue.

In this consolidation pass the Codebook tab was deleted and regenerated mechanically from the Coded extracts sheet, one row per unique Theme / Sub-theme / Code triple, ordered alphabetically within each theme. During regeneration twelve clerical hygiene fixes were applied to the Coded extracts sheet to consolidate near-duplicate code names that had no analytic distinction: nine case, whitespace or stray-asterisk merges between paired variants of the same code within the same sub-theme (for example "Place for residents/locals" and "Place for residents/locals *"; "Environmental Preservation" and "Environmental preservation"), and three single-row cosmetic fixes (a triple-asterisk wrapper removed from one code name, a stray double-asterisk removed from another, and one typo corrected from "scocial" to "social").

All fixes were strictly within the sub-theme: no extract changed theme or sub-theme, and no theme or sub-theme total moved. The total of 687 coded extracts is preserved. The unique code count moved from 326 (raw in v5.1) to 325 (after the v5.2 Row 542 sub-theme reassignment described above) to 316 (after the nine consolidation merges).

Reconciled counts in v5.2 (consolidation pass): 6 themes, 25 sub-themes, 316 unique codes, 687 coded extracts, 56 extracts flagged as layered accountability. The Theme summary tab continues to be live-linked to the Coded extracts sheet and is unaffected by the rebuild. The Codebook tab is now a true rollup of the Coded extracts sheet, so the two sheets cannot drift apart in future without changing the data.

Appendix G: AI acknowledgement

During the preparation of this thesis, the authors used AI-assisted tools (including Perplexity and ChatGPT LLM assistants) to support the writing and revision process. The tools were used for language editing, restructuring and tightening of our own prose, for discussing and stress-testing the framing of arguments, for formatting and document-structuring tasks, and for translating Norwegian-language material into English. All research design, data collection, coding, thematic analysis, interpretation and conclusions are the authors' own. No analytical findings, citations or sources were generated by AI; every source was located, read and verified by the authors, and all theoretical claims rest on our own engagement with the literature. The authors reviewed and take full responsibility for the final content of this thesis.

Ode til Saltstraümens sei — J. Roem M., 1949 (Ode to the Saltstraumen saithe)

I.
Gud skapte fesjkjen i have'
og fesjkjen i vatn og ælv.
Mæn beste og likaste gave
e' straumseien likavæl!
~ Ok, STRAUMSEI ~

II.
Nysst låg dar nokken på fate',
mæn snoft bei fatan tomm'.
Vi bei så mætt og så late, ~
me' fyllstappa magavom.
~ Åh, STRAUMSEI! ~

III.
Du leika så gla uti kave'
og svømte i straum og foss.
Du levde dett liv i have',
du ejndte dett liv i oss.
~ Akk, STRAUMSEI ~

IV.
Ha takk fôrr glæa og nøtta
du gjord' oss i dejnne stujnn,
frå dejnnti du sprella i bøtta
og te' du forsvajnn i vår mujnn.
~ TAKK, STRAUMSEI! ~

I.
God made the fish in the sea,
and the fish in lake and river.
But the finest, dearest gift
is the Saltstraumen saithe all the same!
~ Oh, straumsei ~

II
Just now some lay on the plate,
but soon the plate was bare.
We grew so full and so lazy,
with bellies stuffed to bursting.
~ Ah, straumsei! ~

III.
You played so gladly in the deep
and swam in current and falls.
You lived that life in the sea,
you ended that life in us.
~ Alas, straumsei ~

IV.
Our thanks for the joy and the worth
you gave us in this hour,
from when you flapped in the bucket
to when you vanished in our mouths.
~ Thank you, straumsei! ~

Fra Petter Dass, Nordlands Trompet, først utgitt i 1739 / From Petter Dass, Nordlands Trompet, first published 1739

En mil eller så i fra Bodøens gård,
der løper en strøm så forferdelig hård
at neppe man finner dens like.
Når flod eller ebbe er halveis i gang,
da bryter den frem i så heftige sprang
at båtene må for den vike …
Men hvordan kan strømmene flyte så stridt?
Jo, innenfor der er det åpent og vidt,
men gapet hvor vannet skal løpe,
har forrest en munn som er snever og trang,
og derfor må strømmene skyte sin gang
som om de var jaget av svøpe.

A mile or so from Bodø's farm
there runs a current so fearfully fierce
that scarcely its equal is found.
When the flood or the ebb is half underway,
it bursts forth in such violent leaps
that boats must give way before it …
But how can the currents flow so hard?
Why, within it is open and wide,
yet the gap where the water must run
has at its front a mouth narrow and tight,
and so the currents must shoot on their way
as though they were driven by a whip.